# She-Ra and the Crystal Gems: Fallen Horizons

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General Audiences

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Fandom Fusion

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# She-Ra and the Crystal Gems: Fallen Horizons

by TheInkredibleKaptainKaiju

Summary

Even after saving both their worlds from destruction, there is still so much for both the Crystal Gems and the Princess Alliance to accomplish. But even with their war reaching an end, evil has not yet been vanquished. A secret threat, laying dormant for centuries, is finally prepared to enact a plan that will put the entire universe at risk. New powers, secret origins, new allies, old enemies...but that's just par for the course! Nothing they can't handle...right?

Notes

That's right folks, it's the long awaited next installment in the She-Ra and the Crystal Gems saga! I know you're all as excited for this as I am, so let me just say that this is the part where things get real--a turning point if there ever was one! Alliances will be forged, friendships will be tested...ah, you don't want to hear me ramble, you just want to read it! Well, I won't keep you any longer. Enjoy!

# The Start of Something New

## She-Ra and the Crystal Gems: Fallen Horizons

Chapter One: The Start of Something New

– – –

For millions of years, the planet of Ophidia had existed as an independent world. It had resisted occupation in the days of Eternia, fended off attacks by Homeworld, and prospered through the ages despite this, all under the rulership of an enigmatic individual. "King Hiss" was his name, but many believe this to be simply a moniker, given the sheer length of his dynasty. Surely, no normal Snakekin could live for that long, right?

But now, a new threat had descended from the skies to disrupt the Snakekin's way of life. Gem ships fired from above…but so too did Eternian ships, Etherian ships, even other Ophidian ships, seemingly united in an effort to invade their own planet. In truth, these ships were indeed united under the same banner: that of the New Horde, a rising galactic power under the control of two warlords.

Battle raged on the ground. Having had millions of years of practice, the Snakekin were no slouches when it came to defending their home. Reptilian soldiers fired back at the Horde troopers dropping to the surface, with ships rising to the air to meet the invaders. But as much of the planet slowly turned into a warzone, one individual remained blissfully unaware of the weapon-fire and explosions happening just behind her.

"Fascinating!" Entrapta exclaimed, leaning closer to a plant emerging from a stone. Looking through an eyepiece to magnify one of its leaves, she spoke her findings into a recorder: "The plantlife of this planet appears similar to that of other worlds at first glance, but its cellular structure differs from any lifeform ever discovered! Each individual cell is diamond-shaped, forming into

an almost crystalline lattice–what relation this has to the actual Diamonds, if any, is unknown." She placed a small camera in front of the eyepiece, getting a picture for posterity. "Now to test if this planet's animal life is the same…"

Engrossed in the wonders of scientific discovery, Entrapta was unaware that she was being surrounded. A team of armed Snakes closed in, weapons trained on the mysterious invader. By the time she turned around, she had several guns pointed at her. "You," their apparent commander hissed. "Set down your weapons and raise your hands. Don't make this difficult, for either of us."

Instinctively, Entrapta raised her pigtails over her head rather than her arms. "Uh, Emily?" she said into a device on her wrist. "I might need some help down here…" The Snakekin lifted her up, checking her for any weapons.

"How bold of you to turn your back on the same war you started," growled the leader, glaring at the girl. "Occupying yourself with trivial endeavors while our people fall by the hundreds! Whoever this 'Emily' is…I doubt she will arrive in time to rescue you."

Entrapta now had her hands up as well, their guns pressed into her backs. "No, wait, you've got it all wrong! It isn't 'trivial,' it's science! The life on this world is unlike any I've ever seen before! I was just doing some research to try and find out why that is." She took a few steps forward. "Actually, if you're willing, can I…?"

The captain raised his weapon, stopping her in her tracks. "Be quiet! I don't care what your purpose here is, only that you are in league with these invaders! …Now then, what shall be done with you? Part of me wants to take you as our hostage, but another part doesn't think Catra and Emerald find you that valuable." It was his turn to step closer, holding his weapon underneath Entrapta's chin. "If that's the case, I can think of only one purpose you can serve–"

"Captain!" shouted another one of the Snakekin. "Incoming!" The platoon turned their attention towards the sky, where something

was rapidly approaching. It was too fast and too fiery to be a ship, and it was unlikely that a meteor had singled in on their exact location. Assuming it to be a missile, the Snakes ran for cover, their prisoner momentarily forgotten.

When the object reached the ground, crashing just feet away from where they had been standing moments before, only Entrapta was left out in the open. In fact, she hadn't even flinched at the object's impact, merely lowering her visor to shield her face from the dust. Once it began to settle, a light appeared from the object. It then stood up.

"Emily!" Entrapta said happily, approaching what was revealed to be a robot nearly three times her size, with a single ominous eye gazing back at her. "Am I glad you showed up when you did! Things were starting to get out of hand here…"

Emily chirped happily, her same old voice contrasting quite a bit with her new body. Her front side opened, revealing a cockpit for Entrapta to climb inside. She took the controls, and, guided by her master, Emily stomped forward.

"It was an ambush!" shouted the captain. "All troopers, fall back! Armor, on my position, now!" The ground-based Snakes fell back, firing their weapon at the advancing mechanical juggernaut, for what little good it did. Entrapta barely noticed as she bulldozed through their ranks.

The Snakes' armored vehicles provided more of a challenge, though Entrapta herself was more occupied with other things. Emily did most of the work, a gun on each arm ripping through their hover tanks. A message from up top came through. "Oop, looks like Catra's calling." She pressed the button, and was greeted by the angry voice of her commander.

"Entrapta, what's going on down there?" asked Catra. "I thought you said this was supposed to be 'a brief scientific analysis.' What do you need Emily for?"

"Ah, yes, that," Entrapta said, sheepishly observing the destruction before her. "I ran into some…resistance, who weren't exactly happy with my being here. Probably on account of…well, everything happening." The battle in the skies continued to rage, a truly massive Gem warship in the upper atmosphere overseeing the carnage.

Catra sighed. "Well, at least you're distracting some of them. Just do some damage while you're down there. And hurry back when you're done! Half of the reason we're even here is because you wanted to investigate that signal."

"Is that Entrapta?" Another voice came over the comms, that of Emerald. "Tell her to hurry it up! The longer she's down there, the more time we're wasting before–"

"She can hear you, tell her yourself!" Catra said back. "And I don't think you're one to talk about wasting time, given how we're practically at a stalemate!"

Entrapta laughed awkwardly. "Okay, you two, I'll be back before you know it! Bye!" She quickly shut off the radio, sighing in relief. "I tell you, Emily, those two get worse and worse all the time. Don't get me wrong, they're still my friends, but they can be a… bit tough to deal with sometimes." Emily gave a sympathetic beep. "Now, let's find the source of that signal so we can get back home!"

In truth, the plants and animals of Ophidia were not Entrapta's reason for coming. Rather, mere days after Etheria had emerged from Despondos, she had detected a strange transmission emerging from deep space–specifically, this very planet. Strangely, it was being broadcast at a frequency much too low for most communicators to detect, but was exactly right for her robots to receive. That, coupled with the fact that decoding it revealed a vague yet specific message–'Builders wanted'--led Entrapta to believe it was intended for her. Not literally, of course, as she didn't believe in fate, but still.

Initially, Catra had been skeptical about traveling all that way just for a simple signal. Entrapta had done her best to convince her, but it was ultimately Emerald that had persuaded the newly-crowned Empress. She told her that Ophidia was rich in resources, and would be an ideal first planet for the New Horde to conquer.

The Snakekin had retreated at this point, giving Entrapta enough space to locate the source of the signal. The broadcast led her to a beach, its sand black in color. "Well, this should be the place. Now to see where whoever or whatever was searching for us is hiding. Hmm… Aha!" A cave had been carved into a nearby cliff face, with far too much precision to be natural. Emily stomped over and tried to enter, but soon found she was too big. "Uh-oh. Looks like I'll be going alone this time." Emily beeped sadly as Entrapta stepped out. "Don't worry, I'll be careful! I brought protection!"

Entrapta crept into the cave, holding onto a flashlight and a stun baton. It proceeded much deeper than it had seemed from outside, and she was likely underground before long. She took care not to slip, as the floor and walls were damp with seawater.

"I've located the likely source of the transmission–well, the *location* of the source, anyway," she said into her recorder. "The chance of this being a trap or a trick feels higher than it did on the ship…but still unlikely. After all, there are easier ways to obtain a 'builder' that don't involve luring them with a nearly-imperceptible coded message. Like kidnapping!" She paused for a moment. "Er, anyway, I will now continue on."

Before long, she came across signs that the cave was inhabited: specifically, metal girders holding the cave up. Seeing this as a good sign, she continued on, and soon the cave became entirely metal. Now in more of a hallway than anything, she reached a large door at the end.

"I have reached the inner sanctum of whoever sent the signal!" she announced. "Now, all that stands between me and a fellow mind of science is this giant, impenetrable gateway. It may take

hours to decode what is undoubtedly a highly complex entry code, but I will diligently persevere until–oh, wait, nevermind, it just opened." Seemingly reacting to her very presence, the door slowly began to lift up, creaking and groaning like it hadn't done so in a long time.

But the awakening of this ancient structure had awoken something else as well. Entrapta turned around as her joyful anticipation was interrupted by a chittering sound coming from above. Immediately suspecting the worst, she shone her flashlight at the ceiling, where she caught the briefest glimpse of a blue carapace. The spindly creature dropped to the floor and rushed towards her, at which point she hurried through the still-opening door.

"It seems the locals haven't grown any more fond of me!" she said, finding herself within some kind of laboratory. She skidded to a halt when she reached the opposite wall, the room being smaller than expected. The creature, whatever it was, continued after her, only for an unfamiliar voice to call out.

"Don't worry! He's not dangerous!" said the metallic voice, from somewhere off to Entrapta's right. Sure enough, the creature, although it was hideous and grotesque, didn't seem to mean her any harm. "He just gets excited when he meets new people, is all." It stopped once it got close to her, examining her with its building eyes. It was certainly unnerving, but didn't seem angry.

Then there was the matter of her host. She looked to see him hidden in the shadows, but could tell that he was a strange creature as well. "Um…hi there," she said, unsure if the talking creature was self-conscious about his appearance, or just generally shy. "Were you the one who sent out that coded signal?"

He stepped out of the shadows, revealing his appearance: orange skin with a lot of tentacles, plus a device around his neck that allowed him to talk. "Indeed, indeed!" he said. "My name is Modulok, scientist by trade. I assume you're the one who deciphered it, then? My apologies for making it so complex, I had

to be sure it didn't give away my location to the Gems, or this new Horde that's been everywhere."

Entrapta decided that mentioning her allegiances to the same Horde would be unwise. "Oh, no trouble at all! Actually, it wasn't very hard, I use the same sort of frequencies in my robots. Just a simple matter of recalibrating their receivers was all!"

"My, then, you must be quite the prodigy if that's the case!" he said, sounding very impressed. "And an expert in machinery, no less! You, young lady, are just the help I need! Might I ask your name?"

"Um, Entrapta," she replied. "What are–"

He gasped. "No! Entrapta!? As in, the princess of Dryl? Oh, of all the geniuses my message could have reached, who should it be but my idol!" He began circling her. "You are truly legendary! Why, it was you who inspired me to become a scientist to begin with! Why, this is just perfect!"

Though still a little confused, Entrapta was nonetheless touched by his sentiment. "O-oh, I-I guess I'm…somewhat proficient," she said. "But, could I ask, how exactly have you heard of me? Until a few weeks ago, Etheria was stuck in another dimension."

"My dear, I am *from* Etheria!" Modulok said. "I hail from a small town near Salineas. It's quite obscure, I doubt it even appears on any map. Things were…difficult down there due to the Horde. As soon as the stars returned, I relocated to the furthest planet I could reach, only to find myself under threat from them once more!" Another pang of guilt hit Entrapta. "I truly must thank you. I've dabbled in electronics before, but I've never been able to join the Etherian Makers Guild due to…well, obvious reasons." He gestured towards his face. "But now that you're here, I'll be able to meet my timetable no problem!"

"Um, right, about that…" Entrapta shot a glance at the door. "Not that I don't want to help you, Mr. Modulok, it's just that I have

some friends waiting for me. If you give me a way to keep in touch, I'm sure I can come back later. Now just isn't a good time, that's all…"

Modulok nodded with understanding, though his expression was still of disappointment. "Yes, yes, your friends. It's best to stick with them; loyalty, and all that. I'm sure they would drop everything and run to you if you were in need, as well." Entrapta looked down, beginning to reconsider. "Or, could it be that you are instead worried of the consequences if you do not attend to their whims?" He began pacing behind her, his arms clasped behind his back. "Loyalty can only truly be called such if it is of your own volition. Loyalty borne of fear is something else entirely, especially if it does not go both ways."

"I–" she stammered, unable to deny his words. "But If I *do* stay, what's to stop Catra from getting angry and coming after me?"

He pretended to think for a moment. "Ah! I have just the thing for a time like this! Double Trouble, could you come here for a moment? I have an assignment for you."

Yet another figure emerged from the shadows, this one Entrapta internally classified as 'some manner of reptilian elf or something.' "I was wondering when you were going to let me make my entrance!" said DT, strutting towards Entrapta. They took a moment to examine her. "Alright, I think I've got it down. Now, how about this?" Enveloped in shadowy energy, Double Trouble changed shape before Entrapta's eyes, becoming an exact double of her. "Hey everyone! Who's ready to do some science!?"

Entrapta was amazed. "Woah…this is incredible! It's just like looking in a mirror! A mirror that sounds just like me!" She reached out to touch her doppelganger's hair, but her hand was slapped away by the dexterous pigtails.

"Hands of the merchandise, honey," said the shapeshifter.

Chuckling, Modulok beamed with pride. “Yes, it truly is impressive what a small bit of genetic engineering can accomplish, isn’t it?” He admired his creation, running his fingers through ‘her’ hair. “Now then, Double Trouble will keep up appearances with your ‘friends’ while you help me out. They’ll be none the wiser, I can assure you: not only is the resemblance uncanny, my creation’s acting is impeccable.”

“Ready when you are, boss man!” said Double Trouble, ready to head out as the new Entrapta. Both looked at the genuine article expectantly, awaiting an answer.

It only took a moment for her to consider. “Well…I guess there’s no harm in it,” she said. “I get to help out a fellow scientist, while Catra and Emerald get *me* , technically! Alright, I’ll let Emily know, she might say something if she gets suspicious.” She typed a message into her recorder.

“Then I’m off! Don’t have *too* much fun without me!” Double Trouble-Entrapta headed out the door, leaving the two scientists alone–or as alone as they could be with Modulok’s menagerie of creations, many just out of sight.

Entrapta eagerly hopped over to her new lab partner. “So, what were you working on that so urgently needed my help?” she asked.

“Oh, it’s quite a long story,” Modulok replied. He opened up another door hidden in the wall, leading down to a further chamber. “Come–I will tell you on the way. We have much to do, and little time to do it.” Unseen to Entrapta, a sinister look crossed his face.

– – –

“Lower, lower, lower…okay, now a little to the left. No, my left, which is your right. Or, is it *your* left and *my* right?” In the courtyard of Castle Brightmoon, Bow directed Perfuma on the installation of a new addition. Peridot stood nearby, observing the

process, looking very much like she was holding back the urge to take over.

Perfuma held a large crystalline platform in her vines. “Is it north or south?” she asked. “Just tell me which direction it is!”

Bow studied the platform. “Uh, north, I think.” He looked up towards the sun, shielding his eyes. “What time is it now?”

“Nyah!” Peridot cried out in frustration, dragging the crystal into place, holding out her hands when it was where she wanted. “There! Just put it right there!”

The vines lowered the platform down into a hole, and the warp pad was ready. All three of them admired their work. “Alright, we did it!” said Bow, holding both hands up for high-fives. Perfuma eagerly obliged, while Peridot was a bit more begrudging. “That wasn’t so hard, was it?”

“Uh-huh, yeah, sure,” said Peridot, picking up a walkie-talkie. “Aaand, we’re done! It only took us three times as long as it should have… Anyway, you’re all ready to come through!”

“Okay then, see you on the other side!” came a voice from the other end. The three of them stood back, preparing for the warp pad to activate. Which it soon did, a beam of light shooting up to the sky. It soon vanished, revealing several people standing there: Connie, Lapis, Bismuth and Topaz. It was a bit cramped due to the latter two. “We made it!” said Connie.

“Great, it works!” said Bow. “Now we can travel between Earth and Etheria whenever we want! I’m sure Hessonite will be glad she doesn’t have to ferry us every time we want to visit each other now…”

The new arrivals stepped off of the warp pad, taking in their surroundings. Although years had passed since three of them had been to Etheria, it looked the same as when they had last seen it. Topaz, who had only recently joined the Crystal Gems, was

amazed at the picturesque castle. “This is…” she said, unable to find the right words. “...um, very pretty.”

“Welcome back!” said Perfuma. “It’s good to see you all again! And, for the first time, for some of you.” Topaz waved shyly. “Do you have time for sightseeing, or should we head right in?”

“Well, Glimmer did make it sound like she wanted to see us right away,” said Bismuth. “Hey, how ‘bout you take us on a tour of the new, improved Etheria once we’re done here?”

“That sounds like a plan!” said Bow. “You remember the way to the war table, right?” With him in the lead, everyone headed inside the castle.

“‘War table?’” said Lapis. “I don’t remember something like that. Seems a bit violent for you princess types.”

Perfuma looked down sadly. “Yes. I think everyone thought, and hoped, that things would be peaceful once Catra left. But Glimmer hasn’t been the same since Angella…” There was a brief silence. Even those from Earth had heard the news by now. “Now that Glimmer’s queen, she’s committed to cleaning up what’s left of Catra’s Horde on Etheria.”

“Angella…I wish we could have been here,” said Connie. “If not during the Eartheria debacle, then afterwards to pay our respects. We didn’t get to know her for long, but she was definitely a good queen. A good person.”

“She was,” Bow said sadly. “She really was. And, I know what Entrapta said about her being trapped, and not actually…dead, but, I don’t know.” He took a long, slow breath. “As much as I want to get my hopes up, I feel like it wouldn’t be fair to Glimmer. Thinking that we might be able to save her, I mean.”

Connie put a hand on his shoulder. “Anything’s possible,” she said. “If I’ve learned anything from Steven, it’s that you should always hold out hope, no matter how impossible something might seem.”

“Speaking of Steven,” said Perfuma, “did he not arrive with you all? We were hoping to see him again.”

“Oh, he and the rest of the Gems were busy with something,” said Bismuth. “Some sorta training exercise for his new sword. They’ll probably be along before too long.”

“Let’s hope so,” said Peridot. “We’ll need all the help we can get if Emerald decides to come back…”

“Y-you really think she will!?” Topaz asked worriedly.

“What, you think she’d just leave Earth and Etheria alone, after all she’s done?” she replied. “Not a chance in my book. And even if she did give up, as long as there’s a chance she’ll be back, we have to be ready!”

“I guess ‘anything’s possible’ applies to bad stuff too,” Connie observed.

They soon arrived at the planning room, where a conference was already in session. Most of the Princess Alliance was already there, though Adora was strangely absent. Other new attendees included Hordak, Lars, Hessonite, and Yellow Diamond (by way of hologram). And at the front of the table stood Glimmer, now Queen of Brightmoon. Even at a glance, Connie and the others could tell that she was no longer the happy-go-lucky princess they had known. She was a queen now, with all the regality and dignity that implied.

“Now that the Fright Zone is back under your control, the Crimson Waste has become a hotbed for New Horde activity,” she said. “Instead of scouring the entire desert, we’ll need to locate where they’re operating out of. Have your scouts search for old raider hideouts, oases, anywhere they could afford to hunker down. Your new lieutenants are familiar with the area; have them lead the charge.”

“Oh, right, I forgot we teamed up with Hordak…” Connie said quietly.

Hordak didn't seem thrilled with that plan. "My resources are stretched thin enough as it is," he said. "Although Catra's loyalists are fewer in number, this has necessitated their use of much more conservative tactics. As such, their attacks are much harder to predict. Taking the Fright Zone was one matter, protecting it from guerilla attacks is another entirely. Perhaps the pink one can observe their activity from the skies."

"And how am I supposed to do that without my ship?" retorted Lars. "In case you forgot, Emerald blew up the *Sun Incinerator* ! Maybe you have one I could borrow?"

"Would you like to use the *Crystallon* ?" offered Hessonite. "It may be a bit too large for recon, but better a large ship than none at all." Although holographic, Yellow Diamond was tapping her finger on the table, growing steadily more irritated with this process.

Bow approached the table. "Glimmer, look who's here!" All the others stepped forward too, happy to see their old friends. The new queen, however, wasn't as happy as she would have been.

"Good, you're here," she said, her attitude completely formal. "Now we can really begin. Come and sit down–I think there's enough for all of you. We were just deciding on our next move against Catra's Horde. As I said, they've positioned themselves in the Crimson Waste, so we need an effective strategy to go after them."

There were almost enough seats. Bismuth and Peridot had to share one, leaving Topaz as the only one standing. Yellow Diamond decided to give her hers. "As informative and effective as this meeting has been, the bulk of the New Horde is going after Gem colonies," she said. "I need to focus on keeping the stability for now. Contact me if you need me, though I doubt I'll be much help." Her hologram disappeared, leaving an empty chair behind. Topaz examined it for a moment, before hesitantly sitting down.

"Um…it's good to see you all," said Connie. "Glimmer, Frosta, Mermista…you two…" Spinnerella waved, and though Netossa

looked annoyed, she did the same. “How’ve you been?”

“Well, not terrible,” said Mermista. “Things have been easier since Catra and her people left, but not like *easy* easy. She still has a bunch of minions or whatever causing problems. We aren’t really sure how many there are.”

“Too many,” said Frosta.

“Nevertheless, we have been doing our part to help the people of Etheria finally achieve peace,” said Hessonite. “With any luck, it will only be a matter of time until it is able to join the galactic community! Why, they already have such great relations with Homeworld and Earth! Or…parts of them.”

“And in order to achieve peace, we need to wipe out what’s left of the Horde once and for all,” added Glimmer. “...Where’s Steven? I was hoping his new powers could help us out with that.”

“Training,” Bow, Connie, Bismuth, Lapis, and Peridot said in unison.

“And speaking of swords,” Connie asked, “is Adora here? This doesn’t seem like the kind of meeting she’d miss. I was hoping to see her again.”

A brief look of annoyance crossed Glimmer’s face. “She has a mission of her own she’s been focused on. And as much as I wish she’d be more involved in *our* mission, it’s important to her.” She walked away from the table, summoning a staff into her hand. “We can set out once she and Steven get here.”

“Wait, set out?” asked Bismuth. “Set out where? Where exactly are we goin’? On a mission or something?”

“Yup! Glimmer’s got a plan to take down Catra and Emerald once and for all!” said Frosta excitedly. “Whatever it is, you can bet it’s gonna be awesome!”

– – –

Dust flew up everywhere as the two combatants traded blows, the sounds of the battle echoing through the forest. One of these two was Jasper, fighting with the fury expected of the ultimate Quartz. The other was a towering mountain of a man, who, were it not for the pink gemstone on his stomach, was almost unrecognizable as Steven. In addition to his size, he wore silver barbarian armor, had pitch black hair tied in dreadlocks and a massive beard, and wielded a glowing sword. Although he was clearly powerful in this new form, he couldn't match Jasper's ferocity.

"Slow down a little!" he said, blocking her punches with his sword, though only barely. "I can't exactly learn to fight if you don't give me an opportunity to!"

"Then make your *own* opportunity!" Jasper said, maintaining her assault. "Do you really think your enemy's just going to stand still and let you hit them? No!" She got past Steven's guard with a feint, delivering a punch to his back that sent him staggering forward. "Be more aggressive! You can't afford to just hang back and let your caretakers do all the fighting for you, this is war!"

Steven tried to follow her advice, swinging his sword as hard as he could. Jasper simply summoned her helmet, which the blade simply glanced off of. She then followed up with a blow that threw him against the pile of boulders that served as her house.

Down on his knees, she now loomed over him. "The only difference between me and them is that *they* won't let you get back up." She reached out a hand, helping him to his feet. "Again!"

He tried to lift up his sword, but was unable to, collapsing to his knees. In a flash of light, he reverted back to his original form. He sighed in frustration, sitting down next to the blade. "This isn't working. I need to…ugh. Can I take five?"

Jasper considered this. "Fine. But five minutes means five minutes, no more. Your real enemies won't give you the luxury of taking a break." She leaned against the rocks as Steven dragged

his sword over to a nearby bench, taking a long drink from a water bottle.

"Good work, Steven! I could see some definite improvement that time!" Also sitting on the bench were Garnet, Amethyst, and Pearl, watching Steven's training. "You've really come a long way since you first held that sword!"

Although he acknowledged Pearl's attempts to make him feel better, Steven knew they were just that. "I was a lot better back when I was fighting on Etheria…" he said. "I wonder what happened? Back there, I was a beast, but now, I'm…not."

"Perfectly understandable," said Garnet. "It is much easier to fight when your life, and the lives of your friends, are in danger. The reverse is also true: we often unconsciously hold back to avoid hurting those we consider our friends."

"Or, y'know, our not-enemies," added Amethyst. "Speakin' of, why did ya agree to help train Steven?" she asked Jasper. "You've basically been a grumpy hermit for these past two years. What exactly changed?"

"Emerald changed," Jasper replied. "While I don't *like* being a teacher, I like the idea of living under that egotist even less." She nodded towards the Sword of Power. "And with that, Steven's probably our best bet of making sure that doesn't happen."

Mentally preparing himself for another round, Steven stretched out his sore muscles–which was all of them. "Don't forget about Adora," he reminded her. "I'm not the only one with a giant sword!"

"Just because you bring her up at every given opportunity doesn't mean I know who she is," Jasper said. "I'll judge for myself if she's really as strong as you say."

"She is," Garnet interjected.

"Quiet, you!" Growing impatient, Jasper began to pace. "I don't care about any of that. I'm not here to train Adora, or Connie, of any of your other human friends. Steven's the only one worth my time–and if he hadn't come directly from Pink Diamond, you wouldn't have me being *nearly* this nice."

"Huh. Y'know, I think we have a pretty different idea of what nice means," Amethyst joked. The other Quartz didn't respond aside from a gruff grunt.

Once he was ready, Steven picked up his sword. "Alright, let's get this over with," he said. He moved back into place in the makeshift arena, and Jasper did the same, standing opposite him. She re-summoned her helmet, unable to hide her grin underneath it.

Pearl took this moment to stand up, walking over to him. "Steven, are you sure this is the best idea? I can understand wanting to train more, but you really shouldn't be pushing yourself this hard." She looked up suspiciously at his coach. "Plus, I'm beginning to think Jasper isn't the best teacher…"

"Thanks Pearl, but she's right–this really is something I have to do. Ever since that thing with Spinel…well, look." He tried to summon his shield, but got only a few flickers of light coming from his gem. "I still haven't figured out how to make my powers work. We know Emerald's coming back, so I have to be ready. So I can fight."

Although clearly disagreeing, Pearl nevertheless let him continue. "Very well. But remember not to hurt yourself, okay? Magic sword or not, you're still human." She went to sit back down, still watching him intently.

Jasper scoffed. "Are we gonna talk all day, or were you planning on fighting me sometime soon?" She pounded a fist into her palm, clearly enjoying the action.

Taking a deep breath, Steven lifted his sword to the heavens. “By the Power of Grayskull!”

# All the Lost Things

Chapter Summary

> Adora ponders on Light Hope's parting words. Meanwhile, Scorpia tries to survive on Beast Island, and discovers something about herself.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

## Chapter Two: All the Lost Things

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Three-seven-eight. Four-nine-two. Five-five-three.

These last few weeks hadn't been as perilous or world-threatening as so much of the previous years had been, but they were still quite hectic. Between the New Horde's departure and Glimmer's ascension to the throne, Adora had been left with little time to ponder these enigmatic words given to her by Light Hope. In her free time, she had tried to ponder its meaning, if any, but came up with nothing each time.

Rather than repeat the numbers endlessly to remember them, Adora had taken to changing the Sword of Protection's form into a bracelet that bore them as an engraving. Lying on her bed, she stared at her wrist. "Come on, why can't my brain just make this work!?" she complained, going limp in frustration. "Light Hope's counting on me! Angella's counting on me. Everyone's counting on me…"

Sighing, she pulled herself to her feet, approaching a nearby mirror. While she had pondered on her origins from time to time, Light Hope's words had really brought out the curiosity in her. "Who *am* I?" she wondered, examining her features intently. She had to have come from somewhere before she arrived on Etheria.

Steven had told her she looked a lot like this Prince Adam guy–maybe she really was a descendent of some sort? This would mean not only that she was a First One–or Eternian, rather–but that some of them had survived.

Her attention was drawn away when there was a knock at her door. "Adora?" Bow opened it a crack, peering inside. "We're almost ready to head out. Is everything going okay in here?"

She shrugged. "Eh. Kinda. Nothing's wrong, if that's what you're asking." Bow opened the door further, walking in. "Sorry I missed the briefing."

"It wasn't anything important," he assured her. "Just some more disagreement, as usual. I'm sure Connie and the others would be glad to see you!"

"Yeah. I wanna see them again too, it's just…" She stared blankly at the wall. "With everything that's happened lately, it feels like… nothing's the same anymore, you know? Everything's changed, even more than it had before. We took on an evil undead wizard and an army of killer robots, why does…why does this time feel so much harder?"

Bow nodded in understanding. "It's Angella, isn't it? It's been hard on all of us. I know Glimmer's taken it the hardest of all, but Angella was like a mother to me, and I know she was to you too. We're all going through similar stuff, so don't feel like you have to pull away." After a moment of hesitation, he pulled her in for a hug. "You can talk to us. We're the Best Friend Squad, and we always will be."

Touched by Bow's words, Adora returned his hug. "Thanks, Bow. But…yeah, I miss her, but that's only part of it."

"Catra?" he guessed.

"Catra," she confirmed. "I…I just can't believe she'd do something like this. Trying to destroy the world just to get at me. I-I want to put all the blame on Emerald, and say she's the reason why she

did that, but I know it's not that simple." She cast a pained look towards her friend. "This part of her, it's always been there, Bow. Part of me can't help but think, is it my fault for not seeing it?"

"No, Adora, don't think like that," Bow said gently. "Catra's more than capable of making her own decisions, good or bad. Mostly bad. And I know you want to help her, but you can't help someone who doesn't *want* to be helped. The most we can do is stop her before she does any more damage. Once the New Horde is defeated, then we can try and reform her."

Adora smiled, despite herself. "Thanks, Bow. I just hope Glimmer can see it that way."

The two of them stood up, heading for the door. "She'll come around," he assured her. "Now come on, We're all set to head out as soon as Steven shows up!"

Adora glanced down at her wrist once more as they descended the staircase. *Three-seven-eight. Four-nine-two. Five-five-three* . The meaning of these numbers would have to wait, as she had to put all of her focus into fighting the Horde. She owed that much to Glimmer.

Soon enough they had reached the courtyard where the new warp pad had only just been installed. All the princesses waited there, as well as Hordak, and the Crystal Gem B-team. "Hey, we were just talkin' about you," said Mermista. "Good things, of course."

Glimmer stepped forward, holding her staff. "Are you sure you're up for this, Adora?" Her tone was an odd mixture of accusation and concern. "You've seemed distracted for the past few weeks. I don't want you putting yourself at risk unless–"

"No, no, it's fine, just thinking about those numbers Light Hope gave me," she said. Glimmer raised an eyebrow. "Don't worry, I'll put it aside for the mission! Trust me, the only thing on my mind for the next few hours will be putting a stop to whatever plan the remaining Horde is up to."

This seemed to satisfy Glimmer, who, though still suspicious, turned back towards the warp pad. “At least with Steven’s new powers, whatever Catra left behind shouldn’t be that much to worry about.”

“Indeed. I just hope she left enough for me to rebuild that which I lost.” Adora thought she could see a brief look of sadness or regret in Hordak’s eyes, but it was probably just a trick of the light.

That was when a pillar of light shot up from the warp pad, revealing the form of Steven and the Crystal Gems. Looking the same as he had the last time they met, only this time with a large sword slung over his shoulder, Steven gave a cheery wave. “Hello Etheria!” he said. “Nice to see everyone again! Your majesty.” He gave a slight Bow to Queen Glimmer, who at least seemed to appreciate the gesture.

“Long time no see!” said Bow. “Well, not *that* long. What have you been up to all this time?”

“Training,” replied Steven, drawing his sword and twirling it about. “It’s no shield, but I’m starting to get the hang of it. So, what’s been happening here?”

“Glimmer’s coronation, as you noticed,” Bow said. “It was pretty cool–she fought a giant snake!”

“I did fight a giant snake,” said Glimmer, giving a little smile. “Now then, are we ready to go? Our scouts have a location on a Horde holdout, but we don’t know how long they’ll stay there. I’d like to get there before sundown, just in case.”

“Um, how exactly are you planning on getting us all there?” asked Amethyst. “Didn’t Lars crash his ship or something?”

“Follow me.” Glimmer led the procession of princesses and Gems over to the bridge overlooking the waterfall behind the castle. “It wasn’t easy getting a hold of these, so whoever’s driving, please be careful.”

During their walk, Connie made her way over to Steven. "So, how's Jasper treating you?" she asked. It wasn't so much a question, as much as it was wondering if he was alright.

He shrugged. "Eh, like Jasper. She's never been the type to do anything with a gentle hand. Honestly, I'm surprised she agreed to train me at all. I'd like her to be a bit more positive, but hey, I can't argue with the results!"

"You realize she's probably trying to turn you into another version of herself," Connie said. "All violent and angry like that."

Steven nodded. "I know. Garnet was *very* adamant I understood that before I even started talking to her. But right now, I think it's best if we remember that the Horde are the bad guys now, not Homeworld. Jasper's…intense, but I don't think she'd throw her lot in with them, right?"

This was, admittedly, a question Connie didn't feel qualified to answer. "Um, just be careful, okay? She hasn't really apologized or tried to make up for anything she did, so I wouldn't put anything past her."

It wasn't long before they reached their destination. On the other side of the mountain, they saw the means with which they would be traveling to their destination: a handful of Horde skiffs were parked near some stables, with none other than Swift Wind standing guard. "Hey, about time you got here!" he greeted. "I take it we're ready to go?"

"We are," said Glimmer. She turned around to face the others. "So, who's driving?"

– – –

Heavy footsteps created prints in the sand, which were soon washed away by the surf. Only for their owner to return, repeating the process the other way. Back and forth this went, a distressed Scorpia pacing back and forth on the beach. And the reason for

her distress was quite obvious: she had just woken up on Beast Island.

"Okay, this is alright," she assured herself. "So, Catra basically had you shipped off to Beast Island, so what? Emerald was in her head, she wasn't thinking clearly. Any day now, she'll send someone to pick me up. Why wouldn't she? I'm her bestie! We're the Super Pal Trio!" Her optimism quickly faded, as she gave a worried moan. "I wonder how Entrapta's doing with them. Hopefully Emerald's not putting any ideas in her head either…"

Adding to Scorpia's trepidation, and the reason she had stayed on the beach, there was no shortage of menacing noises emerging from the jungle beyond. Reasoning that they called it 'Beast' Island for a reason, she was in no hurry to venture inland. Though her plan to stay put wouldn't last long, as she was growing hungrier by the minute.

Her stomach growling, Scorpia anxiously peered into the trees. "Okay, just gotta grab something to eat real quick, then it's back to waiting for help to arrive." She crept into the jungle, eyes open for any potential predators that might be lurking in the shadows. The very same shadows that, unbeknownst to her, seemed to be pulled towards her as she trudged through the underbrush.

Not that individual shadows could be seen for much longer, as underneath the trees it was essentially nighttime. Worse still, despite the abundance of screeching and chittering in the distance, the jungle seemed to be completely devoid of animal life. Nothing crawled through the bushes, no birds flew overhead, not even any insects buzzed by. The effect was very much similar to a nightmare, with everything seeming normal superficially, but something being demonstrably off.

The lack of any monsters was somehow scarier than any actual monsters, though Scorpia hoped it would remain as it was. "Hmm…no fruit, no berries, not even any meat," she said, scanning her dark surroundings. "I might have to resort to eating bark…can't be any worse than anything in the Fright Zone

cafeteria…" She experimentally scraped off a strip from a nearby tree, giving it a sniff before tossing it aside. "Nah, 's probably poisonous."

Onward she walked, heading deeper and deeper into the forest. The more distressed she became, the darker it seemed to become. Not helping matters was that all the creature sounds in the distance seemed to silence all at once. Now deathly quiet, she seemed more alone than ever.

"Ah, Beast Island, the perfect tourist destination!" she said nervously, hiding behind a tree from whatever might be lurking in the green beyond. She crouched down to make herself as small as possible, a difficult feat for her. "Come stay at one of our famous five-star monster-infested caves, and enjoy being ripped to pieces by–What was that!?"

Scorpia suddenly froze when she heard the telltale footfalls of something a good deal larger than her. The echoing stomps were accompanied by another sound, a low, chattering hum that seemed almost constant. Based on the shuffling of plant matter, it seemed to be looking for something–likely her.

Luckily, she had a good hiding spot–well, a passable one, in any case. She scrunched herself up even further, wrapping her tail around herself and holding it close to her chest. She held her breath, hoping that her heartbeat wouldn't be enough to tip off the unseen giant.

Minutes that seemed like hours went by, the creature seemingly certain that something had been here. After a few more agonizing moments, its footsteps turned away, retreating from the area until they ceased. Scorpia let out a long sigh of relief. "Man, am I glad that's over."

It wasn't. The silence split apart, as did the tree she had taken shelter behind, torn clean in half by a pair of enormous scythes. Their owner, a titanic insect-like beast, roared in fury. Its maw split open into four parts, each lined with more teeth than most

creatures had in their entire mouth. Instinct took over as Scorpia sprang to her feet, clawing her way through the dense jungle.

The giant bug wasn't intent on letting its next mean escape. Using its sharp pointed legs, it hauled itself up to the top of the trees, pulling itself after her. She looked over her shoulder as she ran: the dark shape was growing closer, the occasional breach of sunlight glinting off its cobalt carapace as it bore down on her. Even with the shadows obscuring it, she could still make out its beady black eyes, glaring at her hungrily.

Scorpia wasn't the fastest runner on the best of days, and all this underbrush slowed her down considerably. It was only due to adrenaline that she was able to get as far as she did, tearing through the plants with her claws as she sprinted away from danger.

While not fast, the monster could haul itself pretty well, especially without worrying about obstacles. Once close to its prey, it dove down blades-first, with Scorpia only barely leaping to the side in time. The attack left her with only a small scratch in her armor, but that was enough to show her that her carapace would do little good to keep her safe against this thing. Her eyes darted to try and find safety, finding the next best thing in a hollowed-out fallen tree. It wasn't ideal, but then again, nothing about her situation was. She was barely able to squeeze inside, the insect reaching its blades inside to try and reach her.

"Why did this have to happen to *me* !?" Scorpia wailed, sure her end was near. "Not that I'd want it to happen to anybody else, but why did *I* deserve this!? I was nothing but supportive to Catra, I tried to be friends with Entrapta, I wanted to see the best in everyone…and this is where it got me…" The insect tore its way through the rotting wood, with seconds left before it reached her. She didn't see the point in trying to get away. Even if she could think of something, where would she go from there? No help was coming. If it wasn't this beast that ate her, it would be the next.

A strange feeling filled Scorpia as the monstrosity bore down on her. Despair, for one, but a sense of finality as well, as though she wasn't afraid of dying. But then, slowly but surely, it was replaced with anger. Anger at this giant bug for giving her such a lackluster end. Anger at Catra and Entrapta for just leaving her here. Anger at Emerald, and Hordak, and anyone else she could think of. And then…

And then her long-dormant connection with the Black Garnet was awakened.

Scorpia was not a sorcerer. She was a warrior of the body, not of the mind. Even with the power of a runestone surging through her, she wouldn't know what to do with it. So, as her eyes glowed red, and shadows from all around flowed into her form, it was her body that began to change.

The monster stepped back as its prey began to morph as she grew larger. The only parts of her that stayed the same were her claws and tail, both increasing in size as well. When the blackness that covered her body faded, her red exoskeleton had spread across her entire form. Her mandibles spread in a furious screech as the giant scorpion faced down its foe.

This display only gave the monstrous bug momentary pause, as it let out a screech of its own before raising its blades, preparing to face down the equally-giant arachnid. Scorpia, or the beast she had become, lunged, grabbing hold of her enemy with her claws. It speared her with the blades, which now had some trouble cutting through her shell. She lifted it over her head, slamming it down on the ground. But it still kept trying to slice her open.

Holding it in place, she speared her stinger into its underside, again and again, not simply content to let her venom do the job. But still it persisted, knocking her tail aside after one last stab, sending its bladed forelegs towards her eyes. She blocked with a claw, reaching out with the other one and grabbing tightly to its arm. With one quick movement, the limb was torn off completely.

The bug staggered back, but did not retreat even after losing one of its weapons. It simply charged forward, likely to its detriment, as Scorpia was not simply a mindless beast in this form. She still had her thinking mind, and now she had a new weapon. She charged as well, using one claw to deflect its remaining blade, while the other held tight to the severed one.

With enough force to smash through sheet metal, Scorpia drove the blade into its former owner's side. Stunned from the impact, this gave her the opportunity to drive it in deeper, as well as grab hold of it with her claws. Stabbing it with her stinger for good measure, she gave one final twist, and completely bisected the monster. Both halves of the beast fell to the ground as she panted, letting out a final screech of victory before falling to the ground herself.

The shadows returned, enveloping Scorpia's body as she returned to normal size. She stood up shakily, reeling from the amount of magic that had entered and exited her form so suddenly. "W-what?" she mumbled, looking up at the insect's broken body. It was hard to tell if it was a robot or just a big bug, seemingly made either partly or mostly, maybe even entirely of First Ones tech. "Did I…do that?" she asked herself.

She looked down at her claws, still not entirely sure what had happened. The sensation itself was entirely alien, but the energy that did it, that felt familiar. She then felt a much more familiar sensation: the rumbling of her stomach.

"Ooh. Not out of the woods yet," she said, looking around. "Literally." She examined the insect-thing's remains, wondering if eating it would be more like eating a bug or eating a robot. Neither would be pleasant, but she reasoned to leave it alone in case it turned out to be the latter. "Alright, gotta be some berries around here somewhere…" She staggered further into the woods, where the distant bestial sounds had resumed. She had survived one encounter…but who could say what–or who–else she would meet on Beast Island?

Chapter End Notes

Hey all! I've been anticipating this chapter for a while now, as Scorpia's arc on Beast Island is one I'm pretty happy with. Some of you might be wondering why she turns into a giant scorpion with her Black Garnet magic: well, there's two reasons for that. First of all, this was planned out before it was revealed the Black Garnet gave her electric powers, so I reasoned it had shadow powers, fitting both the name, as well as how Shadow Weaver used it. The second is that I thought transformation fit her better than actual magical powers, being more physical in nature. Plus, it's also kind of a nod to how it was Catra who turned into an animal version of herself in the original series! Anyway, hope you're enjoying this so far, and there's more to come soon!

# A Minor Shift

Chapter Summary

Plans change for the Horde.

Chapter Three: A Minor Shift

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Three days. The New Horde had laid siege to Ophidia for three days, and had made no progress in capturing the planet. Catra seethed as she looked over their war map, embarrassed that such a backwater planet was able to resist them so well. None of the other planets they reached had done so–but then, those were left over from the days of Horde Prime's empire. Many of them, realizing the Horde had returned, were more than happy to join in Catra's crusade of conquest. But not the Snakekin.

"Has that scientist of yours returned yet?" asked Emerald, strangely far less concerned about how long the battle had raged for. "Cybertroop battalion 13 isn't responding, I want her to give them a looking-over."

Frustrated, Catra looked over at her. "You've got scientists of your own," she said. "Why can't you just get one of your Peridots or whatever to have a look? Why does it always have to be Entrapta?"

Emerald shrugged. "I trust her more with them. She's the one who made them, after all." This wasn't entirely true, but Entrapta was the one responsible for commandeering the Cybertroops and other such machines for New Horde use. "Besides, the vast majority of my Peridots are from Era-2. They wouldn't know a mainframe from a motherboard," she said bitterly.

"Whatever. Anything that'll finish this fight and get us out of here works with me," Catra said, sulking over to a nearby window.

"What's the point of this giant ship if one stupid planet's not gonna go down?"

"The *Supermassive* is among the most powerful Gem dreadnoughts ever designed," Emerald said, her eyes narrowing. "I can't be blamed if it is not used properly."

Interrupting this tension-filled moment, Entrapta walked through the doors. "Hello, I'm back!" she said, chipper as ever. "I got some soil samples! Anyone want to hear all about them?"

"Oh, good, the prodigy of Dryl is back," said Emerald, rolling her eyes. "I don't suppose you made any *useful* discoveries on that expedition of yours?"

"Useful for scientific applications? Most definitely!" she answered. "Useful for this battle? Not so much…" She sat down at the table in the room's center, looking over a datapad filled with her findings. "Did you know the Snakekin actually have more in common biologically with lizards?"

Catra groaned as she laid her head against the glass. "I blame you for this!" she said, pointing at Emerald. "You of all people should've known this planet would be a disaster to conquer! You were in charge of, like, seven galaxies for millions of years, and you chose this place!?"

"First of all, I wasn't in charge–that was the Diamonds," Emerald said. "Which is exactly what I aim to fix with this New Horde. And second, I chose this planet because it was relatively defenseless! As I said before, I can't be blamed for the incompetence of certain other members of this organization!"

" *Your* ship, *your* units, *your* guidance–do I really need to say more?" asked Catra.

"Why, yes, how about *your* leadership?" Emerald retorted.

Entrapta raised a hand, once again halting their arguing. "I know! What if we found some powerful First Ones artifact to give us an

edge? We could send someone back to Etheria to go get one!"

Emerald and Catra glanced at each other. "Did…did you have a specific one in mind?" said the latter.

"No, but I could check my files for anything." She looked through the datapad. "Let's see… We already did the staff, this one didn't work, this one isn't real…Aha! Here it is, the Heart of Etheria!"

"And, what does this 'Heart of Etheria' do?" asked Emerald.

"No idea!" said Entrapta. There was a short, unimpressed silence. "Okay, that's not entirely true. I may not know where it is, *what* it is, what exactly it's supposed to *do* , but apparently, it's super powerful! I've only found a few mentions of it, but they're all talking about it like it's incredibly dangerous, only used as a last resort. Sounds useful, yeah?"

They had to admit, it did sound useful to have the Heart of Etheria with them. Catra brought up the major snag: "How exactly are we supposed to get it if you know nothing about it?"

"Easy: based on the mentions of it in ancient First Ones writing, I've mapped out several possible locations where it could be!" She showed them a map of Etheria, with a number of highlighted areas. "We can just send out a group or two to check 'em out and report in on what they find!"

As Catra examined the map, Emerald placed a hand on her shoulder. "Catra–er, excuse me, *Empress* Catra, may I speak with you a moment?" She pulled her aside. "Surely you can't be considering this! We have better things to be doing now than going off on a wild goose chase for some mythical trinket!"

"Right, because we're so busy losing to a single planet full of lizards!" said Catra, pushing her away. "Look: Entrapta's a lot of things, but one of those things is reliable. Watch." She walked back over to her. "And you're sure about this? You're absolutely certain that this Heart of Etheria thing can help us?"

"Of course!" Entrapta said. "I'm willing to stake my entire reputation on it! If there's something to find, you'll find it here!"

"Good." Catra turned to Emerald. "Put together a team: I'm leaving in twenty minutes." She then headed for the door, having made up her mind.

Emerald was not prepared for her sudden departure. "W-what!? Just like that, you intend to abandon your conquest!?"

"Who said anything about abandoning it?" she replied. "You're still here, aren't you? Just keep these stupid snakes busy while I'm gone, and when I get back with the Heart of Etheria–and I will–we'll show them who's boss. Do you think you can manage that?"

"Of course!" said Emerald, not about to let her pride be slighted. "Hurry after that Heart of yours, though–I can't promise this resistance won't be crushed beneath my heel by the time you return!"

"I'm sure it will be," Catra muttered. "Just keep an eye on her until I get back, alright?" she said to Entrapta.

The purple-haired scientist saluted. "Can do, Empress Catra!" She then went back to her datapad. Soon, she was alone in the room, both of the others having gone to prepare for the mission to Etheria. Unseen, her eyes flickered red for the briefest of moments, 'her' smile becoming a smirk for just as long.

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Despite having been living out in the Crimson Wastes for a few weeks now, a place where one must be hardened by the sand if they wish to survive, not much had changed for Kyle. Despite his new tattered attire and *very* slight tan, his muscles remained about the same, as he struggled to lift a large crate into a cart. Rogelio eventually helped him out.

"Thanks," he said, wiping his face clean of sweat. The large lizard patted him on the back as he went to pick up more crates. "What

exactly are we doing here, again?"

Lonnie was doing her part to load up the cart as well. "You heard the man. We pack up before the princesses arrive, find somewhere else to hunker down, and prepare for when Catra gets back. Simple?" Another cart was full: a few more Horde troopers climbed into it, as a local Crimson Waster drove the beasts pulling it down the road.

"But…are we really sure she's coming back?" asked Kyle. "You saw how quickly she left when she got the chance. Ever since those Gems showed up–no, even *before* that, Catra's been acting strange.

A snarl from Rogelio.

"Rogelio's right," said Lonnie. "That wasn't strange; that's just how Catra is. She's wanted to lead the Horde since we were all little, and now that she can rule not just Etheria, but all those other planets? Of course she'd jump at the opportunity."

Taking a break from loading, Rogelio offered another hiss.

Kyle shook his head. "I don't either."

Resisting the urge to glare at them, Lonnie sighed. "Of course she's coming back. Etheria's her home, no matter how much she hates it. Even with all those other worlds, I don't have any doubt she wants to see it conquered herself. She'll be back. I don't know how long she'll take…but she will be back."

The three heard their commander approaching before they saw him, tipped off by his unmistakable footsteps that all but shook the ground. They looked up to see the towering stony figure looming over them; "You've stopped loading," Callix said grimly.

"Force Captain Callix!" Kyle exclaimed nervously. "We were just, ah, taking a break! Y'know, to avoid heat stroke and all that!"

When Callix didn't answer, Lonnie spoke up. "Can you blame us? We've been doing the same thing for weeks: traveling from camp to camp in the sweltering heat with no end goal in mind, no response from the boss, and nothing to show for it! A few minutes of cooling off after all that is more than warranted."

Kyle flinched as he expected Callix to yell, but he only grunted, walking away. "Don't take too long," he said. "We need to be out of here by nightfall." They stared as he left, clearly unused to his demeanor.

Callix roamed through the settlement, observing the progress his troopers were making in packing up. His path soon took him into the shade of a building, where a large, tentacled woman sat, pouring water over herself. Though many Horde members weren't used to the desert heat, she seemed to be taking it particularly poorly.

"And how are you holding up?" Callix asked, seating himself beside her.

She shot him an annoyed glance, albeit one accompanied with a smirk. "It's hotter than the boiler room of a Horde steamship out here, and I have to splash myself every few minutes to avoid drying out. How do you *think* I'm holding up?"

All Callix said to this was "Mmm." He leaned back, observing the soldiers busy at work. "I overheard some of the troops discussing Catra just now. They're beginning to wonder if she's abandoned us."

"Wouldn't put it past her," Octavia said. She pointed to her left eye, which was hidden under a patch. "Y'know, she's the one who did this to me. I'd respect her a lot more for it if she ever followed up on her threats."

"So, you believe she has abandoned us?" asked Callix.

She shrugged. "Right now, I can't say anything more than 'probably.' I definitely *think* she did, but who knows? She's

surprised me before…in both good and bad ways."

"If that really is the case," Callix added, "perhaps we were mistaken to follow her rather than Hordak."

Octavia scoffed. "No, that's one part of this arrangement I don't regret." She got to her feet. "Who knows where he's gone to now, but if I ever see Hordak again, nothin's gonna stop me from pounding his face in! Great, now I want a fight!" She began pacing anxiously.

Getting up as well, Callix tried to rein her in. "Calm yourself. There will be plenty of fighting once we are able to regroup, but for now, we must leave this place before the princesses–"

"The princesses are here!" called a lookout. Callix, Octavia, and many others turned in the direction of the shout, seeing the tell-tale dust of skiffs approaching in the distance. But what really tipped them off that it was the Princess Alliance was the shape in the air above them, no doubt that of She-Ra's flying horse.

"How is this possible? They shouldn't be here so soon!" shouted Callix. "Someone must have informed them of our location!"

"I blame Grox," muttered Octavia. "That shady little lowlife…"

"Change of plans. All troops, prepare for battle!" With Callix's order, the Horde members dropped what they were doing, leaving the supplies for their weapons. The citizens of the town closed their windows and locked their doors, knowing that a fight was coming. Armed with all manner of scavenged stun batons, staffs, swords, blasters, and anything else they could find, the soldiers waited for their enemies to arrive.

Once the party was in range, those with projectile weapons opened fire. The skiffs split up, circling the town, while She-Ra descended from above. She leapt from the back of her mount, crashing into the ground with the force of a meteor, sending the nearby troopers flying. The second wave engaged, only to be met with her sword.

Hidden inside an empty building, a trio watched the fight, waiting for the right time to strike. Well, some of them were. “Look at her!” Kyle said in a hushed shout. “She’s tearing through our best guys–and she’s alone! What happens when her friends show up?”

“Who cares? She’s still just Adora!” said Lonnie, ready to rush out and engage her. “We know how she fights, so it’s just a matter of attacking at the right moment!”

“Do you really think you can defeat her?” asked Kyle. “Actually…a better question would be, do you think we *should* defeat her?”

Rogelio growled.

“Exactly. She *was* our friend, but that was before she threw her lot in with the princesses,” Lonnie replied. “She’s an enemy of the Horde, and we have to–Aw, great!” In the time they were waiting, the battle had begun in earnest, with not only the other princesses, but the Crystal Gems joining the fray as well. “Look what you did, Kyle!”

“Me!? How did I do this!?” he asked.

“You distracted me!” Lonne groaned in frustration. “Nevermind! C’mon, let’s find another angle. We can’t just wait in here all day.”

“Why not?” Kyle asked as the three of them snuck out of the building. They could see Octavia fighting with Huntara, as well as Bismuth and Topaz fighting back to back. Frosta was tearing through what little armaments they had, so they decided to go the other way. Slinking through the shadows, they didn’t notice Callix engaged in battle with Hordak on one of the rooftops.

Hordak darted around the former Force Captain with his new wings, while Callix attempted to strike him with a massive hammer that was tipped with a drill. “So, you’ve finally come crawling from whatever hole Catra banished you to!” he said, swinging wildly. “Don’t worry about going back, I’ll put you back underground myself!”

“Arrogant as ever, Callix,” Hordak said, nimbly dodging his strikes. “You must be truly desperate for conquest to throw in your lot with the likes of Catra!”

“At least Catra makes no bones about what she wants!” Callix smashed through the rooftop with one mighty smash, almost sending his opponent down. “She never hid her desires for conquest behind some self-righteous revolutionary propaganda! She may use us as tools, but she doesn’t pretend to care about us!”

Ducking underneath one of his swings, Hordak grabbed hold of Callix’s hammer. “And where has that honesty put her in your eyes?” With a single punch, he smashed through the stone of Callix’s chest, halting him. He pulled out a glowing green crystal, and Callix’s body fell to the ground.

In Hordak’s hand, the crystal spoke. “It matters not what I think of Catra,” he said. “Truth be told, I despise her almost as much as you. But the Horde needs a leader to exist. When you disappeared, she filled that void, kept us alive.”

“You seem to think I abandoned you,” Hordak said. “Then where is your new leader? Off gallivanting with her new friends while you are left to rot in the desert. She admits her callousness, but does that truly make her a better leader than I?”

“Anyone is a better leader than you!” While he was speaking with Callix, Hordak didn’t know the Force Captain’s body had risen, until it struck him from behind. The impact made him drop the crystal, which was pulled back into the body’s chest. Callix’s eyes glowed now that he was whole again. “I will ensure that your tyranny *never* plagues the Horde again!”

Hordak stood up, wiping some blood from his lip. “A noble sentiment–perhaps there is hope for you after all.” He ran back in to reengage.

As the battle continued raging on the ground, the trio kept to relative safety. "I don't know if this is the best idea," Kyle said. "We're outnumbered, we're outmatched, we're being outmaneuvered–I think we should focus on escaping!" Rogelio growled, apparently agreeing.

"Enough complaining, both of you!" Lonnie snapped. "If we run away now, we'd be no better than deserters! And I don't care who's in charge–Hordak, Catra, Callix–they all feel the same way about deserters!"

"But…who's battle are we really fighting? Ours, or Catra's? Hordak at least gave us a reason to fight, but what now? Do we really care about…" Kyle hesitated to say a negative word about one of his old friends, but the sentiment was there.

Lonnie was getting heated now, bearing down on Kyle. Rogelio stood between the pair, ready to defuse the situation if needed. "We don't have time to be thinking about this right now!" she shouted. "Like it or not, we're with the Horde, and right now, our people need us! So are you just going to spend all day complaining, or are you gonna take action!?"

"I…you're right," Kyle said. "All of this…I think I can finally see why Adora left. If this is the Horde I've spent my whole life trying to be a part of, then I don't want anything to do with it anymore." He stepped back, dropping his weapon.

For a moment, it seemed that Lonnie was about to strike Kyle with her staff. She growled, only to turn around and charge into the fray, going right up to the largest opponent she could find: a towering armored figure wielding a similarly giant sword. Both Kyle and Rogelio ran after her.

This massive warrior, He-Man, turned around after being struck by Lonnie from behind. "Huh?" He blocked her next attack with his sword, only for several more like it to follow. None of them affected him in his new form, but Lonnie kept at it.

“You think you can just come here and tear us apart that easily!?” she yelled, only still standing thanks to Steven’s reluctance to hurt anyone. “We’re the Horde! We run this planet, and we’ll still run it when you’re…when…” She finally began to slow down, both recognizing that her attacks weren’t doing anything, as well as Kyle’s declaration sparking something.

“Lonnie!” Kyle and Rogelio ran out to her aid, weapons in hand. “Hurry, we can still make it to safety!” They were fully prepared to fight off Steven, or at least attempt to, if it meant saving her, only to find that the two of them weren’t fighting at all. Lonnie had dropped her weapon, while Steven had sheathed his. “Huh?”

She looked over at them, then at Steven, and finally threw her arms up. “What are we doing here, guys?” she said, exhausted. “What are we even still fighting for? Wh-what do we have to gain? Why do we suddenly owe so much to Catra of all people?”

“That…sounds like something you might wanna talk about,” Steven said. “Not *now* , but maybe once all the fighting’s done.” A battle still raged around them, as the other Horde members had not given up just yet.

“You were right,” Lonnie said to Kyle. “You were right all along. We should be fighting for something *we* care about. A cause *we’re* behind. And whatever vanity project Catra’s cooking up this time sure isn’t it.” She took off her armor, letting it fall to the ground. “I don’t know about you two, but I’m leaving the Horde behind.”

They looked at one another, before following suit. Two more breastplates landed in the sand. “That…feels a lot better,” Kyle said. “And not just because those were really stuffy.” The three shared a brief laugh.

“Steven! What’s going on?” asked Adora, rushing over. “Are you okay? I saw you just standing there, and I thought…” She paused when he pointed out the trio standing beside them. “Wh–guys? What are you doing here?”

They looked up, a bit startled to see her. “Adora!” said Lonnie. “We’re fighting a battle, what’s it look like? Well, not anymore, actually.”

“We’re following your example,” added Kyle. “Looks like the Horde’s just not for us. Not this one, anyway.”

“That’s…wow,” Adora said. “Not sure I know what to say. Except that the Princess Alliance would be happy to have you.” She approached, extending a hand.

“We’ll think about it,” Lonnie said.

Meanwhile, Callix and Hordak had demolished several buildings in their clash, mostly due to the former. Hordak was not one to go down easily, and while he packed a punch, it was difficult to take on someone made of rock. “You were once the one who had the entire Horde at your beck and call–where is all that might now?” He swung his hammer, the drill on the end tearing through the concrete and stone of the city. “Is that why you have thrown in with these princesses and desert bandits? Because you’ve finally realized how weak you are?”

“Far from it!” Hordak lunged, flying over one of Callix’s strikes to deliver a kick to his head. “My body has never been stronger, and my resolve has grown to match! And unlike some of us, I do not hide from my enemies in the desert! Not anymore!” He swept his opponent’s legs out from underneath him, attempting to wrest away his hammer as he fell.

Callix kicked Hordak away, quickly getting to his feet. “Useless!” he shouted, throwing him to the ground with a punch. He raised his hammer, preparing to finish him off with one last strike. “And now, at long last, Etheria will be free of the old Horde!”

But before he could bring it down, something stopped him. Hordak couldn’t tell if it was a sensation, a vision, or something else entirely, but it seemed to be something only Callix was experiencing. He staggered back, nearly dropping his hammer. He

let out a surprised cry as a familiar pinkish light began to shine from inside of him.

Hordak moved away, beginning to expect what was coming. More and more beams of light breached Callix's body, growing more intense. With one more shout from him, he was burst from the inside, pebbles and bits of rock raining on the nearby area. In the place where he stood was Glimmer, holding Callix's true body in her hand.

"Certainly an impressive entrance," said Hordak. "Have you ever defeated any of mine this way?"

Glimmer didn't look up. "I didn't do that to save you." She held up the green crystal. "You. You work for Catra, right? Where is she?"

Laughter from the crystal. "And you expect me to answer you why? Because you've bested me, once, in combat? I never bowed to the princesses even before the Horde came along. I will not start now." Some of the rock pieces began to levitate off the ground, preparing to coalesce.

Not content with this answer, Glimmer squeezed the crystal, causing the rocks to shift erratically. "I'm not playing games!" she snapped. "Catra! Where!? Tell!"

"Do not mock me!" Callix grunted, pained. "Even if I was aware of her location, I would never divulge such information to the likes of you! You princesses have no claim to this planet! Imprison us if you must, but know that I will never–Arrgh!"

Callix had cried out in pain due to Glimmer throwing him to the ground, proceeding to drive her staff down on top of him. "Alright, fine, don't bow. But I'm not going to imprison you if you don't start cooperating *real* . *Soon* . Oh, and another thing: I'm not a princess. I'm a queen, and that's something you have Catra to thank for! Not get talking, or else!" She pressed the staff down harder, earning more pained groans from Callix. Hordak watched, impressed with her ruthlessness.

“Glimmer, stop!” Bow appeared, steadying Glimmer’s hand. “You don’t need to do this. The fight’s done, it’s over.”

“It’s not over!” Glimmer protested. “Not until Catra pays for everything she’s done! Not until…until…” She looked around, seeing the town in disarray from their fight. Most of the townsfolk were unharmed, but many had been put in danger from the battle. The Horde troopers had either surrendered or been captured. “You’re right. It’s over.”

Bow picked up Callix’s crystal core, and placed a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder. “We’ll stop Catra. Okay?” he assured her. “Just not like this. But we will find a way. I promise.”

# Hidden in Plain Sight

Chapter Summary

Adora looks for help deciphering Light Hope's words, while Entrapta grows closer with Modulok.

Chapter Four: Hidden in Plain Sight

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The fighting had stopped, and the town had returned to normal– relatively. With help from the Princess Alliance, the townsfolk had begun to repair what had been damaged during the fray, though quite a few were none too happy that they had to in the first place.

"Sorry about all of that!" Perfuma lifted some wooden boards into place, while Bismuth hammered them down. "Things got a little out of hand here. We're happy to help in any way we can!"

And although Bow had managed to calm Glimmer down, she was still looking for answers. She paced in front of Callix and Octavia, who had been restrained, the latter gratefully being immersed in a water bubble created by Lapis and Mermista. "Just what I needed! Maybe you princess types have some good in you after all."

"Save it," said Glimmer. "I'll cut to the chase: Catra's been wreaking havoc throughout the universe these last few weeks, and we know you still answer to her. We need to know how to find her, or at the very least, when she's coming back."

Octavia shrugged. "Wish I could help you with that. The last thing she told us was to prepare for her to return. Then, nothing. We've been out here for weeks waiting for something from her, even a transmission explaining what's going on. I hate to say it, but I think she's left Etheria behind for greener pastures."

Adora and Bow had been standing nearby, partially to oversee the interrogation, partially to make sure Glimmer kept it under control. "You don't really believe that, do you?" asked the former. "Etheria's her home. Even if she has less-than-peaceful ideas in mind, don't you think she'd rather stay closer to what she's used to?"

"Aren't we living proof to the contrary?" asked Callix. "Lord Catra has moved on. Whatever Etheria once meant to her, she has moved on, abandoning her soldiers for those more suited to conquer the universe. She has her eyes set on the bigger picture now, and it is likely more than you can handle."

Hordak took note of Callix's apparent regret. "So much for the 'ideal leader,' then," he said. "Perhaps you were mistaken in following her over me."

Callix glared up at his former boss. "Perhaps I was. Choosing to follow Catra may have been a mistake, but choosing a new leader was not. I joined the Horde because I thought it would fight back against the princesses who control these lands, but it soon became conquest for conquest's sake." He got up, as much as his bindings would allow, him and Hordak in each other's faces. "When you disappeared, I saw Catra as a much better version of you–but I see now that she is merely your successor. A sad, lonely child lashing out at a world that doesn't believe she's special."

An energy blade extended from Hordak's wrist, its low hum silencing the argument. Callix was not intimidated, however, and seemed to dare Hordak to use it. Bow walked up, and wordlessly placed himself between the two. Hordak backed off, though reluctantly, and Callix sat back down.

"Unfortunately, I think that's all we're getting out of them," Glimmer said. "You think it's really possible Catra's done with this place?"

Adora wasn't sure what to think. "I…that's kinda the worst part," she said. "I believe it, but I don't *want* to. Even when Catra was

our enemy–misguided, it felt like Etheria was her goal, her target. But now, she's got so many new allies and weapons at her disposal, I wouldn't be surprised if she wants nothing more to do with this planet."

"Then I suppose there's nothing more to be done," Hordak said. "This 'New Horde' will not bother with us, I see no need to bother with them."

"No," Glimmer said. "As long as Catra's out there, she's still a threat, and not just to us. We'll think of something–we'll get the Diamonds to move against her, or have Hessonite find out where she's hiding. I'm not gonna stop until she pays for what she did!"

"Yes, well, I suppose vengeance does take priority," Hordak said. "And speaking of, what is to be done with these two?" He gestured at the pair of Force Captains.

"I don't say this often, but would you mind taking me prisoner?" asked Octavia. "I don't know how much longer I can stand this desert heat! Some cell in a princess' dungeon *has* to be preferable to this!"

"We'll decide on that later," said Glimmer. "Right now, I want to make sure every last Horde soldier is accounted for. They may not be working for Catra anymore, but they could still be dangerous if they *think* they are. Bow, do you think you can do that?"

He nodded. "I'll take care of it."

"Good. Once everything's done, we'll meet back up at the entrance to town." Glimmer headed off to oversee some of the repairing of the town, Hordak in tow.

Once they were gone, Bow leaned over to Adora as the two headed further in. "Does it bother you at all how close those two seem to be getting? I'm always one for making new friends, but…"

"Oh, absolutely, it bothers me a *lot* ," Adora replied. "I mean, one of my best friends palling around with the man who led a

campaign of carnage against this planet? It doesn't sit too well. But, Hordak has his reasons to be helping us, so I usually just try to let it go."

"That's not all I mean," said Bow. "Lately, Glimmer's gotten a lot more…aggressive. She's always been a bit forceful, but it's gotten a lot worse in the past month or so. I worry that some of his methods are starting to rub off on her."

"It's probably just grief," said Adora. The two were silent for a brief moment, reflecting on what that meant. "I…I'm gonna go now. We'll meet back up later." The two of them split up. Adora, not exactly sure what she was supposed to be doing, leaned against a wall and watched as the townsfolk repaired their town. "Y'know, I should probably help…"

But, just as she was about to head over, she saw someone nearby, who was also overseeing the construction. The tiny green form of Peridot, someone who she wasn't overly familiar with. They had interacted occasionally, but weren't close enough to be considered friends. However, Peridot was one of the smartest people she knew, which gave her an idea. She walked over to the Gem.

Peridot was busy looking over a diagram of the town, accompanied by Connie. "Uh…hey!" said Adora. "Peridot! Doing alright?"

The Gem looked around in confusion. "Yyyes," she said. "Doing fine. Especially now that the fight's over. Did…did you need something?"

"Sort of." Adora awkwardly sat down next to her. "You…aren't busy, are you?"

She glanced down at the map. "No, I guess not."

"Good, because I think I could use your help with something. You too, Connie, if you're willing."

"I guess I could give it a shot," she said. "What's on your mind?"

Adora took a deep breath, taking a moment to decide where to begin. "Well, you might not remember, but a few years ago, Light Hope was destroyed by Horde Prime. You theorized she might still be alive, right?"

"Right," Peridot said.

"Well, a little while ago, during the whole Eartheria debacle…I saw her." Both Peridot and Connie were surprised, but said nothing. "And, she wasn't a hologram this time, but an actual, physical person. She said it was due to reality breaking down, but I don't know the science behind it. The important thing is, before she disappeared again, she told me to find where I came from. And she gave me some numbers: 'Three-seven-eight, four-nine-two, five-five-three.'"

Adora sat and waited for them to process her story. "That's… definitely a lot to take in," said Peridot. "Light Hope's alive, and all she does is give you some strange numbers and then leaves. Do you have any idea what they mean?"

"Bow and I did some looking, but we came up empty," she said. "We know they mean something, but the nearest we could figure out what that they're some sort of–"

"Coordinates," Connie said, the idea dawning on her.

"Exactly," Adora continued. "Light Hope said something about finding out who I was, before I was brought to Etheria. We figured that could only mean something out there…" she glanced up at the sky. "...but we don't have as much experience when it comes to outer space. I figured you of all people might be able to find something out."

"You certainly came to the right person!" said Peridot. "There are numerous systems for mapping out star charts, and given how specific those numbers are–or *aren't* –I should be able to narrow it down!"

“Great! You’re a real help, you know?” said Adora. Her joy soon turned to suspicion, however, as she looked around them. “Uh, actually, do you think you could keep this on the down-low? I don’t want Glimmer finding out.”

“Why?” Connie asked. “Isn’t she your best friend? Why wouldn’t she want you to find out where you came from?”

“Oh, it’s not like that,” Adora clarified, “she just has a lot to deal with right now. Becoming queen so suddenly, it’s been hard for her. I don’t want to distract her from her leadership duties.”

“Well…if that’s what you want, I guess I’ll respect your secret,” said Connie. “But I still think if this is really important to you, Glimmer would want to know about it, too.”

“And I would love to tell her,” she continued, “but I really do think she had more important things going on. I might bring it up if anything comes of this, but for now, let’s keep it as our little side-project. Sound good!”

Peridot gave a thumbs-up. “My lips are sealed!”

“Great! I’m gonna go and do some heavy lifting as She-Ra now. Holler if ya need anything!” As she walked off, she was too lost in thought to notice another dilemma happening beside a nearby building, one she was unknowingly involved in.

Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio had been part of the Horde for their entire lives. The only person they knew for a fact had left it was Adora, and she had some sort of magical destiny that none of them could compete with. Despite their decision to follow her example, there were still some conflicting feelings left over–feelings that had led them to an unexpected kindred soul.

“So, does this mean we’re princesses now?” asked Kyle. “Er–ah, I mean…you know, part of the Princess Alliance. With them now. What else would we be?”

Topaz didn't know much about the history of the Princess Alliance, or its conflict with the Horde, to really answer his question. But she could speak from experience. "It sounds like you don't really *want* to be part of them."

"Not really," Lonnie replied bluntly. "I mean, we've only been fighting them for the last, what, almost two decades now? Probably even longer for some of these people! I still don't exactly trust 'em."

Rogelio offered a reassuring growl.

"And so what if they are!?" Lonnie snapped. "That doesn't mean I can just magically change the way I feel about them after all this time!"

"I…ooh, I'm not sure I'm qualified to deal with this," Topaz admitted. "But when I turned against Homeworld–or, Emerald's version of it, I joined the Crystal Gems. Part of it was because it felt like the right thing to do, but part of it was also because I *wanted* to. They help people, and if they're allies with the Princess Alliance, then I'm sure they help people too. Do you want to help people?"

Their answers were somewhat noncommittal, mostly consisting of 'eh's and shrugs and the like.

"Hmm. Well, I'm sure that the princesses will always have a place for you if that's what you want. And if not, maybe there's somewhere else you can go? Where do you live?"

"Technically, the Fright Zone," said Kyle. "Which is pretty much Horde central…"

"Oh." Topaz really wished she was better at giving motivational speeches. "How about Earth? Lots of Gems went to live there after the war ended. Maybe you could even find a home at Little Homeworld!"

Lonnie was skeptical. “Isn’t that a town for Gems? Plus, moving to a whole other planet seems like a pretty big leap.”

“I don’t know, from what little I’ve seen of Earth, it seems like a nice planet,” Kyle said. “Not to mention, we don’t exactly have anywhere to go.”

Rogelio growled again, gesturing to their surroundings.

“Maybe it’s a nice place for you, but it’s a bit too arid here for us,” Lonnie said. She started laughing, with Kyle and Rogelio eventually joining in. Topaz laughed as well, even though she didn’t know what was funny.

“So, does that mean you’re okay?” asked Topaz.

Lonnie shrugged. “Maybe, maybe not. Honestly, I think we’ve still got a lot to figure out. Maybe we’ll hang around with these princess types for a while to see if joining them’s worth it. But yeah, I think we’re gonna be alright.”

The fusion smiled, happy that her first attempt at counseling had gone so well. “Glad I could help!”

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In the dimly-lit halls of his hideaway, Modulok continued to gush over his guest. “I must have gone over your blueprints for a self-regulating intelligence matrix a hundred times! Of course, even then, I’ve never quite been able to replicate it nearly to your genius. Any robots I’ve built have turned out a bit…off.”

Entrapta eagerly followed him, paying no mind to her surroundings. “I’d be glad to help you out with that!” Seeing as Hordak had defected, and Scorpia had been…banished, it felt good to have a friend who was actually passionate about her work, instead of just seeing it as a means to an end.

“Oh, you truly are too kind,” he said. The pair of them reached an open room, where a workbench littered with clutter sat. Mantenna

followed them at a distance, watching the newcomer curiously. "But I won't trouble you with that now. I need your expertise for another conundrum."

Also present in the room were numerous giant tubes, each of them containing what was presumably one of Modulok's creations. Some of them resembled humans, at least partially, while others were completely unrecognizable as any known species, on Etheria or otherwise. "You are certainly busy," she said, hiding the nervousness in her voice. "Were all of these…people?"

"Many of them," he admitted casually. "Some came to me looking to be stronger, others were injured beyond the realm of what traditional medicine could fix. In both cases, I have transformed them into something far greater than they could ever be."

This explanation seemed to reassure Entrapta, who was genuinely impressed with his work. "I didn't think it was possible to alter an organism's physiology to such an extent." She walked up to examine the creatures. "How did you manage this?"

"I've developed a few formulas in my time," he said, moving some test tubes on his workbench. "That is why I sent out that signal, incidentally: while much of my expertise lies in genetics, my aptitude with regards to mechanics is lacking. Which is why it is so fortuitous that you've arrived!" He gestured for her to come over, which she did.

On the table was a blueprint for a device of an unidentified nature. Although its exact purpose remained a mystery, something about it was instantly familiar to Entrapta. "Is this…First Ones tech?" she asked.

Modulok was once again impressed. "It certainly is! Excellent eye. You see, this entire facility is powered by some First Ones tech I've managed to scrounge. Unfortunately, due to my aforementioned lack of expertise with mechanics, I've not been able to fully optimize its capacity. If it were to fail, well…I fear

what would come of my creations. Now, I apologize if First Ones technology is a bit too complex–"

"Oh, far from it!" Entrapta said excitedly. "In fact, I've done a lot of work relating to their technology recently. I wouldn't call myself an expert on it, but I *do* know a bit about how it works."

Even though Modulok's teeth were always showing, this time seemed like an actual smile. "I should have expected nothing less. Now, let me explain my conundrum…"

In addition to the many monsters floating in vats, some were ambulatory. Mantenna crept into the room and onto the ceiling, his unblinking eyes fixed on Entrapta. A second creature entered from another doorway, a hulking frame colored sickly green. But she was so transfixed on Modulok's explanation that she paid neither any mind.

"Say, for example, that there was an engagement system with several nodes that could be set into an active position after receiving a certain stimulus. For argument's sake, we'll say there are fifteen or so of them. But they cannot be activated and left–if the stimulus stops for even a moment, they will revert to inactive. I need a way to 'hold' them in the active position so that they all may be activated using only one means of stimulus."

"Sounds like a fairly simple problem," Entrapta said after a moment of thought. "Simple, but not quite easy. Do you have any other information? Size, manner of stimulus, that sort of thing?"

"Not at the moment," Modulok said, trying to shoo away his curious creation, who had taken an interest in his new partner. "For now, let us simply put together a general outline of such a machine, and add more details once it is complete."

It was a tall ask, but challenging problems were that much more fulfilling to overcome. "Let's get started!" said Entrapta. Before she could begin sketching an outline of the device, the larger

monster had approached her. It stared at her with its beady eyes, its massive toothy mouth inches from her face. “Uh…hello there.”

“Apologies,” Modulok said, successfully managing to shoo it away. “Leech is much like Mantenna, he is very curious around newcomers–or, *she* is.” He chuckled. “I can never remember with those two! All I know is that one is male and the other female, but I always forget which is which!”

Entrapta laughed as well. “I’m sure that gets annoying!” The two having shared a laugh, however minor, made her feel even more comfortable around him, even after only knowing him for less than a day. However, their newfound camaraderie reminded her just how much she missed Hordak. For just a moment, her expression fell.

Even though it was brief, Modulok still managed to catch it. “Is something the matter?” he asked her. “I apologize if something I said upset you.”

“No, it wasn’t you,” she said, shaking her head. “It’s just…I haven’t been able to share my love of science with someone like this for a long time. It seems like anyone who appreciated me either switched sides or…disappeared.”

She looked down sadly, only to feel a comforting hand on her shoulder. Despite his fearsome visage and strange appendages, he looked at her with a sense of warmness. “ *I* appreciate you,” he said. “I know that can’t mean much at this point, but I hope it is worth something.”

She smiled. “It means a lot,” she said. “I’m glad I got to meet you, Modulok.”

“As am I, Entrapta,” he said. She didn’t notice, but his gaze fell not on her, but on the blueprints she was working on. “As am I.”

# The Two Castaways

Chapter Summary

Scorpia runs afoul of a fellow exile to Beast Island, and finds in them an unexpected ally.

Chapter Five: The Two Castaways

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Scorpia choked down the bitter-tasting fruit, her empty stomach winning out over her unhappy tongue. Although she had determined that the strange, oblong fruits growing on the trees weren't poisonous, they still didn't taste good by any means. But they were filling, and she was in no position to be picky.

"Never thought I'd actually miss that sludge they try to pass off as rations in the cafeteria," she mumbled to herself, tossing the empty rind aside. She walked over to a nearby river, scooping some water into her mouth with her claws to wash away the taste.

A few days had passed since she had first awoken, as well as her first transformation. She hadn't had to use it again since then, but part of her felt slightly safer knowing she had her ancestral magic at her disposal. While she was more or less confident she could fight off any monsters that attacked her, it was the issue of being caught unawares that proved most pressing.

She followed the river, hoping to find its source. With any luck, it would lead to a big pond with lots of things to eat growing around it. And with even more luck, there wouldn't be a giant mutated fish or something living in it. The sounds of snarling and growling filled the air, noises she had grown accustomed to, as she headed along.

Scorpia stayed calm but alert, her eyes darting towards any rustle in the underbrush she heard. More often than not it proved to be

nothing, but she couldn't afford to be incautious out here. She would almost be impressed with how much her survival skills had grown, if it hadn't been out of necessity to stay alive after being unceremoniously dumped here.

Something moved in the bushes behind her. She spun around, her stinger ready to strike at anything that might be attempting a sneak attack. Her eyes darted across the ground and through the trees, but she saw no sign of movement.

However, what she did see was what looked like a face up in the trees. She stared at it for some time, until she was sure that it was just part of the tree and a trick of the light. It did have the texture of wood, after all. Reluctant to turn her back on potential danger, she slowly resumed her journey up the river. "My mind must be playing tricks on me," she said.

The rest of the walk was much less uneventful, though that wasn't to say it was without tension. Scorpia only let down her guard once she reached the source of the water, which was indeed a pond. It was much smaller than she had hoped, barely large enough for her to go swimming in. It flowed up from a rock formation, which she checked to make sure wasn't hiding any hostile wildlife.

The monster sounds had quieted, but it wasn't like the first day, where it was that massive creature that had silenced them. This place felt more peaceful, more natural–as natural as a place like this could feel, that is. After another look around her surroundings, she sat by the pool.

Usually, the only time Scorpia had allowed herself to close her eyes for any extended period of time was when she was sleeping. Even then, she had made sure to hide somewhere camouflaged and out of reach. But for the first time in days, she felt like she wasn't in danger, almost as though there was someone watching over her. For the first time in far too long, she was at peace…

But her peace didn't last long at all. In her relaxed state, she ignored the crunching of a leaf behind her. She didn't notice the rope tying itself around her tail until the appendage was pinned to the ground. "Wha!?" She got to her feet, and was smacked in the face with some sort of stick.

The blow did little more than momentarily disorient her, and she soon caught sight of her assailant. A small, skinny figure dressed in tattered clothing, mostly made from plants found on the island. They also wore a wooden mask; the same mask, in fact, she had thought was part of a tree earlier. But underneath all that clothing, they were undeniably human. Scorpia was so shocked to see another person that she didn't defend herself when they struck her again.

"Hey–knock it off!" she shouted, blocking the next strike with her claws. She pulled her tail from the ground, driving her stinger towards the figure, who deflected it with their staff. She then went in for a harder hit with her claws, knocking them back.

The figure quickly got back up. "You'll have to do a better job than that if you want to catch me unaware!" he said. He spun the staff around, and it began to glow with energy as he did.

Scorpia knew an attack was coming, but was unprepared when it did. When the mystery man next swung his weapon, it unleashed a blast of the same energy that threw her against a tree. "Me!? You're the one who came outta nowhere and started hitting me!"

A glowing circle appeared in his hand–there was no doubt that he was some kind of sorcerer. He swung his arm, casting a multitude of projectiles that homed in on Scorpia. These she was able to weather, though they still kicked up some dust on impact. "Call it a preemptive strike! I'm not letting you guys get the drop on me again!"

'You guys?' Did he mean the Horde? Scorpia looked down, realizing she was still wearing her old outfit. "Okay, hang on, let's talk about this!" she said. "I don't know what kind of beef you

have with the Horde, but we're both stuck on this crazy island, so maybe we should focus on surviving first?"

"Ha! Tell that to Black!" He launched another projectile, this one whizzing right past her. "And while you're at it, let him know I'm coming for him one of these days!" The blast may have missed Scorpia, but it wasn't meant to hit her. The tree behind her, on the other hand, creaked and groaned until it gave way, falling on top of her.

She managed to catch it before she was flattened. Scorpia was strong, but this was a big tree. "I don't even know who that is!" she shouted, groaning from the strain. "I just got here a few days ago!"

He cast yet another spell, this one heading right for her. She dropped the tree, which was blown to fiery bits when it made contact. "Even if that's true, Hordak must have sent you here for a reason. Whatever that may be, you clearly aren't the type to be trusted!"

Emerging from the smoldering bark, Scorpia scowled at her attacker. Lines of black ran across her form like dark veins, seeming to darken the air around her. "Hordak's gone!" she yelled, her voice noticeably deeper. "Catra's been leading the Horde for years!"

This revelation seemed to give the stranger pause, but it lasted for only a moment. "Nice try!" His staff began to glow again as he ran towards her, clearly intending for another strike. Scorpia growled as she ran in as well, her body distorting from her power. Her face was almost unrecognizable, sporting beady black eyes and mandibles.

The two collided, and were blasted back by the force of the impact. Both landed with a thud, Scorpia coming to a rest near the water, and her assailant some distance away. "Urggh…" she groaned, pulling herself up to the pond. She looked to be normal again–she sighed in relief before lying down in exhaustion.

The man got up as well, finding to his dismay that his stick had been torn in two by the blast. “Aw, not again!” he moaned, letting each half fall to the ground. He got to his feet, cautiously examining Scorpia’s still form.

“ *Now* can we talk things out?” she asked. She slowly got to her feet, careful not to set him off again. “You seem like you’ve been through a lot, but I promise I won’t try and attack you, or steal from you, or do whatever it was you were afraid of. I don’t know who this Black is, and I was sent to Beast Island because Catra…” She trailed off, not wanting to relive those painful memories.

He considered it for a moment. “I suppose talking things out couldn’t be so bad. Especially since neither of us look to be in fighting shape.” He glanced over his shoulder at seemingly nothing. “I know I did just attack you and all, but…how hungry are you?”

“Very!” she exclaimed. “All I’ve eaten since I got here are fruits that taste like cleaning supplies! …Wait, you aren’t just talking about those, are you?”

The man laughed knowingly. “No, no. I’ve had enough of those to last me a lifetime. I have some meat grilling back at my hideout, and–” Scorpia was immediately on her feet again, salivating as she waited for him to lead her there. “Huh. I’ll take that as a yes.”

Despite initially being at each other’s throats, the two were now on the way to becoming allies, and were also on the way to the man’s hideout. “So, how long’ve you been here?” asked Scorpia, awkwardly trying to make conversation. She wasn’t exactly keen on talking about her past, and was unsure if he would be the same.

Fortunately, the question didn’t bother him. “Oh, years now, I’ve lost count,” he said. “Last time I saw my daughter, she was a little girl. She’s probably a young woman now…” He stopped, taking a moment to look Scorpia over. “Actually, she’s probably not much younger than you.”

"I'm…sorry," she said, not sure of what else to say. "You seem like a good guy. I don't know why Horday sent you here."

"That's the thing: he didn't," said the man. "But I won't go into that now. Here, this is me." He led her into a cave hidden in a cliffside by a curtain of vines, out of which a delicious smell was emanating. As soon as he pulled the curtain aside, Scorpia ran inside, uncaring that the small chamber was mostly filled with smoke.

As the stranger had said, he was cooking meat in a campfire within. Scorpia immediately snatched it up off of the rotisserie and dug into it; she didn't care that she burned her mouth, nor did she care that she didn't know what it was. "Life is beautiful!" she said, nearly tearing up. Both from joy, and from pain at burning her mouth.

He sat down aside from her. "Hey, save some for me! It took all day to catch that thing!" He removed his mask, setting it down beside him. Scorpia was only just now seeing his face, and something about it seemed oddly familiar. He had black hair and somewhat-dark skin, his face covered with an untrimmed beard. "You don't want us to go back to those soap-fruits, do you?"

Scorpia shook her head, handing the skewer back over to him. "Y'know, I'm just now realizing we never introduced each other," she said. "I'm Scorpia, princess of the Fright Zone and former Force Captain." She held out a claw for him to shake.

He seemed hesitant, but took it nonetheless. "Micah, former king of Brightmoon," he said.

Like a switch had been flipped, Scorpia immediately realized why he had looked so familiar. "Y-you…you're the king?" she said. She probably would have dropped the meat if she had still been holding it. "King Micah, *the* King Micah? Queen Angella's husband, Glitter's dad?"

"Glimmer," he corrected, his face lighting up. "You know her?"

She moved her claw in a so-so gesture. “Eh, we’ve met a few times. Fought a few times too. She seems nice enough–we’d probably have gotten along pretty good if we weren’t on opposite sides.”

Micah looked fondly into the flickering flames. “My little girl’s all grown up,” he said, his tone bittersweet. “Tell me, what is she like? Is she still just as much of a spitfire as she was when she was younger? And how about Angella, are they getting along? Oh…” Reminded of his wife, his demeanor fell. “They probably hate me after all this time away.”

“I wouldn’t say they hate you,” she assured him. “Everyone thinks you’re dead. Hard to hate someone when you think they’re dead. Unless you hated them before, which I doubt they did… Okay, look, I’m not very good at this, but I’m pretty sure they just miss you.”

Despite her lack of confidence, her words did seem to reassure him somewhat. “Thank you, Scorpia,” he said. “I’m sorry about ambushing you and all that.”

“No harm done!” she said, helping herself to some more of the meat.

“That said…what did you mean when you said Hordak was gone?” he asked. “I mean, I know what you *meant* , but could you give me some details? Did Shadow Weaver finally usurp him?”

Scorpia chuckled at the mention of her. “Nah, Shadow Weaver’s been gone for years! She got put in jail for going behind his back, but she busted out, and nobody’s seen her since.” This statement made him narrow his eyes suspiciously. “Catra’s been in charge ever since Horde Prime showed up. Well, her and Emerald.”

Micah clearly had no idea what she was talking about. “Horde… Prime? Emerald? Please, start from the beginning. And who is this ‘Catra?’”

“Oh, Catra’s my best friend!” Scorpia said. However, her cheerful demeanor didn’t last long. “Or, she was. We were inseparable, but then she became Lord Catra, and Emerald started putting all these ideas in her head, and she tried to blow up the world, and…” She got to her feet, staring off into space. “I-I think I need to lie down.”

“Here.” Micah directed her over to a bed of straw at the back of the cave. It was much more comfortable than the rocks she had made her beds, even the ones covered in damp moss. “Go on when you’re ready. At your own pace.”

“S-she put me here,” said Scorpia, the reality of the situation finally hitting her. “She was gonna destroy the planet, and I tried to stop her, and then there was this pain, and then I–I thought we were friends.” Her voice was breaking, and tears welled up in her eyes. “I knew she had problems, but I thought I was helping! I thought I was making her better!”

Micah hung his head. “I know what it’s like, to have a loved one choose power over you. I’m truly sorry.”

Fully breaking down, Scorpia threw her arms around Micah, pulling him closer. “What did she want?” she sobbed. “What did she want that I couldn’t give her?”

“I wish I knew,” said Micah, eventually hugging her back. “Some people are never satisfied with what they have. They want more, or they want the one thing they can’t have, and they’ll do anything to obtain it, even turning their backs on the people they love. But whatever the reason she did it, it wasn’t because of you.”

“I know,” she said, pulling back. “But it still really feels like that. Like, if I had done or said something different, I’d still be back home with her and everything would be fine…” She lay back down, turning her back to him. “I’m sorry, I…”

"No need to apologize," he said. "Get some rest, I imagine it's been a while since you've had a good night's sleep." Leaving her be, he went to put out the fire.

Without the fire's light, Scorpia realized it was later than she had thought. She also realized she was more tired than she had thought. Finally able to let her emotions out, Scorpia cried herself to sleep for the first time in years.

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Scorpia didn't know how long she had been asleep, but it was still dark when she woke up. She rubbed her eyes as she sat up, her vision growing used to the darkness of the cave. Micah sat nearby, upright but still asleep. Rising quietly so not to disturb him, Scorpia crept for the curtain and slipped out of the cave.

She didn't think it was possible for Beast Island to be peaceful, but it was, almost more so than it had been at the pond. There were still those creepy noises in the distance, though they were quieter here, almost ambient. Either this place was further away from the vicious monsters, or a good rest was all she needed to see this island in a new light. Probably the former.

"Good morning, Sunshine." She glanced back as Micah exited the cave. "How'd you sleep? Feeling better?"

She thought about it for a moment. "Yeah. Yeah, I think I am. It… felt good to have someone to talk about it with."

He patted her on the arm. "Same here. I can't tell you how lonely it's been, stuck here without my family, with the only ones who can talk trying to capture me. Don't get the wrong idea, I'm not *glad* you're trapped here with me, but misery does love company."

"That it does," she said, nodding. "Actually…you said there are other people here. Who are they, and why are they trying to capture you?"

He glared off to the side. “Long story.” Scorpia stared at him. “But, we do have nothing but time. Come on.” She followed him further into the jungle. “Hordak’s sent plenty of people here over the years. Some aren’t even on him, like the two of us. But they’ve all more or less banded together since then, formed into a sort of village. Well, not all of them. The ones who don’t want any part of them?” He drew his finger across his throat.

“Ooh,” Scorpia said gravely. “And this ‘Black,’ is he like their leader?”

“Yes and no. He keeps order in their little village, but he’s just a figurehead. Now, *his* boss, that guy’s the one in charge. And the one who sent me here in the first place.”

He stopped them once they reached a large, sturdy tree. He climbed up onto one of its branches with ease, attempting to use his weight to break it off. Scorpia watched as more questions formed in her head.

“And this boss guy, what’s his deal?”

Micah struggled a bit with the branch. “As far as what he wants, I have no idea. But as for who he is, we have a bit of a history. Modulok’s his name; he’s something of a mad scientist type. He captured me for one of his twisted experiments, but that’s as far as I cared to listen.”

Modulok. The name sounded vaguely familiar, but she couldn’t put a face to it. He must have been before her time. “So you’ve just been on the run from him all these years?” she asked. He wasn’t making any progress with the branch, so she reached up to snip it free with her claw, catching him in the other.

“Thank you,” he said, back on his feet with the branch in his hand. He began to fiddle with it, plucking off twigs and smoothing it out with magic. “And yes, I’ve been running for a long time. But with you here, I think we just might be able to help each other. How’d you like to get off this island?”

“Absolutely I’d like to get off this island!” she replied. “But, what exactly can we do? I’m pretty big, but what exactly can I do that you couldn’t do with your magic?”

Micah examined the branch, now a new staff. “Simple: you’re going to help me raid Black’s stronghold. See, Modulok doesn’t stay here all the time. He’s got a ship, one that he keeps stashed away somewhere inside there.” He pointed to her with the staff. “And you’re going to help me steal it.”

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While the battle continued to rage planetside, a small cruiser departed from the *Supermassive* . It wasn’t a particularly heavily-armed, armored, or generally dangerous craft, but it didn’t need to be. Its inhabitants were dangerous enough.

Catra stood up from the pilot’s seat to address her team. “All of you listen up,” she said. “All of Etheria is now considered enemy territory. There are a few pockets of New Horde loyalists here and there, but they’re in no way reliable enough to depend on as allies. For this mission, it’ll be just the six of us. We go in, stay under the radar, find this Heart of Etheria, and bring it back from right under Adora’s nose. Any questions?”

Her entourage–consisting of Bluebird Azurite, a male scorpionkin, a Carnelian, a Mystacoran sorcerer, and a mer-kin–had none. “We’re at your beck and call, Empress!” said Azurite.

“Good.” Catra sat back down, readying the ship for a hyperspace jump. “Hope you’re ready for me, Adora,” she added under her breath.

# The Heart of the Matter

Chapter Summary

Catra and her team arrive on Etheria, while the Rebellion decides how to move forward.

Chapter Six: The Heart of the Matter

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The cruiser descended through Etheria's atmosphere, having chosen a place far from the Princess Alliance's purview to touch down. As it did so, Catra felt some satisfaction at the fact that the planet still didn't have any kind of early-warning systems to alert the princesses to invaders like her. She would surely have been more prepared had she still been running the place–a minor victory over Adora, but a victory nonetheless.

The team soon passed through the clouds, getting a view of the planet below them. Green fields and patches of forest spread all the way to both horizons. "You know, I never would have imagined I'd be seeing Etheria from all the way up here," said the scorpion man. His features were hidden behind a Horde helmet, but one didn't need to see his face to tell that he was the biggest one present. "I'm still kind of in shock that there's a whole universe out beyond its skies."

The sorceress agreed. She, too, wore a helmet, but seemed to have light purple skin. "I'd heard stories of the stars back in Mystacor. All the way back since Etheria was sealed in Despondos. And even then, those stories pale in comparison to the real thing." She looked back up at the skies they were passing through.

"Can we focus, please?" snapped Catra, initiating landing procedures. "This isn't a sightseeing trip! I'm already taking enough of a risk coming here in the first place, so I have to ask

that you take this seriously!" With her subordinates silenced, she went back to the controls.

Their ship touched down next to some old farmland, presumably abandoned. But some precautions would need to be taken just in case. One at a time, the squad filed out of the cruiser, some taking it better than others. "Etheria–pah!" spat the mer-man. He, like most members of his race, was an amphibious being with green scaly skin, and large fins on the sides of his head. "I, for one, could not get away from this place fast enough!"

"Aw, it's not so bad, Sqalish!" said Bluebird Azurite, flying up above their landing sight. She took a deep breath. "Ah! Just smell that air! That's the smell of a planet just waiting to be conquered!"

The scorpion man removed a rather large gun from the ship's cargo hold, lugging it along with him. "I don't know about you all, but that's a smell I can get used to," he said.

Catra thumped on the side of the ship to get everyone's attention. "Listen up! We're not here for sightseeing, or for a trip down memory lane, or to conquer the planet–yet. The only reason we're here is for this: the Heart of Etheria." A holographic display provided by Entrapta showed a spherical object, seemingly no larger than someone's head, made of cobalt-colored metal wrapped around a red core. "If Entrapta turns out to be right, and it does exist, it should give us the edge we need in our war against the snake men–and everywhere else.

Carnelian raised her hand. "And, uh, if it turns out to be not real?"

"Well then, we'll just have to go with plan B: bring back a different First Ones artifact," Catra said, smirking. "And I know a certain sword that would be perfect. But for now, the Heart of Etheria is our primary objective. First order of business: covering our tracks. Crita, if you will?"

The sorceress, Crita, prepared to cast a spell. “Bear with me, this might take a bit.” With rings hovering near her hands, she concentrated, and the ship began to disappear. Gradually it faded, until it was entirely invisible. Aside from an odd flicker as the light passed through it that was only visible from close up, it was nearly undetectable. “There. Save for running headlong into it, nobody should find it.”

“Good. Bluebird, recon.”

“Aye-aye, boss!” Bluebird took off further up into the sky, scanning the perimeter for threats, or for treats.

“Karikon, Carnelian, secure the area.”

Carnelian reached for the gemstone on her lower back, producing a bladed boomerang. “Will do!” She and the scorpion man, lugging his enormous blaster, set off to act on anything Bluebird happened to uncover.

Sqalish eyed Catra with his beady black eyes. “I hesitate to ask, but do I have a purpose, Empress?” he asked reluctantly.

“You sure do,” Catra replied. She tossed him the holograph, a tentacle emerging from his back to catch it. “Chart the quickest way to the nearest site marked on this map. If we’re lucky, the Heart will be there. If not, we’ll just move on to the next.”

He glared at the device. “I assure you, we are most certainly not lucky. Not with me on the team.” He reluctantly pulled up the map and began looking for the optimal route.

While Catra watched over her minions, Crita, her task fulfilled, approached. “Eh…Empress Catra, if I may? Not that I’m suggesting you don’t have a plan, but from how we just landed in a field in the middle of nowhere, meandering to where this artifact *might* be, it seems like you don’t have a plan.”

Her comment earned her a glare from Catra. “Not every attack against everyone we fight has to be some kind of extra-complex

series of events set up weeks in advance! As long as we don't draw too much attention to ourselves, we'll be able to find the Heart without any trouble. Providing none of you find some creative way to screw this all up!"

"So…you don't have a plan, then," Crita deduced.

"The plan is for you to not question your commander!" she snapped. Catra felt around a bit for the ship, climbing atop it once she found it. "Everyone, rally up! We're moving out!"

Sqalish looked up from the map, evidently not finished just yet. "Are you sure that's wise, Empress? We don't yet know what we might encounter."

"We know enough." Bluebird, Carnelian, and Karikon returned to the group as Catra made her way in the direction of the first marked location. "Just stay close, and hope that this isn't a waste of time."

"You mean like the war on Ophidia wasn't?" Karikon asked quietly, earning him a soft snicker from Carnelian and a cautionary nudge from Crita. Luckily for him, she was too focused to be listening closely.

The five troopers followed after their commander, dreading the outcome should this turn out to be a wild goose chase–or even if the Heart was real, what difficulties acquiring it would prove. "I have a feeling this will not be a pleasant mission," muttered Sqalish.

"Don't you get that feeling on *every* mission?" asked Carnelian.

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And so, with the Horde remnant dealt with, the Princess Alliance returned to Brightmoon. Those willing to abandon Catra's ideals were given relative freedom, while those unwilling to give up their life of conquest were detained. All in all, this was a major victory for them…so why did Glimmer still feel so dissatisfied?

She sat on her throne, alone with her thoughts until Hordak appeared, someone she never thought she'd be glad to see. "Queen Glimmer," he said with a slight bow. Even after all this time, she could never tell if his respect for royalty was genuine or mocking. "All of the Horde separatists have been accounted for. Those who have chosen not to remain in the Crimson Wastes have been escorted to appropriate lodgings. I think we have seen the last of the New Horde for some time."

"You'll forgive me for not being optimistic," she mumbled. Glimmer stood up from her throne, strolling over to a window to gaze out at the Whispering Woods. "Hordak, you were part of a galactic superpower once. What do you think is the best way to defeat Catra?"

Hordak scowled at this question. "Catra and Horde Prime can hardly be compared! That traitorous former lieutenant of mine is nothing more than a rambunctious upstart on a galactic scale, while my brother was the most glorious conqueror the known universe had ever seen! Had the sheer scale of his dynasty not stretched his resources thin, Gemkind would never have been able to gain victory over him!"

"Uh-huh, uh-huh, I know," said Glimmer, dismissively waving him off. She'd heard this song and dance before. "But you have to admit, she's being a real pain for all those space people out there–mostly the Gems, but still. You said it yourself: the best way to topple an empire is to wear their resources thin…so how do we *do* that?"

He considered the question for a moment, his days of 'Lord' Hordak coming back to him. "This is an interesting query. Horde Prime was able to transfer his consciousness into other bodies, making himself effectively immortal. The only reason Homeworld was able to win at all was by destroying his other clones. But Catra does not have this luxury." He stood beside Glimmer, looking out the same window with a glint in his eyes. "In cases such as hers, the best way to dismantle an army is to cut off its head."

For the briefest of moments, a shadow of the same glint appeared in Glimmer's eyes. "So we go after Catra directly. But that seems too obvious…what's your angle?"

"Angle?" He grinned. "My dear queen, surely you don't think I would be planning on betraying you and retaking my old throne? Our alliance has become far too mutually beneficial for something like that!"

Glimmer glared up at him. He had to admit, although their size difference, among other things, made her far from imposing, she could have an impressive air of menace when she wanted to. "We may be allies *now* , but don't think that when this is all over, you can just go back to ruling the Horde," she growled. "I didn't forget everything you've done to Etheria. Catra may be the one who killed my mom, but your war got my dad killed."

"Ah, yes, King Micah," he mused. "Shadow Weaver spoke highly of him. I wish I knew what became of him…"

"I know enough," Glimmer hissed. "Now, are you going to tell me how we can get to Catra, or have you decided not to be useful anymore?"

Hordak strolled towards Glimmer's throne, for a moment considering sitting upon it. "Catra never does anything by half-measures. Her fleet will be prepared to destroy any enemy that attempts to get close to her. We can use this to our advantage. She will likely be expecting a grandiose display of aggression, not a small, precision-oriented strike. A single, small craft, one advanced enough to evade detection, and able to carry a battalion of your best warriors. Now where, dear princess, would we find a ship like that?"

Memories of his old hideout in the desert came back to her. "Mara's ship," she said.

"Precisely," he said with another smirk. "I'm sure if we pool our resources, we can get it into working order again."

“No need,” she said, returning to her throne. “I’m sure Peridot would be more than capable of doing this on her own. Would you mind sending for her?”

He hid his dissatisfaction behind yet another sneering smile. “Nothing would bring me greater pleasure, *your majesty* .” He left the room, leaving Glimmer alone with her thoughts. Her thoughts of vengeance, of justice, or retribution. She would not let Catra escape punishment again–she owed her mother that much.

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Strangely, Steven wasn’t with everyone else, relaxing after their latest mission. Connie eventually found him, out in the garden by the newly installed warp pad. He was still in his large He-Man form, seemingly waiting for someone to arrive.

“Hey, He-Man,” she said, strolling over. “Y’know, I’m still not exactly used to all this.”

“Connie? Oh, hi,” he replied. He seemed distant somehow, as though something was on his mind. “Yeah, me either. You think it’s weird for you that I have a big buff body now, imagine how *I* feel!” He chuckled briefly, but stopped just as quickly. “So, what’s going on with you?”

“Me? What’s going on with *you* ?” she asked. “Everyone’s celebrating our job well done, and you’re out here all by your lonesome. I’d have thought you’d be in the middle of it! Is… something the matter?”

He was quick to assure her that he was fine. “No, no, I’m fine! It's just that…” After trying to find the words, he sighed. “Hey, you’ve had a sword for a lot longer than I have. Do you think you could give me some pointers?”

“For sword stuff?” She glanced at the Sword of Power. “I guess I could…but you don’t seem like you need it. I’ve seen you with that thing, and it looks like you can handle it pretty well!”

"Thanks…but something still feels off about it. I can *use* it, but it doesn't feel natural." Steven looked over his shoulder anxiously at the warp pad, clearly expecting someone. "It might take some time getting used to."

Connie sat down on a bench nearby. "Well, there you go: you'll get used to it the more you use it. I wasn't an instant expert when Pearl first taught me. I can give you some tips, but experience is the best teacher–Pearl also told me that!"

"You're probably right, but…" Steven ran his hand over the blade of the Sword of Power. "How much time do we have? The New Horde is out there taking over planets and causing trouble for everyone, and here I am, gifted a magical sword that could really help in stopping them, and I don't even know how to use it right. If… Maybe if I still had my other powers, I'd be more helpful."

Now that the heart of the matter was laid bare, Connie looked at him with pity. "That's what this is about, isn't it?" She walked over, placing a comforting hand on his arm. "Steven, this is also something you can't force. Garnet, Amethyst, and Pearl all had their powers come back naturally. We don't know how it happened, but it did, and sooner or later you'll be just like your old self again. Plus, a sweet new sword!"

It was small, but her little pep talk had Steven feeling a bit better. "Yeah, I guess so," he said. "My powers will come back when the time is right. And even without them, we're still jam buds, right?"

"Of course!" Connie exclaimed happily. "Jam buds for life! Plus, now that we both have swords, you, me, and Adora could all be… uh, blade buds!"

He laughed, and so did she. "Blade buds! I like it!" He took a few practice swings with his sword. "Look out, New Horde, because the blade buds are comin' to get–"

There was a flash of light behind them as the warp pad activated. No sooner had Steven turned around to greet the new arrival than

they had thrown themselves at him: Jasper collided with him head-first, only stopped because her helmet crashed into his sword.

She followed up with a punch to the gut, only narrowly missing his gem. Steven tanked the blow, grabbing hold of Jasper's arm and tossing her aside. She recovered in midair by curling into a ball, rolling at him for another attack. She broke the roll into a slide, moving under a slash from his sword, before springing up and smashing him in the back with a double-fisted hit. He was thrown forward, staggering as she charged in again.

"Steven!" Even without her sword, Connie darted into action, leaping into the air. As though by instinct, Steven caught in and hurled her further–she landed on Jasper, grabbing hold of her hair. She pulled on the Quartz's mane, trying to disorient her to give Steven an opening. He ran in to attack…only for Jasper to grab Connie, and hold her in front of herself like a shield.

With a small gasp, Steven skidded to a halt. Whether voluntarily or involuntarily, he shifted back into his normal form, coming to a stop in front of the Gem. "This wasn't what we agreed on, Jasper!" he said angrily.

Jasper dropped a struggling Connie to the ground, scoffing. "The only thing I agreed on was to train you to be a warrior–and that means showing you everything you might have to face. Do you really think your enemies won't ambush you when your guard is down? Or use your own allies against you? If you really want to embrace the full potential of this He-Man thing, you need to be ready for anything."

"That doesn't mean you can just attack me and my friends out of nowhere! I…ugh. Nevermind." Steven picked his sword back up. "Come on. Let's find somewhere more secluded so you can show me the ropes."

"Steven…did you know she was coming?" Connie asked. She was more confused than angry, though he still looked away guiltily.

“Kind of,” he said. “I figured we’d be here on Etheria for a while, so I asked if she could come here to continue our lessons. I didn’t know she’d come out swinging, though!” He glared at her accusingly.

She looked like she was moments away from rolling her eyes. “If you wanted a teacher who’ll go easy on you, you could have asked that Pearl. You came to me for a reason. If you don’t like the way I do things, fine. But don’t expect any help from me when you’re inevitably outclassed by those renegades.” She walked over to the courtyard’s entrance, waiting for Steven to follow.

Before he could, Connie stopped him. “I know I mentioned this earlier, but are you sure this is the best idea?” she asked. “Her lessons might be helpful for now, but they aren’t *you* . Steven, you’re a loving, caring guardian of hope, not an aggressive berserker!”

“I was,” he said somberly, “until I lost my powers. Until I get them back, this sword is all I have. And Jasper’s probably the only one here who can teach me how to use my *new* powers. I don’t like it either…but what other choice do I have?”

“Not to listen to her,” Connie said softly.

He turned to leave with Jasper. “Wish me luck.”

Connie could only watch as the two of them disappeared. “Your main problem is, you’re still used to using a shield,” she heard Jasper say as they faded into the distance. “A sword is a weapon: you attack, you don’t defend. Understand?”

She went back inside before she could hear his answer. She tried to assure herself that this would all be fine. Steven was plenty smart, and he knew what Jasper was doing. Surely he wouldn’t be molded into being like her that easily, right? But deep inside her, Connie couldn’t shake the feeling that nothing good would come of this.

# In This Together

Chapter Summary

Bow, Peridot, and Hordak are sent to repair Mara's ship.

Chapter Seven: In This Together

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"This is your objective," Glimmer said. She had managed to procure a picture of Mara's crashed ship in the desert. "You might remember it as the place Hordak holed up in back when Horde Prime kicked him out. I asked you two here for one reason: we need a ship."

Peridot and Bow both looked at one another, neither of them expecting a mission of this caliber. "So…we're supposed to go out into the desert, find this ancient decrepit ship…and fix it? Just like that?" asked Bow. "Don't get me wrong, I'm not doubting our abilities or anything, but that seems a bit beyond us."

"I hate to say it, but this seems like something more Entrapta's speed," said Peridot. She knew how much Bow missed her–she even missed her a little herself. They had been Science Buddies once, after all.

Doubtful though they were, Glimmer had complete confidence in them. She teleported next to Bow. "Bow, what are you talking about? You know more about First Ones technology than pretty much anyone else I know! And First Ones tech is basically just Gem tech–Peridot, you're an expert on that."

She opened her mouth to refute this, but couldn't. "I suppose that is *technically* true. But Bow does have a point. That ship crashed years ago, how are we supposed to get it running in time for… whatever it is you have planned?"

"If I may…" Bow and Peridot both jumped, though they tried to hide the fact. Hordak had been so quiet, they had forgotten he was in the room. "I have become something of an expert in First Ones tech as well. I could provide assistance, should these two require it."

Though Glimmer agreed, neither of them did. "Of course–Bow, Peridot, you will be joined by Hordak. I'll also be sending a company of castle guards with you, in case you should run into any trouble."

"You mean if trouble comes with us…" Bow said under his breath. Hordak clearly heard him, but chose not to react. "He's helped us before, but how do we know he won't run off the moment we fix the ship?"

"That's what you're for," Glimmer said. "Even if he does go rogue, he doesn't have his tech, he doesn't have his armies–he shouldn't be much of a match for you and your arrows."

Part of Bow was flattered by just how much confidence Glimmer had in his abilities, but another was wary of how much she had in Hordak. "Still… Okay, fine. I don't like it, but I trust you."

She nodded. "I trust you too." She turned to her new assistant. "Keep them out of trouble. And don't cause any yourself."

"Why would I do anything to ruin our partnership?" said Hordak. Bow swore he saw a slight smirk on his mouth as he stepped out of the room. "The sooner we leave, the sooner we can get this ship up and running."

While Bow may have been skeptical, Peridot shared none of his trepidation. "Alright. Let's see what I can do!"

Before he followed after them, Bow turned back to Glimmer to ask about a suspicion of his. "Why now?" he asked. "We have different ways of getting around. Other ships, not to mention the warp network. So why are you suddenly interested in repairing Mara's ship?"

"I…" For a moment, Glimmer considered lying to him. She was worried that if he knew her intentions, he'd reveal her plan to Adora, which would complicate things. "I'm trying to stop the New Horde. And the only way to do that is to go after their leader."

His suspicions were confirmed. "You're going after Catra," he said. "Does Adora–"

" *No* , she doesn't, and I'd like to keep it that way!" Realizing she had snapped at him, Glimmer quickly composed herself. "Sorry, I… She doesn't know. But you know her history with Catra! If I told her, she'd probably try and convince me there's another way, that we'd somehow be able to talk to her! But we can't. They may have been friends once, but whoever Adora was friends with back then, that's not who Catra is now."

Sympathetic, Bow approached her. He raised a hand, but stopped just short of putting it on her shoulder. "And who is she now?"

"Someone willing to destroy the world out of spite," she growled. "And because of her, my mom is dead. She can't be reasoned with! That's why Adora can never know about this. Because she'd never agree to kill…to do what needs to be done."

Glimmer had always had an aggressive streak, but this was a side of her Bow had never seen. "Is that why you're doing this?" he asked. "For revenge?"

"To save the universe." She walked back up to her throne, sitting down. "For now, don't tell anyone about this. Not Steven, not the princesses, and especially not Adora. Can I have your word on this?" Bow was silent. "Can I?"

"...Okay," Bow eventually relented. "For now, I'll keep it between us. But sooner or later, whether you want her to or not, Adora's going to find out about this. Would you rather tell her yourself, or have her find out you hid this from her?"

She sighed angrily. "Adora's my friend. I trust her…just not with this."

Bow turned to leave. He glanced back at Glimmer once more time, and then was gone. Meanwhile, Glimmer reflected on his words. Was this really something worth risking Adora's trust over?

It wouldn't come to that. She would make sure it wouldn't. And even if it did…well, Catra would be gone. And *that* was worth it.

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It was most likely because of the tension that nobody really spoke during the voyage there. Their skiffs raced across the desert once again, thankfully not running into any trouble on the way there. They found that the ship had remained undisturbed, possibly due to Hordak's reputation.

Peridot's feet hit the sand first. "Okay! Let's get to work–you guys start unloading the materials, we'll case the ship for damages. Bow, why don't you and Hordak handle the outside, I'll check the interior." Having apparently elected herself foreman of the project–foreGem–she walked inside.

"Guess she'll handle that," Bow said. The guards began unpacking the raw materials they had brought along, as well as their tools. Bow grabbed a box of them and went to work, ready to (reluctantly) follow Hordak's lead.

Seeing as he operated out of the ship for almost two years, Hordak was the most familiar with its damages. "The ship is mostly intact," he said, "mostly due to its impressive armor. That said, the propulsion systems are in disarray. We should focus our efforts there."

Bow pried off a panel from the ship's engines, revealing that its internal workings were indeed shredded. "Yeah, that seems about right," he said, brushing some sand out of the wiring. "This might take a while."

"Nonsense. We both know what we're doing. As long as we work together, this will be mere child's play." Hordak prepared some tools of his own, getting to work right away.

Just because Bow didn't trust him was no reason not to be civil. "Nicely put," he said, joining his partner-for-the-moment. "If there was one good thing that came out of the Horde, it was your guys' teamwork. From what I could tell, you all worked pretty well together."

It might have been a trick of the light, but he could have sworn he saw Hordak smile–a genuine one. "You can thank your old friend for that. Before Entrapta came along, I was much less outgoing. I stayed holed up in my sanctum, obsessed with finding a way out of Despondos. But once she came along…" He looked away. "Nevermind. We should focus on the task at hand."

"She…really was your friend, huh?" This whole time, Bow had been convinced that Entrapta had been tricked into joining the Horde. And even if she had, that Hordak saw her as little more than an asset, something to aid in his conquest. But you couldn't fake fondness like that, even if there was a reason to. "I guess you two *are* pretty similar. You're both smart, you like machines, you're both…purple." In truth, Bow wasn't entirely sure why the two of them considered each other friends, or even if Entrapta reciprocated.

Apparently, Hordak was just as confused by this as he was. "What she saw in me, I may never understand. But for whatever reason, she saw value in me." He looked towards the sky. "Wherever she is now, I can only hope that she remembers me fondly."

Wherever she was, Catra and Emerald were likely nearby. "Is that why you gave Glimmer the idea to fix the ship?" Bow asked. "You miss her, and you want to go after her."

"Catra has beguiled her," he said. "I have nothing but admiration for Entrapta, but she is easily led astray. Emerald as well–their honeyed words have, for lack of a better phrase, entrapped her. I am the only one who can save her."

"Uh…whatever you say." In reality, Bow was certain Entrapta had made her decision. If she truly felt that way towards Hordak,

wouldn't she have come back of her own free will? That said, Catra *had* convinced her to join the Horde…

"You care for Queen Glimmer, don't you?"

Bow was taken aback by this question. "Uh, wha? Y-you mean, like, you and Entrapta? Or like…something else?"

Hordak rolled his eyes. "I will never in my life understand the trappings of adolescence. You have known her since you were young, correct? And, in this time, you have grown fond of her–more than just a friend. Am I wrong?"

"Well…you're not *wrong* wrong," said Bow. "H-how about we just get to work. We should probably focus on the task at hand, right?"

Another grin from Hordak, but this one was much more noticeable. "Indeed. Let us get to work."

Meanwhile, as they repaired the ship's exterior, Peridot worked her charm on the inside. Despite crashlanding here so long ago, it was in surprisingly good shape–those First Ones must really have known what they were doing. Her first order of business was getting the bridge up and running, having crawled through a panel underneath the controls. "Aaaaaand…that should do it!" She climbed out, inserting the panel back into place. "Sometimes I even surprise myself!"

Understandably, the ship's controls were quite a bit older than anything she was familiar with, but they were similar enough to Gem tech for her to work her way around. She was soon able to find the startup, filling the bridge with light once again.

"Yes! Power restored!" she said, pumping her fist. "Now, let's see here…" Peridot ran a quick diagnostic on the systems to see what was and what wasn't working. "Weapons and shielding look good. Propulsion should be up soon, hyperdrive shouldn't be that hard to fix. Neither should the onboard computer. Navigation's working fine, though…oh, it uses the Reticulan method."

The Reticulan method was a somewhat-outdated means of interstellar wayfinding, by which the galaxies were imagined as 2-dimensional spaces. Most Homeworld Gems had some knowledge of this method, even if more accurate ones had largely displaced it. Peridot brought up a visual of numerous surrounding galaxies, all transposed on a giant grid.

Near the corner of the screen, there was a blinking line, above which was written a phrase in Eternian. The language was just similar enough to Gem for Peridot to make it out: something along the lines of 'input coordinates.' It was then that something clicked in her mind, remembering just how the Reticulan method worked. "AH! Adora's number! It *is* coordinates!" She wracked her brains trying to remember what it was. "Okay, Peridot, c'mon…"

Thanks to Peridot's mind for details, the numbers soon came to her. Nine numbers, three groups of three: exactly how the Reticulans found their way around. First, she put in the numbers three, seven, and eight. Out of all the galaxies on the chart, this was able to single out one of them.

Next, she put in four, nine, and two. The chart zoomed in on a single star, being orbited by a handful of planets and comets. From what Peridot could tell, and what she remembered from her time as a Kindergarten technician, none of the celestial bodies here were particularly valuable. They were all uninhabited, and they didn't possess any usable resources. That said, a lot could change in a few thousand years.

Finally, the next numbers were five, five, three. This singled out one planet of the bunch, seemingly as unremarkable as the others. Peridot was about to dismiss it as a dead end, when something suddenly came up. A blinking red light appeared above the planet's surface, indicating something in its orbit. Text appeared reading 'Eternian facility detected. Unknown serial number.'

"This…this could be what Light Hope was telling Adora," Peridot said. "Where she came from. Could it be… No, that would be

impossible.” She put the thought out of her mind, or at least tried to. She didn’t want to get Adora’s hopes up, but it was entirely possible the First Ones weren’t as gone as they were thought to be.

As it stood, though, she knew too little to make a definitive conclusion. She’d make a note of this to tell Adora later, but right now, she had to get to work. She headed outside to see how Bow and Hordak were progressing.

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Micah led Scorpia through the jungle; the distance traveled wasn’t terribly long, but they moved slowly to avoid drawing any unwanted attention. Together, they might have been able to handle any beasts that came their way, but the commotion was sure to alert the people they were trying to sneak up on.

“How much further?” Scorpia whispered. “This island can’t be *that* big, right?”

“Bigger than you’d expect,” replied Micah. He held out his staff to stop Scorpia in her tracks. “Alright, we’re here. Try not to fall to your death.”

She pushed aside the bushes in front of them. “Why would I– Woah! You weren’t kidding!” A sizable cliff sat before them, overlooking what appeared to be a village. From what could be seen at this distance, there were a fair bit of huts surrounded by walls of wooden spikes on all sides. There was some movement within, but the people were too far away to make out clearly. “ *That’s* been here this whole time?”

“And that’s not even half of the people Hordak’s sent here over the years,” said Micah. “If what you said about Hordak being gone really is true, perhaps it’s for the best, regardless of what kind of leader this Catra person is.”

Scorpia tried not to think about that too hard. “So, what’s the plan?” she asked.

Micah lay down on his stomach near the cliff's edge. "Sundown's in less than an hour. We slip in under the cover of darkness, and take Black hostage. From there, we force him to fly us back to Brightmoon. Problem solved!"

"Uh, yeah, sounds simple enough." Scorpia blinked, as a strange noise filled the air. She looked around for a source, but saw nothing. "You hear that?"

He looked around as well, even more confused than her. "No. Hear what?"

"Some kinda…I don't know how to describe it. Almost like feedback. Y'know that high-pitched whining sound? You sure you can't hear that?"

Before Micah could answer, something landed on a leaf next to Scorpia. Some kind of bug, colored bright red and with yellow wings. Thinking this was the source, she reached out to touch it. Before she could, Micah tapped her claw with his staff. "I wouldn't do that if I were you," he warned.

She moved her claws away, still looking at the insect. "Huh? Why not?"

"Scraper beetle," Micah said. "They may look pretty, but their bites are no joke. If there's enough of them, they can strip their prey to the bone in seconds. Good thing there's only one of–" His eyes suddenly went wide.

Scorpia covered her ears as the feedback sound resumed, though Micah was unaffected. He pulled her to the ground as another noise, a cacophonous buzzing, filled the air. Also filling the air was a swarm of scraper beetles that burst out of the foliage, quickly surrounding them. Scorpia was considering making her escape down the cliff, but the way off there had been covered too.

The swarm, rather than attacking them directly, instead seemed to be interested only in corralling them. It soon became apparent why, when two figures stepped out of the tent. One had bluish

skin and pointed ears, while the other was a normal human except for having four arms, but both of them wore decrepit Horde uniforms. They stood before the two, aiming wooden spears at them.

They alone probably wouldn't have been much of a threat for either of them, but the bugs made them hesitant to act. "Woah, hold on there, guys!" said Scorpia. "We're all Horde here, there's no reason to get all stabby! Just call off your bugs, and we can talk this out."

Her proposal was met by raspy laughter–not by the two guards, but by someone else in the underbrush. "There is no longer any Horde on this island, girl. Beast Island is the domain of the Mutants!" Another figure emerged. He too was dressed in worn and broken Horde soldier armor. His helmet was cracked at the bottom, revealing a wide grin full of jagged yellow teeth, as well as his pale white skin. The glass on the top half was cracked as well, giving the visor the appearance of a bug's eyes. "And you two are trespassing!"

"Well, good to see you too, Gideon," said Micah.

Scorpia looked down at him. "Friend of yours? Er, former friend?"

He gave her a strange look. "No, that's… Right, I didn't… He's the one I told you about. Black. Force Captain Gideon Black."

(Former) Force Captain Gideon Black hissed like an angry cockroach. "That name no longer applies to me! Thanks to Modulok's blessing, I am now Mosquitor! And you will address me as such!"

Now that he had revealed his name, Scorpia looked closer, seeing that he was covered in bugs. Various ants and flies crawled in and out of his armor, much to his nonchalance. She also noticed he was holding out his hand, seeming to control the scraper beetles like a conductor. "So, are you like…the bug princess, then?" she asked.

Although he groaned in annoyance, he ignored her question. “Modulok asked me to bring you alive, and I will. But my children would like to feed…and you can live without your limbs, yes? So perhaps now you would like to walk back to our village.”

Micah watched the beetles warily, but didn’t seem worried. “We’ve done this song and dance before, mosquito boy. With all the times you’ve trapped me before, what makes you think this time will be any different?”

Mosquitor cackled again. “Because this time, we have a very special visitor!”

Another noise filled the air, this time a loud mechanical hum. A large object passed by overhead: a ship. A personal cruiser of some kind, covered in pitch black armor. Scorpia and Micah watched it descend down to the village, where six legs extended towards the ground, giving it the appearance of a huge insect as it landed.

“You see?” continued Mosquitor. “This time, you can run away as much as you like, but you will not get far! This time, Modulok is here to see to your capture himself!”

Scorpia exchanged a worried glance with Micah. She didn’t know what this Modulok guy was capable of, but with how concerned the King of Brightmoon was, she wasn’t liking their chances.

# Divide/Collide

Chapter Summary

Catra's squad search for the Heart of Etheria, while Hordak plays confidant.

Chapter Eight: Divide/Collide

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The sight of yet another empty cave led Karikon to drive his claw against the wall, taking a good chunk of stone with it. "That's *it* ! We've been at this for hours, scouring this lousy planet for any sign of this so-called 'Heart of Etheria,' and we haven't found jack! In fact, I'd go so far as to say we had more of a chance taking on the snakes *before* we came here! Y'know, for as smart as she is, I'm starting to think that Entrapta doesn't know what she's talking about!"

Catra's ear twitched, but if she planned on defending her old friend, she didn't. "If *you're* upset, just think about how *I'm* doing," she muttered. "Etheria's a big planet, and we still have a lot of searching to do. We might as well get to it." She headed off towards the next location on the map, leaving the others with no choice but to follow.

"Is it just me, or is the hunt for this artifact turning out to be a wild goose chase?" Crita said to Carnelian, whispering so as to not draw their commander's ire.

The Gem shrugged. "It would, if I knew what a goose was. What I do know is that I'm starting to doubt that the Heart even exists."

"Empress Catra, if I may?" said Bluebird. "This search might go a bit quicker if we split up. Y'know, to cover more ground. Besides, we'll be less likely to be spotted if we travel in smaller groups!"

Ready to snap at her, Catra instead considered her suggestion. As much as she hated to be undermined, the fusion did have a point. "Fine," she said, "whatever gets us off this planet faster."

Azurite smirked. "Great! I'll take Carnelian and Karikon, and–"

"Not so fast," interrupted Catra. "You're not taking all of the muscle with you. You can have Karikon, but Carnelian stays with me. I'll take Sqalish as well–he'll be useful for where we're going."

The mer-man reluctantly stepped forward. "And where, pray tell, *are* we going, O glorious leader?"

"I'm glad you asked," Catra said, matching his sarcasm. "The three of us are heading to Salineas. I imagine you're familiar with the place?" She took his silence as confirmation. "Good. Then with your expertise, we should be able to search twice as fast. Any objections?" Nobody raised any. "Good. I expect to hear back from you with an update, whether or not you've found anything. And stay on task!"

"Oh, of course!" said Bluebird. She waved as the group parted ways, Catra's party heading towards Salineas, while hers remained on the original path. "So, onward we go! Hunting for an elusive First Ones artifact! What a fun day we will have!"

It didn't take a genius to figure out she was up to something. "What's your angle here, Blue?" asked Crita. "If we're not looking for the Heart, what else are we going to do?"

The Gem scoffed. "What? And what could *possibly* make you think I had ulterior motives in suggesting a more efficient manner of completing Empress Catra's mission?" She flew around erratically, making big, exaggerated movements.

"Your tone of voice, for one," Karikon said. "Call me the suspicious type, but you've never struck me as a toady. You had your own reasons for coming along on this mission, so care to share what they are?"

Bluebird Azurite rolled her eyes. "Oh, very well. As your superior, I don't *have* to tell you anything, but…I suppose letting you in on a little secret won't hurt. Just so long as Catra doesn't find out!"

"Sure, sure, we won't tell her," said Crita. A promise she wasn't necessarily planning to keep, depending on how their next excursion went. If Bluebird was being sneaky, nobody said she couldn't be, either.

This was good enough for her. "Good! Follow me!" After making sure Catra and the others were long gone, Bluebird led the two in a different direction: towards Brightmoon. "You're right that I have a little mission of my own! Let's call it a side-quest, shall we? It's been a few years now, so I think it's finally time…Time for some revenge on Steven Universe!"

Crita and Karikon looked at each other. "Uh, revenge on Steven?" asked the latter. "Is that really the best use of our time? Not to mention, he's probably, uh, *surrounded* by Gems and Princesses, yeah?"

"Oh, relax, would you?" said Bluebird, a touch irritated. "It's not like we'll be barging in with no plan! First we assess the situation, then we determine the best way to strike! And furthermore, I don't think your job is to question your superiors."

"It's just what he does best," Crita said, walking past the scorpion man. "Though he does raise a good point–are you sure you know what you're doing?"

A sniff of irritation from the Gem. "Of *course* I do! For instance…if we want to get to Brightmoon, first we'll have to get through the Whispering Woods. Should be pretty easy!"

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None the wiser to Bluebird's little detour, Catra, along with Sqalish and Carnelian in tow, soon made it to the edge of Salineas' border. A small port town built beside an inlet, they were hopefully

far enough away from the capital to avoid drawing the Princess Alliance's attention.

Sqalish grimaced at the scent of sea air. "I was hoping to go the rest of my life without returning to this wretched place," he hissed.

"Are…are you *ever* happy?" asked Carnelian. "Seriously, I don't think I've seen you smile *once* . This is the place you came from, I'd have imagined this would be a happy time for you!"

Sqalish just glared at him. "Clearly, he's upset *because* this is where he came from," said Catra. "I can understand the feeling." She rummaged through some bins in a back alley, emerging with a black cloak which she wrapped herself in. "The less attention we draw to ourselves, the better."

When looking for information of any kind, there was one place to go: a tavern. Even with all the commotion around, the three of them weren't given a second glance: there was enough variety in both species and manner of dress that neither Sqalish nor Catra raised any eyebrows. Even Carnelian didn't garner much attention, as several Gems had come to live on Etheria in the time it had returned from Despondos.

The three of them took an empty table to discuss their plan. "Now, please don't just go and announce why we're here," Catra said. "We're looking for the Heart of Etheria, but we can't let anyone else know that."

"And how exactly are we supposed to ask about it if we can't tell anybody what it is?" asked Carnelian.

Once more, Sqalish rolled his eyes. "By being subtle, I should guess. Follow my lead." He approached the bar, taking a seat while trying to look as casual as possible. Considering how morose he was usually, this wasn't that difficult. Soon after, the bartender went over.

“What’ll it be for you?” she asked. She was a gruff looking woman with pinkish skin, and a hook for a right hand.

Sqalish took a moment to examine her wares. “Whatever’s cheap,” he said. She poured him a glass of some truly vile looking fluid, which he choked down. “Can’t imagine you get many rich folks around these parts. No offense.”

She scoffed. “None taken. But I gotta say, that’s kind of an odd question to ask. I mean, sure, some merchant ships pass through here from time to time, but they ain’t exactly pleasure yachts. Why? You planning some sort of heist?”

“Ideally, no,” he told her. “I’m something of a collector. All manner of strange and ancient curios, in particular those of historical significance. First Ones artifacts, some have called them. I figured taverns tend to be a good receptacle of gossip, so if anyone’s heard something, it’d be you.”

The bartender nodded, considering his query. “Yeah, alright, I think I know someone who could help ya out. Wait here, I’ll see if he’s awake.” She stepped through a door behind the bar, and could faintly be heard talking to someone else. Carnelian and Catra each took a seat beside him.

“Wow, who’da thought you had a way with people?” the Gem said. “If I didn’t know better, I’d say you were a professional treasure hunter before joining the Horde!”

“Not exactly, but you aren’t far off,” he said, sipping on his drink. “Under the Princesses’ rule, I had to do what I could to eke out a living.”

Catra grinned under her cowl. “Sounds like we weren’t the only ones who hated the princesses,” she said. “I’m surprised you didn’t join up sooner.”

He shot a brief glare at her. “That’s because the Horde was almost as bad.”

Before Catra could snap back, the bartender returned, flanked by several rough-around-the-edges individuals. One of them, one of Sqalish's species with red scales and a bigger build, took her place as the one at the front. "So," he growled, "I take it you're a fellow connoisseur of the antique?"

Sqalish took a moment to finish his drink. "You could say that. I do hope I'm not intruding on your territory, Mr…?"

The other mer-man brought his fist down on the counter. "You know damn well who I am," he hissed. "Or, at least, *we* know who *you* are. You've got some nerve showing your face around here, Sqalish."

Silently, Catra eyed the two, sensing the tension between them. She held off from intervening under fear of being recognized, but hoped they could resolve their differences without making a scene.

As Sqalish slowly got to his feet, this was seeming less and less likely. "Kenek. I thought I recognized you from somewhere. And here I thought I was just recalling a nightmare I had."

Kenek glared. "You'd better believe I'm a nightmare! A nightmare to anyone who even *thinks* about turning his back on the clan. I should tear you to pieces right here and now…but instead of making a scene, I'll make you a deal. Whatever this treasure of yours is, I want in. Seventy percent of the profits–no, better make that eighty. We've gotta eat back home, after all."

All of this sounded like a pretty good deal to Catra. Not only were some free thugs a plus, especially ones with likely ties to Etheria's criminal underworld, but all they wanted in return was a cut of the money they wouldn't be getting. They were the perfect dupes for the situation. It seemed too good to be true, which it was, because of what Sqalish said next: "There is not a chance I would ever work with you."

“That’s too bad…see, now that you can’t offer anything to make up for your betrayal, we’ll have to treat you like any other deserter.” Two of Kenek’s henchmen rounded the bar, ready to ‘escort’ Sqalish into the back room. “It isn’t personal. No more than it is with anyone else who abandons us, at least. I hope you understand.”

Catra interrupted. “We’ll take the deal.” She glared at Sqalish as she said it, and he glared right back. “Eighty, ninety percent–hell, you can take it all if you want. As long as you help us find it.”

Sneering, Kenek approached Catra. “And who might you be?” he asked. “The leader of this little excursion? I should’ve figured Sqalish wouldn’t be calling the shots. So, tell me…what exactly is it you’re looking for, hmm?”

Catra wasn’t considering telling him. She was about to keep her answer vague, or completely make up an artifact. Or both. Point him in the right direction, but keep him off the scent. She never got around to that, as Sqalish took that moment to escape from his captors, pushing one back and slamming the other’s head against the bar with a tentacle.

“You!” shouted Kenek, and almost Catra too. He quickly put an arm around her neck. “Stand down, before I tear off her head!” She wasn’t about to let that happen, and shot her elbow into his stomach. He doubled over, which she took as an opportunity to throw him over the bar.

Unlike the other two, Carnelian was much happier about how things had turned out. “Alright, now it’s a party!” When one of the thugs went after her, she threw him across the bar with a single punch. That was when things got hectic.

Chaos erupted as the fight spread to the entire tavern, to the point that it seemed like the patrons were just waiting for an excuse to throw down. Much of the aggression seemed to be aimed towards Catra and the others, likely because they were on

Kenek's payroll. As Carnelian went gladly into the fray, the other two fought for their lives.

Luckily, they were no stranger to this. Sqalish extended his tentacles to full, tossing around anyone who came near him. "I knew I shouldn't have come back here!" he groaned, slamming two grunts together. In response to a punch, his skin hardened into a crustaceous carapace, with which he returned the punch.

"There go our chances of staying under the radar!" groaned Catra, fending off a pair of toughs trying to surround her. When one went in to grab her, she knocked him over with a kick to the legs, sending him tumbling into the other. But another one blindsided her, pinning her against the bar.

This was when the bartender made her move, trying to drive her hook down on Catra: she just barely missed, embedding it in the wood inches from Catra's ear. While she tried to wrench it out, Catra broke free from the other one's grip, pummeling his face into the bar. The bartender swung her hook at her once again, but she managed to catch this one, sticking it even deeper into the wood, before knocking her out with a kick.

Meanwhile, Kenek had Sqalish up against the wall, several of his tentacles around the latter's neck. "For that little stunt, the price just went up!" he said. "Now, tell me what it is you're looking for, and I'll make this much less painful for you!"

"I never capitulated to you before, and I don't intend to do so now!" Sqalish hissed. Even as he began to grow faint, he kept fighting, clawing at the tentacles around his throat.

Kenek sneered, only to suddenly let out a pained cry. His tentacles went slack, with one end falling to the floor, severed. Catra stood behind him, wiping blue liquid off her claws. She turned the tables, putting him in a headlock and slamming him to the ground.

He was back on his feet fairly quickly, but now he had no way to defend himself when Sqalish grabbed him with his tentacles. His skin hardened as the two struggled, trying to tear the appendages off of him. Realizing he might be successful, Sqalish quickly rushed up to him, summoning all of his strength to lift him up and hurl him away. "Carnelian!"

The Quartz got the message, leaping into the air to meet Kenek, and delivering a punch that sent him crashing into the floor, through several tables, and finally against the wall. The three Horde members looked over a trashed bar, confident that the fight was over.

Indeed it was–everyone involved on the other side had either fled or been clobbered. But not everyone was finished just yet. Sqalish approached the defeated Kenek, lifting him up by the collar. "Good then, now that business negotiations are through, why don't you help us out? Where is the Heart?"

"What are you talking about?" he coughed. "The Heart? Now you're just talking nonsense!"

Sqalish responded by slamming him against the wall. "Don't try and make up excuses! The Heart of Etheria! I can't imagine an 'expert' in the First Ones like yourself would know! Either you can point us in the right direction, or you can't–and I don't like your chances if you can't."

He responded with a condescending laugh. "You idiot! The Heart of Etheria's nothing more than a legend! Nothing that powerful could actually exist! It's just a made-up story by the First Ones to scare disobedient Etherians into line!"

"And where is this 'legend' supposedly located?" he continued.

Kenek gave up trying to escape, simply shaking his head. "I wouldn't know. I tend not to waste my time chasing after fairy tales. Can't help you with this one–but by all means, good luck on your wild goose chase!"

“Huh, again with the goose…” Carnelian said to herself.

Having gotten what they could, Sqalish dropped Kenek back down. “He’s telling the truth,” he said. “If he really knew something we didn’t you can bet he would be taunting us with it.”

Catra donned her makeshift disguise. “Just in time, too.” There was a commotion outside, indicating that some of the patrons had gone to fetch the guards. “At least it’s something. Come on, we have to go.” The other two followed, making their way out through the back room.

The tavern door burst open, and several guards filed in. “Everyone, stop what you’re doing and put your hands in the… eh?” said the lead guard. Everyone inside was on the floor, and the victors of this little spat, if there even were any, were nowhere to be seen.

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“Y’know…I know this thing’s pretty derelict, but I’m still a bit wary about being in here,” said Bow. He had crawled into one of the thrusters on Mara’s ship to replace one of the igniters at the end, and despite the ship being nonfunctional, was a bit worried about being suddenly incinerated. “Actually, maybe that’s *why* I’m nervous. It could go off at any minute!”

Back outside, Hordak resisted the urge to roll his eyes. “The sooner you repair it, the quicker you can get out. And the faster we can *both* head back.”

“You’re right–just gotta get it done!” Bow said. The sounds of cranking were heard from within. “Aaaand…there! Alright, heading out!” He squirmed his way back out of the tunnel, relieved to be back in the open. “Phew! I’m not exactly the claustrophobic type, but I’d rather not do that again!”

“You realize this ship has three more thrusters?” said Hordak.

Bow's eyes widened at that revelation, before deciding to take a break. "Well, we'll get to those in a bit. Let's just take it easy for a moment–don't want to overwork ourselves in this heat!" He sat down in the shade, indicating for Hordak to join him. Reluctantly, the former warlord did so. "We're making pretty good progress so far," said Bow.

"Mmm."

Something seemed to be on Bow's mind. "Um…I know we aren't exactly close enough to be considered friends yet, but…do you mind if I confide something in you?" he asked.

"As long as I don't have to confide something back," Hordak said. He was met with silence. "...Yes, go ahead."

"Okay, good," said Bow. "So…do you know why Glimmer wants us to fix this ship?"

Hordak nodded. "I do. But she requested I not tell anyone else."

"Yeah, she told me the same thing. But since we both know…I *get* that she wants to go after Catra. I understand why– *both* reasons. Catra was responsible for Angella disappearing, and stopping her could deal a major blow to the New Horde. But is this *really* for the best?"

"Is this going to be some exercise in morality?" asked Hordak, irritated at the prospect. "In case you forgot, I am not exactly the person to talk to about showing mercy to your enemies."

"No, no, that's not what I meant," Bow said. "Well…not the *only* thing I meant. As bad as she is, I'm not exactly comfortable with the idea of killing Catra, but…I imagine Adora would be much less so. Sure, they're enemies now, but they used to be friends. Can you imagine what would happen when Adora finds out her new friend is conspiring to murder her old friend behind her back? What would something like that do to her? What would that do to *them* ?" He looked off into the distance worriedly.

Hordak smiled, but it was not one of malice or sadism–more one of sympathy. "Ah, it seems you are trapped in a web of obligations," he said. "You are equally dedicated to both of them, and yet the dedication to one leads to the betrayal of the other."

Bow nodded solemnly. "That about sums it up. If I tell Adora about what Glimmer has planned, Glimmer would never forgive me. But if Adora finds out I knew but didn't tell her, then *she'll* never forgive me. No matter what I do here, I'm betraying the trust of one of my best friends!"

Just then, Hordak did what neither of them ever believed he would do: he patted Bow on the back. "Chin up. This problem may seem insurmountable now, but a solution will come to you in time. After all my years in the Horde, both leading and serving, one thing that has become abundantly clear to me is that one always does. It may take hours, it may take years, but every problem has an answer."

Although this response seemed to get through to Bow, he was still quite morose about his situation. "Yeah…only we don't *have* years," he said. He slowly got to his feet. "You're right, though. I guess all I can do now is wait. I…I think I'm gonna get back to working on the ship."

"You do that," Hordak said, his eyes closed. He appeared to be pondering something of his own. "If it's all the same to you, I think I'll stay here just a bit longer."

"Take your time!" With that, Bow picked up his tools, slowly crawling into another one of the ship's thrusters. Not long after he disappeared within, Peridot appeared. She strolled out from inside the ship, looking nervous.

"S-so," she asked, "how are things going out here? Repairs proceeding as planned?"

Hordak briefly opened an eye. "Yes, I'd say things are going well. The same on your end?"

"Yeah, yeah, pretty good," she answered. "I've pretty much got the navigation systems up and running." She looked around, confirming that they were alone. "Could I…tell you something? Scientist to scientist?"

Turning himself towards her, Hordak gave her his full attention. "I suppose so. It wouldn't be the first time I've been confided in."

"Right, Entrapta," Peridot said quietly, misunderstanding his meaning. "So…I have something of a dilemma. I don't know if you heard, but apparently, during the whole 'Etheria and Earth combining and then being deleted' fiasco, Adora ran into Light Hope."

"I believe she may have mentioned something about that," he said.

"So anyway, the other day, she told me that *she* told *her* a series of numbers, and she's been trying to figure out what they mean ever since. She theorized that they were coordinates of some kind, pointing to where she originally came from, and she asked me to help her decipher them."

Hordak nodded. "And the problem is…?"

"Well…this isn't the problem, but just now, I think I may have found out where she came from. I put the numbers into the computer, and they turned out some kind of First Ones base. But the actual problem is that she told me to keep this all a secret. Specifically, from Glimmer."

This was all starting to sound quite familiar. "I see. And what are her reasons for asking this?" asked Hordak.

Peridot shrugged. "I'm not sure. But what I do know is that… things haven't exactly been the best between those two. Ever since Glimmer became queen, they've seemed kind of *tense* . And I'm worried that if I tell Adora, she'll just leave, without telling Glimmer why or where for."

"I see," Hordak said. "You're worried about their already-frayed relationship reaching its breaking point, is that it?"

She nodded. "It's just…things haven't always been the best for me as far as relationships go. I mean, I'm friends with Steven and the Crystal Gems now, but we got off to a pretty rocky start. Lapis especially didn't trust me at first–I'm worried she *still* doesn't, to a degree. And then I was 'science buddies' with Entrapta for a while…" She decided to leave out this touchy subject. "...Nevermind. What I'm trying to say is, I want to help Adora, but I don't want to be responsible for ruining her friendship with Glimmer. But no matter what I do, one of them is going to end up getting mad at me."

This was sounding *very* familiar. "I may not be the best when it comes to 'friendship,' but I can tell you that the answers will come in time. Just do what your heart–Gem, rather–tells you is best for everyone."

Just as with Bow, Peridot took this explanation, but it didn't seem to cheer her up. "Best for everyone…that's gonna be a bit tricky. I'll, uh, see what I can do to fix the startup sequence. Let me know when Bow's out of there, okay?" She headed back inside to continue her work on the ship.

And so Hordak sat, pondering what he had just been told. The two of them had just about the exact same problem, coming from two different sources. But it was the differences, not the similarities, that really intrigued him. Glimmer was keeping secrets from Adora. Adora was keeping secrets from Glimmer. "Hmm…this is going to be very interesting indeed."

# After All This Time

Chapter Summary

Scorpia and Micah are captured by Modulok's forces.

Chapter Nine: After All This Time

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Both Scorpia and Micah walked down the path towards the ramshackle village, hands over their heads under threat of being bitten by hundreds of scraper beetles. Black–or rather, Mosquitor, as he called himself–looked rather pleased with himself as he led them there. "This is a nice staff you have made for yourself, Micah," he said, admiring the item in question. "I think I shall keep it as a trophy. A token proving that my nemesis has finally been vanquished!"

Micah rolled his eyes. "I'll bet he wishes I was his nemesis," he said quietly to Scorpia. They both grinned, only to be jolted back by some of the beetles giving them a flyby.

"No camaraderie for captives!" Mosquitor hissed. The five of them continued walking, soon reaching the Mutant village.

As they entered the gates, Scorpia was surprised by just how many people lived here. Hordak had banished his fair share of people to Beast Island, but she had no idea it was *this* many. Either Hordak was even more ruthless than she thought, or someone else had been bringing them here–and with what little she knew of Modulok, either option was just as likely.

As the tribe's name suggested, all of the Mutants bore some form of, well, mutation. Some were recognizable as various races from all over Etheria, while others resembled creatures Scorpia couldn't have imagined, most of them some breed of nightmarish. But they had built their own little civilization here, and she couldn't decide if that was inspiring or foreboding.

“Halt!” Before she knew it, they had reached the ship. All of them stopped as it loomed over them, like some kind of effigy carved from obsidian. “You will show respect to our master when he makes his appearance.” To illustrate his point, Mosquitor had the scraper beetles fly a little closer to them.

“What, does he want us to bow?” Scorpia asked.

Micah shrugged, little more than annoyed at their predicament. “Who knows with this guy. I wouldn’t be surprised if they worship that freak.”

With a loud hiss, the ship’s ramp began to descend. “Silence! Master Modulok approaches!” All of the Mutants quietly awaited their master’s imminent arrival, eagerly waiting for the doors to open. When the ramp locked in place, he descended, with Scorpia slightly recoiling at his appearance. However, he was joined by another figure, one that had the two of them shocked by her appearance.

“S-shadow Weaver…?” Micah said, stunned. The sorceress in question descended the ramp, standing beside Modulok at the bottom. “But…what…why? How? What are you doing?”

Even from behind her mask, she looked amused. “Surprised to see me, dear boy? I can’t imagine why you would be. You yourself said I’m only after power, did you not? And with the Horde in shambles, the Surgeon is now the most powerful person on Etheria.”

“And soon to the most powerful person in the universe,” Modulok added smugly. “But enough boasting–Black, do you have the sample?”

Mosquitor stepped forward, looking much meeker in the presence of his master. “I do, sir. Here you are, sir.” He held out his hand, and from under his armor–at least, Scorpia hoped it was under his armor, and not his skin–his namesake insect crawled, full of blood. Modulok held out a small glass canister, into which it went. “Ice

princess was the hardest, as my children can't survive up there for long. We had to wait for her to be somewhere warmer."

*Hang on, is* he *the reason the mosquitoes have been so bad recently?* Scorpia thought to herself.

Modulok took a moment to examine the insect. "Yes, this should be enough. Double Trouble, would you put this one with the others?"

Much to Scorpia's surprise, a third figure had appeared from the ship, one which she hadn't noticed at first. "Why certainly!" said Double Trouble, taking the canister. "It would be my utmost pleasure!" They offered a grandiose bow, before heading back up onto the ship.

"Now, that makes light, wind, ice…I do believe we have them all," Moduok said. "All except for one. One which, to my pleasant surprise, you have brought right to me, Black." His gaze was fixed on Scorpia.

She looked around. "Uh, me? A-and what exactly do you need with me?"

"Nothing you need to be concerned about," said Modulok, producing a large syringe as he approached her. "For clarity's sake, let's just say I'm completing my collection of princesses. Indirectly, I assure you." She shied away from the device as it came closer to her arm.

"Thing about that is, ah, I'm not big on needles," she said. "Especially when some weird guy wants my blood for reasons I don't know, and–Yah!" The sudden jabbing of the needle into her arm caused her to jolt, knocking Modulok away with her claw. The two guards went over to help him, as Mosquitor angrily brought his bugs closer. "Sorry, sorry! It's a reflex!" Shadow Weaver did nothing to help him, simply watching as he fell, almost amused.

As they helped him to his feet, Modulok shoved off the guards. "Get away, get away! I'm not so helpless I need you fussing over

me like a child! Merely a fleshwound." It didn't look like a fleshwound, as there was a sizable gash down the length of his face. But he didn't seem to care in the slightest, simply examining the syringe. "No matter; this should be enough."

"What shall we do with these two?" asked Mosquitor. With the way he glared at Scorpia, it was clear what he *wanted* to do with them. The beetles buzzed hungrily.

Much to Scorpia's surprise, the cut on Modulok's face had already begun to heal. Within seconds, there wasn't so much as a scar left. He waved his hand dismissively; "Do what you will with the princess, but Shadow Weaver has requested that Micah be brought along. Load him onto the ship."

The two guards did just that, bringing him closer to Shadow Weaver. She noticed his dissatisfaction, gently stroking his cheek. "Oh, there's no need to be upset, dear. Now things can finally be how they were supposed to. I can teach you everything you ever wanted to know about magic–I've learned quite a few new tricks in my time."

"I've learned all I need to know, thank you very much," he growled. "But if you want to take me off this accursed island, fine–as long as she comes too!" He looked over at Scorpia.

Modulok impatiently shoved him up the ramp. "Not a chance. We're not taking the brute with us. Black, please handle this."

"With pleasure!" Mosquitor directed his bugs towards her, corralling her in place. She looked around for an escape, but she was completely surrounded. He apparently wanted to savor the moment, as instead of siccing them on her all at once, he instead had the swarm slowly draw closer and closer. Individual beetles zipped past her, leaving sizable cuts where they bit into her skin. She swatted at them with her claws, but they were too small, and too numerous.

Seeing his new friend in danger, Micah made quick work of the guards holding him. He elbowed one in the stomach, pushing him into the other before shoving past Modulok. "Let her go!" he yelled, running towards Mosquitor to retrieve his staff. Unfortunately, he was halted in his tracks as many shadowy hands grabbed onto him, pulling him back towards Shadow Weaver.

"I didn't come all the way here to watch you run away again," she said, watching as he struggled. "You should be grateful: if not for me, you would be sharing her fate."

Micah glared at his former mentor. "And why should *she* have that fate?" he asked. "Her time with me, her loyalty to the Horde, to *you* , that means nothing?"

Her eyes narrowed. "No. No, it means nothing."

Things weren't looking good for the pair. Scorpia was about to be devoured, and there was little Micah could do without his magic. "C'mon, Scorpia, do the thing!" she said to herself. "Just do what you did last time!" She tried to remember when she was attacked by that monster; all the culmination of emotions she had felt at the time. Right now, she was afraid, concerned, angry…and that seemed to be enough. Her eyes opened, glowing red.

All of the nearby shadows flowed into her, covering her like armor. Then they became armor, as her body began to twist and distort, nearly tripling in size. Everyone watched her in awe, and no small amount of terror, as she became a gigantic scorpion.

Mosquitor wasted no time in sending the swarm at her, but it was no use; her carapace was too hard for the scraper beetles to bite through. They collided uselessly with her form as she rushed him, unable to stop her from knocking her master away with a swing of her tail.

As Scorpia fought off the Mutants trying to subdue her, Micah was momentarily forgotten by his captors. "How long has she been able to do that?" asked Shadow Weaver, using her magic to try

and tie the behemoth down. But Scorpia simply shrugged off her magic, just as she did the guards' attacks.

"And here I thought you were something of an expert in the Black Garnet's power," Modulok said. He produced another device, this one resembling a small metal crossbow. He took aim at Scorpia, firing a small syringe filled with an orange liquid. However, he ran into the same problem as his subordinates, as the needle shattered against her hard shell. His failure was met with a glare from Shadow Weaver. "Ah. That's somewhat embarrassing."

With everyone preoccupied, Micah had managed to sneak away, heading for his discarded staff. Just as he reached down to grab it, another hand grabbed hold as well. "I'm not about to let you slip through my fingers again," Mosquitor hissed, "especially now that you're right within my–"

Rather than any sort of magical attack, Mosquitor was felled by a sucker punch from Micah. "Save it, would you?" he said, reclaiming his staff. A sigil appeared in front of his hand as he unleashed a blast of magical fire, knocking all of the Mutants off of Scorpia. "Come on, Scorpia, it's time to go!"

The two of them met, and Scorpia lifted Micah up onto her back. With surprising speed she ran from the village, the king launching magical projectiles at any Mutant who tried to follow them. She tore a path through the foliage, heading out further into Beast Island and leaving their captors behind.

Modulok growled in frustration. "Yet another endeavor failed due to incompetence." He was quick to calm down, heading back up to the ship. "No matter–we got what we came here for. Black, contact me if and when you apprehend those two."

"Gladly, Master Modulok," Mosquitor said. He and an army of mutants set off in the direction the escapees had gone.

Shadow Weaver refused to board the ship. "You're giving up? One slip-up, and you're willing to abandon the entire reason we came

here?”

He sighed, turning to face her. “No, Shadow Weaver, I’m willing to abandon the entire reason *you* came here. My objective was obtaining the blood of the princesses, which I have done. Reuniting you with Micah was simply a bonus, one which I am no worse off to be without. Now come–there is still much we have to do.”

Disappearing into the darkness, Shadow Weaver reappeared in front of him. “And what,” she asked menacingly, “is stopping me from *making* you stay?”

If Modulok was intimidated, he didn’t show it. “If I recall, my end of the deal was giving you Adora, not Micah. And I will deliver, but do not forget, you have your own end to fulfill, as well. The Mutants will handle the deposed king, now might we be off?”

Reluctantly, Shadow Weaver stepped aside. “Yes. We may.” She continued to stare daggers at Modulok as he went past her, her patience with their ‘deal’ growing thinner by the day. As long as he was useful…

Mosquitor and his Mutants followed the path after Scorpia. Not that it was hard, given that it was like following a bulldozer, given the amount of destruction she had left. But over time, the path of broken trees and torn-up underbrush got thinner, with Scorpia returning to her true form. There was still a sizable path to follow, however, and follow it they did. “Hunt them down!” he bellowed. “I want the king in chains, and her stinger mounted on my wall!”

The hunting party passed over a small creek, only a few bothering to glance over at the waterfall near its source. But even if they had given it a closer look, none of them would have seen the cave hidden underneath it. The cave had been obscured by a quick spell from Micah, as he and Scorpia watched anxiously as the Mutants headed past.

They both sighed in relief once they were safe–for now. "Okay. I think they're gone, but let's stay here a bit longer, just in case." The two sat in awkward silence for a bit, only the sound of trickling water filling the cave. After a bit, he spoke again. "So… you didn't tell me you could do that."

"Didn't know I could until a few days ago," Scorpia said. "After that, I, uh, kinda had other things on my mind." She was silent for a bit as well, running her claw through the dirt. "So…you know Shadow Weaver too, huh?"

" *Know* her? She was my mentor back in Mystacor," he said, smiling, which didn't last long. "Back then, she was known as Light Spinner. Back before she sort of betrayed us by learning forbidden magics and running off to join the Horde. I wonder how she got involved with someone like Modulok."

"I don't know all the details, but I know she and Hordak had something of a disagreement a few years back," Scorpia said. "Then she escaped from prison, and nobody's seen her since."

This didn't seem to surprise him. "History repeats," he said. Scorpia recognized the look on his face. It was the same look she had on hers when thinking about Catra. About how she had betrayed her and left her here.

"Is she who you were talking about?" Scorpia asked. "Back when we met, you said you knew what it's like to have someone choose power over you. You were talking about Shadow Weaver, weren't you?"

He nodded solemnly. "But we can't focus on that now," he said, getting to his feet. "Right now, we need a plan to bust into that village and steal that ship! With my magic, and you gargantuan-ness, there's no way we can fail!"

"Yeah!" A thought occurred to Scorpia. "Wait, wasn't Modulok just about to leave? He'll be long gone by now, won't he?"

"No, no, his backup ship," Micah explained. "Modulok's not the type to let himself be backed into a corner. I have it on good authority he has a second ship hidden somewhere in the village, just in case something were to happen. That ship's our ticket back to Brightmoon!"

Scorpia got to her feet as well. "Great! Then let's…" She trailed off. "Hang on, you said 'back to Brightmoon?' Does that mean I…I'm coming there too?"

"And why not?" Micah sounded confused. "Given everything that happened to you, I doubt you'd want to go back to the Fright Zone. And if you've got nowhere else to go, then…why not come back with me? We are friends, after all, right?"

Scorpia almost teared up at this gesture of kindness. "Yes. Yes we are friends." She walked over and wrapped her arms around Micah. "I promise you, you're majesty, I'm gonna get you home to your daughter."

Clearly feeling the sentiment, Micah hugged her back. After a bit, they stepped back. "I appreciate that, Scorpia. You don't know how much I do. Now come on–let's get to work!"

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"Is it weird that this feels so…official?" asked Lars, walking into the throne room. "I mean, back before Glimmer was queen, her asking to talk with us would just be sort of 'Oh yeah, what's up?' But now, it's a summons from the queen herself! You know?"

"...I predict I will have no idea what Lars is talking about," said Padparadscha.

Glimmer had summoned for the Off-Colors, but for what reason, she hadn't specified. Whatever it was, it was likely important, so they had all hurried to see her. With them assembled, she got off the throne to approach.

“Good, you’re here,” she said. There was a slight urgency in her tone. “I know this is short notice, but I’d like to keep this under wraps if possible.”

“Ooof cooourse,” said Fluorite. “Whaaat dooo you neeeeed, yoooour hiiiighneeess?”

“I’ll keep this brief: I sent a team to repair Mara’s ship out in the Crimson Waste. Seeing as how all of you know your way around piloting a ship, and have recently lost your own, you seemed like the best choice to give this one to.”

“Wow, a new ship!” said Rhodonite. “...Hang on, why do we need to keep this a secret?”

Glimmer hesitated, as though knowing this question was coming. “That’s… Let me put it this way. You don’t have to keep the ship a secret, but…I’m not giving to you for free. There’s a certain mission I’d like you to run, one that I’d rather nobody else know about. And no, I’m not telling you any more than that. Just know that it’s classified, strictly need-to-know.”

“Um…well, not to come off as insubordinate or anything, but if *we’re* doing this mission, wouldn’t *we* need to know?” Lars asked. “Just sayin’.”

Before Glimmer could snap at him, someone else entered the room. “Uh, Glimmer? I mean, Queen Glimmer?” Mermista approached, but something was definitely off. She seemed much more anxious than usual, as though walking on eggshells. “We’ve got something of a problem…”

She groaned, teleporting over to her. “How much of a problem is it?”

“Well, it’s…” She looked over at the Off-Colors. “It’s the kind that maybe we don’t want them hearing about.”

“Whatever it is, we won’t tell anyone,” said the left Rutile sister. “Yeah, we’ve got lots of practice at keeping secrets!” added her

right sister.

Thinking for a moment, Glimmer grabbed onto Mermista and teleported them both up to her room. "Okay, so what is it?" she asked.

Once Mermista got her bearings, she told her the news. "So, I just got word that there was a tavern brawl in a town on the edge of Salineas. That sort of thing happens all the time, but it's who was involved that got alarm bells ringing. One of the witnesses provided a sketch."

She showed Glimmer the drawing, which, although not a dead ringer, definitely implied someone they knew all too well. The woman's most striking features were her pointed ears and her mismatched eyes, both of which were unmistakable. Glimmer was quiet for a time as she examined the picture. "You're sure this is her?"

"Who else could it be?" replied Mermista. "I don't know why she's here, or why she's starting bar fights, but…Catra's on Etheria."

More silence from Glimmer, who rolled up the parchment and handed it back. "Round up every soldier you have, and hunt her down," she said, eerily calm.

"I will," Mermista said. "But don't you think that–"

Glimmer teleported back into the throne room, startling everyone with her sudden appearance. "Okay, to recap: you're getting a new ship, which you can tell everyone about, but you also need to fly it on a certain mission, which you *can't* tell anyone about. Dismissed." With that, she left the throne room behind, heading for the war room.

Everyone was left confused, with more questions than answers. "What was that about?" asked Lars. "Pads, you see anything?"

The Sapphire peered into the past. "I can see…someone returning. But it's too murky, I can't see who. It could be Glimmer,

or it could be us."

"Or it could be one of our greatest enemies, returning from beyond the grave to seek vengeance!" said a worried Rhodonite.

"Nooow nooow," assured Fluorite, "leeet's nooot juuump tooo coooncluusions."

Lars nodded. "Yeah, that could mean anything. Let's focus on the important things now: like the fact that Captain Lars and the Off-Colors are starbound once more!"

As Glimmer paced through the halls, she silently seethed with rage. Why was Catra back? What was she planning!? Whatever it was, she would *not* let her catch her by surprise. This time, she would make the first move. And this time, she would hold nothing back.

# Fury

Chapter Summary

Under Jasper's tutelage, Steven grows more accustomed to the Sword of Power. Emerald's faith in Catra begins to wane.

Chapter Ten: Fury

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Having found somewhere with enough space to duel, Steven and Jasper both readied themselves for the fight. “Remember: you can’t fight like you’re used to,” she reminded him. “You’re a warrior now, not a healer. So fight like one!”

“Catra’s army of robots might tell a different story!” he replied, swinging the Sword of Power around. “Emerald could probably vouch for my skill, too.”

“‘Skill?’ Don’t make me laugh,” said Jasper. “What you have now isn’t skill, it’s raw power. That may be enough to get you through a few basic scraps, but against the New Horde’s higher-ups? They’ll wear you down, then shatter you to pieces. The only way you’ll stand a chance is if you’re honed from a hunk of raw ore into a fine blade. And I’m just the blacksmith to do that–now say the words!”

Steven held the Sword of Power aloft. “By the Power of Grayskull!” He could feel ancient energy flowing into him through the sword, transforming him into a mighty warrior. Now able to match Jasper in size and strength, he assumed a battle stance. “Don’t think I’ll go easy on you this time!”

Jasper sneered. “Me either.” She launched herself at him in a burst of speed, delivering a punch before he could block. Her fist collided with his chest, and though his armor protected him, he still slid back several feet. He responded with an uppercut with the blade, though Jasper sidestepped his attack and delivered another

punch straight to his jaw. This one sent him reeling a bit, but he quickly recovered.

Putting all his strength into his slashes, He-Man cut through the air with enough force to create small gusts with every swing. But it still wasn't enough to catch Jasper, who could easily anticipate his attacks. Apparently growing tired of his efforts, she caught him by the wrist, before knocking him off his feet with a kick. Steven fell to the ground, where Jasper threw another punch. Her fist stopped inches from his face.

"If I was still trying to kill you, I would have just now," she said. She walked away, not bothering to help him back up. "It's not enough to throw your weight around! You need to be precise, efficient! It doesn't take genius, it just takes anticipating an enemy's movements, and then acting accordingly."

Steven let out an irritated huff as he got back up. "You might be good at fighting, but not so much at teaching!" he groaned. "How is repeatedly kicking me to the dirt going to help me learn how to be a better fighter!?"

"This is how *I* learned," Jasper said, "and look how I turned out! Even as the ultimate Quartz, I wouldn't be the fighting machine I am today if I hadn't learned how to throw a punch–or to take one! I am a warrior tempered by time and pain, and if you want to master that sword, it'll *take* time and pain. Round two!" She charged at Steven, giving him barely enough time to react.

His first instinct was to hold the sword up like a shield, a maneuver which she easily subverted. Jasper darted behind him, grabbing hold of his shoulder and hurling him against a nearby tree. Steven grunted as his body collided with the trunk, rolling out of the way before Jasper's fist dug a hole into the bark. He swung, creating a small cut in her leg, but it healed almost instantly.

Jasper moved quickly, diverting his blade when he tried to swing it again. "Stop playing defensively!" she bellowed, grabbing hold of

his collar. He tried to break free by bringing his sword down atop her head, but her helmet put a stop to that. “Find your anger; use that!” She threw him a good distance away, where he landed hard on his back. He got his bearings just in time to block an attack from above.

Lying on the ground, Steven’s sword was struck by Jasper’s fist, the two of them struggling against the other. “I don’t *have* any anger!” said Steven, almost sounding angry at this fact.

“Then find some!” Jasper leapt over Steven to avoid his sword, pounding her helmet down hard against his face. His new form protected him, but it was still a devastating impact. “You can’t win all your fights with hand-holding and cheery songs!” She lifted him up again, before knocking him back to the ground with another headbutt. “Now *get angry* !”

Steven’s hand tightened around the sword’s hilt. His breathing picked up as he gritted his teeth. With his powers still gone, and unable to master He-Man’s powers, he had been feeling pretty useless for a while now. And he was unsure how exactly that made him feel. But now, Jasper had reminded him: he felt *angry* . Angry at himself, angry at Emerald and Catra, but right now, he was angry at Jasper. “You want me to get angry?” he growled. “How about I get *furious* ?”

Steven threw his sword at Jasper, who, confused by the maneuver, easily sidestepped the weapon. She looked back too late to realize the true purpose of this tactic, as he was then upon her, delivering a punch powerful enough to shatter her visor.

Reeling from the impact, Jasper held a hand up to her jaw. “Huh… now we’re getting somewhere!” she said, wearing a smile of bloodlust. She returned to the fray, throwing another punch, this one Steven blocked with his arm. He punched with his free hand, but Jasper lowered her helmet to block. With the two trapped in a lock, Steven raised his knee, kicking Jasper and knocking her back.

As the two of them traded blows, Steven felt himself being overcome by a feeling of ecstasy, the likes of which he had never felt. He was supposed to be angry–he *was* angry, so why did it feel so… *good* ? Even as Jasper's fists rained down against him, he couldn't help but smile, even as he roared with fury. All of his worries and concerns, everything outside of their fight, it all simply faded into the background. This was where he belonged.

Another punch from Steven was caught by Jasper, who twisted his arm as though to break it. He repeatedly drove his free fist against her face, but she refused to let go. He was finally able to break free by slamming his arm into her elbow, wrapping his arms around her torso. He then hoisted her above his head, hurling her away.

But such an attack wasn't going to have Jasper down for long. As soon as she hit the ground, she rolled into a ball, speeding towards Steven. He blocked the attack by holding his arms in front of his chest; the two of them struggled as Jasper clashed against Steven's bracers. Jasper broke through his defenses when she uncurled and slammed her helmet into his face. While he was stunned, she caught him in a headlock.

"I'm definitely seeing improvement!" she said, holding him in place. "But it's not enough! Throwing away your sword was your first mistake–you'll need to use all the tools at your disposal to beat me!"

"You mean like this?" Steven held his hand against Jasper's shoulder. Unseen by her, the discarded Sword of Power behind her slid forward on the ground before rocketing towards its owner's hand, this time blade-first. Jasper roared in pain as it pierced through her side, letting go of Steven. "Not just raw power now, am I?"

With Jasper reeling from the attack, Steven moved to reclaim his blade. He grabbed hold of the handle to remove it, but rather than pull it out straight, he moved it like a lever, further cutting into Jasper's form. She bellowed again, shoving him back. But he

already had a tight grip on the hilt–this movement was the last straw, and Jasper's arm was severed completely. She held the stump in shock, looking down at her fallen limb. But soon, her own rage bubbled up, and she hurled herself at him.

Even with only one arm, a punch from Jasper would have been more than enough to flatten any opponent. But Steven was no ordinary opponent, especially now. He deflected the blow with the blunt side of his blade, before swinging his sword back around and slicing through her midsection. Jasper fell to her knees, and Steven prepared to deal the final blow.

Jasper opened her eyes. Steven had roared as though to finish her off, but the Sword of Power was now mere inches from her Gem. Panting, Steven smiled as he loomed over her. "If I was still trying to kill you," he said, "I would have just now."

Rather than being upset at being defeated and nearly killed, Jasper was instead proud to see such bloodlust in her new pupil. A wide smile matching Steven's appeared on her face as she got back up. "Now you're starting to show some promise! With anger like that, I'll make a warrior out of you yet!" She picked her arm up off the ground, putting it back in place where it reattached itself quickly.

"That was…I've never felt that way before!" Steven said, pacing about excitedly. "The excitement, that–that *rush* , it's like I was on cloud nine for that whole fight! No wonder you like battling so much!"

Jasper felt her side, where the cut was beginning to repair itself as well. "Glad you can see things my way, kid," she said. "Alright, I think you've earned a break. Come and see me when you want to–"

But to her surprise, Steven was in no mood for a break. "Are you kidding? I'm just getting started!" he said, swinging his sword around. "I feel like I could take on one of the Diamonds! No, I could take on all three at once! C'mon, let's go again!"

"Now you're speaking my language!" Jasper said. The two of them retook their positions in the courtyard, preparing for another match. Unbeknownst to them, they had something of an audience: through a window on the castle's upper floor, Connie had watched their bout with growing concern. Although she couldn't hear Steven's words, his excitement and glee were visible even from afar.

As much as Connie wanted to tear herself away from the sight, she couldn't. "Steven…what is she doing to you?" she wondered aloud, watching in horror as Jasper's teachings rubbed off on him. How much longer would she allow this to go on for?

A better question would be, how long would *Steven* let this go on for?

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Sqalish hit the ground with a thud. "You idiot!" Catra hissed. "We had that fool right where we wanted him! He could've led us right to the Heart, but you couldn't swallow your pride for *one minute* ! Now the Princess Alliance is no doubt on to us, all because you just had to show up your old rival!"

"Sounds familiar," Sqalish growled. He tried to get up, but was kicked back down by Catra.

"Do. Not. Go. There." she said, her claws twitching. "You don't have the right to speak to me like that! *I'm* the one who rebuilt the Horde from the ground up–what did *you* do?" At the risk of being hit again, he stayed silent. "I thought so. Now let's keep moving."

Although Carnelian was amused by seeing Catra wail on Sqalish, she could recognize when Catra's temper was clouding her judgment. "Uh…moving to where?" she asked. Catra's ear twitched, but she didn't lash out…yet. "N-not that I'm questioning your leadership or anything, I was just wondering what your plan is! The plan that I'm certain you have, of course."

Catra let out a harsh sigh. “Alright, you want to know the plan? The plan is to lay low, because *someone* put all of Salineas on high alert! We can’t look for the Heart of Etheria with all of the princesses breathing down our necks, which they no doubt will be now that we’ve exposed ourselves like that. All we can do now is hope that Azurite and the others are more competent than you two.”

“How ‘bout the Fright Zone?” suggested Carnelian, at the risk of further angering Catra. “We could go there! They’ll never suspect that!”

Sqalish glared at her. “Are you dense!? The old Horde capital is exactly where they’ll suspect we went!”

“Maybe, but what if we use that to our advantage?” she replied. “Like, they won’t suspect us going there because it’s too obvious, but we *will* go there specifically because it *would* be the obvious choice, thereby making it *less* obvious! How’s that for strategy?”

For a long while, Sqalish just stared at her. “...Your understanding of reverse psychology is murky at best,” he said. “What do you suggest we do, Empress?”

After considering it for a bit, Catra decided. “Okay. Your reasoning behind it is flawed, but you might be onto something in going to the Fright Zone.” Carnelian smiled proudly. “But! The place is bound to be crawling with Hordak’s loyalists, so we have to lay low. Luckily for you both, I know the place like the back of my hand. And maybe…maybe Entrapta left some of her research behind. We might be able to find more out about the Heart.”

“Excellent. Then let’s get moving,” said Sqalish. “The sooner we can get as far away from Kenek as possible, the better.”

“How true,” Catra muttered, leading the three of them towards the Fright Zone.

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“Entrapta? Entrapta!?” Emerald strolled through the halls of the *Supermassive* , calling the scientist’s name. “Where could she have run off to? You there, Amethyst! When was the last time you saw Entrapta?”

The Amethyst was surprised by her commander’s sudden appearance. “W-who, me? Oh, I, uh…I think she was with you?”

Emerald groaned. “Useless, utterly useless! With Catra off on her Etheria adventure and Entrapta getting distracted at every turn, I have to run this whole circus myself! And with the way things are going, Ophidia isn’t going to be conquered any time soon.” She headed for the command bridge, with the Amethyst close on her heels.

“Uh, if I may, My Emerald…” she said hesitantly, “why are taking this place over again? I feel like it doesn’t offer up much advantage, strategy-wise.”

Emerald rolled her eyes. “And that is why you’re just a lowly Quartz. Ophidia and its people have stood unconquered for millennia! Homeworld couldn’t take them, Horde Prime couldn’t take them…but we will. We’ll claim their bountiful resources, and further the expansion of the New Horde all across the universe. Empress Catra has assured me that Hordak’s followers will be more than happy to join us once they see the extent of our power.”

“It’s just that, um, that Catra doesn’t seem all that trustworthy, does she?” said the Amethyst. “I get that she knows how to take charge, but…so do you, right? I dunno. It just feels like she’s distracting you with this place while she goes off and takes care of the important stuff back on Etheria.”

“I’d watch your tone if I were you,” Emerald said. “Catra and I may…disagree from time to time, but she is still a respectable fellow conqueror. And with the conquest of Ophidia, I will have accomplished what even the Diamonds–even Horde Prime–failed to do!”

Amethyst wrung her hands nervously. “Right, it just feels to me like maybe she’s taking advantage of your need to feel superior,” she suggested. “Like how you want to prove yourself better than Horde Prime–”

“I *am* better than Horde Prime!” Emerald shouted, pounding her fist into the table. “I know that because *I killed him* ! The graveyard of his ships currently orbiting Krytis is testament to that!” Breathing heavily, she managed to calm herself after her outburst. “Ahem…apologies. But you would do well not to question me again!”

Frightened by her shouting, Amethyst had recoiled in fear. “Uh-huh, yeah, absolutely, My Emerald. I-is there anything I can do for you?”

“Yes, actually, there is. Go and fetch Entrapta. I have much to discuss with her regarding…well, you know.”

“Right away, My Emerald!” Amethyst ran out the door, her footsteps receding into the distance. But as soon as she was out of sight, she hid, her frightened expression turning mischievous. A thin membrane blinked across ‘her’ eyes as they turned red. Their body shifted into murky blackness, and Double Trouble resumed the form of Entrapta.

Emerald was none the wiser, thinking that the purple-haired gadgeteer entering the room was the genuine article. “ *There* you are! I’ve been calling your name all morning! What exactly were you up to that was so important that you couldn’t be bothered to show up?”

“Sorry about that, just working on some modifications for Emily!” she said, sitting down at the table eagerly. “So, what did you want to talk to me about?”

“Well, I was initially planning to review our current strategies, but instead I have to ask…Entrapta, you’ve been friends with Catra for some time, yes? Might I ask, what exactly do you think of her?”

“Oh, Catra’s my friend!” Entrapta said cheerfully. “She can be a bit tricky sometimes, though. I used to be part of the Princess Alliance, but she convinced me it’d be better to join the Horde. She’s pretty good at convincing people to go along with her.”

This was intriguing to Emerald. “Hmm…I see. So you would say that manipulating people is a regular occurrence for her?”

Entrapta nodded. “Definitely! Friend or foe, she’s not comfortable unless she has everyone around her on a string. Just one of her little quirks, you know? I’ve learned to live with it. Why? She isn’t back yet, is she?”

“No, not yet,” Emerald said, thoughtfully staring out the window at the space beyond. “And there’s no telling when she’ll be back. Perhaps never? The Heart of Etheria must be difficult to find, surely…”

Entrapta stared at her blankly, hiding the fact that she knew exactly what she had done: the seed of doubt had been planted. Emerald was beginning to distrust Catra, and discontent was soon to follow. “So, what now, boss?”

“‘Boss,’ hmm?” Emerald said, enjoying how that sounded. “Perhaps we will discuss our strategy after all. Who knows? If taking Ophidius proves not to be worth the effort and resources, we may have to take our conquest…elsewhere…”

“Sure thing!” said Entrapta, ‘her’ eyes momentarily flashing red. “Whatever you say! Without Catra, you’re the one in charge, after all!”

# Tension Building

Chapter Summary

Bluebird, Crita, and Karikon run into someone in the woods. Modulok shows Entrapta his inner sanctum, and Peridot reports her findings back to Adora.

Chapter Eleven: Tension Building

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Trees. Trees here, trees there, trees every which way you looked. And with no other landmarks in sight, it was all but impossible for the trio to tell which way they were going versus which way they had been. "I'm not hearing a lot of whispering," Crita said. "They should call this place the Wandering Woods, because that's all we seem to be doing."

Bluebird turned around in a huff. "Well, that's hardly *my* fault!" she said in a huff. "Even from above, everything in this place looks the same!"

"I never said it was your fault…" Crita muttered. Tensions had been rising since they arrived, not helped by Catra not being there to keep them in line.

"Why don't we just set this whole place on fire?" suggested Karikon. "We wait for it to burn, and then we march to Brightmoon through the ashes. Problem solved."

Crita shot him a glance. "Are you seriously suggesting that? I shouldn't even need to explain to you why that's a terrible idea… but I will anyway. First of all, a forest fire would only draw attention to us, which is the last thing we want. Second, do you have any idea how long it would take for an entire forest to burn down? More than we have!"

Karikon had stopped listening. “Uh-huh, yeah, cool. Are you sure we aren’t gonna die here? Because if I am gonna die on this planet, I’d rather it not be wandering around in some woods.”

“We aren’t lost!” snapped Bluebird. “Brightmoon is to the east of the Whispering Woods, that much I know. So, all we need to do is keep going west, and we’re there! And this way is west.” She kept flying on, with the other two following her.

“Is it?” Crita asked, though quietly enough for Bluebird not to hear her. “Maybe your fire idea isn’t the worst…”

“Shush!” Bluebird stopped them, hiding behind a tree. The pair joined her. “Enemy approaching! Stay low.” She peered around the tree at a sound that she had heard.

It was somebody singing–well, humming, but they weren’t alone. A rustic cabin sat in a small clearing that the three of them had stumbled upon, where someone, likely its owner, was hard at work just on the other side. “If we’re lost, then whoever that is must be *really* lost,” Crita said. “Who’d want to live out here?”

“An ally of the princesses, no doubt,” said Karikon, pounding his claws together. “C’mon, let’s give ‘em a pounding and get some answers!”

Crita held him back before he could give away their position to someone they knew nothing about. “Hold on there. This place used to be a lot more dangerous than it is now. Someone who actually lives here probably isn’t your normal woodsman.”

“Exactly as I thought, Crita,” said Bluebird. “I’ll scout ahead, move in when you hear the signal.” She flew up atop the tree, fluttering off to get a better look.

“...What exactly is the signal?” Karikon asked. Crita shrugged.

From up on her perch, Bluebird saw that the source of the noise was an elderly woman, sweeping leaves off her front walkway. “There, looking much nicer for when Mara comes to visit!” she

said. “Hmm?” She held her broom up to her ear as though listening to it. “Of course I had to do it myself! Whenever I let you do it, the leaves end up all over the place! Even on the roof!” She walked back into her house.

Bluebird whistled, flying over to another tree. When neither Karikon nor Crita moved, she angrily whistled again, signaling for them to move in. They each flanked from either side of the cabin, with Bluebird herself approaching the door. The old woman opened up after a knock.

“Oh, hello there, little one!” she said, smiling warmly at the visitor. “What’s a little Gem doing all the way out here? The woods are no place for a little thing like you–are you lost?”

“Something like that,” Bluebird replied. “We were on our way to Castle Brightmoon, but this place is like a maze! If you could point us in the right direction…”

“...It would really help us out.” Karikon and Crita emerged to surround the woman, looking as intimidating as possible. Despite that, she wasn’t afraid of them in the slightest, responding to their emergence with a cheery grin.

“Oh, more guests!” she said, clasping her hands together. “Come in, come in, I was just about to put the kettle on! It can’t have been easy, coming all this way. I’ll point you in the right direction just as soon as you’ve got your strength up!”

Just as she was about to walk back inside, Karikon put his hand on the door. “Quite the gracious host, aren’t you? Unfortunately, we don’t have the time to hang out. So why don’t you tell us what you need to know, and we’ll be on our way?”

The old woman stared at him for a moment, but the fact that he was threatening her didn’t seem to register. “Oh, that reminds me! I’m running low on firewood.” She strolled past the three over to some trees. “You seem like a big, strong lad. Be a dear and help me chop some trees, would you?”

"I'll chop more than those trees!" Karikon angrily made his way over to the woman as she disappeared behind a tree–literally. He arrived to find that she was nowhere to be found. "What the?" He rounded the tree in question a few times, even looking up to see if she had climbed it. "Where'd she go!?"

"You don't look to be around here." Crita jumped as the woman suddenly appeared behind her. "New allies of the princesses? Or are you visiting Brightmoon from a far away land?"

Crita looked around awkwardly, unsure of how to deal with this apparently-senile lady. "Um…look…?"

"Madame Razz!" she said. "But please, call me Razz."

"Right. Uh, Ms. Razz, sorry for being rude, but we're actually in somewhat of a hurry. See, we're on a very important mission to find a powerful First Ones artifact, and we think Brightmoon might have a clue to where we can find it. Or…do you think you know where it might be?"

"Oh, sure, just tell her our whole mission while you're at it!" said Bluebird. "She could be an ally of the princesses! She might warn them we're coming! And why would she know where the Heart of Etheria is!?"

"Yeah, and now she knows she *should* warn them, since you just told her!" Crita shot back. "And she's old, who knows what she's heard! I'm sorry, Razz, tensions have just been a bit high lately… hmm? What's the matter?"

Razz was giving her a strange look. It almost seemed like she was beginning to realize that the three of them were dangerous. "Where…where did you hear that name?" she asked worriedly. "Nobody should know about the Heart of Etheria. Mara made sure it would be lost forever!"

"I don't know who this 'Mara' is, and I don't really care," said Karikon. He approached her, doing his best to loom menacingly

over her. “Question is, how do *you* know about the Heart of Etheria?”

Concern had now washed over the old woman’s face, and not due to him. “The Heart of Etheria was the First Ones’ greatest weapon. With it, entire planets would have fallen before their might! It was only thanks to Mara that the universe was spared their wrath.” She approached Bluebird, trying to grab her hands only for the Gem to recoil. “Please, you must stop searching for this abomination! In the wrong hands, it could doom us all!”

Karikon lifted the woman up to face level. “Enough games, you senile old bag! Just tell us where we can find this thing, and nobody gets–ack!” Razz tossed a handful of dust into the scorpion’s face, scampering off as soon as she hit the ground. “Hey! You tricky old biddy!”

Bluebird growled in irritation. “If we get outsmarted by a grandma… Get after her! I’ll make sure she isn’t hiding anything.” She went inside Razz’s cabin, while the other two chased after her.

“Has it ever occurred to you that interrogating someone by shaking them like a ragdoll isn’t the best means of getting answers?” said Crita, chasing after Razz with her partner.

He shrugged. “Hey, it hasn’t failed me yet!” A pause. “Well, before now.” They managed to corner Razz in front of a rock. “No way to run, granny. Now, we can do this the easy way, or the hard way.”

Despite what her surroundings would imply, Razz wasn’t as trapped as she seemed. “Please…you must tell the child of Halfmoon that the Heart of Etheria is not to be trifled with.” Reaching a hand into her pouch, she threw a handful of dust to the ground. “Razzle Dazzle!” There was a blinding flash of light, disorienting the pair. When the light faded and their vision returned, Razz had disappeared, leaving no trace.

Crita looked around, throwing her arms up in frustration. "Great! Guess she chose the easy way. You're explaining to Bluebird that we really *were* outsmarted by a grandma."

"Bah, you give up too easily!" he replied. "She can't have gotten far with those old bones of hers. She has to be around here somewhere." While he went off to search for her, Crita went back to the cabin to report their failure.

It didn't seem like Bluebird had much luck either, as she was pacing angrily outside of the cabin. "Worthless!" she exclaimed. "For someone who knows more than she lets on, she doesn't keep a lot of secrets in her home." She noticed Crita approach alone and empty-handed. "Don't tell me she took the big guy!"

Despite her annoyance, the visual of Karikon being spirited away by the old woman made Crita crack a smile. "No, but she didn't stick around, either. She pulled some sort of disappearing act, but…before she left, she said something about 'the child of Halfmoon.' Do you have any idea what that could mean?"

"How should I?" replied Bluebird. "I don't know anything about this lousy planet except what was covered in briefings. She probably meant Brightmoon, but her old lady brain just got confused." She massaged her forehead. "Okay. As disappointing as this is, this wasn't a *complete* loss. We know more about the Heart of Etheria than we did before we came here. In fact, I'm sure Catra would be pleased to hear about this!" She took out her communicator, trying to contact their commander.

Karikon then returned, unsurprisingly empty-clawed. "That woman is either very fast or very magic," he said. "I couldn't find any trace of her, not even footprints! No wonder she's survived living out here by herself." He was quiet for a moment as they waited for Bluebird to finish her call. "...Did you notice how spooked she was when we brought up the Heart of Etheria? She must really think it's dangerous."

"I'd imagine a powerful First Ones artifact would have to be if both Catra and Entrapta want to get their hands on it," said Crita. "Especially if it really is capable of destroying planets. Though I'm not convinced she wasn't just exaggerating."

Bluebird returned. "No signal," she grumbled. "The sooner we get out of this forest, the better. So, let's keep moving!" She took to the air, continuing in the direction they were headed before the diversion, with the other two following behind.

"I just hope it doesn't destroy *this* planet," said Karikon. "Not while I'm on it, at least. …Where were we going again?"

"To Brightmoon, so I can have my revenge on Steven Universe," Bluebird said impatiently. "Please try to keep up. Hopefully, we should be there soon if we keep heading west."

Crita leaned closer to Karikon. " *Is* this west?" she asked quietly. He shrugged.

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"So, how'd you meet Modulok anyhow?" asked Entrapta. Although Leech wasn't much for conversation, it hung onto her every word, staring at her with its beady black eyes. "Interesting! It seems like you and your buddy trust him a lot."

The buddy in question, Mantenna, also seemed to be watching Entrapta, intently watching her while hanging from the ceiling. All the while, she worked at assembling the blueprints for Modulok's device. Exact specifications would come later–for now, a general outline was all she needed.

"I see you've made some new friends." Entrapta turned around to see that Modulok had suddenly returned. "My creations are often distrustful of newcomers, but these two have taken to you quite well. Though I imagine you have that effect on people, don't you?"

She couldn't help grinning. "Oh, I'm not much of a people person, but I try! Anyway, what are you doing back so soon? I thought you had an important mission to run. Actually, *how* did you get back here so quickly? I didn't hear your ship landing."

It was hard to tell, considering his heavily-mutated facial features, but something seemed to be bothering him. "There was a…slight complication involving someone I was supposed to meet," he said, avoiding meeting her eyes. "As for how I'm back so fast, I simply opened up a portal." He was met with a confused stare from her. "...Oh? Did I forget to mention I had a working portal generator?"

"You do!?" Entrapta shouted excitedly, jumping up from her workstation. "When and how did you make it? Was it back on Etheria? Did you ever manage to make it out of Despondos? Can I see it!?"

Modulok chuckled good-naturedly. "I can see this is something you're very passionate about!" He turned to head down a hallway, gesturing for her to follow. "You've been hard at work, so I guess you deserve a break. Come, I'll let you try it out."

The two of them walked towards the portal chamber, Mantenna and Leech watching as they disappeared down the hall. "Portals were something of a passion for me and Hordak back in the day," she said. "We managed to open a few, but all that led to was capturing Lars and his crew, and resurrecting Skeletor, and Horde Prime invading, and nearly destroying both Etheria and Earth. None of which were ideal outcomes."

"I would imagine so. I, too, spent many years trying to open a way out of Despondos," Modulok explained. "In all my years of experimenting, I only succeeded once, and the portal only remained stable for mere moments. This was many years ago, before the Horde arrived on Etheria. Oftentimes, I wonder if anything–or anyone–came through that day." He didn't know for sure, but he suspected.

Modulok opened a door, letting them into a room that contained a large frame. "Wow…it looks just like Hordak's!" said Entrapta, walking in to examine it. "This…this wasn't based on his specifications, was it?"

"No, no, but it wouldn't surprise me if he based his portal device on previous versions, such as those of the First Ones, or Horde Prime." Modulok stepped up to the control panel to activate the portal frame. A glowing sphere manifested in the device's center. "Now, since Etheria's expulsion from Despondos, I have set up devices like this across many planets all over this galaxy and many others. I could go anywhere…but I want to take you somewhere special."

He activated the portal, which appeared from the sphere as a glowing whirlpool of energy. "Lead the way!" said Entrapta. Modulok entered, and she followed after. She was unsure of what awaited her on the other side. Her mind went through a variety of alien landscapes and wondrous locales, but she was surprised by where she found herself. Her first sight was a view of the stars through a giant window, with a large planet taking up most of the view. "Woah…" she said, walking closer to the glass to get a better look. "Are we on some kind of orbital station?"

"That we are," replied Modulok, looking out the window at the planet below. "This is the planet where my people came from, so many years ago. I returned to this facility once Etheria was freed from Despondos to continue my research." He placed a hand on the glass. "It was abandoned long ago, but still, it holds something of a sentimental value to me. Sometimes, I find myself wondering where they've all gone…"

Entrapta didn't want to interrupt Modulok's sentimentality, so she waited a moment before asking her next question. "Is…is that why you wanted to build that device? To reactivate this station?"

"I…Indeed, yes." Modulok faltered for a moment, but recovered fast enough that it wasn't noticed. "As I said, it's merely sentimental, but it would mean a lot to me."

“Hey, I understand completely!” replied Entrapta. “I feel the same way about my robots. Even if they don’t turn out the way I wanted, I can never bring myself to recycle them. Now, why don’t we see what kind of systems we’re working with.” She headed over to a nearby door, placing her hand on the adjacent scanner. However, there was no response.

Modulok walked over. “Apologies, but I’ve had to seal all entryways in the facility once I arrived. No central power also means no oxygen… I will give you the full tour once it is working, but for now this room is all I can show you.” He gestured over towards the portal, indicating it was time to go.

She stood in front of the frame as he booted the portal up once again. Before she went through, she noticed that he was standing back aways. “Aren’t you coming too?” asked Entrapta.

He shook his head. “I think I would like to stay here a while longer. Keep up the good work, I will join you shortly.”

Entrapta shrugged. “Okay then. See you in a bit!” With that, she headed through, the portal closing behind her. Once she was gone, Modulok turned back towards the window…for a split second.

His next move was to head for the door that was apparently sealed. He placed his own hand on the scanner, which reacted by lighting up. The door slid open, giving way to a room filled with plenty of oxygen, within a facility that was already activated.

Not only that, but he wasn’t alone. A figure robed in dark red was already in the room, manipulating a ball of black particles before her. “How long do you plan on deceiving her?” asked Shadow Weaver.

“As long as is necessary,” Modulok said, strolling over to a nearby workstation. More of the black dust Shadow Weaver was manipulating was on it, sealed in various vials along with other odd substances. “She really is a brilliant young mind, though I

doubt she would agree with our end goal." He began mixing several of the substances together.

Shadow Weaver placed the black dust into a pouch, placing it on the table. "While we're on this matter, you have been concerningly vague about what you get from our alliance. I understand what I stand to gain, but what is your angle?"

He smiled. "Beware the skies above, young one, for darkness hides within. The stars have all gone out, young one, they now control the sky. The Many Who Are One, young one, the First Ones' greatest sin. Devour all they see, young one, and now you've caught their eye. Even though now they're gone, young one, they may yet still win. For even a dead god, young one, can never truly die."

The sorceress stared at him like he had gone mad. "I was unaware you were a poet," she said, slightly annoyed. "But would you be so kind as to spare me the pretension?"

"I take it you never heard that poem when you were younger," he said, standing up. "In all your time in Mystacor, you've really never heard of the Many Who Are One?"

She hadn't. "That name doesn't sound familiar. Of course, I was busy training to be a sorceress, I didn't exactly have time to document every fairy tale or nursery rhyme I heard."

Modulok began to pace around the room, giving off a smug aura. "Oh, I think you're more familiar with them than you think. You see, the legend of the Many Who Are One is a legend that permeates both Etherian and Eternean culture alike. Stories of a shadowy entity too horrible to be given a name, merely a title. The myth has taken many forms over the millennia: Keldor and his band of cultists referred to it as 'Skeletor,' suggesting a connection to undeath. Here on Etheria, it is largely known as 'The Many Who Are One,' likely implying a hive mind nature. Meanwhile, the name I knew it by in my childhood has largely been lost to time, only remembered by a handful of ancient

sources, most of them forbidden. Its true title, or at least the closest it has to one, is simply…'The Unnamed One.'" He turned to face Shadow Weaver, expecting her to react.

*This* name she had heard. At the mention of the Unnamed One, a small cluster of shadows began to dance around her fingertips, accompanied by the faintest of disembodied whispers. Memories of grasping hands and peering eyes resurfaced in her mind. "That is why you sought me out?" she asked. "Because of my connection to the Unnamed One?"

"You catch on quick," he said. "Don't worry–I abandoned Keldor's idea of an apocalyptic doomsday cult long ago. I merely seek this being to utilize a fraction of its power. It is a means to an end–nothing more, nothing less."

"I know I am the one who asked, but in truth, your plans are of little concern to me," she responded. Just so long as I get what I was promised."

He nodded, returning to the workstation. "That you shall, my dear." Shadow Weaver returned her gaze to the numerous pods that lined the walls. Dozens of them, each large enough to hold a human being. Many of them did. "That you shall."

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"Ladies and Gems, may I present to you the new, improved, First Ones star cruiser formerly owned by Mara!" announced Peridot, standing atop the ship as it was towed into the courtyard. "Please, no need to pretend you're not impressed!"

There it was: Hordak, Bow, and Peridot had completed repairs on Mara's ship, which had just returned to Brightmoon. Pulled by a procession of Horde skiffs, just about everyone in the castle was there to see it. "To be honest, I was expecting something a bit… bigger," noted Perfuma.

"Bigger, smaller, as long as it gets us from place to place at faster-than-light speed, that's all that matters," said Glimmer,

approaching the ship to examine it. “Seriously, though, you guys did a good job fixing this up. I imagine Hordak didn’t cause too much trouble?”

Bow stepped down off a skiff to join her. “No, actually, he was really helpful. I can’t believe I’m saying this, but…he’s actually not that bad a guy.” He looked away from Glimmer’s judgemental stare. “Y’know, aside from the whole ‘global conquest’ thing.”

Glimmer laughed. “I believe you–still, though, we should probably keep an eye on him. Lars should be around here somewhere, I’ll have to let him know his new ship is here. Did anything else happen out there in the Crimson Waste?”

Looking at Hordak for a brief moment, Bow quickly averted his gaze. “Uh, no, not really. Just a lotta sand, honestly. No sign of the New Horde, if that’s what you’re asking.”

“Good. I’ve been having Adora keep an eye out for them. Now, where is she–Adora!” Adora made her way over. “Still no new activity on the planetary scanners?”

“Not that I saw,” she replied. “According to Hessonite, most of their troops are still occupying Ophidia. She would have alerted us if there was any significant breakaway.”

After her initial bombastic entrance, Peridot had disappeared once the ship was in place. Now, she peered out from behind it, trying to get Adora’s attention. She was waving at her and not-so-subtly trying to draw her over, trying not to alert Glimmer in the process. Adora cleared her throat when she saw her. “What’s up?” asked Glimmer.

She shrugged. “Nothing, nothing. I’m, uh, gonna check this thing out. It belonged to Mara, so there’s a chance it has some stuff on She-Ra we don’t know yet. Oh look, there’s Peridot, she can help me access the ship’s databanks! Be right back, Glimmer!” Adora then headed off towards Peridot, just a little too quickly.

Under normal circumstances, Glimmer might have found her behavior suspicious. And while she did pick up that she was acting a little off, there was too much on her mind at the moment. "Bow, the ship *is* spaceworthy, right? I don't want to send Lars and his crew off on a mission in a faulty ship."

"It's…" Bow paused for a moment. "We should probably run a few tests before we take it up there. Just in case." He wandered off to look for Hordak, with Glimmer close behind. "So, this mission you're sending Lars on…is it *that* mission?"

"It is," Glimmer said grimly. "I'll be going too: not just to provide backup, but because I want to make sure the job is done." Her hands glowed as she gritted her teeth, something Bow took as a sign to keep his distance. He couldn't help but shake the feeling there was something she wasn't telling him.

Meanwhile, Adora hurried to join Peridot in a nearby garden. "Hey, what's up?" she asked. "Did you find anything?"

"I did, actually," Peridot replied, looking around to make sure they weren't being overheard. "So, um, are you familiar with the Reticulan method of interstellar wayfinding?"

"...No," Adora said.

"That's alright, it's a pretty outdated system. But the point is, you were right: those numbers Light Hope gave you were coordinates. I put them into the ship, and they showed me a First Ones facility somewhere in this very galaxy. A space station, orbiting around an uninhabited planet."

Adora was overjoyed at this information. "Th–that's great! Peridot, this could be where I'm from! It could be my home! Thank you *so much* for doing this for me, I'll repay you however I can!"

Peridot didn't share her enthusiasm, and indeed seemed a little uncomfortable by how excited she was. "Um, okay, yeah, yes. It *could* be where you're from. Possibly. Maybe. I wouldn't get your hopes up, it could've been abandoned long ago…"

“Oh, don’t worry, I’m not expecting to meet any of my relatives– as cool as that would be,” said Adora. “Light Hope gave me those coordinates for a reason, so even if nothing comes of this, I owe it to her to at least check it out.”

“And, um, how exactly do you plan on getting there?” asked Peridot.

She shrugged. “I dunno. I’m sure there’s a Gem who could give me a ride. Or better yet, I’ll take Mara’s ship for a test flight! I’ll zip on down, be back in less than a day, and Glimmer’ll be none the wiser! Perfect plan, right?”

Peridot didn’t agree. “No, not perfect plan!” she said. “Why are you so focused on keeping this from Glimmer? Wouldn’t it be easier to just tell her where you’re going?”

“I…” Adora paused to ponder this. “Glimmer’s made it clear she doesn’t want anything to do with Light Hope’s numbers. I don’t think she trusts her, and I don’t know why. This’ll be easier if it’s something I do myself.” She turned to leave, offering up a grateful glance before she was gone. “Seriously though: thank you for this, Peridot. I mean it when I said I’ll pay you back.”

“N-no problem,” said Peridot, giving an unenthausiastic thumbs-up. With Adora gone, she was left alone in the garden, pondering what this all meant for the Princess Alliance. “I don’t think I made the best decision here…”

# Underneath the Surface

Chapter Summary

Catra follows Entrapta's trail, while both Scorpia and Glimmer prepare for battle.

Chapter Twelve: Underneath the Surface

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In spite of all that had changed over the years, the Fright Zone was not much different now than it had been before Hordak's disappearance. Upon his return to power, his loyalists once again banded around him, preparing to take the fight to the princesses once again. However, even when Hordak kept his alliance with Brightmoon unbroken, still they stayed by their leader, ready to conquer whoever he should demand.

"An undead sorcerer, a network of killer machines, the total destruction of the planet, and he's still stuck to his same old path," Catra noted, as the three of them overlooked the Fright Zone from a rooftop. "Why anyone would willingly stay under his rule is beyond me."

Carnelian looked around nervously, weighing the pros and cons of pointing out her flawed logic. "Um, didn't you–"

"I meant as opposed to *me* !" she snapped. "A better option presents itself, and they just stick with the self-defeating old fossil!? I have no sympathy for any of them. Come on, let's find this thing so we can get out of here."

The three of them made their way towards Hordak's inner sanctum as stealthily as they could manage, leaping over the rooftops. Catra and Sqalish were plenty agile, but Carnelian had to move carefully, lest she make too much noise. Luckily, the Fright Zone wasn't as crowded as it used to be, unless one counted the increased presence of cybertroops.

If there was one major difference in the modern Fright Zone, it was that it seemed much more casual, for lack of a better word. The soldiers patrolling the streets were far more likely to simply be shooting the breeze, and likewise, recruits weren't constantly looking over their shoulder for a Force Captain to reprimand them for this or that. The entire aura of the place felt much less tyrannical, though whether this meant that Hordak himself was less so as well remained to be seen.

"Question: how do you suppose we get inside his sanctum?" asked Sqalish, the three of them stopping in front of the tower. "I doubt he's any less paranoid than he was years ago. If anything, he's probably got even *more* defenses."

"Easy!" Carnelian began glowing, and had soon taken on Hordak's form. "Look at me, I'm Hordak!" she said, in a horrible imitation of his voice. In fact, one wondered if she had even heard him speak before. "C'mon, let's go conquer some place! Don't challenge my authority!"

Sqalish rolled his eyes. "Of course, how did I not consider that? I'm sure everyone will fall for your ingenious disguise."

"Aww, thanks, buddy!"

While the two of them bickered, Catra was busy examining the building to determine their best way in. The obvious entrance was a window or grate, but as little as she thought of Hordak, she figured he was at least smarter than that. No, there was only one way to make it to Entrapta's files. "You two, knock it off and get ready to move. We're going in through the laundry chute."

The two shot her confused glances. "The…laundry chute?" asked Sqalish. "Surely there's easier and less-secure ways to enter the building. Why go through so much trouble?"

"Because as far as anyone in the Fright Zone knows, people can't fit through there," she said. "And they can't, at least not fully grown. Adora and I used to sneak out through there when we

were younger. But considering your shapeshifting, and your malleability, I think we'll fit just fine."

"And, what about you?" asked Carnelian. "You're probably a lot bigger now than you were then. How're you gonna fit?"

Catra grinned. "Because I'm a cat. I can fit through any opening, no matter how small!" She led the way towards the chute, with the others following after her.

The chute was located behind the building, looking not only unremarkable but dirty and unsafe as well. A load of dirty clothes fell out into a full bin, which was then taken away by a small robot. " *This* is how we get inside? Crawling through everyone's used unmentionables?" complained Sqalish. "We might as well wade through the sewers while we're at it! At least that way I can be of some use!"

"That's enough out of you," Catra said. "We're going this way, and that's final. Now wait for my signal…" Before long, another robot brought an empty bin to replace the first, scooting away to elsewhere. "Go!" All three of them leapt down from the building, sneaking over to the entrance.

Catra was first, hopping into the bin and crawling up the chute as soon as she reached it. Sqalish hesitantly climbed in after her, peering up the chute with trepidation. "What's the matter?" asked Carnelian.

"'What's the matter?' The matter is that this is the most humiliating thing I've ever done," he groaned. "I don't see how you aren't bothered by this."

"It's only humiliating if you focus on it too much," she replied. "Now get in there and make your empress proud!" She pushed him into the chute, following after him shortly. However, she found that her bulky body was too large to fit. "Uh-oh. Okay, hold on a second."

Sqalish crawled through the chute after Catra, using his tentacles to climb the slick surface. There wasn't much light available, but he was able to see when a glowing light appeared from behind him, followed by the sound of another joining him in his climb. "I'm hoping that's you," he said.

A small laugh from Carnelian. "I just had the perfect plan," she said. "Check me out! Hey, turn around, see what I came up with!"

"Will you two shut it!?" Catra whisper-yelled at them. "In case you forgot, we're trying not to be discovered! So unless you wanna wake up the whole place, maybe take this more seriously–" Catra was interrupted when an undershirt landed on her head. She growled, throwing it at Sqalish. "Keep going. Say nothing."

Using her knowledge of the Fright Zone she had accumulated in her childhood, Catra knew exactly where to go. She led her team up to a higher level of the building, thankfully avoiding having any more clothes dumped on them. Eventually, they were able to reach their destination, climbing out into a hallway. She peered down both directions, crawling out when she saw nobody was there.

After her came Sqalish. "Here's hoping getting out will be easier than getting out." Carnelian climbed out after him. "I really could go without–Why do you look like that?" he asked, exasperated.

Carnelian had shapeshifted into a Horde trooper. "Eh? Eh? Pretty ingenious, right? Not only was I small enough to fit, but now if anyone finds us, I can just say 'it's alright, they're with me!' I'm on a roll with these good ideas!"

"I'm sure none of them will question why your armor's the complete wrong color," Sqalish said. "Or why you have a gemstone on your back."

She shrugged. "Hey, I can just stand with my back against the wall, like this. And if anyone asks, I'll say it's just the lighting." Carnelian leaned back casually, crossing her arms and trying to

look stern. "'Hey, you 'sposed ta be up here?' That's what I'll say if anyone comes in. Got your back, boss!"

Catra rolled her eyes, heading over to the door to Entrapta's lab. "Whatever. You two stand guard out here, this shouldn't take long." Entering the lab, she found that not much had changed over the years. It had been largely untouched in that time, with the only major difference being the addition of several more terminals. "Now comes the hard part: sorting through Entrapta's stream-of-consciousness."

Despite being relatively unchanged, it was clear that Entrapta's old lab had been used extensively in the time since Hordak had reclaimed the Fright Zone. He had likely been accessing her research, but for what purpose, Catra could only guess. Whatever the reason, he hadn't added in any extra security, meaning she was able to easily get into the files.

Before her was a multitude of projects Entrapta had logged, completed, unfinished, or abandoned. Catra scanned over them: a few of the names listed were ones she recognized, like the Staff of Keldor and Multi-Bot. There were plenty more she either hadn't heard or hadn't bothered to remember, but she didn't find anything relating to the Heart of Etheria. "Come on, Entrapta, give me something here…"

Seeing as there was nothing of use listed under her projects, she tried looking through Entrapta's various logs. As before, many of them were of no help. "During my research into the Citadel today, I came across this bad boy! I think, and I'm only guessing here, it might be the legendary Staff of Keldor!" "I've been looking into this 'Surgeon' person, but I haven't been able to find any trace of them. It's like they're a ghost!" "Apparently, 'Horde Prime' is a title passed down from the machine network currently attacking Etheria, all the way down to Hordak's brother! It begs the question, just who were the other Horde Primes that came about in the interim?"

"This is getting me nowhere," Catra muttered, skimming through the video logs. With how obsessed Entrapta was with the First Ones and their technology, she refused to believe she had nothing on the Heart of Etheria. Eventually, she decided to look through some of her earlier ones, from just after their initial attack on Brightmoon. She didn't know why, but somehow, this one felt different than the others.

"Okay, so, my experiments with the Black Garnet were…sort of a success!" said the recording of Entrapta. "I was able to successfully prove that all of this planet's Runestones are connected in a sort of network, but…I think it goes deeper than that. Literally: this network, it seems to be drawing energy from the planet's core. Or possibly, supplying the core with energy? I'm not really certain, but *something's* down there, and whatever it is, messing with it could be a very bad idea. Considering my hypothesis of Etheria being an artificial structure could be true, this 'heart' could very well be its power source, and disrupting it could have apocalyptic consequences. For now, I think it's best we left it alone."

And with that, it all clicked. Entrapta had already figured this all out. The Heart of Etheria was no ordinary object, it was *literally* Etheria's heart: the planet's core. In addition to that, two things became very clear in that moment as well. First, if even Entrapta, who would experiment with just about anything if it produced results, was afraid to deal with the Heart, then it must be more dangerous than any of them could have imagined. And secondly, their mission to retrieve it just got much more difficult.

Catra turned off the computer and returned to the hallway, where Carnelian and Sqalish were both standing guard. "We have what we need. Time to leave," she said.

"That was fast," Sqalish said. "So, where we goin' next?"

She led them back to the laundry chute. "Back to the ship. I know where the Heart is, but it's beyond our ability to reach as is. We'll

have to contact Azurite's team and rendezvous with them before heading back to the *Supermassive* ."

Carnelian leaned in closer. "So? What's the big scoop? Where do we find this magical doodad?"

"At the planet's center," Catra said.

Neither of them were expecting that. "So, the Heart of Etheria is… *literally* the heart of Etheria?" asked Sqalish. "Huh. I'm surprised none of us put that together sooner."

"Entrapta did," Carnelian noted. "If she figured this out years ago, how come she didn't tell us before we came here?"

They landed in the bin, crawling out before they were detected. "Who knows what's going on in her head?" Catra said. "Come on, let's get moving. I don't want to stay here longer than we need to." But as they began to make their escape, Carnelian's question arose another one in Catra's head: why, if Entrapta was so hesitant about the Heart of Etheria before, did she change her mind? Was the situation on Ophidia really so dire? Whatever the reason, it left her with a nagging feeling that stuck with her even as she put her mind on other things.

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A few hours after the duo had made their escape, the village had more or less calmed down. Modulok and Shadow Weaver were gone, and the hunting parties had returned from their search. Now, after avoiding being taken back inside, all that remained was to get back inside.

"I count three guards along the eastern wall," Micah said from his perch in a tree. "If we move quickly, we can get past them without raising any alarms. Of course, by the time we break down the wall, everyone will know we're there. Are you ready?"

On the ground, Scorpia stretched as she prepared herself to transform. "You bet! I think I've finally got the hang of this giant

scorpion thing. Okay, here we go, and…!" She thrust her arms out, with her tail hanging over her head. Despite her pose, nothing happened. "Uh, hold on, just gotta…Now!" A few streaks of darkness slid along her pincers, but aside from that, she remained as-is.

Micah climbed down, seeing she looked distressed. "Something wrong?" he asked. "Do you think it only works when you're in distress?"

"No, no, I got it!" she assured him nervously. "I just gotta concentrate harder!" She strained, with shadowy energy visibly building up inside of her. The shadows all around were drawn to her, but the moment she lost her focus, it all faded. Disappointed, she collapsed to the ground. "No! Why now, I don't get it! It worked fine before, but now it's like I'm outta fuel!"

Having a princess for a daughter, this was a concept Micah was familiar with. "That explains it: your energy is drained," he said. "Princesses can only use their powers so much before they have to recharge at their Runestone."

"That's…not much help," Scorpia replied. She got to her feet, glancing through the bushes at Black's stronghold. "We can't exactly head on over to the Black Garnet for a quick recharge, can we? …Can we? You're magic, aren't you? Couldn't you just, like, magic us up a solution?"

He grinned. "Trust me, in the years I've been stuck here, I've tried everything. Although…" Having a sudden thought, he raised a hand to his chin. "...What if there was a way for you to connect to your Runestone without necessarily touching it?"

Scorpia stared at him for a moment. "Uh, are you askin' me? Because yeah, that would be pretty good, but I don't know how we would do that."

"Luckily for you, I think I do!" he said. Micah concentrated his magic into his staff, holding it out as he scanned the horizon with

the end. “Like I said, I’ve been on this island for years. In that time, I’ve come to learn that its magical energies are unlike anything else any *where* else on the planet. So if I’m right…” He apparently found what he was looking for, walking off away from the village. “We’ve got a way for you to recharge!”

He led the way off into the forests of Beast Island, with Scorpia following after. “Great! So, uh, where exactly are we going?”

“I’m not entirely sure,” he said. “But if I’m right, our path will take us down. *Far* down.” Unsure and uneasy, Scorpia nevertheless kept on after him, trusting that the more experienced of the two knew what he was doing.

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As the Horde trooper whispered something to Hordak, Glimmer looked at the two from the corner of her eye with a sense of unease. Nothing they were talking about could be good, especially with that urgent tone. “I understand, thank you,” he said, as the trooper left the room. Hordak then made his way over to Glimmer to deliver the news. “Apparently, the Fright Zone’s command center has just been breached.”

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. “How so? Was anything stolen?”

“No, though what the perpetrator did was equally troubling. A computer containing all of Entrapta’s research and discoveries was activated without my approval. Taking into account that someone was not only able to infiltrate the Fright Zone, but know where to find this information, only one suspect makes logical sense.”

“Catra.” Glimmer stared at the floor from her throne, her whole body tensing up. “Any idea what she was after?”

Hordak sighed, unwilling to admit he had no idea. “It is likely she was after Entrapta’s data. We don’t yet know her reason for returning to Etheria, but I would surmise it has something to do with her findings.”

“And that could be anything,” said Glimmer, exasperated. “Well, have someone go through Entrapta’s files to see if there’s anything she might’ve been looking for. As for right now, we need to figure out how to handle this.”

“How else?” Hordak said with a slight smile. “Your enemy is within striking distance. Why waste time waiting for the perfect moment when you can *make* the perfect moment yourself? Send someone to eliminate her.”

The idea certainly intrigued her. “We have to be careful about this. If Adora finds out we plan on killing Catra, she’ll get in the way. We’ll have to send someone who won’t tell her.”

“Your Majesty, if I may…” Hordak said. “In my time leading the Horde, I preferred to delegate my tasks. That said, I am also intimately familiar with the old saying, ‘If you want something done right, you need to do it yourself.’” He loomed behind her, hanging onto her throne.

Glimmer got to her feet, her staff appearing in her hand. “You’re right,” she said. “I’ve been sitting here telling everyone else what to do for too long. I’m the queen now, and I’ve got the powers to prove it.” She looked over at her new advisor, a sinister glint in her eyes. “I think it’s time I showed everyone what a more proactive queen looks like!”

Hordak smiled. “Long live the queen.”

# Ambushed

Chapter Summary

Glimmer decides to go after Catra personally, but the New Horde is planning its own attack.

Chapter Thirteen: Ambushed

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"So, what have you managed to find out?" Glimmer asked. She waited in her throne room, speaking to a figure on a holographic viewscreen. Hordak stood to her side, viewing the figure as well from just out of her sight.

Hessonite was on the other end, speaking with the queen from the bridge of the *Crystallon* . "Well, not entirely. We looked through our scan logs, and no unidentified ships were seen entering Etherian airspace when Catra would have arrived. However, considering the location of the first sighting, combined with the length of time before her arrival at the Fright Zone, I believe we may have calculated where she will head next."

Glimmer raised an eyebrow at this assertion. "And how exactly did you figure that out? *We* don't even know why she came back, why do you think *you* do?"

Another figure pushed Hessonite out of the way: Demantoid. "Actually, Your Highness, it was simply the matter of calculating the most likely probability." One of her mechanical hands turned into another screen covered in countless equations. "Given the time passed between each location, as well as possible landing zones, reasons for arriving, and potential motives, I have narrowed down her three likeliest locations to head next. I will send a map marking these locations to you shortly."

Admittedly, Glimmer was somewhat impressed. "And you figured all of this out in a matter of hours?" Hordak would have been

similarly impressed, if not for the fact that the accuracy of these calculations had not yet been verified.

"A matter of *one* hour–around fifty minutes," Demantoid said casually. "Though, are you certain you want this matter to remain discreet? The commander of the New Horde personally arriving on this planet seems like it would be cause for concern."

"That's exactly *why* I want this to stay under wraps," she said. "Could you imagine the panic that could result if this got out? For the time being, I want as few people to know about this as possible, got it? So don't go spreading the word."

Demantoid was then, in turn, pushed aside by Pyrope. "No promises, princess! We have quite a lot of Gems on board, and *quite a few of them* can be a bit nosy." She shot a glare at someone offscreen, likely Duchess. "Are you certain you do not need our help?"

"No, you all keep an eye on Emerald," said Glimmer. "If she makes any moves, let me know immediately. I'll handle things with Catra out here."

Hessonite pushed the other two out of the way. "You can count on us, Your Highness. Sending you the report now." She pushed a button, and then the screen closed. Glimmer and Hordak were then alone once again.

Next, the map in question appeared in their place. Both of them looked it over–three places were marked where Catra would likely head to next. Each one had a time listed next to it, likely the moment when Catra would arrive. "And why exactly would Catra go back the same way she came?" Hordak asked about one of these.

"I don't know, but Peridot tells me she's one of the smartest Gems on our side. If this is what she's figured out, then I'm willing to believe it. Now there's only the matter of figuring out which one of these places she'll be…"

Hordak examined the map. "I doubt she would be bold enough to head straight for Brightmoon," he said, noticing that one of the spots was in that direction. "Most likely, she would continue heading north, getting some distance from potential pursuers. That would be the smartest course of action."

"We can't risk missing her just because we assume where she's going," Glimmer said. "Demantoid narrowed it down to three locations for a reason. I don't like it…but we'll have to recruit some others to bolster our forces. We'll deal with the fallout once we have Catra in our custody." She stood up from her throne, heading for the door. "C'mon. Let's get the gangs together."

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"Now, we don't know what these Horde insurgents are capable of," Glimmer said, briefing the others, "but we have to assume they're just as dangerous as the ones we've faced in the past. Hessonite informed me that they were sighted at three locations, which is where you'll all be sent to investigate. Hordak has already marked the locations on the speeders' maps. Any questions?"

Just beyond Castle Brightmoon, just about everyone in the Princess Alliance was present, as were the Crystal Gems. "Um, yeah, how come I'm not going?" asked Adora. Glimmer had been adamant that only three groups were to depart, leaving many of their members behind. "If these guys really are that dangerous, shouldn't this be an 'all hands on deck' situation?"

Glimmer stepped down from her speeder. "I need someone to stay back and protect Brightmoon," she said, which wasn't entirely a lie. "I can't discount the possibility that this is all a setup to leave us vulnerable. But between you, Bow, Steven, and the Gems, I'm sure this place is in good hands." Without so much as a second glance, she stepped back on. "Team one, you're heading to Salineas. Team two, just outside of Brightmoon's borders. We're heading to the Fright Zone. Now go!"

Team one, consisting of Bismuth, Lapis, and Peridot headed off. Team two was made up of Mermista, Perfuma, and Frosta, and they sped towards their destination as well. Team three was Glimmer herself and Hordak, with Topaz as well. “This is my first official mission since joining the Crystal Gems…I won’t let you down!” said the fusion.

“Of course you won’t. From what I have heard, you are more than capable, Topaz,” Hordak assured her. “Those traitors won’t know what hit them, should a fight be necessary.” Topaz was flattered by his faith in her, beaming quietly as the speeder sped on.

Back at Brightmoon, everyone watched as the three teams faded into the distance. “Well, this was utterly pointless,” said Jasper, returning to the castle. “Come on, we aren’t done yet,” she told Steven.

Steven looked uncomfortable, sharing a glance with Connie. However, though it was clear he rather wouldn’t, he followed after Jasper, much to Connie’s concern. Her sentiment was shared with the other Gems.

“Is it just me, or is Steven spending *way* too much time with her?” said Amethyst. “Like, I get that he wants to get better with his He-Man stuff, but it’s starting to seem like he’s obsessed.”

Pearl sadly watched him leave. “I think that’s because he is. Ever since he lost his powers because of Spinel, I’ve noticed he’s been a lot more withdrawn. I’m worried he thinks he’s useless without powers.”

“Mmm,” Garnet said, nodding. “Someone needs to talk some sense into him before something bad happens.

Connie sighed. “We can try…but what if he won’t listen?”

As the Gems faced one way, Adora faced the other, watching the speeders vanish over the horizon with Bow. “Should…should we talk to her?” she asked.

"We've been talking to her," Bow replied. "What else is there to say? We're all sad that Angella's gone, but she was her mother. We feel bad too, but we can't know how she feels right now."

"That doesn't mean she has to push us out!" Adora said. "I mean, you've noticed it too, right? She's just been so distant lately! And I think I know why."

Bow started, looking away anxiously. "Y-you do? Why's that?"

Adora's eyes narrowed. "Hordak. He glued himself at her side the moment Angella disappeared. I know he's *technically* on our side now, but…don't you think it's weird that her change started around the time they started working together?"

Bow remembered his conversation with Glimmer, and his later one with Hordak. "Uh…yeah. No, that does make sense. But, I, uh, I don't think it's *all* Hordak. She's hurting, Adora, and the only way she thinks she'll feel better is by taking down Catra–ah, and the New Horde."

"No, it's gotta be Hordak, I just know it," said Adora. "There's no way he isn't just using her to take the New Horde for himself. C'mon." She headed back to the castle as well.

"Huh? What are you up to?" Bow asked, following her.

"We've got some investigating to do," she said. "If Hordak's hiding something, there might be some evidence of it somewhere in the castle. It's time we did a little snooping around!"

He followed after her, not liking where this was going. "Adora, wait! You can't just go looking through Glimmer's things!" But his pleas fell on deaf ears, as she was determined to save her friend from herself.

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"So, what's the plan now, boss?" asked Carnelian, trudging through a swamp just beyond Salineas' border. "How're we

supposed to find the Heart of Etheria here?”

Catra growled. It wasn’t enough they had to wade through a disgusting swamp to avoid capture, but her teammates just had to be oblivious. “First step, rendezvous with the others,” she said. “We’ll meet back at the ship, head back to the *Supermassive* , and tell Entrapta what we found. Now that we know what the Heart of Etheria is, getting to it should be much easier, at least in theory.”

A large object moved through the water, and stood up, revealing it to be Sqalish. “With respect, we know *where* the Heart is, not *what* it is. And furthermore, are you sure finding it is such a good idea?”

“And what exactly do you mean by that?” Catra asked, shooting him a glare. “We need every advantage we can get at this point. Adora’s got an entire planet of Gems on her side now.”

“I simply mean that the Heart of Etheria is likely more dangerous than we thought,” he replied. “The center of the planet itself? That sounds more important than we initially thought. Not to mention how anxious Entrapta seemed about it. I’m worried us going after it will open up even more troubles than we have.”

She huffed angrily. “And when did you start caring about trouble?”

Sqalish was about to respond, but Carnelian beat him to the punch. “When they became *his* problems!” she said. He groaned, but something caught his attention before he could retort. He dove down into the water, racing ahead of the other two. “Hey, what gives? Did I strike a nerve?”

The vibrations he felt in the water soon proved his point. He hurried back, surfacing when he reached them. “Someone is coming. Hide!”

“‘Hide?’” said Carnelian. “Who’s so tough that we have to hide from–” Catra elbowed her. “If you say so, boss. But let’s call it ‘taking cover’ instead.” She hid behind a large nearby tree. Catra climbed to the top of one, while Sqalish submerged once again.

The merman's suspicions were soon confirmed, as the hum of a skiff soon gave way to the vehicle itself. It passed over the swamp, moving just slowly enough to indicate that its occupants were looking for something. As it drew closer, two of the three realized that they were quite familiar with the ones upon it.

"This should be where they are," said Perfuma, looking all over for any sign of their targets. "I hope Glimmer knew what she was talking about."

"Of *course* she does!" Frosta shot back. The skiff slowed to a halt right where the three were hidden. "She wouldn't have sent us out here unless she was sure there was Horde around!"

"I-I know, I just meant that I hoped she wasn't mistaken!" Perfuma said quickly. "I'm sure she knows what she was talking about, but everyone can make mistakes, right?"

Mermista tried to calm the situation down before it turned into a feud. "They might not even be here, remember?" she said. "We're just here to see if they are, right? So, let's keep looking, just in case."

Peering out from her hiding spot, Carnelian looked at Catra, shrugging as though to say 'What do we do now?' Catra, knowing the princesses' search of the area would be thorough, took a deep breath and lowered herself under the water. She gestured to Sqalish, pointing at the skiff. He knew what to do.

Sqalish made his way over to the vehicle, quietly extending his tentacles to infiltrate the underside. Moments later, when the princesses tried to start it up again to be on their way, they found that it refused to move.

Frosta smacked the controls, to no avail. "C'mon, you dumb thing, get moving!"

"It's probably all this swamp stuff worked its way inside this thing somehow," said Mermista, looking down in disgust. "All these

slimy plants and filthy water… Someone's gonna have to go down there to clean it out."

Preparing to step down into the water, Frosta decided against it at the last second. "I dunno, that water looks pretty deep. I-I'm not scared, I just don't want to get dirty, that's all!"

"But Mermista, isn't water your specialty?" Perfuma pointed out. "Besides, you've dealt with dirty water before. Remember the Fright Zone sewers?"

Mermista shuddered. "More than I'd care to."

Her gaze fixed on them like a hawk from her perch, Catra was prepared to launch the ambush. The princesses were distracted, their only means of transport had been sabotaged, and help was presumably miles away. Moments before she could pounce, however, she was startled by a sudden noise in her ear. Her communicator rang, signifying a call from the other team.

The sound alone probably wouldn't have tipped off the princesses, but Catra's sudden flailing from being caught unawares certainly was. Thinking it was just a bird, Perfuma looked up to the tree, seeing a figure watching them. "Look, up there!" she shouted, alerting the others. Knowing the jig was up, Catra leapt down to the ground, just as Perfuma tried to grab her with the tree's branches.

"Welp, so much for that," mused Carnelian. "Ah, screw it! Cannonball!" She leapt out from behind the tree, crashing into the skiff. All three princesses were thrown into the water, but recovered quickly.

"Ugh, seriously?" moaned Mermista, as she was cast into the filthy swamp. She had little time to dwell, as tentacles suddenly shot up from below, dragging her under the surface. She formed her tail, breaking free from Sqalish's grip and darting after him.

Frosta fired icicles in Catra's direction. "That's Catra!" she exclaimed. "What's she doing here!?"

“I have no idea!” Perfuma brought the trees’ roots to the surface, flailing them around to try and locate her. “There’s no way Glimmer knew, right? She’d have told us if she knew!”

“Look out!” Frosta saved the two of them with an ice wall, as Carnelian hurled the skiff towards them. It crashed into the wall, destroying them both. “There goes our ride!”

As Catra dodged her opponents’ attacks, her teammate tried getting through to her. “Catra? Hey, Catra, are you there?” asked Karikon. “We’ve been trying to reach you for hours! We think we’ve got some crucial information about the Heart of Etheria!”

Yeah, so did they. “Now really isn’t the best time!” she replied, slicing through icicles with her claws. “Can’t this wait until we get back to the ship!?”

“Uh, I guess, but Bluebird said we should call you now. See, we met this old lady, who said that the Heart was super dangerous. I think it’s some kinda superweapon.”

“Oh, *you think* !?” Catra watched as Sqalish was thrown out of the water by a massive geyser conjured by Mermista, and Carnelian was tangled in vines. “Look, just put Bluebird on.”

As Catra dashed over to help her team, the sound of the communicator being tossed could be heard. “Catra! Good to hear from you after so long,” said Bluebird Azurite. “Has your side of the mission been successful?”

Catra sliced through vines, holding onto Carnelian when the water tried to grab them. “You could say that. I think we have what we need–get back to the ship, and we’ll meet you there.”

“Will do! We’ll be there in no time!” said Bluebird, hanging up. “Good to hear she has things handled.”

Bluebird, Karikon, and Crita were hiding as well, just on the edge of the Whispering Woods. “Aren’t you going to ask if she needs

help?” asked the latter. “It sure didn’t sound like she had things handled.”

The Gem brushed her off. “Ah, you’re underestimating our Empress! She’s just fine with the other two. Besides, we have a mission of our own to focus on…”

From their spot in the woods, they could see much of the goings-on at Castle Brightmoon. In particular, Steven sparring with Jasper. He was quite a bit larger than Azurite remembered, but that gemstone was unmistakable.

“You sure this is a good idea?” asked Karikon. “He looks a bit… bigger than I was expecting. And I've heard the horror stories about Jasper. Are we really up to the task?”

“That remains to be seen,” Bluebird grumbled. “Just follow my lead. If we do this right, Steven Universe will be completely helpless against our assault…”

# Unleashed

Chapter Summary

Bluebird Azurite launches an ambush on Steven, unaware that she may have bitten off more than she can chew.

Chapter Fourteen: Unleashed

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Catra dove in with her claws, her attack blocked by Mermista's trident. The princess hurled her aside, but she was caught by one of Sqalish's tentacles. He lifted them both out of the way of one of Frosta's ice blasts, with the resulting wall in turn broken by Carnelian. She was tangled by a cluster of vines extending from out of the water, which Catra soon freed her from.

The three princesses regrouped. "What do we do now?" asked Frosta. "Our skiff's trashed, we have no way to contact Glimmer, and these guys won't quit!"

"We just have to keep fighting!" answered Perfuma. "Someone's bound to give eventually. Charge!" The three of them went back into battle, hoping that the one to give wouldn't be one of them.

On the other side of things, the New Horde members were having many of the same thoughts. "So, do we keep fighting?" Sqalish asked. "Because I'm not sure we can last much longer against three princesses!"

"Just keep fighting!" Catra was fully engaged in the battle, almost acting like a fully feral cat. She slashed and clawed with ferocity normally reserved for when her life depended on it, putting the princesses on the defensive. Her teeth bared, she hurled herself toward Frosta when her back was turned.

Frosta turned around too late to summon an ice wall, but Mermista was able to react in time. "Look out!" She blasted Catra

aside with a jet of water, before standing in front of the smaller princess defensively. “You okay?”

“I’m fine,” said Frosta. “But what’s up with Catra? I’ve never seen her this angry before. And why is she even here?”

Mermista looked away. “I-I don’t know. Maybe Emerald kicked her out? That would explain both.” She called up a series of waterspouts to separate their Horde opponents.

Sqalish jetted around through the water, keeping the princesses on their toes. They were careful not to let themselves be seized by his tentacles, but this caution left them open to Carnelian. She tossed her boomerang at Perfuma, who dodged at the last second. The weapon became embedded in a nearby tree.

“Come on, flower girl, you can do better than that!” said the Quartz, strolling towards her. “Gimme a good fight!”

Perfuma summoned several vines up from the water. “Be careful what you wish for!” These vines shot towards Carnelian, and though she did her best to dodge, several managed to catch her. She called her boomerang back to her, using it so slice through her binds.

While Mermista’s guard was down, she was seized from behind by Sqalish, who dragged her down into the water. She fought him off, turning her legs into a tail to better face off against him. “I’ve been waiting for this opportunity for a long time!” she growled, armor hardening over his fists.

“Keep waiting!” Mermista shot forwards with her trident pointed. The attack simply glanced off Sqalish’s carapace, but this move had been only a distraction. Mermista turned herself around, using her control over water to push herself faster and faster as she circled her foe. Soon enough, this created a whirlpool, dragging Sqalish down towards the lakebed.

Up above, Frosta had engaged Catra, using ice gauntlets to counter her claws. “What exactly are you doing here!?” she

demanded, glaring up at the taller combatant. "You've got some sort of insidious plan going on, so spill it before things get ugly!"

"They already *are* ugly!" Catra hissed, her pupils having narrowed into slits. "Just once, I'd like things to go my way without you princesses screwing things up! With how insistent you all are on meddling in other peoples' business, it's no wonder it was so easy for Hordak to stir up an uprising against you! It's no wonder that Entrapta decided to jump ship!"

Frosta, propelled upwards by a blast of icy mist, managed to land an uppercut square into Catra's jaw. The blow was strong enough to throw her against a tree, cracking the bark as well. "Don't try and use Entrapta like that!" yelled Frosta. "She only joined the Horde because you tricked her! And she only *stayed* because of Hordak! Where is she now, huh? Still with you? Do you think she'll still stay on your team when she hears Hordak is with us?"

Catra wiped a stream of blood from her lip, having seemingly gone completely calm. Hackles raised, she hurled herself forward, extending her claws. Frosta charged as well, re-freezing her ice gauntlets as they both leapt into the air, preparing to strike…

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With a resounding *Clang!* , Steven's sword collided with Jasper's helmet. The Gem was unfazed by the strike, pushing back and causing Steven to stumble. She followed up with a super-fast punch, only for Steven to catch her by the wrist. He spun around, hurling her behind him.

Jasper recovered, sliding to a stop once she landed. "I'll admit, you're getting better," she said, their fight giving her a rare smile. "But until you can destabilize me, you're not good enough!"

"Then I guess I'd better stop holding back!" said Steven, likewise enthralled by the battle, sporting an uncharacteristically bloodthirsty grin. His new legs propelled him high up into the air,

rocketing back down sword-first. Jasper followed him up, and the two collided, sending out a powerful gale when their fists met.

The two traded blows as they fell to the ground, with Jasper using Steven to break her fall. “Give up yet?” she asked, holding him in a headlock. His sword had fallen a few yards away–he reached out to pull it back, only for Jasper to grab it before it got to him, embedding it in the stone floor behind her. “You’re running out of options, kid!”

He knew he was, but he was unwilling to admit defeat. As he tried to pry Jasper’s arm from around his neck, he heard something just beyond their courtyard. He threw back an elbow into her ribs before pushing her away. Without the distraction, he stood up to try and better determine the source of the sound.

Jasper quickly got to her feet, lunging at Steven and throwing another punch. Her fist stopped less than an inch from his back. “You’re dead,” she declared, but Steven didn’t react, still entranced by whatever it was he had heard. She rounded around to his front. “Hey, you’re dead! Ya hear me? You space out like this on the battlefield, no amount of strength is gonna save you!”

“Hang on,” Steven said quietly, holding up a hand. “There’s someone here.” He closed his eyes, hoping to hear the rustling sound again.

While Jasper listened for a moment to humor him, she quickly dismissed his claim. “It’s probably just a princess or something. Hey! We’re busy training here!” she hollered. “If you’ve got something to say to Steven, you can wait until he’s done! There, problem solved. Happy?”

But Steven’s curiosity wasn’t sated yet. He continued to listen for any sign that could indicate the intruder. His instincts would prove correct, as he caught a barely audible sound coming from behind him: a soft whistling as something sharp hurled towards his back. He spun around, grasping the projectile in his hand, which turned

out to be an icicle. However, the moment he touched it, the ice began to spread over the rest of his arm.

"Well, well, well, you've certainly grown since the last time we saw you!" The source of the icicle flew out into the open, hovering above the two of them. "What was it you were called again? 'He-Man?' A bit on the nose, don't you think?"

Steven recognized the fusion both from secondhand accounts as well as her two gemstones. "Bluebird," he said, his brows furrowing. He shattered the icicle in his grip, before breaking off the rest of the ice by slamming his fist into the ground. "What are you doing here?"

She sneered. "What else would I be doing here, silly? I've come to get revenge on you! With a little help from my new friends, of course!" She snapped her fingers, summoning Karikon and Crita. The former leveled her enormous gun at the two, while the latter prepared her magic.

"You three are New Horde, I take it?" Jasper said. "A wizard, a scorpion brute, and a traitor." She glared at Bluebird, who glared right back.

" *You're* the traitor!" the fusion replied. "You used to be Homeworld's greatest warrior! Now you work alongside its greatest enemy, throwing your lot in with traitors, off-colors, and organics! There couldn't *be* a bigger fall from grace."

"Is that so?" said Steven. "Because last I checked, she's still working for the Diamonds. You, on the other hand, work for Emerald, who wants to overthrow them. Not to mention, fusion wasn't really high up on a list of Homeworld's values."

Bluebird swung her saber before he could continue, launching a blast of ice that froze his leg in place. "Be quiet!" she shouted. "You, the Diamonds, *everyone else* are the real traitors! The New Horde is going to right those wrongs, to return Homeworld back into what it should be, starting with *you* ! Get them!"

Karikon opened fire, hitting Jasper with a massive shot of explosive plasma that launched her back. Steven once again broke free from the ice, racing towards the scorpion man. Instead, he was intercepted by a blast of purple flame, courtesy of Crita. His enormous form prevented much of the damage, but he was hindered just long enough for the sorceress to summon magical chains up from the ground, wrapping around him.

"You really think I can be held down that easily?" he asked, struggling against the chains.

"I sure hope so," Crita replied. "Otherwise, I'm gonna have a real angry muscle-man coming after me." The chains managed to hold Steven in place, but just barely, as it took all of her strength to keep him there.

Meanwhile, Jasper was going after Bluebird, chasing her down as the smaller Gem darted around through the air. "Where's all that talk now?" Jasper said. "Are you gonna sit still and fight me? Or are you gonna run away like the bug you are!?"

"I resent that 'bug' comparison!" said Karikon, once again opening fire. Jasper was privy to dodge the incoming shots this time, which exploded in the garden behind her. She prepared to get in close, only to feel a slash down her back while she was distracted. Trying to grab the source of the strike, Bluebird just darted out of her reach.

Steven held out his hand, pulling the Sword of Power to him. He used it to slash through the chains, chasing after Crita. She created a series of shields to block his strikes, but each swing of the weapon destroyed a barrier. "Karikon! I could use some help over here!"

The scorpionkin turned his blaster towards Steven, who managed to block the shot with his sword. He fired again and again, only for Steven to deflect each shot. "Now *I* could use some help!" he shouted as Steven grew closer and closer.

Upon reaching him, Steven grabbed hold of his weapon, yanking it out of his claws. Another swing of the sword, but Karikon managed to latch onto the blade, disarming him as well. The two continued to trade blows, though it was clear who was winning. "Do you even know who I am!?" Steven bellowed boisterously. "I'm the one who took on the Diamonds head-on! I brought Homeworld to its knees! What chance do you have!?"

While Karikon narrowly avoided being pounded into the ground, Jasper continued trying to chase Bluebird down. Although she was unable to do any lasting damage to the Quartz, her saber allowed her to limit her movement, while using her own speed to keep herself out of reach. It stayed this way for a while, but soon something happened to break the stalemate.

"He's over here!" Alerted by the commotion, Connie led Bow and the Gems out into the courtyard where they witnessed the fighting. "Steven!" Drawing her sword, she hurried out into the fray with the others.

"A little late to the party, aren't you?" said Jasper, breaking free from Bluebird's ice.

Garnet summoned her gauntlets, standing beside her. "Less talking, more fighting!" The pair tried to corral Bluebird to prevent her from flying away. She did, of course, try to escape upwards, only to be forced to dodge Amethyst's whip.

Crita and Connie began fighting, though the former found the latter's sword much less threatening than Steven's. "What's that thing made of, plastic?" she asked, preparing to shoot a spell at her. An arrow from Bow hit her hand, causing her to misfire.

"Stand still and find out!" said Connie, lunging and smacking her with the flat side of it. Momentarily stunned, Crita was unprepared for Bow to pin her to the wall with a net arrow. The two fist-bumped, but their celebration was short-lived as they noticed Steven's situation.

He was handily winning his fight against Karikon, having him on the ropes. Pearl had gone over to help, but it didn't seem like he needed it. If anything, it was his enemy that needed to be helped! "Steven, what are you doing?" she asked, concerned at seeing him act this brutally.

"What does it look like?" he asked, turning away from Karikon for a moment. "I'm winning!" The scorpionkin took this moment to wrap his arms around Steven, repeatedly jabbing him with his tail. Pearl and the others cried out, concerned at how this would turn out, but their worry was unfounded; Steven angrily grabbed hold of the stinger, yanking it out, taking most of the tail with it. While Karikon cried out and reeled in pain, Steven lifted him over his head and hurled him towards the castle.

With nobody watching her, Crita used her magic to escape the net by turning herself intangible. She hurried over to help Karikon, only to be intercepted by Pearl. "Outta the way, Gem. This fight won't turn out in your favor."

"Is that so?" Pearl's gemstone began to glow, producing numerous copies of herself that surrounded the sorceress. "Then I should even the odds!" The holo-Pearls set upon Crita all at once, potentially overwhelming her as she struggled to fight them all off.

Garnet fired her rocket fists up at Bluebird, who continued to dodge. This did fill the air with explosions, though, giving her less room to move. "She's too quick," she said.

"Well then, we need to be quicker!" Amethyst said.

She suddenly found herself grabbed by Jasper. "In that case, think fast!" Jasper hurled Amethyst into the air, a move that Bluebird wasn't expecting. She spun as she sailed towards her target, colliding with her and forcing her into a crash-landing.

Now that she was grounded, Jasper moved in for the kill, poofing Bluebird with a stomp. Garnet leapt into the air to catch Amethyst,

landing beside her. “Never thought we’d make a good team!” Amethyst said.

Jasper scoffed. “I wouldn’t exactly call us a team,” she said, grabbing hold of Aquamarine’s inert form. “Now, where’s that other one?”

Having managed to fight her way through all of Pearl’s clones, an exhausted Crita now faced the genuine article. “Okay, maybe I’m not as out of your league as I thought,” she panted. “But there’s only one of you left!”

“And that’s more than enough!” Both of them charged the other, with Pearl firing blasts from her spear. Crita leapt over the shots, throwing magical discs at Pearl, who deflected them by spinning her spear. She landed, preparing to unleash a powerful blast of magic, only to be stunned as electricity coursed through her body. She fell to the ground, revealing Bow had shot her with a shock arrow.

“You looked like you could use some help,” he said. Pearl grinned, offering a look of silent thanks.

As this all happened, Steven made his way over to the fallen Karikon. “I’m…I’m not down yet,” he slurred, trying to stand up. “Jus’ give me a few minutes–” Steven brought both of his fists down hard, denying his request.

Connie hurried over as he continued to brutalize his opponent. “Steven! Stop! This isn’t you!” But he refused to listen, overtaken by his newfound bloodlust. Karikon’s helmet cracked open under the repeated strikes, revealing his bruised, bloodied, nearly unconscious face. “Please, listen!”

“I *am* listening!” he yelled. “And you know what? This *is* me! A newer, stronger, *better* me! Steven was weak–but I’m He-Man now!” He pulled his sword into his hand, raising it above his head in preparation to finish Karikon off.

"No! Don't!" Connie ran towards him, but she wouldn't be fast enough to prevent him from taking a life. In desperation, she cried out the only thing she could think: "Aren't you Rose's son!?"

The Sword of Power stopped moments before it impaled Karikon. Steven's vicious smile had vanished, replaced by an expression of pure dread. As he got back up, his hands shook, enough that he almost dropped the sword. He fell to his knees, his He-Man form dissipating. "C-Connie?" he said, turning to face her.

She knelt down beside him, wrapping him in her arms. "It's okay, Steven. It's okay now."

"...Is it?" he asked quietly.

With the battle over, everyone stood around Steven, looking at him with concern–or, in Jasper's case, irritation. In their worry for him, nobody noticed another figure sneaking from behind, brandishing a knife. Though when she shouted out a war cry, it was hard *not* to notice her.

"Die, Steven!" yelled Eyeball, raising her weapon as she prepared to impale the object of her hatred. Moments before she could, a pink blade cut through her form, and the surprised Ruby disappeared in a puff of smoke. Connie, wielding her sword, stood over her gem.

Everyone was shocked silent for a moment. Eventually, Amethyst spoke, picking up Eyeball's gemstone. "So…what now?" she asked, looking around at their fallen enemies.

"Um…get them inside, said Bow. "Make sure they're secured. Once they wake up, we'll see if we can get any information out of them. I'm sure Glimmer will have plenty of questions when she gets back."

"For the Honor of Grayskull!" There was a flash of light from around the corner, and Adora as She-Ra sprinted onto the battlefield, sword raised. "I'm here! I'm ready to…fight the guys

that…you already took care of…" She stood there awkwardly, realizing she was late. "Um…sorry."

Jasper lifted Karikon over her shoulder. "Great, *now* we're safe. Not that we needed you, but you coulda been here earlier, you know." She walked past Adora, glaring at her as she went.

As everyone secured the prisoners, Bow went over to her. "So, I don't agree with Jasper's rudeness, but…she has a bit of a point. Where were you? Usually She-Ra's the first one on the scene whenever there's trouble."

Adora looked around awkwardly, before de-transforming. "I maaay have gotten a bit distracted looking for some things," she admitted.

Bow looked disappointed. "Adora, I told you not to go looking through Glimmer's private things. It's bad enough you did that, but ignoring your friends when they're in danger? I really think you're letting this Hordak thing get to you."

"I didn't ignore you!" Adora said. "I just didn't notice that you were all in trouble! …That's not much better, is it?" Bow shook his head. "Okay, but at least nobody got hurt, right?"

They looked over as Connie helped Steven to his feet. He looked almost despondent, staring at the place Karikon had been laying until she pulled him away. "Not on the outside, at least," said Bow.

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Carnelian had Mermista on the ropes, having forced her onto dry land. She threw her boomerang again and again, further pushing her back as she evaded the projectile. "I'd give up now if I were you!" she said, intent on keeping her away from the source of her power.

"Giving up isn't something I do! Unless I'm *bored* !" Mermista decided that if she couldn't get to the water, she would bring it to her, summoning a waterspout towards her. This floating stream

circled around her like a torrential ribbon, before she shot it at Carnelian.

The serpentine water formation chased after its target, who was surprisingly agile for her size. Eventually, though, it was able to bind her, holding her in place while Mermista lunged with her trident. But Carnelian wasn't the type to give up without a fight. "Not so fast!"

She fell backwards just as the trident shot forward, sending her leg up in a kick that knocked the weapon out of Mermista's hand. The princess tumbled to the ground, with Catra eagerly moving in to finish her off. She was stopped at the last minute as a thick wall of vines separated her from her prey.

"Quick, do something!" said Perfuma. "I can't hold her for long! Her claws are way sharper than they used to be!"

Frosta appeared beside Mermista. "I think this calls for a tag-team move!" she said eagerly.

"I couldn't agree more!" Carnelian threw her boomerang to distract them, but Frosta was able to deflect it with an ice shield on her arm. Meanwhile, Mermista drew the water back to her, reshaping it into a long stream that she hurled at the Gem once more.

As it sped towards its target, Frosta held her hand up to it as it passed by. The water froze as it flew, turning it into a trident of ice. "Subzero Piercer!" she proclaimed. Expecting to just be able to endure the torrent, Carnelian was unprepared for this sharp-pointed projectile hurling right at her. Impaled by its three prongs, she was thrown back, soon after disappearing into her gemstone.

Mermista and Frosta shared a fist bump, but their victory was short lived as Catra made her reappearance. "You're gonna pay for that!" she hissed, lunging with her claws out. Perfuma tried to grab her with some vines, but she sliced through these as well.

This did give Frosta enough time to grab Carnelian's gem, however.

"Hey!" she yelled, getting both Catra's and Sqalish's attention. "Stand down, or I'll break this thing into a thousand pieces!" She covered one of her fists in ice to show she was serious.

Catra couldn't care less, running at her. But just as Frosta had turned her frozen gauntlet into a  shield, she realized Catra had been halted by a tentacle around her waist. "We need to go!" yelled Sqalish.

"No we don't!" Catra replied. "We don't need Carnelian to beat them!"

"We can't take on three princesses by ourselves! I'm sorry, commander!" With that, Sqalish leapt into the water, dragging Catra behind him. Mermista and Perfuma rushed forward to stop them, but he was too agile. The former leapt into the water, only to emerge a moment later, empty-handed.

She shook her head. "No sign of 'em. That mer-man must be a really good swimmer to get away that fast. I doubt Glimmer's gonna be happy about this…"

Frosta held the scarlet gemstone over her head. "She won't be *too* upset, seeing as we took a prisoner! We can get her to tell us what Catra has planned!"

"Excellent! We've managed to salvage the situation after all!" said Perfuma. "Although…how exactly are we going to get back?" She looked over at their wrecked skiff.

"I guess we could walk," said Frosta. "Might take a while, though. We'd have to stop somewhere first.

Mermista considered the situation. "Lemme try something." Manipulating the water, she was able to right their damaged skiff, which was just intact enough to serve as a platform floating on the marsh. She stepped on, waiting for the other two to do the

same. “This should get us close enough to Salineas to find another ride.

The princesses aboard. “Smart thinking, Mermista! I knew we could count on you!”

“Yup, you sure can,” she said, looking away uncertainly. She directed the makeshift boat down the stream. “I’m tired of this place. Let’s go home.” As they floated along, she wondered if they would judge her for knowing Catra had returned beforehand.

# Out of the Bag

Chapter Summary

Secrets are revealed. Trust is broken.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Fifteen: Out of the Bag

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"Adora, I'd just like to reiterate that I *really* don't approve of this!" said Bow, as he and Adora made their way into Glimmer's room. "It's more than just a breach of privacy, I'm pretty sure snooping in on the queen's things counts as treason!"

"Relax, Bow, Glimmer's our friend–in theory," she added bitterly. "Hordak has to be the one pulling the strings, turning her against us. If we can find proof that he's trying to take back the Horde, we can get her back!" She immediately went over to rifle through drawers, open cabinets, and even look under mattresses.

Bow cringed at the display. "This is so wrong!" he said quietly. "Please, Adora, can't we just ask *her* what's bothering her?"

She let out a frustrated huff. "I already told you, Bow, that wouldn't do any good! Hordak has his hooks in her, and if we try to confront her about it without proof, he'll just turn *us* into the bad guys!"

"Well, we are going through her private things…" Bow pointed out.

"Yeah, but for her own good!" Adora produced Glimmer's diary, quickly flipping through the pages. "Come on, help me look!"

The conflict between helping his friend and invading his friend's privacy began to reach its boiling point. "How is this supposed to help her!? Even *if* Hordak is really manipulating her, how do you think she's going to react when she finds out we went through her stuff!?"

"She'll thank us! If anyone understands that sometimes you have to do dirty deeds for a good outcome, it's Glimmer! Hordak taught her that one…" she muttered. "Are you gonna help me or not?"

He took a deep breath to calm himself down, but it didn't do its job very well. "Adora, while I agree that Glimmer has been acting strange lately, this is going to do more harm than good. So please, *stop this* before you see something you shouldn't!"

"I *can't* stop!" Adora shouted. "My friend is being turned into a tyrant by a madman, and I'm not just gonna sit there and let it happen! You don't have to help me, but don't try and stop me!"

"Fine." With a heavy heart, Bow walked out the door. "I can see now that you're intent on destroying our friend's privacy. I can't stop you, but I *can* tell you that when Glimmer finds out, she'll be very upset. And you'll only have yourself to blame!" After making his dissatisfaction clear, Bow closed the door behind him, afraid of what this meant for the three of them down the line.

Adora was desperate to find something, anything, that could help free her friend. She all but tore up her room in the process, so focused was she on locating what she hoped would be decisive evidence. In fact, she was so focused that she didn't notice when a fight broke out in the garden–until it was already over.

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The moment Glimmer learned of the attack at Brightmoon, the queen immediately sped back to deal with the situation. Flanked by Hordak and Topaz, she stormed past her guards and up to the room where everyone was gathered. "Where are they!?" she demanded.

"We're keeping them all in here," Bow said, pointing to the guest room beside them. Steven sat on the floor nearby, surrounded by all of the Gems and Connie, as well as the other three princesses. Glimmer took note of this, but rather than ask what was wrong, felt that checking in on their prisoners was more pressing. The trio headed inside.

Spinnerella and Netossa were standing guard, the latter holding a dome-shaped net around the villains. "Oh, Queen Glimmer, we weren't expecting you to get here so fast," said the former. "Did you deal with those Horde insurgents?"

The corner of Glimmer's mouth twitched slightly. "They didn't show–but we'll deal with them later." She approached the net, examining the captives. Two Gems, a scorpionkin, and a sorceress from Mystacor. The scorpion was the largest of the group, but appeared the most heavily injured. He was the only one who didn't look up at her. "Let me guess, she set this all up in advance. Tried to lure me out so you could all attack Brightmoon when I wasn't here."

"'She?'" said Netossa, but Spinnerella stopped her before she could continue. She needed to keep her focus to maintain the dome holding them all.

The blue Gem scoffed. "Don't underestimate me–this plan was all me!" Wings emerged from her back, and she flew up next to Glimmer's face. "As if I'd care about *you* . No, this was all about revenge on Steven Universe!"

"Sure, just tell her the whole plan, why don't you!" said the red Gem, rolling her single eye. The blue one glared at her.

A light knock on the door–Spinnerella opened it. Bow peered inside. "Uh, Glimmer, are we starting the interrogation? I think everyone should be here for this. I, uh, don't want you to have to handle it on your own." He left out the part about him worrying what she would do if left to her own devices.

"Alright, fine, let them in," she said. Bow motioned for everyone to enter. The three princesses came first, followed by Steven, who entered reluctantly, with Connie and the Gems refusing to leave his side–she'd ask later. "So, what happened?"

"Steven and Jasper were sparring when these three, er, these four attacked," Bow said. "It seems like they have a grudge against them both."

"You got that right!" shouted Eyeball, jumping to her feet and pounding her fists against the net. "I used to look up to Jasper! She was my hero, ever since the Earth War! But after *you* came along," she glared at Steven, "she's practically one of the Crystal Gems!"

"I wouldn't go *that* far," said Bismuth.

But the Ruby wasn't done. "Y'know, I used to have it all! I was a local hero when I testified against Rose Quartz! But once Era 3 came along, all anyone talks about is Steven, Steven, STEVEN! Is it any wonder we wanted revenge!?"

"Now who's telling them everything?" snapped Aquamarine.

Crita put her head in her hands. "I can't believe I sided with these people…"

"Alright, enough!" Glimmer shouted. "Okay, so it's clear now that you only came here for revenge because you're petty little babies." Both of the Gems glared at her. "And I assume those two were just along for the ride. But I can't imagine you came all this way without Catra's knowledge, at least not without her noticing. Did she send you here?"

There came a laugh from the large scorpion man, who everyone had assumed to be unconscious. "This isn't exactly an ideal situation for an interrogation, princess! Think about it: not only do we not have any incentive to tell you what you want to know, but you've got no way of making us. *We're* in here, *you're* out there–what was your plan again?"

Glimmer clenched her jaw. “My friends were able to handle you just fine on your own. Imagine how much worse things are for you now that I’m here. And that’s ‘queen’ to you.”

“Terrifying,” said Karikon, examining the tiny girl. “Why don’t you try sending him in here?” He nodded towards Steven, who looked away in shame. “Now that might actually get something done!”

“Why are you giving her ideas?” muttered Crita.

Despite feeling that the interrogation was more pressing, Glimmer couldn’t ignore the issue with Steven any longer. “Okay…what happened with him?” she asked.

Nobody, including Steven himself, seemed to want to answer. Eventually, however, he stepped forward to tell her what had happened. “I…I lost control,” he said. “I was He-Man, and I was fighting with Jasper, and when these guys attacked…”

“Steven.” Connie placed a comforting hand on his chest. “You don’t have to relive this again.”

He shook his head. “No, it’s fine, *I’m* fine.” He turned back to Glimmer. “Something about the Sword of Power is making me more violent. The more I use it, the more I enjoy fighting. I’m worried that if I keep using it, I-I won’t be able to stop.” His voice grew quieter as he related this, eventually trailing off.

Seeing how upset he was, Glimmer decided not to mention how this could be seen as a positive. Especially considering she had seen firsthand what happened when She-Ra lost control. Hordak spoke before she could: “We’ll have to deal with that later. Right now, we have more pressing matters to attend to.” He turned his attention back to their prisoners.

“He’s right.” Mermista approached the net. “She sent you here, didn’t she? What’s Catra doing on Etheria?” When none of them opted to answer, Glimmer subtly took her aside, where neither they nor the others could hear them. “Just you wait, we’ll come up with something to make you talk!”

Huddled together, Glimmer asked her the question that she had been meaning to since she returned. “You ran into her, didn’t you? Tell me what happened.”

“Yes, we saw her,” she said. “I convinced Perfuma and Frosta to hold off on telling everyone for now, but they both have questions. She got away, but we did manage to capture another one, a Gem.”

“Okay…I think I have an idea.” Glimmer returned to the center of the room, glaring at the captives. “I’m going to give you one last chance: did Catra send you here? Did you come alone?”

“Does there always have to be a sinister plot behind everything?” asked Crita. “These two already told you: we came here for revenge on Steven. I doubt they even told Catra we were going anywhere.”

Glimmer hid her growing smirk. “You expect me to believe you came here with just the four of you? What would be the sense in that? You’re telling me you don’t have any kind of backup plans at all?”

She received a shrug from Karikon. “Never said we were the brightest bunch. My partner here’s right: we came here for one reason only, and we failed. Oh well!”

“In that case…Netossa? Could you give me a little opening?” The princess closed one hand, and a small hole appeared in the net. After that, Glimmer nodded to Perfuma, with Mermista backing her up. “Then how do you explain this?” Perfuma produced a small object wrapped in vines from her pocket, unraveling it before tossing it through the hole.

The object, Carnelian’s gem, clattered to the floor, before it started to glow. Azurite’s group tried to hide their recognition as her body was restored, which proved difficult to do as she looked at each of them when examining her surroundings. “What!? Who!? Where!? …Oh. They got you guys too, huh?”

Glimmer chuckled, the cards turning in her favor. "If you came here alone, then what's she doing here?"

"What do you mean?" Crita said, doing her best to obfuscate. "I don't recognize her. Even if she *is* with the New Horde, there's Gems all over the place. She could easily be here for some other reason."

Carnelian caught on quickly, doing her best to corroborate her details. "Yeah! I don't know these guys! Me 'n Catra were just here on a scouting mission when you guys attacked us for no reason!" …But not quickly enough.

The moment she said this, nearly everyone present tensed up. They knew now. Everyone knew. Adora, looking all but stunned, approached the net. "Catra is…here?" she asked, staring at Carnelian.

It was now that the Quartz began to realize she had accidentally let something slip. "Uh…no, why? I mean, she *was* here, but not… anymore…" She looked to her allies for help, but they only responded with varying degrees of anger and disbelief.

"Catra came to Etheria personally," Lapis said gravely. "What is she after?" she demanded of them.

Netossa had almost faltered, nearly releasing the prisoners, but Spinnerella was there to keep her together. "Stay strong, you can do this," she told her, supporting her both physically and emotionally. She turned to the others, her concern obvious on her face. "She has to be planning something. She wouldn't be here without a reason."

Mermista had rather uncharacteristically frozen up, looking like she was moments away from bolting out of the room. Making matters worse, Frosta took that moment to sidle up next to her. "Is this why you didn't want us to tell everyone?" she whispered.

Nobody heard her–except for Pearl, who glanced over, confused. "Tell everyone what?" she asked. "Did you know Catra was here

already?" Mermista looked over at her in panic, while Frosta tried to shrink into the background. Perfuma whimpered, turning away. Their reactions seemed to confirm her question.

"You…you *did* know?" asked Bismuth. A schism had begun to form in the room: the Crystal Gems on one side, the princesses on the other. "Well, why not say something? I mean, sure, there was an attack here, but if one of the New Horde's leaders was here, you'd think we should know about that, right?"

An increasingly-worried Mermista glanced over at Glimmer, who responded with a stern almost-glare. "W-we wanted to avoid causing a panic," she explained. "Like is happening right now! Sure, Catra is here, but we don't know where, or why, or–

"That's exactly why we *should* be panicking," Adora said gravely, turning away from the dome. "We don't know anything. Which means she could be up to *anything* . And that should scare you all." She turned to Mermista. "Where exactly did you run into her?"

"In the swamp just outside of Salineas," she replied. "But she's long gone by now. There's no telling where she went."

"I'll ask Demantoid to calculate the possibilities," Glimmer said. "She found her once, she can find her again."

"Don't tell me you knew too!" pleaded Adora.

"Indeed she did."

Everyone's attention now turned to Hordak, none of them having expected him to speak up. Glimmer, about to argue that she hadn't known all the details at the time, was aghast at being revealed like this. Adora was equally horrified. "...What?"

"Queen Glimmer and Princess Mermista have known that Catra was on-world for some time now," he continued. "Indeed, keeping this a secret was an attempt to avoid panic, as well as to prevent

her plan from getting out. Of course, this was a plan she had concocted even before knowing this."

Glimmer was furious, her eyes piercing through him as her hands glowed with magical energy. "Why are you telling them this?" she asked, her voice disquietingly calm.

"A better question would be, why didn't *you* tell *us* ?" Glimmer turned to see Adora looking hurt. "I mean, preventing panic, I get that, but what about Bow and I? Didn't we deserve to know?"

"Oh, he does know," Hordak continued, as Bow silently gestured at him to stop. "He knows all about Glimmer's master plan. He shared his reservations about it with me himself."

Everyone's focus was away from the prisoners, who were listening intently to this breakdown of partnership occurring before them. With their enemies distracted, Karikon and Crita shared a quick nod. Karikon discreetly removed a hidden communicator he had taped to his back. Crita magically summoned it to her hands, and began broadcasting.

Adora looked back and forth between Bow and Glimmer, growing madder by the second. "And this 'master plan,' what exactly is it? No sense in hiding it now that we all already know!"

Because Bow had completely clammed up, Hordak placed himself behind Glimmer. "Go on. Tell her. She deserves to know. The two of you are friends, are you not?"

"You know what? No!" shouted Glimmer. "Yes, you're my friend, but *I'm* the Queen! *I'm* the one who decides what's best for Brightmoon, best for Etheria! So if I say you don't get to know, then *you don't get to know* !"

"That's not a queen, that's a dictator!" Adora shouted back. "Don't you get it!? Hordak's getting inside your head, trying to turn you into a copy of him!"

"In case you forgot, I'm the one who went to him! I take his advice because *I* decide it's right, not because he's tricking me! I'm the most powerful woman on this planet, and I would never let anyone manipulate me!"

"There's no way the Glimmer I know would act like this! Do you really think Angella would want to see her daughter acting like–

"My mother is *dead* !"

"SHE WANTS TO KILL CATRA!" Bow slapped his hands over his mouth the moment the words had left it. Too long had the secret festered inside of him, too long had he allowed it to linger. In the heat of the moment, he had let it out. Everyone stared at him in varying degrees of disbelief, but none more so than Adora and Glimmer.

Adora no longer looked angry. There was no way to describe her expression as anything other than hurt. "You…what?" she asked quietly. "Glimmer…why? Why would you–is that true?" She looked over at her old friend, silently pleading that it wasn't.

No longer could she hide the truth. Glimmer closed her eyes, clenching her fist. "Yes," she said, just as quietly. "Yes, it is!" she roared. "I want to *end* her, once and for all! I want to fly up to that ship of hers myself, and *tear her apart with my bare hands* !" Tears slid down her cheeks, her face contorted in pure fury. "She's the reason my mom is dead, Adora! She nearly killed *all* of us, everyone on Earth and Etheria! *How can you still be defending her* !?"

"Because she's my friend!" Adora yelled back. "She was the only one I had growing up, and I can't just forget that! Glimmer, this… this isn't you. I thought you were my friend. I thought I could *trust* you."

Hordak glanced over at Peridot, who tensed up. "Now, now, Adora, Queen Glimmer wasn't the only one here keeping secrets.

A little bird told me you've been hiding something from her as well. Something about a mission of your own?"

Glimmer glared at Adora, who looked over at Peridot. "You *told* him? I shared that with you in confidence!" Peridot tried to hide her face. "If you had to tell anyone, why him!?"

"Tell him what, Adora?" Glimmer wiped her eyes, her rage replaced with a sinister calm. "Go on. I shared my secret. Now share yours."

She took a deep breath. Glimmer was right–now was the right time, if there was any. "It's…the numbers Light Hope gave me. I know you told me to stop looking into them, but they could be the only way to find out where I come from. And they are! I asked Peridot to look into them, and it turns out they're coordinates for a First Ones space station! If I can go there, I might be able to find my family, who I was before I came to Etheria…"

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. "That's *it* ? *That's* the big secret you were so insistent on keeping from me? Why would I care!?"

"You *wouldn't* , that's the problem!" Adora shouted back. Ever since Angella… Ever since then, you've been so laser-focused on the New Horde that you've turned into a completely different person! I assumed that if you heard about this, you'd throw your queenly weight around and forbid me from going!"

"Do…do you really trust me that little?" she asked, hurt by the accusation.

"Apparently I do," Adora huffed. "And it seems like I was right to. You're letting Hordak turn you into a tyrant just as bad as he was."

"Oh, sorry going after the *bad guys* makes me a *tyrant* !" Glimmer shouted. "Just because he gave me the idea doesn't mean that–"

"See!? *See* !? He planted the idea in your head! That's what he *does* , he's insidious! Please, Glimmer, you have to come to your

senses! I looked everywhere to find some sort of proof, anything to show you that he's lying, but he must've hidden it better–show me where it is! Help me help you!"

"What do you mean, you looked everywhere?" Glimmer said. "What exactly were you trying to find?"

Adora faltered, but figured there was no reason to hide anything now. "Okay, so I may have dug through your room to try and find some proof, but–"

"And now you're invading my privacy!?" Glimmer teleported up to her, pressing a finger against her chest. "I could have you imprisoned for treason!"

She threw up her hands. "Go ahead, it's not like anything's beneath you at this point! After all, you were already plotting to *assassinate my best friend* !"

Bow stepped forward to try and mediate the conflict. "Um, Adora, while I don't condone Glimmer's plan, you have to remember that Catra did try and destroy-slash-take over the world," he said. "I hate to say it, but maybe she's not as good a friend as you once–"

"I don't want to hear it from you!" Adora snapped. "You were complicit in all this! Why don't you just go and join her team? You're already on her side!"

"Don't talk to him like that!" shouted Glimmer. "And he's right, you know–why are you still sticking up for Catra after all she's done!?"

"Because it's not her fault! Not *all* her fault," she hastily corrected. "Emerald was involved in this too, but I don't see you going after her!"

"That's because she isn't the biggest threat right now," Glimmer replied. "Her time will come, same as everybody else in the New Horde. But right now, I'm focusing my efforts on the biggest threat to not only Etheria, but the rest of the universe. And I don't care that she used to be your friend, I'm taking her down."

Adora's hand twitched, slightly reaching towards the sword on her back. "I'm not letting you kill her," she said.

"And I'm not letting you stop me." Glimmer turned her back, facing towards the prisoners with a chilling glare. "Go on. Go chase after that past you want so much. I won't stop you."

After a tense moment of silence, Adora responded. "Maybe I will." With that, she stormed out of the room and up to her own, but not before shooting one last remark over her shoulder. "Just don't be surprised if I don't come back."

"Adora, wait!" Bow ran after her, but it was clear she was in no mood to listen. He stopped just outside the door, returning after he watched her walk down the hallway. Before he could accost Glimmer for her role in this, one of the prisoners spoke up.

The silence was broken as Karikon broke into laughter. "Now that was pretty spectacular! We didn't even have to do anything, your whole chain of command just broke down all on its own! What are we even doing here? At this rate, the Princess Alliance is just gonna tear itself apart by itself!"

Instantly, Glimmer vanished in a flash of light, appearing within the net before the scorpion man. She pressed her fist, glowing with energy, against his chest as she looked him dead in the eye. "I want you to remember exactly what He-Man did to you," she growled. "And then remember that He-Man can't fire white-hot lasers out of his hands. However badly he broke you, I can do a *thousand* times worse. Understand?"

All four of the prisoners were frozen on the spot. Karikon, with a mix of respect and reluctant self-preservation, only nodded.

"Good. Remember this when I come back for the real interrogation." She teleported back out of the dome, appearing next to Spinnerella and Netossa. "Sorry this is taking so long. Just hold them for a little while longer, until I get a more permanent solution."

“You kidding? I could hold this pose all day!” Netossa said confidently, albeit strained. Spinnerella stayed by her side, ever worried about her. And although both of them put on a brave face, they were *both* worried about Glimmer.

Glimmer herself, however, was not worried. “Well? What are you all standing around for?” she said to everyone else. “Catra’s here! ! Ready the castle’s defenses, ready your offenses, we need to prepare for the worst!” She disappeared in another flash, most likely returning to the throne room.

Everybody wanted to talk about what had just happened. But at the same time, *nobody* wanted to talk about what had just happened. Seeing as neither party involved in the argument wanted to be talked to, all they could do was listen to the queen. She did have a point about Catra being a threat, after all. Princess and Gem alike left the room to prepare for what may or may not be coming.

Then only three were left. Hordak began making his way to the throne room, and Bow and Peridot, after sharing a quick glance, followed after him. “So, was this all part of your evil plan?” he asked bitterly. “Wait for just the right moment to reveal our secrets, and let everything fall apart?”

To their surprise, Hordak let out a sigh. “In my time as leader of the Horde, I’ve come to learn one thing: secrets should only be kept if absolutely necessary. And secrets kept by subordinate from superior are decidedly *not* necessary, nor is a superior keeping their subordinates in the dark. Revealing the truth may have painful consequences now, but may have spared even more painful consequences later on.”

“How? By turning Glimmer and Adora against each other?” Bow asked. “How is that supposed to help anyone?”

“Because now, both of them can pursue their objectives without interference,” answered Hordak. “Adora will find what she is

looking for, while Glimmer and I can handle what is *truly* important. All without getting in each other's way."

Bow didn't look impressed. "Yeah, except now they hate each other. I wouldn't exactly consider that a win."

Hordak only shrugged. "And if either one were to find out of their own accord, how would they react? What we saw from them today would look subdued by comparison. I did what was best for everyone involved, harsh though it may seem to you. Now, if you are sated, I have more important business to take care of." He walked off, leaving the two of them standing in the hall. Bow glared after him.

"Do…do you think Adora meant what she said?" asked Peridot, guiltily staring at the floor. "About not coming back?"

"Of course she…" Bow was about to assure Peridot that there was no way Adora would leave Etheria for good, but went silent when he realized he couldn't be sure. If she really found her home and her family, would she have any reason not to stay with them? "I guess all we can do is wait and see."

Peridot slumped to the ground. "This is all my fault," she whimpered. "If I had just told somebody…"

"No, it isn't your fault," Bow reassured her, offering a comforting pat. "If it's anyone's fault, it's mine. I kept secrets too."

"Maybe Hordak's right," Peridot wondered aloud. "Maybe this is like ripping off a…what do you call those?"

"Bandage?"

"Like ripping off a bandage. It hurts now, but it has to be done."

Bow wasn't so sure, but if anyone could stay positive, it was him. "I hope you're right," he said, though he still hesitated to believe Hordak didn't have ulterior motives. "It would be so much easier that way…"

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Nobody had noticed, but during all the commotion, Steven had stepped outside to get some fresh air. Nobody noticed, that is, except Connie, who headed out after him. "You alright?" she asked, sitting beside him on the steps.

He didn't seem nearly as upset as he had just under an hour ago, which was a good sign. "Fine," he told her. "Well, no, not fine, but…I'll live."

"Just 'live?'" she replied, playfully nudging him. "You don't have to put on such a brave face, you know. I'm right here if you need to tell me what's bothering you."

Steven looked away. "You *know* what's bothering me. "I can't…I can't afford to lose control like that again. I might hurt somebody I care about next time. I might *kill* somebody next time!"

"Steven, I know you're scared," Connie assured him, "but this isn't your fault. Jasper's been trying to turn you into *her* idea of a warrior, without restraint or mercy. And the more time you spend with her, the more control she has over you."

He took the sword off his back, holding it in his hands like it could catch fire at any moment. "No," he said quietly. "Jasper didn't make me do that. She didn't turn me into…that. Whenever I become He-Man, I feel stronger than I've ever felt before. And since I don't have my Gem powers anymore, I like that feeling. It's the only time I feel…important. But I have thoughts when I'm transformed–bad thoughts. And I just…let my power control me. This isn't the first time I've lost control. Just the first time someone got seriously hurt because of it."

Connie could hardly stand seeing him like this. "You're *not* useless, powers or not, okay?" He nodded, but didn't say a word. "And I'm sure Adora can help us with that issue. She's had the Sword of Protection a lot longer than you've had yours, so she has to know some tricks by now."

“Thanks, Connie,” said Steven, “but I don’t think this is something we can fix. I think…I think the only way I can avoid hurting people is to not be He-Man.” He placed the Sword of Power on the ground; a weight seemed to lift off his shoulders when he did so.

“I’ll admit, I don’t know much about magical swords and transforming warriors,” she said, “at least not personally. But if this is what you think is for the best, then I believe you.” She opened her arms for a hug, which he eagerly returned. “Feeling better?”

“Much,” he said, smiling warmly.

Chapter End Notes

If it wasn't obvious, I have been eagerly awaiting this chapter for a while now! Hope you're all prepared, 'cause this is where things get real!

# Depths

Chapter Summary

As Catra's and Modulok's plans come together, Scorpia and Micah make a descent in search of power.

Chapter Sixteen: Depths

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At the edge of Salineas, the swamp narrowed into a river, which let out into the ocean. Out of the water crawled two figures, exhausted. Having done most of the work pulling them out of harm's way, Sqalish collapsed onto the sand. Catra shook herself off before trying to get him on his feet again. "I hope you aren't planning on laying there all day."

Still panting, he slowly pulled himself up. "Look, I understand if you're mad," he said. "I've come to expect that from you. But you can't honestly expect the two of us to take on three princesses by ourselves!"

"As much as I *want* to be mad at you, I'm not, believe it or not," Catra grumbled. "But I *am* mad. Do you know what I'm mad at?"

"I have a feeling I'm about to find out," Sqalish mumbled. A remark like that normally would have earned Catra's ire, but she ignored it this time.

"I'm mad at myself for making us split up. I'm mad at those princesses, for coming out of nowhere. I'm mad at Carnelian for letting herself get defeated so easily." She began stomping towards the water's edge, continuing her tirade. "I'm mad at Adora for just *letting* all of this happen! I'm mad at Emerald for being such a sub-par second in command! And I'm mad at Entrapta for sending us here to look for *something she already knew about* !" she bellowed out to sea.

Despite knowing the risks, Sqalish figured it would be better for him to try and calm her down. He slowly approached once her rant was over. "So…what's the plan now?"

Catra resisted the urge to accost him for asking such a stupid question–even as mad as he was, she realized it was a fairly valid thing to ask. "We…we have to find out more about the Heart of Etheria," she eventually said. "For now, we get back to the ship. We contact Entrapta, and tell her what we have so far. We can worry about the others later." Based on the tone of her last sentence, both of them knew they were more than prepared to leave the others behind if it came to that.

But it was at that moment that Karikon's pocket began to vibrate. The two glanced at the source of the noise, then at each other. He removed his communicator to check the message. "Crita," he said softly.

He played the message, expecting to hear her voice, but heard someone else's instead. "...decides what's best for Brightmoon, best for Etheria!" The voice was a little distant, but Catra knew immediately who it was.

"Is that Glimmer?" she asked, leaning in closer. "How are they getting this?" Sqalish increased the volume.

Another voice responded, immediately recognizable as Adora's. "That's not a queen, that's a dictator! Don't you get it!? Hordak's getting inside your head, trying to turn you into a copy of him!"

"Sounds like there's dissension in the ranks," Sqalish noted. Catra nudged him to silence him.

"Do you really think Angella would want to see her daughter acting like–"

"My mother is *dead* !"

"SHE WANTS TO KILL CATRA!"

This outburst was unmistakably the voice of Bow. Both of them froze up upon hearing it, just like it seemed everyone on the other end had. Sqalish looked over at Catra, worried how she would take this revelation. Instead of anger, however, a grin spread across her face, which gave way to laughter. "Uh, boss?"

"I can't believe that princess is taking this personally!" she scoffed. "I always knew she was petty, but this? This is just too good!" She stopped the recording, her attention turning inland. "You know what, Sqalish? I think I have a better plan. We're going to Brightmoon."

Sqalish wasn't sure he wanted to know, but he asked anyway. "And, uh, what is our plan, exactly?"

"Simple: we're going to get rid of the biggest threat to the New Horde," Catra answered, beginning the next leg of their trek. "Glimmer wanted to go straight for the source of her problems, so we'll do the same thing. By using her anger against her." She took hold of Sqalish's communicator, replaying the message to make sure they heard everything. Crita may have just given them all they needed to dismantle the Princess Alliance for good.

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As she sidled along the narrow ledge barely big enough to support her, Scorpia tried to focus on the landscape just beyond. From this vantage point she could see almost the entire forest, and the nearby waterfall created a mist that framed the entire view in a rainbow. "Y'know, I never thought a place called 'Beast Island' could be this pretty," she said. "But it is, isn't it? Pretty."

Micah was a short ways ahead of her, leading the way along the cliffside. "It isn't so pretty once you know what's lurking in the shadows," he added darkly. "...But yeah, from up here it is pretty. Just try not to look down."

"Why would you say that!?" shouted Scorpia, already trying her hardest. "Okay, you can do this," she reminded herself. "Just keep

going, just keeeeeep on going…you'll catch me if I fall, right?"

"I'll try." Micah's assurance didn't exactly assure her very much. "Don't worry, we're almost there. Just a few more steps."

Micah soon disappeared into a crevice hidden behind the waterfall. Scorpia felt around with her claw, making her way inside with his help. "Okay, that was… Look, scorpionkin aren't great with heights. It's not that we're scared, it's just that our bodies aren't suited for climbing, or, y'know, falling. So is it alright if we never do that again?"

Micah smiled, hoping she wouldn't take it as laughing at her. "Sure, if you can find another way out! But let's focus on this for now…" He illuminated the end of his staff, leading the way down into the cave.

Speaking of the cave, it was only now that Scorpia realized that there was a huge cave leading deeper into the mountain. "Woah… so, where exactly did you say this went?" she asked.

"Down," Micah replied. "Far, far down, deeper than anyone has been, I'm pretty sure. Somewhere we'll find enough magic for you to recharge."

Scorpia noticed the tunnel sloped as they continued on, but not by much. If it really was as deep as he said, they'd be walking for a long time. "How exactly did you find this place?" she asked. "Did your magical dowsing skills lead you to the source of all magic on Etheria or something?"

"Um…" Micah looked away. "Actually, I fell in a hole."

"You fell in a hole?" Scorpia repeated.

He nodded. "I fell in a hole. I was out in the woods looking for food, the ground gave out under me, and I fell in a hole. Actually, the spot I fell through shouldn't be too far from here. But after that, I felt a strange pull, like the magic down there was reacting to my own. I'll show you once we get there."

They continued down the tunnel for a little while longer, with practically no change in the environment. But before long, the narrow cave widened out into a much larger room, big enough to be the grand hall of a castle.

But that wasn't all: in the room's center was a pool of crystal-clear water, filled by droplets falling from above. A hole in the ceiling (made by Micah, no doubt) let in a beam of sunlight that the pool reflected all throughout the chamber, dancing across the walls and stalagmites.

Scorpia turned around to take in every inch of the chamber. "Woah… No wonder you felt magic in this place! Man, if this whole island wasn't infested by unholy monstrosities, I'd wanna come here for a picnic!"

"Oh, this? This is nice, but it's far from the main attraction!" said Micah. "What we really want is down that way." He pointed towards yet another cave located behind the pool, leading deeper still. "You can feel that, can't you?"

"What exactly am I supposed to be feeling?" Scorpia waded through the pool over to the opening. "Relief? Pride? Trepediation?" But as she drew closer, she felt a light tingling wash over her. It wasn't a physical feeling either, but more like something in her mind knew what was down there. She didn't, of course, but the feeling got stronger as she held out a claw. It felt a lot like a gentler version of what she felt when she had transformed into a giant scorpion for the first time. "Is this…the feeling?"

"Trepidation," Micah corrected. "But yes, that's the feeling. I don't quite understand how, but there's a little bit of the Black Garnet down there, as well as the Moonstone, the Pearl, the Heart Blossom, maybe Runestone in the area, maybe even the whole planet. Everything we need to defeat Modulok, just down there. Are you ready?"

Normally, Scorpia would be hesitant about crawling into a dark, foreboding cave, especially one that contained the secrets and powers of every princess on Etheria. But if what could help her new friend was down there, what reason did she have to hesitate? "Let's do it!" With a nod, he led the way, and they continued on.

Despite her initial enthusiasm, it quickly fizzled out once she realized they were walking through more of the same dark, narrow chasms as before. The underground grotto had offered a brief sense of wonderment, but now she just felt like they were walking through long-abandoned catacombs, except less interesting. And hopefully with less dead people.

"Hey, I just had a thought," she said, breaking the silence. "Why couldn't we have just gone through the hole in the ceiling back there? It didn't look like *that* big of a drop."

"Oh, that," Micah said. Scorpia noticed his voice was much quieter than before. "I didn't want to risk waking them up."

"Waking–" Scorpia clapped her claws over her mouth, before continuing, quieter. "Waking who up?"

"You'll see in a moment," he replied eerily.

Despite her curiosity being piqued, Scorpia decided to take his word for it. This being Beast Island, it wasn't hard to imagine that whoever 'they' were, waking them up was not in their best interest. Suddenly, every footfall, every dislodged pebble sounded much louder than before.

After what felt like ages, Micah stopped in his tracks. He held out his staff, and Scorpia saw that a massive pit stretched out before them. The room itself was easily much larger than the previous one, with the pit only adding to the sense of emptiness this place brought. She wasn't sure how deep it was, but any pit that didn't have a visible bottom was automatically *too* deep. Still, Scorpia could feel the tingling growing stronger, so this was where they had to go.

“Please tell me we don’t have to jump,” she said with a gulp.

Micah held a finger to his lips, but shook his head. Proceeding slowly so as to make as little noise as possible, he rotated his staff, which began to glow. A circular sigil appeared before them, hovering just over the pit. He stepped onto it, revealing that it was a platform, large enough to carry them both. “Come on, it’s safe,” he whispered.

Somewhat reluctantly, but just as determined, Scorpia cautiously stepped onto the glowing platform. With a wave of his hand, Micah began their descent. The platform carried them deep down into the bowels of this cave, moving just a bit faster than she was comfortable with. But Micah showed no signs of worry, so she didn’t either.

The walls of the pit were the same as those in the earlier tunnels, with no crystals or reflected light to make them interesting. However, once they reached a certain depth, the walls…changed. Reddish-brown growths began appearing, more of them the further down they went. “Those are some weird-looking rocks,” Scorpia whispered. She glanced over at Micah, who was also looking at the ‘rocks’ with a quiet dread. “...Those aren’t rocks, are they?”

“Harpies,” he said quietly. The way he said the word, coupled with the way he looked at the beasts, showed that he had a history with them, and not a pretty one. “There have to be hundreds of them. There weren’t nearly this many last time I was here…”

Looking closer, Scorpia could tell that the ‘rocks’ had a scaly texture to them, and seemed to move in a way that couldn’t just be the flickering of the light. With a start, she realized that they were breathing. As they continued to descend, she did her best not to look at them.

After a few more minutes, a thought crossed her mind. “Hang on…if you coulda created a platform this entire time, why couldn’t you just have lifted us up that cliff in the first place?”

Micah waited a moment, considering his answer carefully. “You’re too heavy to go up,” he finally said.

“What!?” said Scorpia, still keeping her voice hushed. “What do you mean ‘I’m too heavy?’ I’m pretty sure I’ve lost more than a few pounds these last few weeks, and even if I hadn’t, aren’t you magic? What does weight matter to you?”

“Hush!” he replied. “In case you hadn’t noticed, I’ve been stuck on this island for years, which hasn’t exactly done wonders for my magical skill! So even if you weren’t a scorpionkin with all that armor, going up would be a lot tougher than going down!”

“Then how exactly do you plan on getting us out of here?” she asked.

“I’ll figure that out later!”

A sudden noise to the side made both of them stop in their tracks. One of the harpies had heard their bickering, and slowly unfolded its wings. It was horribly gaunt, clinging to the wall with massive talons while a hideous batlike face peered in their direction. But its beady eyes were glassed over, not focusing on them directly. Living underground, it seemed the creatures didn’t have the best sight.

It couldn’t see them, but it could see Micah’s light. Rather than see this as an intruder, however, it was irritated by the brightness, soon covering itself up again. The crisis narrowly averted, the two of them remained in silence for the duration of the trip.

After a few more agonizing moments, they reached solid ground. As they stepped onto the floor once again, Scorpia could feel that the tingling was stronger than ever. She pressed on, not even needing Micah’s guidance to find its source. Even in the near-total darkness of the chasm, she still knew exactly which way to go.

Before long, she saw the light at the end of the tunnel–literally. At first, she thought there was another sunlit pool ahead, but as she got closer, she found that it wasn’t sunlight, but a multicolored

glow. She reached its source, and found what she at first thought were glowing vines, shining in all kinds of different colors. She touched one, and despite looking to be made of plant matter, it revealed itself to be hard like stone.

"Pretty cool, right?" said Micah. He ran a hand along the magical vine. "As far as I can figure out, these are connected to the Runestones up above. What they are or why they're here, that I couldn't tell you. But I *do* know that the Runestones' powers flow through them.  So if you want to recharge, all you have to do is find yours."

As many colors as there were, she didn't see the dark red of the Black Garnet just yet. "Just a bit further," she said, feeling her way deeper into the tunnel. More vines threaded in and out of the stone, weaving around like the roots of a gigantic tree. She followed them, but they weren't leading her. Instead, it was the feeling inside of her that guided her way, like a sixth sense for magic. "It's here–woah…"

If Scorpia had a Horde credit for every large room she'd found today, she'd have three of them, one more than she would have preferred. This one, like the first, was much more pleasant than the second, with a veritable rainbow of glowing vines coming together in the center of the chamber. All combining into a huge pillar, they pierced through the floor, going even deeper than they already were. "See it here?" Micah asked.

Sure enough, one of the vines knit together with the others was the same color as the Fright Zone's very own Runestone. "Yeah. That's it right there." Scoria approached the pillar, reaching out a claw to touch it. She pressed the tip against the red crystal, and felt a familiar power flowing into her body. It was like taking a drink of water after being lost in the desert for days, without even knowing how thirsty she had been. She gasped at the alien, yet somehow very familiar, sensation. Either way, it was definitely welcome.

Scorpia's touch had caused the entire vine to begin glowing brighter than it already had been, bathing the entire cavern in an eerie red light. "Mm. Reminds me of someone," Micah said somberly.

"I know who you mean," said Scorpia, looking aside. "I still can't believe Shadow Weaver's the one who trained you. I mean, you're like night and day!"

He averted his gaze, but still smiled at the compliment. "Part of me likes to think that she's still the same woman deep down," he said quietly. "That somehow, Hordak is the one to blame for her becoming what she is today. But after seeing her working with Modulok…I'm not sure I can believe that anymore."

Although Scorpia hadn't had as many interactions with Shadow Weaver as Micah or Catra had, she still knew that the woman was bad news. Seeing how even now it brought Micah distress, she eagerly changed the subject. "So, how far down do you think all this goes? I mean, it's gotta be here for a reason, right?"

"Maybe all the Runestones are powered by Etheria's core," Micah suggested. "They've gotta get their power from somewhere, and that's just about as deep as you can get. Or it could be the other way around…"

Whatever reason this was here, Scorpia was glad for it. Finally feeling full, she removed her claw, and the glowing faded. "Alright, ready to go! So, have you figured a way out of here?" She hoped his answer didn't involve going back through that harpy nest. Those things freaked her out.

Unfortunately, Micah was silent for the next few moments. "Um…I could try lifting us separately," he said, sounding unsure. "Of course, I'd have no way of knowing where you were if I did that. Wait, I've got it! I'll give you a pebble, and you throw it down once you reach the top! Then I'll carry myself up there to meet you!"

But Scorpia wasn't listening. She was at first, but something behind Micah had drawn her attention. There had been a small bit of movement from the darkness, slowly revealing itself to be the horrific form of a harpy. The monstrous creature crept forward, focusing on Micah's voice. Scorpia was frozen in place, trying fruitlessly to get him to turn around by gesturing with her head, but he was too focused on his plan. The harpy's maw split open wide, readying itself to lunge at his throat.

"No!" Moments before the harpy could bite down, Scorpia launched her claw forward, grabbing hold of Micah and yanking him out of harm's way. She tossed him behind her, swinging her other claw at the beast as it leapt onto her. The harpy screeched up a storm as it tried to tear into her claw, until a jab from her stinger put it out of commission. It struggled against her neurotoxin for a moment before succumbing, falling to the floor. Its screeches still echoed all through the caverns.

Micah looked at its unconscious form, then up at the cave they had traveled through. "Get ready," he said, preparing his staff.

"For what?" asked Scorpia nervously, but she had a feeling she already knew.

More screeches answered the first, followed by the sound of fluttering wings. "That."

It started slowly at first. More of the monsters crawled out of the shadows, emerging from hidden tunnels all over the room. They grumbled and croaked as though communicating with each other, surrounding the pair before making their move. Scorpia held up her claws and tail, but knew she wouldn't be able to fend off this many attackers. "Still wanna go with your first plan?" she asked.

Despite the dire straits they were in, Micah flashed a confident smile. "Actually, I think I have a new one!" He held his staff up high, and…chucked a nearby rock at one of the harpies. Not only did it not hit its target, it angered the creature enough to fly at him, along with the rest of its flock. This was when Micah cast his

spell, illuminating his staff once again. Only this time, it was much brighter, creating a dome of light around the pair. The beasts were driven away, but still stayed close, waiting for the right moment. "Go, now, go!"

Following his advice, Scorpia ran through the tunnels back the way they came. "Your plan was to piss them off even more!?" she shouted in disbelief. All around them the harpies swarmed, occasionally swooping down, only to be driven back by the light.

"My plan was to keep them at bay until we could think of something better," he said, running alongside her. "Which I haven't exactly done yet, but we've got time!"

"No we don't!" Before long, they had ended up back at the bottom of the massive pit, with hundreds of the harpies divebombing them. Their sheer numbers meant that a few of them got through the light, slashing at the pair with their talons. Micah blasted them back with spells, and Scorpia tried to sting as many as she could, but they were barely making a difference. "We're gonna die down here!"

Micah held up a magical shield, pushing away several harpies in one go. "No we aren't! We just need to think of something!" One of them got a little too close for comfort, cutting into his back before he drove it off. "I hope you work well under pressure!"

"I don't! Quite the opposite, in fact!" Scorpia was operating purely on autopilot now, swatting away any harpy that got close, but her mind too clouded to think. She was operating entirely on animal instinct, fight or flight dictating her every move–

Wait a moment… *animal* instinct. That was it. Scorpia had her epiphany. There was a way out of this, and she had just absorbed enough power to make it happen. Focusing on the fear and anger she felt in this situation, she let the shadowy magic flow across her body, transforming her once more into a giant scorpion.

Her new bestial form let out a screech to rival the harpies', before she swung her tail through the encroaching swarm. A bunch of the creatures were knocked aside, crashing into the wall. More appeared to take their place, but no matter how many beset Scorpia, they couldn't cut through her impenetrable carapace.

Micah's confidence grew significantly now that they had a giant scorpion on their side. He held his glowing staff aloft, continuing to keep the harpies at bay. The only problem was, his spell could only last as long as he had stamina. The moment he grew too tired, it would be over for them. "Scorpia!" he called, hoping she was still cognizant in this form, and pointed to the top of the pit. "We need to get up there!"

Despite her inability to speak, there was a flicker of understanding in the titanic arachnid's eyes. Her stinger hooked onto his robe, hoisting him onto her back. With him secured, she made her way over to the wall, and began climbing towards the top.

Her tail swatted at the nearby harpies while Micah held on tight, both to his staff and to her back. "Not to rush you or anything, but I'm not sure how much longer I can keep this going!" The dome of light had begun to shrink, and with it, the harpies were growing bolder. Scorpia kept going, but she could only climb so fast.

One harpy came from directly above, its talons aimed at her eyes. She was able to chase it off, but the surprise attack caused her to stumble, nearly falling back down to the bottom. Before she could, Micah fired a pair of magical strands into the wall, pulling her back into place, though clearly not without a ton of effort.

"Just a little bit longer," he said, clearly worn out. "You can make it. I believe in you!" He couldn't even attack the harpies anymore, too focused on keeping the light lit. "You're almost there…"

Despite his assurance, Scorpia couldn't even see the top. At the rate they were going, they'd be lucky to make it there in under an hour–which they clearly didn't have. Her eyes darted all around in

search for an easier escape, but all she could see was the swarm of harpies flying all around them. From the light of Micah's staff, they created a bunch of flickering shadows on the wall, looking to overwhelm Scorpia's own.

As her eyes settled on her shadow, that tingling sensation returned. At that moment, the answer came to her. Looks like Shadow Weaver had taught her something, after all.

Hoping against hope that this would work, Scorpia felt herself melting into the shadows cast by the light spell. She vanished into the cave wall, thankfully taking a surprised Micah with her. With nothing to hold them back and no harpies able to harm them, Scorpia swam up the wall at great speed. The swarm grew agitated at her sudden disappearance, unable to see or hear her anymore.

Having become one with her shadow, Scorpia reached the top in no time. She burst out of the darkness like a breaching whale, landing on solid ground at the top of the pit. Micah was a bit shaken by the journey. "That was…incredible!" he shouted. "Scorpia, you beautiful giant bug, you saved us both!"

But there was no time to celebrate, as the harpies had found their targets once again. Scorpia wasted no time racing down the tunnel they had first come through, just barely able to fit. Micah kept his staff trained on their rear, preparing to blast any harpies that approached. Sure enough, the winged monsters rapidly caught up to the pair.

Micah fired spell after spell into their number. He was able to stun a few, but their numbers were too great. But then, just as they were about to catch up, he caught a familiar glimmer of light ahead of them. Scorpia burst out into the sparkling cavern, and with a tremendous leap, carried them up towards the ceiling. She wasn't able to lift them completely out of the cave, but her claws did tear through the rock, widening the hole Micah had made.

Even more sunlight spilled into the cavern. Repulsed by this sudden onset of brightness, the harpies hissed and shrieked, flailing in a panic. They wasted no time in returning back the way they came, leaving the pair alone. Micah brushed himself off, shakily getting into his feet, relieved to be alive.

"We did it!" he proclaimed, before turning in the direction of his partner. "No, *you* did it! The two of us would both be harpy food if you hadn't…Scorpia?" He approached the fallen rocks in search of his friend. "Scorpia, are you–"

One of the boulders was pushed aside, revealing a very dusty but very alive Scorpia. "Whew! That, uh, that wasn't exactly fun. Hey, the next time we venture into an ominous and foreboding cave, you think you could give me a little heads-up if it's infested with bloodthirsty monsters?"

Micah smiled in relief. "You have my word! But, seeing as how we have everything we need to take Black's base, what do you say we get off this island?"

"Sounds good to me!" Scorpia pounded her claws together. "Let's go swat that Mosquitor!" The two of them climbed out of the hole, ready to take the fight to their enemies.

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"Do you know what I appreciate the most about you, Shadow Weaver? Your patience. I don't think I've ever had a partner who didn't, at some point in time, try and find out for themselves what I was after. But not you. No, you're content to simply follow my lead, only asking what needs to be known. I must say, I'll almost be disappointed when we go our separate ways."

Shadow Weaver, of course, didn't exactly feel the same degree of appreciation towards Modulok. "It helps that I don't care much about what you're after," she said. "As long as I get what you promised me, I'll be content."

He responded with a grin–though given that his mouth was a constant mass of teeth, it was hard to tell. “All the better for both of us! That said…I do think you are owed something of an explanation. I *do* hate leaving such a loyal partner in the dark.”

Modulok led her into a side room in the First Ones station he was using as a base. Some of his research was strewn around, a bit messier than was usual for him. Shadow Weaver was immediately drawn to an image on an old page: a shadowy mass covered in piercing eyes and grasping hands. The Unnamed One.

“This ancient being has given you its power, and yet you have no understanding of what it is,” he said, creeping around behind her. “You’ve only tapped the surface of what it can offer you.”

“I already have as much power as I could want,” she replied, which wasn’t entirely untrue. “You, on the other hand, are the sort of person who always wants more. Is that what you’re seeking? A way to conquer the universe?”

He only chuckled. “Don’t mistake me for a substitute Horde Prime. My goals are only to restore what was once rightfully ours. To shine the light of Eternia once more on the cosmos. But to do that…” He held up a pouch to Shadow Weaver. “...we must commune with the darkness.”

She took it. Inside was the same black dust that Modulok was so often playing with. She noticed he frequently used it in his experiments and creations. “And what exactly should I do with this?” she asked.

“Why, awaken it, of course.” He said this like it was the most obvious thing in the world. “We cannot commune with the darkness if it cannot listen.”

Now that he mentioned it, she could feel a familiar power flowing through this dust. Familiar, because it was *her* power. Shadows danced around her wrist as she infused the dust with a small bit of her magic. Almost instantly, it began to move and flow within

the pouch, like it was filled with small creatures. It was an entrancing sight, and she would have watched it much longer if he hadn't snatched it away and closed it up tightly. "I thought you said you trusted me."

"I do trust you," he replied. "It's *him* I don't trust." Modulok held the bag like it contained a live bomb. "If Horde Prime and White Diamond have shown us anything, it is that Great Computers are incredibly unstable, and highly likely to go berserk. The Unnamed One is no exception."

Shadow Weaver raised an eyebrow. "'Great Computer?' You mean to tell me that this source of unholy magic is just a machine?" She glanced down at the old picture in disbelief that a machine was the source of her powers.

"Yes, yes, but this machine is not 'just' anything," he said. "The Unnamed One is a brilliant merger of mechanics and magic–the first of its kind, in fact. Like certain others of its kind, the Unnamed One blurs the line between computer and god." He held up the pouch. "And now, we have the power of a god at our fingertips."

She eyed the pouch suspiciously. "And what exactly do you intend to do with this power?" she asked.

"Simple." Modulok made his way out of the room, back into the main chamber. "I'm going to reawaken the Heart of Etheria, and fulfill its intended purpose. I'm going to cleanse this universe, once and for all."

# Hope for the Best

Chapter Summary

Adora and Glimmer both move forward following their argument.

Chapter Seventeen: Hope for the Best

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After holding the prisoners for so long, Netossa was glad to finally be able to take a break. She released her net, falling to the ground in exhaustion–Spinnerella was quick to help her up. "Don't worry about me, I coulda held it up way longer if I had to."

"I'm sure you could have," she replied, offering her a kiss on the cheek. "But right now, let's let them handle things."

The four spies sent by the New Horde were now trapped behind separate magical barriers, courtesy of Castaspella. Her task fulfilled, her concentration faded as well. "There, that should hold them," she said. Perhaps due to the circumstances, she was much more somber than anyone who knew her would come to expect. "So, what exactly are you planning to do now?"

Glimmer regarded the four prisoners with fire in her eyes, though remained calm. "We still don't know why Catra came back here. Until we can find her, getting someone to answer that question for us should be our top priority." She walked up to Azurite's container, the two Gems having once again fused. "Luckily, we have four new friends who should be *more* than willing to help us out."

Ever the dignified presence, Azurite responded by sticking her tongue out at the queen. "And what are you gonna do about it, huh? Ask us politely? Ha!" She turned away. "Get lost, glitter-pants!"

“I didn’t expect this to be easy,” Glimmer muttered. “Maybe one of your friends will be more willing to let us know?” She began pacing around the room, eyeing each of them as she passed. Despite her efforts, none of them were intimidated by her.

“Perhaps we could try something else?” suggested Castaspella. “Something tells me none of them are going to give up that information willingly…”

“Exactly my point,” Glimmer answered darkly. She held up her fist, which began to glow with the power of the Moonstone. “How about we turn this into a game? First one to fess up *doesn’t* get a beatdown?” She pounded her fist into her palm to demonstrate, creating a surge of energy.

Castaspella stepped forward to try and calm her down. “Actually, I was thinking something more along the lines of bribery,” she said, “or at the very least, a truth spell. I’d rather *not* descend to the Horde’s level just to get answers.”

“Neither would I,” Glimmer replied, “but we don’t have a choice. Every second Catra’s allowed to run free is another second she has to plot! We can’t just leave her out there knowing she has it out for Brightmoon. We have to take action.”

“But is this really the best action to take?” asked Castaspella quietly.

Glimmer looked down at her still-glowing hand. “ *I* definitely can’t think of any better options,” she mumbled. “Now, who wants to talk first!? Do we have any takers?” The four of them stayed silent in contempt, still not taking her seriously. “Okay, fine! Why don’t we start with you?”

She then teleported inside of Carnelian’s cage, throwing her against the wall with a blast of her powers. “Glimmer, wait!” Castaspella urged, hurrying over to the magical barrier.

“You were out there with her; what’s she planning?” the queen demanded, giving her more blasts of energy. Despite Carnelian’s

size and strength, she couldn't do much against an enemy that could warp away from her grasp. "Tell me!"

Her blasts were doing little more than annoying the Gem. "Hold still, ya little…thingy!" she grumbled, grasping at the air, just barely missing her each time. "Stop it! That's cheating!" Castaspella soon dispelled the barrier, to both of their surprise.

"Glimmer, there's better ways to go about this," she said in her best 'mom voice.' Realizing she was free, Carnelian tried to grab the sorceress, only for her to put the barrier back up, trapping her again. "I know you're eager to find this girl and keep Etheria safe, but–"

"Aren't you even a little bit angry?" Glimmer asked, looking up at her. "About what Catra did? All the pain she caused Etheria? You have to want revenge on her at least a little bit!"

Castaspella thought about the best way to approach this situation. "I…I *am* , Glimmer, and I *do* want her to be stopped. But it's the same as before: I don't want to stoop to their level to defeat them. If we become the same as the Horde–"

"We *won't* ," she said firmly. "The difference between us is that the Horde attacks innocent people and takes everyone's land. We fight back against them. We protect people. We're doing this for a good reason, so why should our methods matter?"

"Yeah, you tell her!" shouted Azurite. Both women shot her a glare. "Embrace the hate! Become like us!"

Crita shushed her. "Don't give her any ideas!" she hissed.

Before Glimmer could give them a piece of her mind, Castaspella pulled her back. "No, keep listening. I know why you're doing this." She knelt down to be at her niece's level, gently lifting her head up by her chin. "I miss Angella too. She was a wonderful woman, like a sister to me. We may not have always seen eye to eye, but Micah loved her, and that was good enough for me. But I've seen what happens when someone goes to great lengths to

defeat their enemies: this thirst to avenge her will only corrupt you, pull you closer to darkness."

Although Glimmer's countenance softened for a moment, she was still set on her mission. "Don't tell me I need to forget her," she muttered. "Because I can't. I *won't* . I refuse to forget her."

"And you shouldn't," Castaspella continued. "You should always keep your mother's memory alive. But would she really want this?"

"You know what?" interrupted Karikon. "I think she would! Ol' Angella was always a thorn in the Old Horde's side! In fact, I think she'd be proud of you for continuing her legacy, kiddo!"

Glimmer's fists clenched as she struggled to ignore him. "She wanted us to be rid of the Horde as much as anyone. Why would she have a problem with this?"

"Because it wouldn't be what she wanted for *you* . I'm sure Angella would have wanted you to be a kind and just queen, who treats her enemies with as much respect as her allies. She wouldn't want you to turn into a tyrant."

Being called a tyrant brought back memories of her argument with Adora, still fresh in her mind. "And who says I'm turning into a tyrant!?" she asked, pulling away. "We're at war, in case you forgot! What, am I supposed to invite Catra over for tea, and that'll solve everything!? These kinds of people don't respond to anything except violence!"

"That's true!" shouted Karikon. "Plus, Catra hates tea, so I don't know how well she'd respond to that."

Her patience with him had finally worn out. She warped into the makeshift cell with him, beginning with a blinding flash of light. He stumbled back, falling against the barrier. Glimmer pressed her hand against his side, her palm growing hotter as it glowed with magic.

“You wanna stop being funny and help me for a change?” she hissed, pressing her hand into where he had been wounded by He-Man. Karikon winced, but said nothing. “Where did you last see Catra? Where was she headed? Tell me!”

Once again, Castaspella tried to rein in the enraged queen. “Glimmer, that’s enough! Stop this right now!” Glimmer only shot her a glare before turning her focus back to the prisoner.

Karikon grit his teeth and laughed at her. “It’s cute how you think you’re actually intimidating,” he said. “You think a few sparkles are enough to scare me? You’ve been cooped up in your castle for too long! You don’t know what *real* war is!”

With fury in her eyes, Glimmer sent a surge of energy coursing through Karikon’s body. He howled and clutched at his wound, but she proved surprisingly strong, and was unable to be moved. “Glimmer! Stop this, please!” But with her tunnel vision, she could no longer hear Castaspella’s voice.

Crita pounded on her barrier, trying not to look too concerned. “He’s right, you know. He’s endured far worse than this! You’re only scratching the surface!”

“Am I?” she asked, shooting her a glare. “Then maybe I’d better dig deeper!” Glimmer then drove a glowing fist into Karikon’s face, releasing a shockwave that reverberated through the room. Even the other prisoners could feel it. Rather than fight back, Karikon found himself stunned by the blow. This left him unable to resist as she struck him again and again.

“Glimmer!” Castaspella finally dropped the barrier, pulling Glimmer off of the already-wounded soldier. Not wanting to give up, she teleported out of her grip, continuing to pummel Karikon. “You can’t do this! This isn’t you!”

“Shut up!” Before Glimmer knew what was happening, she had whirled around and fired a blast of energy at her aunt. Castaspella’s reflexes were quick enough that she was able to

create a magical shield to block it, but she was still thrown back. The shock was enough to stun her, leaving Glimmer free to return to Karikon.

She placed her foot on the scorpion's wound, pressing down hard. He groaned, futilely grasping at her leg. Crita continued to bang on the barrier. "Stop it! Leave him alone!"

Once again, Glimmer's tunnel vision made her unwilling to listen. "Unless you want to keep your ribcage intact, *tell me where Catra's hiding* !" Her entire body glowed with energy from the Moonstone, all but blinding her victim.

Karikon coughed, spitting out a bit of blood. "Do your worst, *princess* ," he groaned, looking up at her with a smirk.

With a roar of rage, Glimmer thrust out both of her hands, preparing to unleash all of her energy into a single blast. The effects this would have had on Karikon likely would have been devastating, had she not been halted at the last moment by a shout.

"She wants the Heart of Etheria!" Before Crita even knew what was happening, the words had left her lips. Her teammates looked over at her, shocked. So did Glimmer. "She's…we're looking for an artifact called the Heart of Etheria. Nobody knows what it is, or even what it does, but it's supposedly extremely powerful. She thinks it could finalize the New Horde's conquest of the universe."

Glimmer was a bit stunned, at first, but soon swelled with pride knowing she had finally got her answer. "See? Was that so hard?" she asked a battered and beaten Karikon. "I *told* you I could–" Her expression suddenly darkened when she looked over at Castaspella.

Her aunt stared at her with a mix of pity, disappointment, and, if she wasn't mistaken, fear. The realization of what she had done finally hit her, and she fell to her knees. Upon seeing her like this,

all of Castaspella's doubts vanished, and she hurried over to comfort her niece.

"Why did I attack you?" Glimmer said quietly, almost unaware that Castaspella had wrapped her arms around her. "I-I didn't mean to. I just wanted… What's happening to me?"

"So much is happening to you," Castaspella replied. "Everyone you've lost, and now you're faced with all the responsibilities of being a queen, coupled with the threat of war…it's no wonder, with all the stress you're under! But please, Glimmer–Angella wouldn't want her little princess to turn out like this. She also wouldn't want you to have to face this alone. Just because you're the queen doesn't mean you have to shoulder all of these responsibilities by yourself.

"Yes I do," Glimmer said, barely audible. "I owe it to her. I have…I have to do this on my own."

Castaspella got to her feet, helping Glimmer to hers. "The only thing you owe Angella is being a good daughter, and as far as I'm concerned, you've got that covered already. Come on–I think you need some rest." She quietly put Karikon's barrier back up, wincing sympathetically as he pulled himself back up. The two of them left the room, heading for Glimmer's bedroom.

Once the two of them had left, Azurite immediately turned on Crita. "Nice job, you traitor! Way to tell them everything they wanted to know! If Catra asks us why the Princess Alliance is on to her plans, I'll tell her it's all your fault…"

"What was I supposed to do? Just let her kill Karikon?" she protested.

The injured Scorpion man almost looked offended. "Hey, I'm a tough guy, I can handle a few sparkles!" He looked down at his battered form, realizing that Glimmer had messed him up pretty badly. "Still, though…thanks. I, uh, appreciate the sentiment."

Azurite rolled her eyes. "Oh, now don't *you* start!"

“You’re welcome,” Crita said, a bit more aggressively than she meant to. “Besides, we aren’t finished here yet. There’s still time for us to escape.”

“...How?” asked Carnelian.

Karikon chuckled. “Oh, don’t you worry. I put in a call to some friends of ours!”

As she headed up the spiral staircase, Glimmer pondered on what kind of queen she was becoming. Had Adora been right all along? Was Hordak really turning her into another version of him? No, of course not, she was in full control, she was still the queen after all. But the thought that she alone was responsible almost made her feel worse.

“Aunt Casta?” In that moment, all of Glimmer’s grudges and duties were forgotten. She was simply a scared child who lost her mother, something she hadn’t allowed herself to be. “I know you’re probably busy in Mystacor, but…do you think you could maybe stay in Brightmoon for a couple days? I don’t…I don’t think I can trust myself…”

“Of course,” Castaspella assured her. “You shouldn’t have to do this alone.”

“Thank you,” Glimmer said softly. “Because I need all the help I can get.”

Castaspella assumed she meant help with her queenly duties, or help keeping her on the right track. But now Glimmer knew what Catra was after, and she needed help if she wanted to take her down for good.

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Connie accompanied Steven through the castle, holding onto the Sword of Power for him. “Are you sure you want to do this?” she asked. “I know we can find another solution if we try.”

Steven's hand had been placed on his stomach. For all his life, his gemstone had a comforting warmth to it, especially after he began discovering his powers. But for some time now, it had been absent. Part of him wondered if turning into He-Man was a desperate attempt to get it back. "Thanks, but I'm sure. I don't want to risk it."

"If you're sure." Connie held the sword close to her, while also trying to keep it away from him. A part of her still blamed Jasper for this, but Steven was convinced it was all him. And besides, giving up this power was his choice. All she could do was support him, and make sure the sword stayed someplace safe.

On their way to the armory, the pair ran into Adora, who seemed lost in thought until seeing them snapped her into the present. "Oh! Uh, hey. Sorry about all of that back there, I guess I just got a little heated…"

"No worries," Steven assured her. "Just a…little argument." They all knew Adora's and Glimmers disagreement was much more than 'little,' but decided to leave it alone for now. "How are you holding up?"

At first, it looked like she didn't know how to answer. "...Fine, fine," she said eventually, though it was clear she didn't quite mean it. "Hey, have either of you seen Lars anywhere? He wasn't at the meeting."

"I think he's outside with that new ship," Connie said, looking out towards the yard. "Why?"

Without stopping to explain, Adora headed in that direction. "I have some stuff I need to ask him about. Sorry again, see you later!" Staring after her with an odd look, Connie and Steven decided to carry on.

But something was still nagging at Connie's mind. "Adora?" she called after her. Adora stopping, turning around. "Have you ever had…problems with She-Ra? Like, where you lost control?"

Adora noticed the Sword of Power in Connie's hands, as well as Steven's nervous demeanor, and drew the connection. "Oh…um, sorta. Certain First Ones artifacts could corrupt the sword, and make me go berserk when I was transformed. I don't know if this is the same thing, but it might be related."

Steven wondered if Jasper counted as a First Ones artifact, but doubted it. "Thanks anyway," he said. "I'll let you know if I have any more problems, but at this point, I probably won't."

"Um…I'm glad I could sort of help," said Adora. "Good luck with dealing with that." Connie and Steven left to store the sword, while Adora continued out to the castle grounds. The ship that used to belong to Mara sat in the middle of the grassy field, surrounded by Lars and his crew. She took a deep breath, hoping he would be willing to listen, and approached.

The Off-Colors were deep in conversation. "I can't believe Glimmer wanted us to *kill* someone!" moaned Rhodonite. "Even someone as bad as Catra!"

"Technically, she just wanted us to take her to Catra so *she* could kill her," Lars clarified. "Which isn't much better, now that I think about it. But hey, if it'd stop the New Horde…"

Both Rutile twins looked at him incredulously. "Lars, are you saying you think she should kill Catra?" asked left. "You always seemed like more of a pacifist," right added.

Lars floundered for a moment. "I'm not saying I think she *should* , it's just that, maybe, it's the quickest way to stop the war. It's obviously not the *best* solution, and I'm against it, but…"

"Nobody's killing Catra." They all turned towards Adora, who had declared this with certainty. "Not while I'm still here. Yes, she's evil, and yes, she's trying to take over the universe and almost killed us all…but she was my friend. That has to count for something, right?"

"I foresee Adora being conflicted about her loyalties," said Padparadscha. "She will be forced to choose between Catra and Glimmer, which will make her sad."

Adora stammered and tried to deny this. "I-I'm not choosing sides! I just don't want anyone to get hurt! Look, we can deal with that later, right now, I need to ask you all a favor. Is that alright?"

"Whaaat dooo yoooou neeeeed?" asked Fluorite.

"I…" Adora hesitated. "Okay, so Glimmer asked you to take her to Catra, right? But she won't need you to anymore because Catra's already here. So, since you're not busy, do you think I could borrow your services in a bit? Just a quick flight, honestly."

The Off-Colors looked at each other in silent deliberation. "Yeah, I think that's fine," Lars said. "Where do you want to go?"

She took a deep breath. "I recently found out where I came from before I was brought to Etheria. The coordinates should already be on Mara's ship. I wasn't sure if I wanted to go at first, but with everything that's going on…I think I'm ready."

"Ooh…learning about your origins, that's very important!" said Padparadscha. "But…why do you want to keep it a secret?"

"How did…nevermind. She's right–could you all not mention this to Glimmer? I don't think she'd approve."

"Your secret's safe with us!" Rhodonite assured her.

Adora smiled in relief. "Thank you. I'll let you know when I'm ready to leave." She turned to head back into the castle. "But right now, I've got to make sure everything works out with Catra…"

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"Alright, c'mon, let's make this quick," mumbled Tung Lashor, accompanying Callix and Octavia through the desert. "I hate

having to play babysitter for a couple o' traitors longer than I have to…"

"Nobody's saying you have to," Octavia grumbled, also not happy about their arrangement.

"Actually, Hordak did," Tung shot back. "So drink fast."

He led the two down to a river near the settlement. Octavia submerged herself in the water as the others waited patiently for her to remoisturize. Tung made sure to keep a close eye on them in case they tried anything funny. Callix seemed like he certainly wanted to, but wasn't sure it was worth the risk.

While Octavia was hydrating, she noticed something moving in the river next to her. "Huh?" The shape darted towards the shore, careful not to be seen. She considered alerting Tung Lashor…but decided to see where this was going instead.

"If you hate him so much, why are you working for him?" asked Callix. "You seem like the sort of man who prefers to call his own shots."

"Let's just say that's how we do things in the Crimson Waste," Tung replied. "I could say the same about you and Catra. Why follow her?"

The rock-man averted his gaze. "Things are different now," he muttered. He wasn't exactly glad at being left behind while her old boss went off with her new friends. He wondered what he would say to Catra if she was here now…

"What are you doing in there!?" asked Tung angrily, stomping over to the bank. "You'd better not be trying to escape, otherwise–" A tentacle shot out of the water, wrapping around his neck. With a shout, he was suddenly pulled under.

Callix was in no hurry to save him, but was still a little annoyed. "Octavia, please don't make this harder for us," he mumbled, approaching the spot where their chaperone had been dragged

into the water. “How will the princesses react if they hear we tried to stage an escape?”

“That wasn’t me.” To his surprise, Octavia pulled herself out of the river several feet away from where Tung Lashor disappeared. “There’s somebody else here.”

“Who?”

“Us.” Callix turned around, and was shocked to see Catra standing behind him. “You didn’t think we’d leave without saying goodbye, did you?”

Unsure of how to react, Callix only stammered out a basic question: “W-why are you here?” Given the look on Octavia’s face, she was wondering the same thing.

Catra smirked, and began walking around the pair. “Simple. I made a promise to the New Horde that we would destroy the Princess Alliance once and for all, and I’m here to make good on that. That is what you want, isn’t it? To get revenge on the princesses?”

Before Callix could air his grievances with his former leader, Tung Lashor suddenly shot out of the water. He crashed down in the sand, unconscious. Sqalish emerged from the river behind the pair, flexing his tentacles. “I wouldn’t let this opportunity slip by,” he said.

Octavia spoke up before Callix had the chance to. “We’re in!”

# Expect the Worst

Chapter Summary

Uninvited guests arrive in Brightmoon.

Chapter Eighteen: Expect the Worst

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By order of the queen, the Princess Alliance had gathered in the throne room. Most of them had heard something about Glimmer's conversation with Castaspella, but most of it was just hearsay. Nevertheless, Glimmer was eager to stop any rumors before they could spread, and so had doubled down on her queenly mask. "I have good news: we finally have an idea of what Catra is after." She made sure not to show any emotion, either in her voice or her posture as she sat on her throne, completely still.

While everyone noticed that she was acting strange, none of them wanted to comment on it. "That's great news!" said Bow, though his enthusiasm sounded at least partially forced. "Tell us, how can we use this to *capture* her, and nothing else?"

"Let us not get ahead of ourselves." Hordak stood on one side of Glimmer's throne, and Castaspella on the other. "All we know for certain is what she is seeking: the Heart of Etheria."

There was some murmuring among the princesses, mostly of confusion. "The Heart of Etheria?" said Bow. "But isn't that supposed to be a myth?"

"I always believed so as well, but Entrapta was convinced it was real," Hordak continued. "She came to the conclusion that it was no mere artifact, but the literal heart at the planet's center. Furthermore, she felt that it was too dangerous to investigate fully. Knowing Entrapta, I'm sure you can fathom just what that implies."

"So, Entrapta must have told Catra everything she knows about it," said Frosta. "She…she didn't find out how to use it, did she? Because if Catra knew…"

"If Catra knew, she would have used it already," Glimmer said. "And seeing as she still has her henchmen searching for it, we can reason she doesn't know where it is. The only logical thing to do is to find it first, and lead her into a trap."

"Okay, so…how do we do that?" asked Mermista. "If Entrapta, one of the smartest people on the planet, couldn't find it, how are we supposed to?"

"Simple: we just have to dig!" said Perfuma. "The Heart of Etheria is at the planet's core, right? So if we keep heading down, we'll reach it eventually!"

Glimmer held up a hand. "I have a much simpler idea. I've asked Demantoid to run a scan of the planet, searching for any large hollow pockets. If we can find one large enough leading to the core, that's our access point. We'll claim it before Catra does, and lead her into a trap. If it works, we'll have captured her, and control the most powerful weapon in the universe. Win-win."

Bow didn't like where this was going. "Uh, did you just call the Heart of Etheria a 'weapon?' I thought that Entrapta calling it the most dangerous thing she's ever heard of would mean we shouldn't mess with it. Especially not as a weapon!"

"Bow, relax," Glimmer said. "Sometimes, the best way a weapon can be used is by not using it at all." Hordak nodded in approval. "Once the rest of the New Horde learns we control the Heart, they'll be forced to stand down."

"So, you'll be holding a gun to the rest of the universe?" Adora, who had been silently listening at the back of the room, stepped forward. "Keeping everyone in line through force isn't something that the good guys do."

Glimmer's hands clenched into the throne's armrests. "Maybe I'm *not* a good guy," she hissed. "Maybe I just want to keep my people and my planet safe! And if that means taking control of some sort of ancient First Ones weapon…" She calmed down. "Nevermind. Infighting is the last thing we need right now."

The slight glare directed at Adora when she said this made it clear this was more of a warning than a suggestion. "Well, you're right about one thing: I'm not gonna fight with you. But I don't think I want to fight *for* you, either. Not the way things are going. I mean, I can't be the only one who sees this, right?" She gestured around the room at all the other princesses. "Ever since she became the queen, Glimmer's been acting more and more tyrannical! I already said I don't want to see the Princess Alliance turning into the next Horde, but what about *you* ? Do any of you want that? Is that really where we are right now?"

Her words seemed to touch the others' hearts, as everyone looked away uncomfortably. "Adora…I just want this war to be over," said Frosta. "First the Horde, then Skeletor, Horde Prime, the New Horde…this has all been happening since before I was born. I want peace for Etheria, just like you. But if the only way we can get that is…this way…"

Bow walked up to Adora. "I know you're not comfortable with this," he said. "Neither am I. But we don't have any other options right now. Like I said, Glimmer's in a bad place now, but if we stick with her, we can help her."

"The problem is she doesn't *want* our help," said Adora. "She's convinced that killing Catra is the only way to solve her issues, but even *if* that was okay, it wouldn't. The only way she's gonna get that is if we stop supporting her decisions like this."

"Adora, Glimmer's your friend," he said.

She cut him off. "Well, she sure isn't acting like it." She walked past him, glaring at Glimmer. "If you want to take control of this Heart of Etheria thing, and become no better than Hordak, fine.

But I won't be a part of this. Come and see me when you've come to your senses." She stormed out of the room, leaving the rest of the princesses in awkward silence.

"Wait, Adora!" Bow tried to go after her, but was stopped by Glimmer.

"Let her go. She doesn't understand that this is for the greater good. I'm sure she'll come around eventually." She glanced out the door where Adora had gone, a silent *At least, I hope she will* going through her head.

Castaspella inched closer to her niece. "Oh, I'm certain she will. The two of you are very close friends, after all." Glimmer glanced up at her smiling face, unable to tell if there was a hind of blame hidden behind it. She might have asked, had Hordak not continued their earlier conversation.

"Once Demantoid uncovers its location, we will move to secure the Heart. Until then, we must keep a vigilant eye out for Catra's forces. She is no doubt still searching, and we cannot allow her to find the Heart before us."

The princesses stood around, waiting for Glimmer's orders. "Well? You heard him–get to watching!" The five of them shuffled out of the room, somewhat unsatisfied.

"How exactly can we look for Catra if we don't know where she is?" Spinnerella quietly asked her wife.

Netossa chanced a quick glance back at Glimmer before shrugging. "I guess she wants us to do the heavy lifting for her now, too."

Once the others had gone, and Bow was the last one left, he too looked back. "Glimmer…" he said, a hint of pleading in his voice.

"I know, I know!" she snapped. "I'll talk to her…I just need to talk to Demantoid first. But I'll go and see her after."

"You promise?"

Glimmer huffed. "Yes, I promise, okay? Just…I want to be alone now. Is that fine?"

"You got it," Bow said with a small smile. He left the room as well, leaving Glimmer with her two advisors. For a moment, there was a look of sadness in her eyes as she watched him leave, but it quickly faded. "Um…when I said alone, I meant *alone* alone."

"Hmm? Oh! Of course!" said Castaspella once she realized what she meant. "We'll give you some time to think. Come along, Hordak." She paused, realizing just who she was ordering around, before continuing. Hordak wordlessly followed.

Once she was well and truly alone, Glimmer let her emotions show, slumping down in her seat and letting out a big sigh. Bow was right: she was pushing Adora away. She was pushing everyone away. But as much as she hated it, it was necessary to stop the New Horde. She produced her Gem communicator, and sent a message to Hessonite.

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It was late evening as Adora leaned against the bannister, looking out over Brightmoon. "Maybe *I'm* the one overreacting," she said to herself. "Maybe I'm wrong, and this is the only way to stop the New Horde. Emerald didn't seem like the type to give up easily…" She placed her sword in front of her, looking down at her morose expression. She-Ra was supposed to be the savior of all of Etheria, but right now, she felt like she wasn't saving anyone, on either side.

She hated everything Catra had done, everything she had become, but she couldn't bring herself to hate her. Despite everything she had done, she couldn't just forget how they had grown up together. But despite her fondness for her old friend, Glimmer's insistence left her with a tiny flicker of doubt. What if Catra would really never stop, and was willing to go to any low in

order to get what she wanted? She had already destroyed Etheria once, so it wasn't impossible…

Her train of thought was interrupted when she saw movement on the pathway below. She initially brushed it off as a guard doing their nightly rounds, but something made her look closer. It was a guard alright, but something about their movements was…off. Their armor didn't seem to fit right, and their gait was uneven. She was pretty sure she would have remembered if she saw someone walking like that during the day.

"Uh, hey! You there!" she called, hurrying down the stairs towards the odd guard. They didn't react, not even to quicken their pace. Instead, they just continued shuffling along, heading towards an unknown destination. "Are you ignoring me? Come back!" Adora ran over to the figure, grabbing hold of their shoulder to get their attention. But the moment her hand made contact, she was battered away by something long, thin, and very strong that shot out from under the robe.

Adora quickly got to her feet, drawing her sword. "Well, that didn't last long. I'm honestly surprised I made it this far," said the 'soldier.' The robe and armor came off, revealing a green mer-man who bared his fangs at her, multiple tentacles thrashing. "The jig is up, gang! Time for a raid!"

All of a sudden, over a dozen Horde members of all different species came out of the woodwork, climbing up over the castle walls, emerging from bushes and behind rocks, a few even flying into the castle. Many of them surrounded Adora, while many more headed deeper into Brightmoon. Before they had time to react: "For the Honor of Grayskull!"

A few of the raiders were blinded by the flash her transformation caused, leaving them open to a smack from her sword. She-Ra wasn't as interested in dealing with the small fries, though, figuring that the mer-man was their leader. She charged at him, but he proved far slipperier than he appeared, dodging one of her sword strikes. "Catra was right, you *are* clumsier than you look!"

“And your trash-talking needs work!” Adora swung again, this time connecting, but Sqalish’s skin hardened into armor. The blow was still quite powerful, enough to throw him against the wall. Before he could move away, she had him pinned. “You were saying? Now, did Catra send you here?”

He chuckled in response. “Technically, yes, but I don’t think ‘sent’ is the right word.”

“And what is that supposed to mean?” she asked.

“Hey Adora.”

Of course. As if an ill-timed invasion wasn’t bad enough. Adora slowly turned her head to see her old friend-turned-foe strolling out of the shadows, looking quite pleased with herself. “You…” she said quietly, with just as much surprise as anger.

“Me indeed,” Catra purred. “You don’t look too happy to see me, Adora. Here I thought you’d be overjoyed.” She slinked further down the walkway, perching atop the stone guardrail. “You’re not still mad about that debacle with almost destroying the planet, are you?”

Adora growled, tossing Sqalish aside to face her. “You shouldn’t be here.”

Catra laughed her familiar laugh. “Adora, you should really know by now that I go where I want, not where I’m wanted. You used to like that about me.”

“That’s not what I meant.” Adora’s tone softened ever so slightly. “If Glimmer finds out you’re here…”

Catra laughed again, harder this time. “Aww, it’s sweet that you care about me like that! But I’m not scared of that twinkly little brat. If she wants to kill me, she’s welcome to try her best. After all, if I can beat you as She-Ra, what chance does she have?”

Despite her current feud with the girl, there was a brief pang of anger in Adora at hearing her friend being bad-mouthed. But she ignored it in favor of trying to reason with Catra. "I don't know how you know about that, but since you do, why come here? This can't just be about showing up Glimmer, right?"

"What, like I'm gonna tell you our plan outright?" Catra scoffed. "As far as you're concerned, we're just here to topple the Princess Alliance. Shouldn't be too hard, considering how easily we got in!" She hopped off her perch, readying her claws as she nodded to Sqalish. "Go get the others–I'll handle her."

Sqalish nodded, using his tentacles to carry himself further into the castle. Adora tried to give chase, but was forced to block as Catra lunged. Her claws screeched across the metal, Adora pushing her back before they could reach her skin. She ducked underneath another swing from the Sword of Power, which collided with the wall.

Noise and commotion had now spread throughout the castle. As bad as things were, at least Brightmoon hadn't been caught by complete surprise. They were mounting a defense, one that would hopefully be enough. Adora wasn't worried, though–she had faith in the others.

"You know, at some point, you have to ask yourself why you're still doing this," Adora said. "Shadow Weaver disappeared, Hordak gave up, who are you trying to impress?"

With a smirk, Catra kicked Adora's legs out from under her. "Myself," she said, stomping on her wrist before she could raise her sword. "I'm not some little girl desperately looking for someone's approval, despite what you think of me. This isn't so I can finally be loved, or so we can be friends again, all of this is so I can finally have what I never had in the Horde: control over my own life! Now, I actually have a say in what happens to me!"

Adora could have broken out of Catra's hold that very second. But instead, she looked up at her with sympathy, and almost pity. "Do

you really need to hurt people to have that?" she asked softly. "You're more than what the Horde taught you, Catra. We both are. You can leave that life behind, like I did."

For the briefest of moments, less than a second, there was a flicker of sorrow in Catra's eyes. It was immediately replaced by rage, for daring to assume the two of them were anything alike. With a howl, Catra raised her claws and drove them down towards Adora…but was thrown to the side before she could. A glowing white beam of energy had blasted her to the side, its source marching out into the open.

"You made a mistake bringing the fight here," Glimmer said, her fists glowing with heat. "Your *last* mistake."

Adora got to her feet, standing between her and Catra. "Glimmer…" she said, almost a warning. "You don't want to do this."

"You don't know what I want!" Glimmer yelled. "Your mom wasn't killed because of what she did!"

"I know!" Adora yelled back, before calming herself. "I know. But doing what you're about to do isn't going to fix anything. Please, can we talk about this before any of us does something we regret?" Catra suddenly leapt onto her back, pulling her down to the ground. Her sword fell out of her hand, and was then kicked away.

"Oh, I don't think that'll be a problem." Catra squared up against Glimmer, not afraid of her in the least. Her claws were bared, and she was ready to pounce.

Glimmer's eyes narrowed. "Then I guess that's one thing we have in common."

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A state of chaos was unfolding around Steven. Horde soldiers filled the halls, wielding all sorts of makeshift weapons.

Somewhere to his left, Garnet and Bismuth held Callix at bay. He ran past Octavia lashing her tentacles at Perfuma. Mermista and Lapis had teamed up to push back the intruders using the castle's abundant water. Everyone was fighting, except for him.

Sure, He-Man would probably make things worse, but this feeling of helplessness was almost as bad as guilt. He ran past the fighting, wishing there was more he could do. That was when he saw it: Sqalish, not that Steven knew him, climbing up the castle walls towards where the prisoners were being held. With all the fighting, nobody else noticed him.

Steven tried to get somebody's attention. "Pearl! Spinnerella! Hey, someone, there's a…" Amidst all the commotion, he wasn't heard. "It has to be me, then." He ran towards the armory–back when he had stashed the Sword of Power there, he had seen something that he knew how to use.

Meanwhile, since all the guards were distracted, Sqalish was easily able to slip into the guest room unnoticed. The four prisoners looked up to see him enter, looking unusually pleased with himself. "Well, look who managed to get themselves captured," he mused, walking over to inspect the magical barriers. "And look who had to come all the way here just to rescue you…"

"Never took you for the gloating type," said an unimpressed Crita. "I don't suppose you brought a way to get us out of this mess?"

"I did, because unlike you, I take the time to think up a plan before rushing blindly into an enemy stronghold." Sqalish produced a small trinket from his pocket: it resembled a tiny silver disk the size of a pocket watch, with several dials inlaid with crystals. He began adjusting the dials to the sounds of gears turning within. "I just need to find the right frequency, and…"

He was interrupted when the door suddenly slammed open. "Hold it!" Standing there was Steven, a shield emblazoned with the emblem of Brightmoon strapped to his arm. "You're gonna have to deal with me first!"

“Oh, goody, He-Man’s back!” Karikon said with a mocking grin. “But where’s his sword? You didn’t give it up because of me, did you?”

Sqalish put the device back in his pocket. “This shouldn’t take long.” One of his tentacles lashed out towards Steven, who knocked it aside with his shield. He sprinted towards his opponent, who met him with a punch. Steven rolled under it, trying to kick out Sqalish’s legs, but the mer-man remained standing.

Steven then found himself lifted into the air by one of the tentacles. He bashed at both the limb and its owner, but found himself lacking in his usual strength, either Diamond or He-Man. Sqalish watched him flailing, unimpressed.

“Told you,” he said, before hurling Steven at the wall. Fighting through the pain, he got back to his feet, letting out a battle cry as he ran at him again. He swung his shield violently, but Sqalish merely sidestepped each attack. “I can appreciate your dedication, but as for your results…this is just sad.”

Gritting his teeth, Steven continued to swing. “Maybe if you stood and fought me, I’d actually get some results!” Sqalish kept on dodging, causing Steven to swing more and more violently in response. The mer-man sidestepped one of his strikes, and his shield clanged against one of the barriers. For a moment, Steven saw his reflection in it: his face was twisted in anger, looking not dissimilar to Jasper. This distraction gave Sqalish enough time to swat him aside, where he tumbled across the floor.

“Give it up, little man,” said Sqalish, going back to fiddling with his device. He wasn’t even looking at him. “Some people just aren’t meant to be fighters.”

“Poor little Steven,” Azurite mocked. “No powers from your mum, no magical sword, what do you still have?”

As he struggled to stand back up, Steven tried to think of a witty retort. He planned on saying something like 'I have heart!' or 'Just enough fight left in me to beat you!' but nothing came to mind. So, since he couldn't think of anything, Connie said it for him.

"He's got me!" She reached out a hand to help him up, holding her sword in the other. Glad to see her, he eagerly took her hand. "You know, if you needed help, you could've just asked."

He beamed. "Thanks, Connie. You're right, I can always count on you." Side by side, the two of them squared up. "Let's take him down, together!"

Sqalish groaned in annoyance. "Are there any other distractions you plan on using? Because now would be a good time to get them out of the way!" His tentacles shot out at the two of them, who split up. Connie sliced through the ones after her, while Steven blocked his with his shield. They met again in the middle, where Steven used his shield to springboard Connie into the air.

Connie came down on top of Sqalish with a powerful swing. He held up his arm to block, his skin becoming armored. When the sword clanged against his carapace, he tried to follow up with a punch, but Connie had already dodged out of the way, striking him in the face. As he stumbled, Steven hit him again with his shield.

The two of them had Sqalish pinned between them, repeatedly striking him to keep him off-balance. "No, don't let 'em pin you like that!" cried Carnelian, pressed up against her barrier. "You gotta get outta there!"

"What does it look like I'm trying to do!?" replied Sqalish, seconds before taking a shield to the chin. The pair had him up against a wall, reading each other's moves like they were dancing. They were so in sync that they began to glow, moments away from fusing. Connie noticed, and was overjoyed, but didn't say anything for risk of breaking their synergy.

As he was repeatedly pummeled, Sqalish saw something shimmer on the ground: he had dropped his trinket. This was his chance: he waited until Steven struck, blocking the blow with his hardened skin, and hoisting himself towards the ceiling with his tentacles. Steven broke off from their formation to go after him, and the glow faded. "Steven, wait!" shouted Connie.

Sqalish dove to the floor to grab the device, while Steven leapt into the air, preparing to bring his shield down. With a smirk, Sqalish intercepted him by snatching him out of the air with a tentacle around his neck. "Once again, valiant effort, poor execution!" He adjusted the dials once more, and pressed on a crystal in the center.

A burst of magic exploded from the trinket, wrapping all over the room. Instantly, the magical barriers dissolved, freeing the prisoners. Connie raised her sword, but Steven was thrown into her, sending them both crashing against the wall.

Catra's squadron wasted no time escaping. Karikon punched a hole through the wall, immediately leaping through it, closely followed by Carnelian and Sqalish. As Crita lowered herself through, Azurite waited to taunt Steven one last time. "So close! Oh well, maybe you'll get another chance soon. Actually, scratch that…once Catra has the Heart, you'll all be destroyed! So much for that!" Cackling, she flew outside as Steven hurled his shield her way.

They had tried their hardest, but the prisoners had still escaped. Breathing heavily, Steven glared at the hole in the wall, before falling to his knees. "Hey, it's alright," Connie said, crouching beside him. "They got away, but we can still stop Catra. … Steven?"

"It's not Jasper," he said quietly. "It's not Jasper, it's not the Sword, it's not Mom…it's my fault. *I'm* the reason He-Man is dangerous! All this hate and anger I'm feeling, it's been in me this whole time!" He looked up at Connie, looking ready to tear up. "Connie…am I a bad person?"

Hearing him ask that almost made her tear up as well. Instead, she dropped her sword and placed her arms around him. "Steven, everyone gets angry sometimes. Everyone feels hate sometimes. You're one of the nicest, gentlest, most loving people I know, and feeling like that doesn't make you bad. It just means you're human."

He returned her hug, but couldn't help looking down at his gem. "Maybe *too* human," he mumbled. He retrieved his shield, and she her sword. "C'mon, let's go help the others!"

"Sounds like a plan!" They hurried downstairs to deal with the rest of the invaders.

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Catra leapt off of the bridge and onto another as the cobblestone behind her exploded. The source of this blast appeared within the smoke, unleashing beam after beam from her palms. "Stop running, coward!" Glimmer shouted, her voice distorted by the energy flowing through her. She teleported in front of Catra to intercept her, but she just barely slid underneath her laser.

"Coward? Says the princess with magical powers going after someone without them!" Catra swung her claws, but Glimmer warped out of the way. She reappeared right behind her, an energy blast hurling her across the bridge. Glimmer warped above her, blasting herself down into the stone like a flaming comet, which Catra only just managed to evade. "This isn't exactly a fair fight!"

Glimmer was unaffected by Catra's taunts. "Since when have *you* cared about fighting fair!?" She threw blast after blast in Catra's direction, who nimbly dodged each one. Although she didn't show it, Catra was starting to feel like she was outmatched for real. "Was trying to destroy the world a fair fight!? Was *killing my mom* a fair fight!?"

“I didn’t kill anybody!” Catra said, more out of exasperation than desperation. “All I did was open a portal. Whatever Angella did next was her own fault.”

Unsurprisingly, this was not a wise choice of words. Glimmer roared, a pillar of energy erupting from around her body. She vanished, reappearing beside Catra and launching her off the bridge with a glowing punch. Instead of waiting for her to fall, Glimmer warped underneath her for another punch, and then another, and another. Quicker than the eye could see, she repeatedly pummeled Catra in midair.

Adora finally managed to catch up to them, leaping off the bridge in pursuit. “Can we please talk about this for a moment!?” she pleaded as she fell, crashing down beside the river. Catra slammed into the ground not far away, Glimmer looming over her. “Glimmer, stop this! You already beat her!”

A badly beaten Catra rose to her feet, clearly struggling to do so. This wasn’t good enough for Glimmer, who hovered above with glowing eyes. “You know what? I almost feel sorry for you.” Her voice was back to normal, but it was almost more chilling than before. “But then I realize, you brought this all on yourself.”

“What are you–” Catra tried to scoff, but was struck by another beam, throwing her against the ground.

“Adora didn’t make you stay with the Horde. Hordak didn’t force you to keep this war going after he left. Shadow Weaver didn’t make you try to destroy all of Etheria. Adora thinks you can still leave the Horde behind, but I don’t think you can. Once you took over the Horde, you became the Horde. And the only way for this war to be over is when the Horde is gone! For! Good!” She unleashed the biggest energy blast of all, one that could’ve vaporized Catra in an instant. But once the light had dimmed, she saw Adora, having transformed the Sword of Protection into a shield.

She-Ra glared up at Glimmer. “At first, I was just asking. But now, it’s not a request. *Stand down* , Glimmer. I won’t tell you again.” Her sword retook its true form.

Pure rage flared through Glimmer’s eyes, mixing in with pangs of betrayal. “I am your queen! You don’t command me, *I* command *you* !” She teleported inches away from Adora, knocking her back with an energy blast. Adora’s sword dug into the ground to stop her movement, before she launched herself at Glimmer. Before she could grab her, however, the princess warped over to Catra.

She lifted Catra up by the collar. “You’re right about one thing: I’m the Horde now. I’m Empress Catra. And this miserable planet means *nothing* to me anymore. Once I get the Heart of Etheria, you’ll be the first to go.”

Glimmer raised a hand, energy pooling into her palm. “All the more reason to get rid of you.” But before she could fire, she felt a set of claws rake across her cheek. She shouted and grabbed her wound as Catra fell back to the ground, sprinting away on all fours. Roaring, Glimmer unleashed all the energy she had, firing randomly at everything she could see. Adora held up her sword to block the attack, but there were too many projectiles. Her sword was knocked out of her hand, and the energy forced her to the ground.

Catra darted out of the way of the blasts, but there were so many of them that she couldn’t evade all of them. One eventually caught her, grazing her side and causing her to fall down near the river’s edge. Glimmer suddenly appeared by her side, kicking her back down before she could get up. The princess was then on top of her, laying into her with glowing fists.

The two were tangled together in a mass of fists and claws, both desperately trying to do as much damage to the other as they could. Catra was lashing out at any bit of Glimmer she could reach, who was ignoring her slashes through sheer rage. “I’ll kill you!” she roared, her vision obscured by tears. “I’m gonna do to

you exactly what you did to my mom! I'm…I'm…" The scratches had ceased.

Breathing heavily, Glimmer backed off her defeated foe. Catra was barely hanging on to consciousness, having been all but beaten into the ground. She was still lucid enough to taunt her, however. "What? Getting too tired to finish the job?" she asked, her laughter turning into a cough.

In truth, Glimmer had every opportunity to finish the job. She had expected to get some sort of satisfaction out of seeing Catra so utterly broken. She had wanted to see her afraid, knowing there was nothing that could stop her from killing her. But nothing of the sort came to her. Her anger, her sorrow, none of it dissipated the way she expected it to. Truthfully, she was tired. "I just…want this to be over," she said quietly.

"It will be soon," Catra said, trying and failing to stand up. She had noticed someone approaching–a group of someones. "For what it's worth…at least you *had* a mom. One who cared about you. Focus on that."

The rest of Catra's squad descended from the bridge above. "C'mon, we've gotta go, now!" said Crita, holding Catra up and helping her into the water. With Sqalish leading the way, all six of them vanished under the water, and were gone. Glimmer barely had any energy left, and didn't even try to stop them.

"No!" Adora sprinted to the river and dove in. After several moments, she burst out of the waves with a deep gasp, climbing back onto the shore. She went over to Glimmer, immediately expressing shock at her wounds. "Are you…?" She reached down, only for Glimmer to push her hand away.

"I'm fine," she said, getting to her feet. "Did they…?"

Adora nodded. "I couldn't see any of them. That squid guy must be faster than he looks. I'm sorry."

Averting her eyes, Glimmer offered a barely-audible "I am too." Several others had arrived in pursuit of the prisoners, Hordak and Castaspella leading their numbers. "How's the situation at the castle?"

Immediately, Castaspella rushed over to her niece, throwing her arms around her. "Glimmy, what happened to you!? Did Catra do this!? Come on, let's get you back to the castle to get you fixed up." Glimmer looked like she wanted to protest as she was led back to Brightmoon, but lacked the energy.

"We've dealt with the incursion," Hordak told her. "Most of the attackers scattered once we mounted our defense, but we managed to capture the rest. I recommend having them shipped to more secure locations–ones with actual holding cells, for one."

As the rest of the group headed back home, Adora retrieved her sword and was met by Connie and Steven. She noticed that the latter was armed with a shield, but not the pink one she was used to. "How'd things go without your powers?" she asked, remembering their conversation from the other day.

"Not well," Steven replied. His look off to the side told Adora that he was still working through some things. "I didn't see the fight here, but I could hear it. Glimmer really was serious about that, wasn't she?"

"I…yes and no," said Adora. Glimmer certainly *could* have killed Catra, but she didn't. This, however, didn't seem to have been mercy on her part. "Let's get back and clean up the castle. Something tells me tomorrow's not gonna be pretty…" The three of them headed homeward.

# To the Stars Redux

Chapter Summary

Adora, Scorpia, and Catra alike all head skyward.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Nineteen: To the Stars Redux

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"Once again, we have success!" declared Hessonite. Beside her appeared a holographic representation of Etheria. "It took quite a bit of coordination between the three of us, but we eventually managed to complete our seismic scan of Etheria, just as asked! You are quite welcome, of course."

"...Thank you," said Glimmer from her throne. After the attack, the rest of the Princess Alliance had reconveined for another meeting. "So, what did you find out?"

The hologram of Hessonite in the middle of the room was pushed aside by a hologram of Pyrope. "I'm so glad you asked that, it would be my pleasure to explain! So…" She tapped the model planet, which became a cross section showing a variety of tunnels dug underneath the surface. "As it turns out, Etheria is indeed hollow, in a way that could not have occurred naturally. This, of course, is proof that it was terraformed to some degree by the First Ones."

"That makes sense, considering Entrapta's theories," Hordak noted. "Proceed."

Pyrope was then, in turn, shoved out of the way by Demantoid. "According to *my* research, most of these tunnels and channels are located far underground. There are a few of these that reach

up to the surface, but the most prominent is located here, underneath this large structure." She pointed out the location, which wasn't too far away from Brightmoon.

"The Citadel…" Glimmer said quietly. Where all of this had begun. "All this time, the gateway to the Heart's been this close…"

Hessonite pushed Demantoid out of the way, but left just enough room for her and Pyrope to remain. "Not quite, your majesty. This Citadel is indeed the entrance to the Heart of Etheria, but we currently have no way of activating the structure. Based on our–I mean, Demantoid's research, we would need some kind of internal computing entity to access the planet's inner workings through it."

Upon hearing this, Adora emerged from the background. "Someone like Light Hope?" she asked.

"As a matter of fact, Light Hope would be perfect," said Demantoid. "Etheria's many structures were designed to be overseen by her, after all. Do you have a way of reactivating her?"

Adora looked down at her sword, holding onto hope that she could still be alive in there somewhere. She had seen her in person not long ago, hadn't she? Who else could that have been? "I don't know, but I might have an idea." She turned to Peridot. "Those coordinates–she must've given them to me for a reason."

"I…but…isn't that where you're from?" she said. "Why would Light Hope be all the way over there?"

"I don't know, but if it could get us down there before Catra, then we have to try," said Adora, before looking up at Glimmer. "How're Lars and his crew doing?"

Glimmer waited a moment before replying. "They weren't involved with the raid, if that's what you mean," she said, sounding surprised. "But, weren't you just going on about how bad it would be if I had the Heart just yesterday? What's with this one-eighty?"

She took a deep breath, stepping up before everybody. "You're right, I don't think anybody should have the Heart of Etheria if it's as dangerous as they say. But, if it comes down to us having it versus Catra having it…I'd rather it be in the hands of somebody who can be reasoned with. Don't get me wrong, I still don't think it should be used, under any circumstances…but if she's bold enough to try another attack on Brightmoon, we can't afford to play it safe anymore. We need something to deter the New Horde."

"I knew you'd come around eventually!" said Glimmer. Her satisfaction soon turned into disappointment. "Adora, I… Normally, I'd want to come with you. This could be your family, your home! But I can't leave Brightmoon, especially now that we're so close. But I wish you luck."

Adora felt the same way. When Light Hope had told her she could find her home, she couldn't imagine going there without Bow or Glimmer. But now, it looked like this was a journey she would be taking alone–not counting Lars and the Off-Colors, or course. "Thanks. I'll…be back as soon as I can. Who knows? Maybe we can go back there for real once this is all over."

For a split second, Glimmer smiled, before going back to her queenly, stoic demeanor. "Mara's ship should be set, just tell him you're ready to go. As for everyone else, we need to find out where Catra's gone while Hessonite's crew takes control of the Citadel. Spinnerella and Netossa will secure the…"

Her orders trailed off into the distance as Adora made her way out of the castle. Here it was; it was really happening. She could finally find out where she had come from, after all this time. Admittedly, it hadn't been a question she was that concerned with, but her chance meeting with Light Hope had planted that seed in her mind. She had to have a family, right? One who she had been taken away from? By Light Hope herself, ironically enough, but that didn't matter now. What mattered was that she would finally know who she was.

"Adora!" She turned around as Bow hurried down the corridor after her. "Hold on! You didn't think I'd let you leave alone, did you?"

"Aww, Bow," she said. "I'm glad you want to come with me, but Glimmer needs you here." She glanced behind him, making sure nobody was watching. "And I need you to keep an eye on her. Make sure she doesn't make any bad choices with the Heart."

He smiled, even though he was sad to see her go. "I do want to go with you, but that wasn't what I meant." He handed her what looked like a miniature version of his trackpad. "If you run into anything unexpected or need our help, call me with this. I'll do anything I can to get you back safe and sound."

Taking the device, Adora made sure to stow it somewhere safe. "Thank you, Bow. You really do so much for all of us." He beamed at the compliment. "I'll try to be back as soon as I can."

"Good luck out there," he said. "And don't worry, I'll hold down the fort here!" Bow waved as Adora headed outside, towards new frontiers. "...as best as I can, at least."

– – –

"You ready?" asked Micah.

"Ready!" He and Scorpia looked down at Mosquitor's encampment from atop the mountain, observing its defenses. They couldn't see many guards from here, but more would no doubt make an appearance once they began. "So, how're we doing this? Straight down the middle? Lure 'em out? Go for the proverbial throat?" she asked.

Micah motioned for her to follow, and the two of them slid down the mountainside. "We only have one shot at this, so we'll need to make it count." He silently crept along, hiding behind some bushes. "I'll grab the attention of as many guards as I can, while you look for a weak spot. Break in once they're distracted, and

you should have an easy path to–or you could do that, that works too."

Scorpia had already transformed, smashing through the walls with ease. The unprepared guards took a moment to react, due to the shock of a gigantic scorpion suddenly tearing apart their sturdiest of defenses. With a terrible screech, they were brought back to the present, rallying their numbers to take her down.

"This might just be easier than I thought," Micah noted, following her trail of destruction.

"Breach! There's been a breach!" yelled Mosquitor through the base's speakers. "Detain the creature immediately! We cannot let them interfere with Master Modulok's plans!" Despite the fervor in his voice, he was nowhere to be seen.

More guards poured out of barracks, taking aim with cobbled-together blasters. Scorpia was bombarded by a barrage of lasers, but her armor was far too tough for them to bother her. With a hiss, she took out another wall with a swipe of her tail, sending the entire battalion tumbling to the ground.

While she was on the warpath, Micah moved through the shadows, not that this was necessary considering everyone's attention was thoroughly seized. Working subtly, he incapacitated any guard that was looking to catch her by surprise. Though considering she was making short work of them so far, she didn't seem to need any help.

Mosquitor's camp had been designed to hold off any of the abominable monsters that inhabited Beast Island. Seeing as Scorpia wasn't one of these monsters, they were entirely unprepared for her. Most of the base was already in ruins. "...I hope she didn't accidentally flatten the ship," Micah said to himself.

Soon enough, once his army had been flattened, the master of Beast Island deigned to show himself. His presence was

announced as a swarm of scraper beetles burst forth from one of the broken buildings, swarming above it like a storm cloud. “So, the princess of the Fright Zone has finally embraced her gift,” Mosquitor said. He rose out of the basement, surrounded by the bugs. “How unfortunate for you that I hold mastery over all the land’s insects! Be bent to my will!”

He thrust his hand out towards her, expecting her to writhe and convulse as she futilely struggled against his dominance over her mind. Instead, all she did was stare at him, possibly in confusion. “Um…I’m no expert, but aren’t scorpions arachnids?” Micah pointed out.

“Silence!” Mosquitor directed the swarm towards the king, their hungry jaws chattering as they flew. He prepared a barrier spell, but this proved unnecessary, as Scorpia leapt in front of him. As before, the scraper beetles proved unable to pierce through her thick carapace. “Unworthy wretch! Taste the wrath of Mosquitor!” Try as he might, the beetles only proved to annoy her.

With Scorpia protecting him, Micah had the chance to cast another spell. Spinning his staff around like a baton, he summoned a powerful gale that scattered the beetles, leaving Mosquitor without his defenses. He looked around, but none of his guards were conscious enough to aid him. Scorpia ran forward, pinning him against a broken wall with her claw.

“Huh. That went surprisingly well,” said Micah, approaching the lackey. He, however, was more focused on Scorpia, her beady black eyes appearing to bore straight through him. “I’ll cut to the chase: we know Modulok keeps a spare ship around here, and *you* know where it’s hidden. Care to show us?”

Mosquitor only laughed. “Try as you might, you’re still nothing more than filthy castaways! It doesn’t matter that you used to be royalty–I will never betray my master to the likes of–” He was cut off as Scorpia’s stinger positioned itself right in front of his throat.

Though surprised by this, Micah continued. “Now, I’m pretty sure most scorpionkin have paralytic venom. But as for my giant friend here, I can’t be certain. She’s filled to the brim with the power of darkness, not to mention the sheer size difference. She might not even *need* venom, what with how big her stinger is! So…do you want to find out, or do you want to go for a ride?”

His efforts of trying to look tough didn’t last much longer. Mosquitor gulped, absolutely drenched in sweat. “Y-you want the ship? Fine. I’ll take you to the ship.” Keeping her stinger closely pointed at his back, Scorpia let him get up and make his way over to what remained of his central stronghold.

Now that their enemy was essentially neutralized, she turned back to normal. “Hey, we did it! Good work out there, pal.”

“Are you kidding? That was all you,” said Micah. “You made short work of this place! …Come to think of it, I can’t believe we were afraid of this guy.”

The comment made Mosquitor raise an arm to summon more bugs, but a near jab from Scorpia convinced him otherwise. “Hey, none of that!” She turned back to her partner. “So, are you ready to see your daughter again?”

Micah should have been happy, but it seemed there was still more to do. “Not yet. I can’t rest until Modulok is stopped. That’s why I need the ship: to travel to his base and kill him once and for all. It’s what I set out to do all those years ago, and I can’t go home until it’s done.”

“Then let’s go get that son of a…gun!” Scorpia said, eagerly raising her claws like boxing gloves. “I’ve come with you this far, so why not go all the way?”

The ground briefly shook, as Mosquitor had activated a hidden elevator beneath his base. The floor slid aside, and a small spacecraft was lifted up before them, thankfully just large enough for them all to fit. “Climb aboard,” he said sardonically.

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Battered, bruised, and thoroughly demoralized, Catra and her crew approached their hidden dropship. None of them, except maybe Catra herself, had expected the attack on Brightmoon to be terribly effective, but they had been thoroughly thrashed despite having the element of surprise. The addition of a master sorceress had probably aided in their defeat, as had Glimmer's surprising ferocity.

As bad off as they were, none had taken a beating worse than Catra herself. She could barely walk once they had exited the river, but was insistent on not being helped, leaving her to limp most of the way. Seeing how angry she looked, the others were content to leave her be, seeing as she might snap at any moment.

She waited impatiently as Crita dispelled her illusion, making their ship visible again. "You all stand guard out here," she ordered, heading inside. "With any luck, Entrapta won't be too busy." The door closed behind her, leaving the other five out in the cold.

"Did…did she just lock us out?" said Karikon. He knocked on the side of the ship, to no response. "Huh. Guess she really *is* pissed."

"I would be too, if I got beat that badly," Azurite said with a smirk.

"You *were* beat that badly," Carnelian reminded her. "We all were. Dunno why she's taking it personally…or out on us."

Sqalish sighed. "Whyever it may be, I'm beginning to get tired of bailing you all out. Consider yourselves lucky we've been fighting near rivers so far."

"Hopefully, we can finish this up and head back soon," said Crita.

Within the ship, Catra sent the call to Entrapta. After a few moments of waiting, not that long all things considered, but far too long for her liking, the scientist picked up. "Oh, hey Catra! It's been a while since I've heard from you guys. What's up?" She

looked back into the ship, realizing Catra was alone. “Uh-oh. They didn’t get captured, did they?”

“Not anymore,” Catra muttered. “Look, I’d rather not stay here longer than I need to, so I’ll make this quick. Glimmer and her princesses know about the Heart of Etheria, and they no doubt know where it is. So all we need to do is wait for them to lead us right to it. Is that good enough for you? Good, because we’re heading back.”

“Wait!” shouted Entrapta, quite forcefully. Perhaps too forcefully, as Catra stared at her like she had just requested she physically bring the Heart back. “...Stay there, we’ll come to you! If Glimmer’s going for the Heart, then we don’t have any time to waste! I’ll let Emerald know, and she’ll send the *Supermassive* to take care of business. See you then!”

“Entrapta, hold on, don’t–” But she had already hung up. Catra snarled, slamming her fist down on the console, before managing to calm herself. “Alright…this isn’t a big deal. What’s a few more hours with these idiots?” She opened the ship up, and was greeted by the five of them whispering conspiratorially. A clearing of her throat led to all of them turning around.

After an awkward pause, Karikon spoke. “So, I take it we’re ready to head out?” he asked, stepping on board.

Catra sighed. “Yes, but apparently, Entrapta thinks Emerald will want to come to us. So we’re stuck here until they decide to show up.” She sat down in the captain’s chair, none too pleased. “We might as well wait this out in orbit.”

“At least our long, difficult journey is nearing its end,” mused Sqalish, preparing the ship to take off alongside the others. It was clear that Catra was not the only one eager to get off this planet.

As they ascended into the sky, something buzzed at the back of Catra’s mind. “What exactly were you talking about just now?” she asked.

It was clear Karikon wasn’t prepared for this question, pausing awkwardly before asking “What do you mean? We were just talking.”

“Is that so?” said Catra, her eyes narrowing. “I would appreciate it if you did a little less of that.”

“...Less talking?” asked Carnelian. “How are we supposed to–”

Catra waved her hand, quieting her. “Yeah-yeah-yeah, I don’t care. If at all possible, I’d like these next few hours to be spent in complete silence.” She laid back in her chair, looking at the stars as the ship hovered in orbit. “Although…keep an eye on the comms at all frequencies. We don’t want to miss anything.”

Chapter End Notes

> For some reason, autocorrect kept wanting to chance "beetles" to "beatles." Not even capitalized, either.

# Point of Origin

Chapter Summary

Adora makes the journey home, while Modulok's plans are set into motion.

Chapter Twenty: Point of Origin

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“Engine?”

“Ready to go,” said a Rutile.

“Thrusters?”

“All systems green!” said Rhodonite.

“Super lightspeed thingy?”

“...Do you not know how ships work?” asked Lars.

“Great! Team, prepare for takeoff!” Adora pointed towards the sky, more than prepared for whatever awaited her at Light Hope’s coordinates. Although a bit nervous as well, her excitement overrode her trepidation.

The First Ones ship that had belonged to Mara ascended into the air, leaving the ground far behind. “Inputting coordinates,” said Padparadscha, feeding the computer the numbers that Adora knew by heart. A holographic image of a planet appeared, accompanied by a ring around it indicating the facility’s orbit.

“Location confirmed: Primus,” said a pleasant computer voice. “Destination: Research Facility #2102. Hyperspeed ready.”

Adora’s birthplace now had a name: planet Primus. Or Research Facility #2102, in orbit around Primus. Either way, she was elated

to have a name to put on her original home. But little did she know, she wasn't the only one who knew it.

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The crackle of static alerted Carnelian that something was nearby. "Hey, boss! I'm picking up some sorta transmission here!" she called, gaining the attention of the rest of the expedition. "Another ship's comin' into orbit!"

The others scanned for the source of the signal, locking on to the ship in question. "Well, look at that," said Karikon. "Seems to be First Ones in origin. Seems to be broadcasting down towards Brightmoon."

"Intercept it," Catra ordered. "I want to know exactly where she's going."

Silently wondering if Catra knew more than she was letting on, Crita did as she asked. Her suspicions seemed to be confirmed when they heard the voice of Adora. "Glimmer…I know we haven't exactly seen eye to eye lately, but it felt wrong to leave without letting you know where we're going. Apparently, it's a planet called Primus. I've never heard of it, but it's got some sort of First Ones base there or something." Catra silently instructed the others to make note of this. "I honestly don't know what to expect. Will my family be there? Would they even recognize me? Who was I *supposed* to be before I became Adora? I guess I'm just…kinda nervous."

There was a long pause that followed. Carnelian was about to suggest adjusting the frequency, but Catra shushed her.

Adora soon continued. "I guess this just feels…wrong without you and Bow. Everything's been changing so much recently, and I know it isn't my fault, but sometimes I wonder if…if I'd done something differently, then Angella…" She trailed off once more, and they could hear the sounds of her crewmates talking in the background.

Even though she was his enemy, Sqalish couldn't help but feel a little bad for the girl. "Should we pursue?" he asked.

Reasoning that they had already gotten everything they could from her transmission, Catra agreed. "Set course for Primus," she said. "But wait until we're out of scanner range before jumping."

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"You sure you're up for this?" asked Lars, noticing how upset Adora had suddenly become. "We're alright with heading back if you want to postpone, right guys?" Words of assent from the Off-Colors.

But Adora refused to give in. "No, I'm alright. Just nerves, that's all." She laughed anxiously. "You know how it is, going to meet your long-lost family who may or may not even exist!"

Lars didn't know, but figured he understood her fears. "Well, if you think you're ready, so are we. Ensign Rutile? Engage the hyperdrive!"

"Since when did we make ensign?" one Rutile twin asked to her sister, who shrugged. Nevertheless, they prepared the ship for its jump, launching the First Ones vessel towards its destination.

But they would not be the only ones to make the jump. As soon as Mara's ship had vanished from sight, Catra's shuttle made the preparations to follow. The planet Primus was on their star-maps, so all it took was a matter of locking on, and they sped off as well.

"Hope you're ready for me, Adora," Catra drawled, ready to end their feud once and for all.

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Double Trouble really needed to sell this performance. Not for the purpose of convincing Emerald–they could probably just phone it in, and the Gem would be none the wiser, so focused was she on having her revenge. No, this one was entirely for themself, and

the fact that this moment was make-or-break regarding Modulok's master plan.

Their Entrapta guise as flawless as ever, they worked up a believable sweat by running through the ship's halls, before bursting into Emerald's quarters as Entrapta was known to do. "Emerald! Big news!"

The Beryl nearly fell out of her chair, turning to angrily face 'her.' "How many times have I told you not to barge in here!?"

"Sorry, but this is important! Crucial, even!" said not-Entrapta. "Catra found the Heart of Etheria! We have to go after it, immediately!"

"What?" Emerald stood up. Her momentary elation at the news was soon dampened by the following statement. "And why isn't she bringing it back here? Why do we have to give up our assault on Ophidia to do her job for her?"

The answer wasn't exactly a lie, but it was just as exhilarating for Double Trouble to say. "That's the tricky bit: the Heart is *big* , way too big for her to take with her. Plus, there's also the matter of it being buried beneath Brightmoon Castle. So, we talked for a bit, and decided that a project like that was best left for the Supermassive. She's waiting for us to launch the attack as we speak!"

Emerald's mild irritation was easily eased by the prospect of such a powerful weapon being so rife for the taking. "So, all we have to do is level the castle…"

"...and the Heart will be ours!" Entrapta finished. "Of course, I can understand if you're hesitant to leave Ophidia behind, considering how much we've expended on our campaign–"

"Right, you stay here and monitor the situation," Emerald ordered, already heading off to the command bridge. "Once I have the Heart of Etheria, this planet's defenses will mean nothing! Even the Diamonds themselves will crumble before the New Horde!"

She burst out into cackling laughter, which Double Trouble happily joined in. “I’m serious. Get down to the surface immediately!”

Entrapta saluted. “Will do, boss!” She left her ‘boss’ behind, smirking as she made her way to the hangar. That had gone even better than they thought it would! Not only had Emerald taken the bait hook, line, and sinker, but she had given Double Trouble the perfect excuse to stay behind! All that was left was to contact their real boss, and inform him that everything was proceeding according to schedule.

The hangar was almost entirely empty, as most of their manpower was fighting on or near the planet’s surface. Emily, hooked up to her harness and ready to be deployed, beeped as she saw her not-creator approaching. It was lucky she had been brought into the fold straight from the get-go, otherwise she could have compromised their entire plan.

“Well, hello there!” said Double Trouble, their eyes momentarily turning their original red. “Are you excited to see Entrapta again? Hmm?” The mech’s front opened up, accompanied by a few joyful chirps. “I’ll assume that’s a yes,” they said as they climbed inside.

Just as the mech disengaged, dropping down towards the planet, the Supermassive began to turn around, heading for Etheria. Double Trouble silently wondered if Emerald really would be able to defeat She-Ra all on her own, even with the gigantic ship. An intriguing thought, but the winner of that little tussle didn’t matter too much in the long run. They tuned Emily’s radio to their secret channel.

“Yes, yes, what is it?” came Modulok’s irritable voice. “Entrapta was just about to show me the fruits of her labors.”

Double Trouble smirked. “In that case, you’ll be happy to hear this! Emerald is on her way to Etheria as we speak! She should keep those princess types busy while you work your magic.”

Although Modulok didn't have the most expressive face even when they could see it, they were just certain he would be beaming with pride if he could be. "Excellent work, Double Trouble. I will inform our agents of her imminent arrival. Now all we need to do is wait for Adora. Return immediately." He ended the communication.

As Emily continued rocketing towards Modulok's Ophidia base, Double Trouble allowed themself a moment to be proud of themself…more than usual, at least. They leaned back in their seat, wondering just how Modulok would get by without such an essential follower.

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"Who was that?" asked Entrapta, not looking up from her project. The disc-shaped device was almost complete, and she was excited to finally learn what it was for.

"Oh, just a business associate," Modulok said absently, walking over to examine the device. Mantenna and Leech hung nearby, watching Entrapta as closely as ever. "More importantly, I understand you're putting the finishing touches on my design? I am surely just as excited as you to see it in action!"

Took the words right out of her mouth. "You bet! Ah…so, what exactly does it do? I mean, obviously it's a way to combine several disparate energy sources, but is there a particular reason you need to do that?"

Modulok's face was always hard to read, even after all this time of working with him. "I discovered some ancient First Ones ruins some time ago," he explained. "Try as I might, even with all my resources and intellect, I just could not manage to access the inner chamber. But now, thanks to you, I will finally be able to discover just what lies beneath that sealed door. How lucky I was to be found by such an expert on First Ones technology!"

Entrapta couldn't help but beam at the compliment. "Aw, Moddie, you're too kind! But really, I'm the lucky one here. It's so nice to finally have a friend who's just as interested in science as I am! … Who doesn't end up leaving me, at least." She looked away sadly, but her reflection lasted only a moment before she continued working.

Although Modulok twitched slightly at her nickname, he retained his sympathetic tone. "I can't imagine why anybody would want to leave someone as bright and charming as you. In any case, I certainly have no intention of leaving you behind. In fact, I am looking forward to the many projects we'll be working together on in the future."

Entrapta paused. Did she really want to stay here with Modulok? Was she willing to leave her friends and home behind? The more she thought about it, the more it made sense. The Horde was no longer for her. Bow and Peridot likely hated her guts, Hordak and Scorpia had disappeared, and Catra and Emerald only saw her as an asset. "I…I'd like that," she said. "I'd like that a lot."

Before they could bond any further, Double Trouble entered the room. "Now, hold on a moment! I put up with your antics because you were useful, but don't think about taking *my* spot as Modulok's favorite!" They glared at Entrapta for a moment, before snickering playfully upon seeing her reaction. "C'mon, show us what you've been working on!"

With the four of them waiting expectantly, Entrapta proudly put the finishing touches on the device. "I hereby present, the Modulok-Entrapta brand type-four First Ones energy siphon receptacle mark one!" She held up the device, which resembled a thin disk around a meter across. Multiple wires extended from the edge, retracting into the machine with the press of a button in the center. "With this baby, up to fifteen different energy sources can all be routed to the same destination! Not too bad for only a few weeks' work at most, if I do say so myself!"

"'Not that bad?' Entrapta, this is truly a work of art!" Modulok said, taking the device to examine it. He held it gingerly as he inspected it, exuding reserved excitement as he did so. "I believe I speak for everyone here when I say you are truly an invaluable part of this team!"

"Does that mean we're ready to go?" she asked, barely able to contain herself any longer.

For an agonizing amount of time, Modulok considered whether to bring her along. "I suppose it wouldn't be fair to do this without you," he said. "All of you, come along: it is finally time for my lifelong project to come to fruition!"

Mantenna and Leech were as unreadable as ever, while Double Trouble clapped politely. Entrapta, meanwhile, cheered enthusiastically, hopping with joy. "At last, we can unlock the secrets of the First Ones! But, uh, what kind of secrets are we going to be unlocking, exactly?"

Modulok smiled. "I'm not sure–that's why they're secret!" He gestured for the four of them to follow, leading them to his portal generator. "But before we return to Etheria, there is something I must take care of. Please bear with me, it should only take but a few moments…assuming my other associates have done their jobs."

Swirling energy filled the frame, manifesting into a portal. "I hope you're prepared for what comes next!" Double Trouble told Entrapta cryptically, vanishing into the gateway. She simply shrugged it off, moving to go after them, but heard something from outside. A faint beeping, very familiar, coming from outside of the cave.

"Something on your mind?" asked Modulok. "If you'd rather, you are more than welcome to stay here."

The prospect of missing out on her achievement put all thoughts of her old friend out of her mind. "Nope. Don't start without me!"

She bound forward to jump through the portal. Behind her, a satisfied Modulok followed, accompanied by his pair of monstrosities. In the silent cavern, the beeps continued.

Emily had been excited to see the real Entrapta, but not it seemed like she couldn't even hear her. She peered in through the entrance, quietly hoping she hadn't been forgotten in favor of her master's new friends. Where exactly could they have gone?

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"Here we are: Research Facility #2102!" said Lars, as Mara's ship decelerated out of hyperspeed. The large First Ones space station hovered in orbit around planet Primus, a world almost entirely blue. Adora immediately began scanning both the station and the planet for any signs of activity, any sign of her people. "Is there anywhere we can dock?"

"Yeah, there's a hangar right here, but…" said Rutile, trailing off uncertainly. "It's open and ready for us. Like we were…expected," her twin continued.

This normally would have put Adora on edge, but her mind was occupied by other things. "Light Hope!" she exclaimed. "O-or my parents! They're waiting for me!" She excitedly pointed at the open hangar. "Quick, land already!"

Despite their trepidation, the Off-Colors eased the ship into the docking bay. "Try hailing the station, see if anyone answers," Lars suggested.

"Triiied aaalreeeady," said Fluorite. "Nooo aaansweeer."

Mara's ship came to a stop, the hangar completely empty. There was a notable lack of ships or people, not that this deterred Adora, who raced out as soon as the doors opened. "Man, this place is a ghost town. Ship. Station," said Lars, thoroughly creeped out. "Are you *sure* you got those coordinates right?"

"Positive!" said Adora. "I mean…sure, it has been a while." Her enthusiasm dimmed slightly as the certain prospects became apparent. "It's not like it's impossible nothing happened while I was gone. …But there should still be something here! Even if everybody left, there should still be evidence, right?"

The others made their way off the ship, also feeling the sense of foreboding the station held. "What exactly happened?" Rhodonite wondered aloud. "Can you see anything, Pads?"

Padparadscha sparkled as she used her past vision. "I see…hmm. Someone *is* waiting for us, but I can't tell who."

"It has to be Light Hope. It *has* to be," Adora said, heading further into the station. She only stopped when Lars grabbed onto her shoulder.

"Hang on!" he said. "We don't know who or what is waiting for us in there! At the very least, we should all stick together."

"Yes," Padparadscha agreed, "especially since Catra just arrived."

"See, Catra's here, which means we–What!?" shouted Lars, just as another ship appeared just outside the station.

The Horde shuttle had just come out of warp, seemingly having locked onto their signature. None of them had any time to react as it landed next to their ship, but not before ramming into the vessel as an act of spite. "B-but how did they know how to find us!?" shouted Rhodonite.

It didn't matter now, as they were already there. The shuttle's doors opened, and the squadron emerged. Adora recognized them from their attack on Brightmoon: the scorpionkin with a giant gun, the mer-man, the sorceress, the Carnelian, and Bluebird Azurite. And lastly, Catra climbed out of the ship, flanked by her warriors, and grinning maliciously at her prey.

"Hey Adora."

# Truth

Chapter Summary

Upon falling into Modulok's trap, Adora discovers who she truly is.

Chapter Twenty-One: Truth

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Mosquitor's ship was barely big enough for two people, let alone three of them, especially with Scorpia being one. She, him, and Micah were all crammed into the tiny craft, which the pair doubted even had hyperspeed capabilities. "So, where exactly is this base of his?" she asked.

"In orbit around a planet called Primus," Mosquitor grumbled. It was clear he would rather not be divulging this information, but didn't have a choice. "Apparently, it has some sort of connection to the First Ones, but Master Modulok rarely went into detail. Exactly what could be hiding there, I can't say."

Despite trying to stay stoic, Scorpia could tell that Micah was worried. "Y'know, I was pretty gung-ho back on the ground, but now that we're up here…are you sure this is a good idea? Just the two of us, going up against whatever Modulok's got waiting out there? Maybe we should go and get backup first…"

Her comment was met by a scoff from Mosquitor. "Who would you go to? The Horde, who cast you aside? The princesses, who you made enemies of? That should be interesting! 'Hey, I know I tried to kill you all several times, but there's this guy I need your help to kill! So, whaddya say? Wanna team up?'"

"...I don't sound anything like that," said Scorpia.

Micah knocked the back of Mosquitor's head. "Quiet, you!" He turned to his partner. "Don't worry–we have one of his top

lieutenants here with us! If Modulok has anything up his sleeve, we'll know about it. Won't we?"

"I promise nothing!" Mosquitor snapped.

Micah's confidence eased her nerves a little, though Scorpia was still wary. "If you're sure. I mean…we *do* make a pretty good team, after all."

"The best!" Micah replied.

"Am I part of this team too?" asked Mosquitor sarcastically. They ignored him.

With newfound confidence, Scorpia looked to the stars. "Onward, to Primus!" she declared, pointing with her claw. Mosquitor wordlessly activated the ship's warp drive, and the three of them were carried off to parts unknown, to face down with their nemesis once and for all. Little did they know, they were far from the only ones to head that way…

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"Catra." Why was Adora not surprised to see her here? The two archnemeses stared each other down, backed by their respective entourages. Of the two, Catra's seemed a lot more willing to fight than Adora's. "Let me guess: you're here to get your paws on some sort of First Ones loot?"

"Actually, I might not need it," she answered, readying her claws. "There I was, waiting for Emerald to show up, when who should I see but my old friend Adora, traveling all by herself? Well, she might as well have been by herself.." She looked over the Off-Colors dismissively. "Lars. I see you and your circus freaks are doing well."

He huffed. "Actually, we *are* , thank you very much!"

The two parties grew closer and closer to the inevitable confrontation. "Um, h-how about we all take a moment to talk this

out?" Rhodonite suggested, though it was unlikely to be taken. "We don't even know what this place is for! If we have to fight, shouldn't it wait until we know a bit more about where we are?"

"Oh, this should be *way* too easy," said Karikon, readying his weapon as he too sized up the Gems. "Just say the word, boss, and we'll light 'em up!"

Catra grinned. "Let 'em have it. Just leave Adora to me!" She suddenly lunged at Adora, giving her only just enough time to block the attack with her sword. The rest of her squadron charged as well, only prevented from reaching the Off-Colors by the timely intervention of Fluorite.

There hadn't been any time to think: the grandmotherly Gem had simply acted on instinct. "Looook ooout!" She hurled herself between her friends and their attackers, her long body preventing any of their attacks from reaching. "Gooo, nooow!"

Lars and the others huddled together. Adora and Catra were fighting on one side, and all the other Horde baddies were on the other. "No, we can't just leave you!" Lars declared. "We may be outmatched, but I'm not going down without a fight!"

"Adora!" cried Padparadscha, getting her attention. "Hurry, find your family! We'll hold them off!"

Adora parried one of Catra's strikes, hurling her back. "No, I can't just leave you here to–" She saw it in all of their eyes: an unspoken promise to do everything they could to help her achieve her goal. To fight as best they could, giving her as much time as they could. "...Okay. But be careful!"

"We always are!" Lars said, with a twinkle in his eye. "Off-Colors, attack formation!" With Gem-enhanced reflexes, he leapt over Fluorite into the fray. The rest of his comrades, emboldened by his example, followed suit.

As Karikon was preparing to fire another barrage, Fluorite slammed into him, using her massive form as a battering ram.

That did the trick, knocking him down. “Uuuse yooour pooowers!” she instructed.

“ *What* powers!?” asked Rhodonite, who had been quickly grabbed by Sqalish’s tentacles. “We’re off-colors! We don’t have powers!”

Meanwhile, Lars was dealing with Crita. Though outmatched, he was able to resist her spells better than most due to his unique nature. “Have you ever tried? The Crystal Gems have powers, and Homeworld considered them off-colors too!”

This was something she hadn’t considered. “I…I’ll give it a shot!” Rhodonite said, not expecting much. She was half-Ruby, so she focused on that, summoning forth her heat as her component had done many times before. Instead of ordinary fire, her larger hands glowed with hot plasma, burning the tentacles and causing Sqalish to drop her. She landed on her feet, surprised at how that had gone. “...I can do that?” she asked herself, looking at her hands.

Sqalish retracted his tentacles, hardening his skin into a carapace. “So you can shoot fire–big deal! I’ve dealt with fire before!” He charged. Although Rhodonite cried out in fear, she stood firm to face him.

As Lars valiantly ran from Crita, Carnelian took aim at him with her boomerang. “Oh, this is gonna be too easy!” She carefully lined up the shot, but just as she moved her arm to throw, she felt the friction of the floor completely disappear. With a shout, she fell on her side, and the boomerang missed its target completely. The floor felt cold; in fact, she noticed that it had been completely frozen.

“Oh! I have done it!” Padparadscha cried, having managed to use her ice powers. “This is a joyous occasion!” However, she then noticed that Carnelian had gotten back up, and had summoned another boomerang to chase her down. “Oh dear!” The Sapphire ran, with the Quartz giving chase.

Crita continued chasing after Lars, eventually able to snag his ankle with a magical snare, and dragging him over. “Would you please cooperate?” she grumbled, more irritated than angry. “We don’t have to fight if you just stand down!”

“Oh, yeah, that’s a pretty good point,” Lars said. “But y’know, I have a good point too: YAAAAAH!” Lars unleashed a powerful scream that threw Crita against the wall, freeing him from the snare in the process. “Guess I won this debate! Huh?” He suddenly found that his foot had been frozen to the ground.

Childish laughter at his predicament came from his side, and he turned to see Azurite floating towards him. “You should have stayed on Homeworld, underground, where you belong!” she said, dragging her saber along the ground. Lars tried to break through the ice, but he wasn’t fast enough–she swung the weapon, launching an icicle towards him.

Lars braced for impact, but as the projectile raced towards him, it disappeared through a red portal that suddenly appeared. Both he and Azurite stared in confusion, until another portal opened up and sent the icicle back at its source. Azurite was knocked to the ground, frozen in place. “Not bad, huh, Captain?” said Rutile.

“That was you?” asked Lars. Rhodonite hurried over to thaw the ice over his foot.

Both Rutile twins smiled. “Yup! Didn’t think we’d ever open one of those. Just goes to show what a little confidence can do!” She, Lars, and Rhodonite disappeared into another portal before Sqalish could arrive.

And so, the Off-Colors fought off the squad with their newfound abilities as Adora and Catra continued their bout further into the station. Having become She-Ra, Adora had the advantage, but Catra was not about to let her get away. She darted around the hallway, having all but gone feral, slashing her claws on whatever she could find.

“What are you still fighting for!?” asked Adora, blocking one of her strikes. “Do you really need to be in control that much!? You weren’t content with just Etheria, so now you need the whole universe?”

“I only want what I’m *owed* !” snarled Catra, ducking under the Sword of Protection to deliver a slash to Adora’s side. “For once in my life, I want to feel important! And I can’t do that with you standing in my way!”

She pounced, only for Adora to grab her and throw her against the wall. “I’m only standing in your way to protect the people I care about! And that’s supposed to include you, Catra!” She pointed the sword at her foe. “You could have come with me. You could have left the Horde behind, moved on to a better life! We could be fighting on the same side… Did I really mean that little to you?”

Catra got to her feet, hissing. “Don’t try and make this my fault! *You* walked away from *me* ! Fighting on the same side? There’s only one side I wanna be on–mine! You’re right, I used to think we were friends. But now? Now, you’re just another obstacle standing in my way.”

The look on Adora’s face was one of heartbreak, but also of understanding. “Then I guess we didn’t know each other as well as we thought.” She turned away, heading further into the base. “I held out hope for years that you’d come around, but you never will, will you? You’ll just keep turning more and more into Shadow Weaver, until you find another innocent girl to pass on your hatred to! Well, I’m not about to continue that cycle! I’m here to find my *real* family, who won’t throw me out the moment I decide to go my own way! Goodbye, Catra…I hope you have a good life.” With that, she left the other girl behind.

“Don’t turn your back on me!” Catra roared, lunging once more at She-Ra. But Adora responded with a swing of her sword, throwing her back where she crashed down on the floor.

"No! I'm not going to be a part of your games anymore," Adora said firmly. "I don't want to be your friend, or your nemesis, or whatever it is we are to each other! I don't want to keep up this back and forth thing, where I try to get you to come to the Princess Alliance, and you refuse, and we fight, and…and…" She sighed. It wasn't worth it anymore. "Nevermind. I'm done. Go get your soldiers and go home–this isn't the place for you."

Left behind, Catra could only quietly snarl. She wanted to lunge again, to sink her claws into Adora's skin…so why couldn't she? Nothing was physically preventing her from pouncing, and yet she stayed right where she was. As Adora continued walking away from her, she collapsed to the ground, offering a quiet whisper. "Don't leave…not again…"

But Adora was serious. She wanted nothing more to do with Catra. All she wanted was to find out what secrets lie within this facility, secrets that would tell her just who she really was. She shivered as thoughts of her family, her true family, filled her head. Actually, she was shivering because it was getting colder the further she walked–why was it so cold? She could see her breath, and frost had appeared on some of the walls. Things seemed to get even colder when the lights went out.

Adora held up her sword, illuminating the area slightly with its runestone. It was then that he heard a voice she hadn't heard in a long time, and wished she would never hear again. "Now, children, there's no need to fight. Not when we can finally be together again…"

Chills ran up both of their spines. "No," Catra said, barely audible. "It can't be…"

A form appeared from out of the darkness, gliding ethereally. Crimson robes and a blood-red mask floated towards them, two glowing eyes locked on the two of them. Shadow Weaver came into view, dark magic swirling around her form. "Adora. How long has it been? Years? Far too long, if you ask me. And you brought Catra along as well." She reached out to stroke Adora's cheek, but

she stepped back. “What’s the matter? Aren’t you glad to see your mother?”

“W-what are you doing here?” Adora stammered, terrified despite her massive power. “You aren’t supposed to be here! I’m supposed to find my family!”

“I *am* your family, child,” said Shadow Weaver, growing impatient. “Why else do you think I was waiting for you? You didn’t truly believe Light Hope would lead you here herself, did you?” As though preparing for a fight, shadows began to swirl at her feet.

Indeed, she would have one, as Catra was unable to hold her emotions in any longer. With a scream of rage, she hurled herself at the woman who raised her, claws aimed to kill. But Shadow Weaver simply closed her fist, and dark tendrils covered the girl. Her angry shouts were cut short as she disappeared into the darkness.

By the time Adora realized she was next, there was no time to react. Shadowy tendrils wrapped around her arms and legs, with one twisting her wrist until she dropped her sword. “Don’t be afraid–it will all be over soon,” Shadow Weaver assured her. But Adora was far from assured, her vision blurring and her body becoming numb. The last thing she saw was the woman’s masked face before she faded into unconsciousness.

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Words. Lots of loud words. Someone was shouting, but she couldn’t understand the words. But the voice sounded familiar, somehow. Adora opened her eyes, quickly closing them again due to the light. But once they adjusted, she finally saw the scene before her.

She was in some sort of control room, if the computers by the wall meant anything. She tried to move, but realized that her arms and legs were locked in place. A look revealed she was suspended in the air, locked into some sort of floating ring-shaped

device. As the blurriness of her vision began to fade, she realized that the voice was indeed coming from a familiar source: "En… Entrapta?" she asked weakly.

The former ally of the Princess Alliance, and their on-again, off-again foe was currently engaged in a heated conversation with someone unseen. "I'm just saying, this is all a little excessive! Adora and Catra used to be my friends! Granted, they aren't *now* …but that's no reason to treat them like this!"

"Yes, yes, I'm sure you're very fond of them," a metallic voice answered. "I can assure you, this is all very necessary to achieve my goals."

Adora's vision was suddenly blocked by Shadow Weaver appearing before her. "Ah, you're finally awake," she said, brushing the girl's hair out of her face. "Now we can get on with this."

Entrapta turned around. "Get on with what?" she asked, more than a little nervous. She wasn't the only one. Adora had no idea what everyone was doing here, or why Light Hope had given her the coordinates for this place. But all of that and more was about to be answered.

Movement from the shadows revealed a familiar figure emerging. "Adora," Modulok said. "The last time I saw you, you were barely old enough to walk. Look at you now: wielder of the Sword of Protection, ally of the Princess Alliance! My, how the times do change…"

She recognized him, but just barely. "Modulok?" she said, the mystery deepening. "W-what's…what's going on here? What are all of you doing here?"

"Why, waiting for you, of course!" he said, as though it was obvious. "You took longer than I expected to follow our directions, but you got here eventually. I was beginning to consider sending Double Trouble after you with a reminder."

“Three-seven-eight. Four-nine-two. Five-five-three.” Adora knew that voice all too well. She nearly gasped as Light Hope walked into her line of vision. She was smiling smugly, a look that was almost completely alien on her face. “I’ll admit, I doubted you’d be smart enough to figure things out! Good thing Modulok’s not the only one with a lovable green sidekick!” Her form began to shift, and soon, Double Trouble revealed their true form.

The same one, Adora realized, who had pretended to be Flutterina. “You,” she said. She turned towards Modulok. “Then, that would make you…”

Modulok grinned. “Indeed, I am the Surgeon! Honestly, considering what you know about me, I’m surprised you did not make the connection sooner.”

“I’m not.” Adora turned to see that Catra was also present, having been silent up until now. She was not held as securely as Adora was, but her arms were still secured by a powerful-looking cuff, which was chained to the wall. “What? I grew up with you, remember? You were never exactly the brightest.”

“I *do* love a family reunion,” Modulok muttered, “but I’m afraid we are on a timetable. Miss Weaver, would you kindly bring your two daughters along? I did promise Adora I would introduce her to her family, after all, and I am not the kind to go back on a promise!”

There was a groan from Shadow Weaver, but she complied nonetheless. The ring Adora was in began floating along, carried by shadowy tendrils. Catra was pulled along as well, led by the chain like a prisoner.

Entrapta followed along with the party, trying to talk with a disinterested Modulok. “Why did you never mention any of this!? I-if I had known you were working with Shadow Weaver, I–”

“You never would have helped me?” Modulok guessed. “That, my dear, is precisely the reason I neglected to tell you. I needed your mind, not your heart, and you performed your duty. You should

consider yourself lucky I still admire your intellect, otherwise I may have cast you aside." Entrapta said nothing, numbly walking along.

They soon reached a larger room, which was all but completely darkened. "Now, Adora, I would ask that you keep an open mind," said Shadow Weaver. Adora couldn't tell if she was actually concerned for her or not. "I can imagine this will not be what you were expecting. Just know that this does not change how I see you."

Knowing Shadow Weaver, that could mean anything. Modulok said he was going to show Adora her family, but what could that mean? She was dreading what she would see when the lights turned on, all sorts of horrible possibilities running through her mind. Had all the inhabitants perished long ago, and he put them on display? Or maybe he mutated them into horrible monsters, as he liked to do. She braced herself for what she was sure would be a gruesome sight.

"As I'm sure you are aware, this station is an ancient Eterian research base. First Ones, as I believe you call them. It dates back centuries, all the way to when Etheria was first discovered." He held up Adora's sword. "The Sword of Protection was of great interest to us, especially considering the Sword of Power was lost in the Great Gem War. Unfortunately, those who could wield its power were few and far between–those who could be controlled, doubly so."

Catra scoffed. "Would you just spit it out already? Nobody cares about whatever hour-long exposition you're about to spew! Just cut to the chase, we're already bored enough!"

Modulok couldn't help grinning. "Oh, very well. Essentially, we only had one adequate She-Ra among our numbers. And rather than trying to replicate her, someone–perhaps someone in this room–had the thought to *literally* replicate her."

With that, he activated the lights. The room was even larger than it had looked, spanning further than Adora could see. But what she could see, she never would have expected in a million years. Hundreds, if not thousands of pods lined the walls, each one lit with a dim bluish glow due to being filled with some sort of fluid. But inside of each pod, there was also…herself. Hundreds and hundreds of herselves. The room was filled with Adoras.

She was silent with shock. Modulok, however, almost seemed to revel in her silence. "And there you have it. I promised to reunite you with your family, and here they are! Look at all your sisters, Adora! This is where you were from before Light Hope snatched you away into Despondos. You, Adora, are a clone! A clone of Queen Marlena Grayskull, the first Eternian to wield the Sword of Protection! That is why she chose you, Adora. You were designed to be She-Ra. You were painstakingly engineered to be Etheria's savior."

If Adora could, she would have fallen to her knees. For so long, she had wondered who she was, and the answer…was nobody. She wasn't special. She wasn't even a real person. All she was was a copy. A tool, and instrument, of conquerors. "Adora?" said Catra, a surprising amount of sympathy in her voice. But she refused to be roused.

"And now that I have fulfilled my end of the bargain, it is time for you to fulfill yours," Modulok said, handing the Sword of Protection to Shadow Weaver. "I trust you know what to do?"

She took the sword with no small amount of disdain, for it and for him. "Indeed." As she gripped the handle, shadows began to swirl around the weapon, violently twisting around the blade. She gripped it tighter and tighter as her powers continued to constrict it, causing a small crack to appear on its side.

This was enough to snap Adora out of her stupor. "What? Wait no! Shadow Weaver, don't" She struggled against her restraints, which likely would have held her even as She-Ra. "You can't! Please, I'm nothing without the Sword!"

“Exactly,” Shadow Weaver said coldly. The sword began to glow as its power leaked out, more and more cracks appearing in the metal. “Everything will be just as it was. Catra, Adora, and myself, a family once again. And She-Ra will be nothing more than a distant memory.”

With one final surge of power, the Sword of Protection shattered. Shards of its previously indestructible blade fell to the floor, followed by its handle, landing with a clatter. Shadow Weaver held onto the red runestone that had been fixed to its hilt. “Ah…the key to Etheria’s heart,” Modulok said, taking the jewel. “I truly cannot thank you enough, Miss Weaver.”

“Just leave, and don’t think of coming back,” said Shadow Weaver. “I’ve had quite enough of your machinations.”

“Yes, yes, you won’t see me again,” he said, turning his back. Double Trouble moved to follow him, offering a smug grin back at the others. “Feel free to use this facility as you see fit. Create more of your children, grow new bodies for yourself when you grow old, whatever you choose. I, on the other hand, shall now go to fulfill my destiny.”

Just as he was about to leave, he found that Entrapta was standing in his way. “Etheria’s heart,” she said. “You need that to… to unlock the Heart of Etheria, don’t you? That’s all that you needed me for, isn’t it?”

He and Double Trouble both got an annoyed look. “As I already explained, that is indeed the case. Now, you are more than welcome to come join me, or stay here with your friends, or return home as you please. But I’m afraid if you stand in my way, I will have to remove you. Do we have an understanding?”

“I don’t think we ever did,” said Entrapta, her voice hoarse. “You can’t activate the Heart, Modulok. Power like that, i-it’s too dangerous! With all the energy Etheria has collected over the years, it’d be enough to destroy–”

“To destroy an entire planet, yes, yes, what do you think I want it for!?” Modulok hissed, clearly growing impatient. “Now step aside, before I have you…removed.” His hand went down to a compact crossbow around his waist.

For a moment, he and Entrapta simply stared each other down. After a while, the latter seemingly gave way, her despair at being abandoned by a friend yet again leaving her unable to stand up to him. With a whimper, Entrapta walked over to Catra and Adora. “Just go,” she said, barely heard.

Modulok smirked. “A wise choice.” He and Double Trouble turned once more to leave. “Go and fetch Leech and Mantenna, will you? There remains the possibility that we will need some extra–

With a shout, Catra suddenly pounced atop him, raking her claws into his orange hide. Adora suddenly realized that Entrapta had undone her chains, everyone else too busy focusing on Modulok himself. “I’m so sorry about all of this!” she said, beginning to shut off Adora’s prison. “I had no idea what he was really after!” Adora was too shaken to reply.

Despite being in the process of being torn to shreds, Modulok was unfazed, as his body repaired itself as quickly as it was damaged. “Would you care to calm yourself?” he said, not even raising his arms. “You are only embarrassing yourself.”

“Don’t tell me to calm down!” she roared. “I’ll never calm down! Not until you and all your freaks are dead!” Catra’s clawing of the mutant was interrupted, as She-Ra suddenly grabbed her by the collar and hurled her away. After getting her bearings, she was surprised to see her. “What?”

‘She-Ra’ smiled, blinking to reveal red reptilian eyes. “Hey Catra!” In their new form, Double Trouble approached Catra to continue the fight, but they didn’t count on Catra’s resourcefulness. Realizing where she lay, she grabbed a shard of Adora’s blade, giving Double Trouble a nasty slash in the leg. “Aargh! Really!?” This threat momentarily occupied, she ran back over to Modulok.

“Back for another try?” he asked, almost amused. However, his tone changed significantly when Catra drove the shard into his shoulder. He let out a pained screech, noticeably not from his speaker, throwing Catra off. “Weaver! Control your pet!” he yelled, clutching his wound. Double Trouble ran over to help him, reverting to their base form.

Shadow Weaver seemed to be enjoying the struggle. “Now, Catra, you’ve had your fun,” she said, dark energy swirling around her. “It’s time to stop playing conqueror and come home, where you belong.”

In reply, Catra just laughed. “You seem nice and comfortable here, waiting and watching behind the scenes while we do all the work! Remember the last time we fought? I took you down. Handily. How do you think it’ll go after all this time, when I’ve been honing my claws for years?”

A veritable vortex of darkness appeared around Shadow Weaver. “Would you care to find out?” she asked. She sent a surge of dark magic towards Catra, who leapt out of the way.

Finally, Entrapta was able to disable the ring holding Adora. “Yes!” she shouted, catching her with her hair before she hit the ground. “Adora, speak to me! Are you alright?”

“I’m…not real,” she said, somberly looking down at her broken sword. “I’m just a copy. My whole life, it’s a lie.”

Shadows filled the room as the battle between Catra and Shadow Weaver escalated. “No, don’t think like that!” Entrapta said, picking up the Sword of Protection’s hilt and carrying Adora to safety. “Clone or not, you’re still you! It just matters that you’re Adora, and I’m sure everyone else at Brightmoon would agree!”

Brightmoon–Adora hadn’t even considered that. How would everyone else react when they found out what she was? Surely they wouldn’t think any less of her, right? Her pondering on the

matter would have to wait, though, as Entrapta stopped dead in her tracks.

"Oh dear…" Entrapta said quietly, backing away from something emerging from the shadows. The hulking form of Leech emerged, dripping saliva from all three of its mouths as it loomed over them.

Meanwhile, Double Trouble and Mantenna helped a frozen Modulok over to the portal. I don't understand this–why isn't it healing!?" he asked, still holding his wound. "It should have regenerated by now!"

"Relax, it's only a flesh-wound," Double Trouble said. "I'm sure you'll figure something out, you always do. Now, should we do anything about these upstarts?"

"No time. Emerald has undoubtedly begun her assault by now," he said, wincing as he began to activate the portal. "We must gain control of the Heart now, to avoid potential…complications from the princesses."

He, Mantenna, and Double Trouble disappeared through the portal, which closed behind them.

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Given how powerful the Heart of Etheria was, finding a way to access it was a matter of utmost importance. Hessonite was up to the task, dispatching all of her experts on all manners of science and technology to find a way into the Citadel. This, of course, meant that Pyrope was to stay behind.

"You know, I choose to believe Hessonite gave me this job due to my importance," she said, fanning herself as she reclined in the captain's chair of the *Crystallon* . "Surely only one as disciplined and focused as myself could handle such a momentous task!"

Meanwhile, Duchess was playing a game at one of the ship's consoles. "Uh-huh," she said absently.

Pyrope continued, believing she was being listened to. "Yes, and I was truly the only choice for the job! Why, on my watch, this ship is all but impenetrable!"

Almost as though she was listening in, Emerald chose that moment to bring the *Supermassive* out of warp. The Crystallon was already a fairly-sizable ship, but Emerald's dreadnought made it look like a skiff in comparison. The enormous vessel loomed over both the planet and the smaller craft, preparing to unleash death from above.

After a brief stunned silence, Pyrope dropped her fan before scrambling to activate the ship's defenses. "All hands, we have an enemy approaching from hyperspace!" she said, just barely staying calm. "Battle stations, immediately!"

"I, uh, don't think we're gonna be able to do much to that thing…" said Duchess, staring up at the ship that eclipsed their own. It didn't even seem to notice them, moving straight towards its target. Duchess and Pyrope realized with a start that Brightmoon was directly in its path.

From the bridge of the Supermassive, Emerald had her eyes fixed on the castle down on the surface, her face twisted into a manic grin. "Soon, Brightmoon will fall. Soon, the Crystal Gems will be crushed! Soon, *ultimate power will be mine!* Onwards, to the Heart of Etheria!" Little did she know, elsewhere on the planet, the mastermind behind her crusade had arrived, and has his eyes set on this prize as well.

# Collision Course

Chapter Summary

> The heroes struggle to survive as Modulok and Emerald make their final moves.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Twenty-Two: Collision Course

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Scorpia wasn't sure if it was the ship's size or stability that was to blame, but whatever the reason, their jump out of warp was very bumpy. She and Micah were jostled against the walls of the tiny craft, much to Mosquitor's silent amusement. "We're here," he announced.

The two picked themselves up. "I noticed," said Micah. A large space station had appeared before them, in orbit around the planet. "So, this is where Modulok's been operating from…"

"This is just one of many of Master Modulok's strongholds," Mosquitor gloated. "They are scattered all across the cosmos, lying in wait for–" He went silent, his eyes glancing between the monitor and the station. "Impossible."

"What? What's impossible?" asked Scorpia, slightly worried. "Are we too late? Did something go wrong?"

"...We aren't the first ones here," he said. "It seems that two other ships have already docked. And not only that, but there's some sort of commotion in the hangar." The screen showed footage of the Off-Colors doing battle with Catra's forces.

Scorpia immediately recognized them. “Hey, I know those guys! Those Gems work with Steven, who works with the Princess Alliance! Hey, Mosquito guy, is there anyone else on board?”

He groaned. “Of course there is. But I assume you mean anyone aligned with either of them.” He rewound the security footage, revealing two others present. Adora, and–

“Catra,” Scorpia whispered. The footage was blurry, but her silhouette was unmistakable. “Take this thing in. We have to land, now.” Her demeanor was uncharacteristically serious.

“What? There?” said Micah. “If we head into that fray, all eyes will be on us. Modulok will see us coming a mile away. No, we need to land in a different hangar, preferably one closer to him.”

Taking that as a direction, Mosquitor brought the craft down into a hanger on one of the upper floors. The engines had hardly stopped running when Scorpia was out the door, bolting for the lift. “You should probably go after her,” he said dryly.

Micah did indeed. “Scorpia! What’s gotten into you? I thought that was the woman who sent you to Beast Island in the first place! Why are you so concerned about her all of a sudden?”

Scorpia paused for a moment to turn back. “I-I don’t know! Look, I can’t explain it, but even after what she did to me, I just…I wanna make sure she’s okay! She was in a really bad place when I last saw her, and even though she’s done some really bad things, I can’t hold it against her! Now come on, we can look for her and find Modulok at the same time!” She bolted once more.

Although he wasn’t sure this was the best idea, Micah couldn’t help but admire her compassion. She had a point, too: this was a big facility, so finding both Catra and Modulok would take time. Before he followed after her, he cast a spell behind him, surrounding the ship (and Mosquitor) in an impenetrable field. “What in–!? What is the meaning of this!?”

"I can't have you warning your boss about us, now, can I?" Micah said, following after Scorpia. "Sit tight until we get back!"

Mosquitor banged on the shield a few times, before giving up and slumping back down in the seat. "Not the best day for Mosquitor…"

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The *Supermassive* had breached the planet's atmosphere. The titanic ship hung over Castle Brightmoon like a dark star, preparing to unleash its arsenal. From the balcony of the throne room, the Princess Alliance and Crystal Gems observed the threat.

"We all knew this day was coming," Glimmer said gravely. "And now that it's here, we can't afford to wait any longer." She teleported down to the courtyard, where Netossa and Spinnerella waited. "Activate defenses!"

Netossa collected herself, preparing to protect the castle from an aerial barrage. "You can do this, Darling," Spinnerella assured her. "Remember Mizar? This should be a cakewalk compared to that!"

"Maybe, but Skeletor didn't have high-yield siege turrets," Netossa pointed out. "Still…here goes nothing!" A surge of energy flowed from her body, forming a shield that solidified around the castle. A huge dome now protected it from attacks both from air and land.

The sight of this amused Emerald. "Do they really think their feeble princess magic is strong enough to withstand the full force of Homeworld's greatest war machine? Let's put that to the test, why don't we? Fire all weapons!" Every cannon at the front of the ship aimed down towards the shielded castle, unleashing a rain of plasma upon it. Torpedoes rocketed out of their tubes in droves, colliding against the force field. The *Supermassive* was strong, it was true, but so was Netossa.

Upon seeing her withstand the onslaught, Glimmer warped to the outer courtyard, where Frosta and Mermista were waiting. "Second layer, go!"

Mermista collected herself, and then collected just about all the water within the dome, pushing it up against the inside edge. Frosta then went to work, freezing it in place, while also creating pillars of ice to support it. A second dome now stood just underneath the first.

"They'll have a tough time getting in here now, that's for sure!" said Frosta. …But what are we supposed to do until then? We can't exactly fight them from in here."

"Reinforcements are on the way," Glimmer informed them, before warping back to the castle. Soldiers were preparing their armor and weapons in case the enemy got in, while the castle staff were being evacuated to below-ground. Everyone else was there as well, preparing to fight. "Your reinforcements *are* coming, right?" she asked Hordak.

He turned around, looking almost amused. "I haven't let you down before, and I don't intend to start now. Huntara has informed me that the entire Fright Zone aerial defense force is en route. I just hope it will be enough."

Missiles and cannon-fire continued to pound away at the shields. "It better be enough," Glimmer said quietly, before warping over to Bow. "How's the evacuation going?"

Bow watched as everyone who needed to was ushered into the underground passageways. "Everyone who wants to get out should be out in the next five minutes," he reported. "I just wish we had some way to stop Emerald's assault directly. If only we could get on that ship…"

"We won't need to," Glimmer said. To prove her point, she held up a Gem communicator to contact Hessonite. The screen came up, showing her and several other Gems standing before a massive First Ones structure. "Hessonite, tell me you've made some progress on the Citadel."

"We *have* made progress, though I doubt you'd be pleased to hear how much of it we've made," Hessonite said. She showed several of her Gems working to access the building's hidden entrances, though none of them had successfully been opened. "Luck permitting, we should have access to the Heart of Etheria in…oh, say, a few hours or so."

"We don't *have* 'a few hours or so!'" Glimmer hissed. "Emerald is here now, raining fiery death on us as we speak! Pick up the pace, otherwise we're all…we're…" She trailed off.

Hessonite held up a hand. "No need to worry. I'll contact Yellow Diamond, see if she can't spare an armada or two for us. Just hang in there a little while longer." She ended the call, leaving Glimmer and Bow in an uncertain situation.

"That…didn't sound too reassuring," Bow said. After a short pause, he took a step closer. "Glimmer, I know Castle Brightmoon is our home, but maybe…maybe we should all evacuate too. It's just a building, after all–we can still fight them if we live another day."

Glimmer pulled away. "No! I'm not giving up on this place! If we give up now, then everything my mom did would be for nothing! Besides, without the Moonstone, I wouldn't have any power." She looked like she was about to storm off…but didn't. Her angry expression softened, turning to one of sorrow and regret. "Have you…heard anything from Adora?"

Bow blinked. "How did you…?" He took out his trackpad. "Nothing yet. I'll try and contact her, though, and let her know what's going on."

"Good," Glimmer said with a nod. "In the meantime, let's focus on keeping this place in one piece." She teleported away once again.

Nearby, Connie geared herself up with armor, as did the other Gems. "Everybody, if there was ever a time to bring your A-game, it's now!" Bismuth announced. "This is just like the battle of the

Eurasian Front: the odds are stacked against us, the enemy has the skies, but if we stick to what we do best, we'll be able to pull out by the skin of our teeth!"

Peridot was trying and failing to fit a helmet over her hair. "Uh, I'll take your word for it," she said. "Hey, Steven! You gonna suit up here, or what?"

Unlike the others, Steven wore no armor and held no weapon. He simply sat on a crate nearby, forlorn. "Hmm? Oh, uh…I dunno. You guys don't really need me. Maybe I'll just go underground, hide with the others. I wouldn't want to hold you back."

"'Hold us back?' Steven, powers or not, you're still a member of this team, and this family," Garnet assured him. She sat down next to him. "We would all be lucky to have you with us for this battle. But if you really think you should leave, we won't force you to stay." Amethyst and Pearl appeared beside him as well, silently concurring with her.

Connie joined them. "You know…I know you've felt helpless since you lost your powers." She sat down beside him. "And I know you think using the Sword of Power was like a crutch for you. But even though you're afraid of what it might do to you, now of all times might be the time to take that risk."

"What? Connie, you've seen what I'm like when I'm He-Man," Steven said, horrified at the thought. "I almost killed somebody, twice! I can't risk losing control; not again. I can't be trusted with that kind of power!"

She pulled him in for a hug. "Steven, based on what you told us, Adam chose you. He didn't choose you because of your powers, or your fighting skills, he chose you because you're *you* . So what if you get angry from time to time? Everyone does! But you of all people know how to control that anger–better yet, how to direct it where it's needed. You think you can't control He-Man, but I think you just don't know how. We'll learn how, together, but not right

now. Right now is the time to lose control. Now is the time to let loose, and kick Emerald back to wherever she came from!"

Connie's pep talk was certainly unorthodox, but Steven could at least agree that he needed the Sword if he was going to help. "Okay," he said, standing up. "I don't like that sword, but if it means protecting my friends, I'll do what I have to."

"Just so long as you aren't forcing yourself to," said Pearl. "We would never ask you to stay and fight if you didn't want to."

It was around then that Lapis flew in from recon around the dome. "Hey, everyone? I think you'll want to see this," she said, landing in the courtyard.

"Wuh-oh. That doesn't sound good," said Bismuth. "What's goin' on?"

Lapis led the congregation outside, where numerous smaller craft had descended from the *Supermassive* . Shuttles carrying New Horde troopers landed around the castle, setting up weaponry in preparation for the shield's destruction. And to make matters worse, the ships joined their mothership in hammering the shield with gunfire, doing everything they could to weaken it as much as possible.

"This isn't good," said Perfuma. "We're surrounded on all sides! If our shields go down…"

"They *won't* go down," Jasper growled. "We're going to crush Emerald before that happens."

Bow found himself agreeing with Jasper. Unfortunately for them, there wasn't much they could do themselves. "Where are those reinforcements?" he wondered quietly. Hordak's armada was theoretically on its way, and Homeworld's fleet might or might not join them. His only other option was to contact Adora, and hope there was some way she could help them.

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Entrapta raced back into the room as shadow magic tore it apart. Not only was Leech hot on their tail, but Shadow Weaver and Catra fought with Catra, their battle wreaking havoc on the chamber. She carried Adora with her hair, hoping to get the girl to safety.

She skidded to a stop as a dark tendril cut off her route, changing direction just as Leech grabbed for her. Catra leapt off the wall towards her opponent as Entrapta fled. "You went from Hordak's pawn to Modulok's. Really moving up in the world, aren't you?" Catra sped in close for a claw slash, only to be forced back by a dark aura.

"I am nobody's pawn!" said Shadow Weaver, forming her shadows into a giant arm. It slammed down on Catra, who was just able to avoid the attack. "I was using Modulok, just as I was using Hordak to achieve my own ends! They were to be cast aside as soon as I no longer had any use for them–much like is the case with you!"

Catra felt a tangle of shadowy tendrils grab her by the ankles, pinning her down. She was then thrown across the room by a blast of dark energy, sending her crashing into the wall of cloning pods. Glass shattered and solution spilled over the floor as several incomplete clones landed beside her. Catra's anger was momentarily put on pause as the inert figures' uncanny resemblance to Adora disquieted her. Luckily, Shadow Weaver seemed to have the same reaction.

The masked woman just stared at the unfinished bodies, more than merely unnerved. Catra used this opportunity to hurl one of the bodies at her, throwing her thoroughly off her guard. Holding a shard of glass in one hand, Catra feinted a strike, slashing with her makeshift weapon just as Shadow Weaver moved to block. It left a sizable cut from her chest up to her shoulder–she roared in pained anger, the force of her magic pushing Catra back.

"Face it–you made me tougher than you'll ever be," Catra said, throwing the glass aside. Rather than blood, she noticed that

black, smoky shadows flowed from her wound. “That said, we could use you in the New Horde. Just say the word, and we can put all of this behind us.”

Still clutching her wound, Shadow Weaver glared up at Catra. “I told you…I’m nobody’s pawn!” Shadows from all over the room coalesced into her fist, which she drove down into the floor. A massive explosion rocked the room, tearing the ground apart and sending both of them falling to the level below.

The burst of magic knocked Entrapta off her feet, causing her to drop Adora as well. Scrambling to get up, she could hear Leech’s breathing as the titanic creature barrelled towards them. “Adora, get up!” she shouted. “I know you’re upset, but this is no time to–” She cried out as Leech grabbed onto her hair, pulling her towards it.

The monstrous mutant lifted her up, holding her inches away from its circular maw. She held her breath, certain she was seconds away from being eaten. But the creature only held her to observe her. Slowly but surely, she opened her eyes to see it regarding her with its beady own. For whatever reason, it seemed intrigued by her.

This intrigue lasted for only a second, as Leech suddenly released an angry hiss. After her initial shock, Entrapta looked down to realize that Adora had stabbed it with a piece of her sword. Though glad to see she was out of her funk, Entrapta’s joy was short-lived, as Leech turned towards her. “Thanks, Adora! Now run!”

Adora took a few steps back as Leech turned to face her, dropping Entrapta to the ground, who scrambled away. “Um, hey, maybe we could talk about this?” Leech hissed again as it lunged, with Adora narrowly rolling aside. “Okay, nevermind!” Looking around for anything else to use as a weapon, she spotted the discarded hilt of the Sword of Protection. Even though it was likely useless to her now, she wasn’t about to leave it behind.

Leech very quickly zeroed in on her once again, chasing her out of the cloning chamber into the halls of the station. With no real way to fight it at the moment, she figured she could at least lead it away from the others. If she was lucky, she'd lead it somewhere its bulk would give it a disadvantage.

"Entrapta? Entrapta!" In the chaos, the two of them had gotten separated. Adora looked around for her, but she seemed to have gone another way. "That's good, at least she's safe. I hope…" She hid in what appeared to be a maintenance closet, holding her breath as Leech passed by. After an agonizingly long time, he moved on to search elsewhere. "Alright, Adora, you've gotten yourself out of worse jams. There's gotta be something here I can use." A quick glance around the closet revealed nothing even remotely weapon-like. "Maybe if Bow was here, he could rig up a– Bow!"

In the chaos of the last few minutes, she had entirely forgotten about Bow's parting gift. She produced the mini-trackpad, which had thankfully remained undamaged throughout her ordeals. But just when she was about to contact him, the pad emitted a ringing noise that, despite not being that alarming itself, startled her with its suddenness. Bow was the one to contact her.

She tapped the screen, on which his face appeared. "Adora! I was worried you wouldn't have time to pick up!" There was an awkward pause. "...So, did you find your family?"

The sheer amount Adora had learned in this one day had almost left her completely despondent. She figured it would be best not to drop that all on Bow at one time. "Um…no. No, there's nobody here. It was all a trick." She suddenly gasped. "A trick by Modulok, who's after the Heart of Etheria! Bow, you all have to get down to the Citadel, quick!"

"Don't worry, don't worry, Hessonite's already taking care of it," he assured her. "Whoever Modulok is, I'm sure she can handle him." Adora wasn't so convinced. "And we…kinda have our hands full right now." He pointed the camera skyward, showing Emerald's

fleet bombarding the shielded castle. "I'm sorry about what happened there, but we could really use your help right now."

Adora wanted nothing more in that moment than to make a beeline for the hangar, fly back to Etheria, become She-Ra, and solve all of their problems in an instant. "I…I'm sorry, Bow. Before Modulok left, he…" She wordlessly let the camera fall, revealing the broken hilt of her sword.

There was a small gasp from Bow, followed by silence as it sank in. "Oh, Adora…" The hopelessness Adora had been trying to hold back now began to spread to Bow, even as he tried to fight it. She-Ra had always been a symbol of hope for the Rebellion, and now without her, that hope began to crumble as well. "We'll…we'll figure something out, I promise."

"Will we?" Adora asked. "I dunno how we move forward with this, Bow. Without my sword, I–"

"Is that her?" Glimmer suddenly appeared beside Bow on the screen. "Adora! You have to get back here, quick! We need your She-Ra strength to destroy Emerald's ship!" Bow grimaced, while Adora continued to stare at the floor. "Adora? …What?" Bow gestured towards the hilt. "...Oh. *Oh* ."

Bow tried to think of something to say. "This… It's okay, we can still make it. We don't know for sure She-Ra's gone. You'd say 'for the *honor* of Grayskull,' not 'by the *sword* of Grayskull,' right? Maybe that means you don't need the sword to transform. Have you tried?"

Adora briefly looked up from her stupor, holding the hilt aloft. "For the Honor of Grayskull." Nothing happened, and she let the remains of her sword fall to the floor. "I'm sorry, guys, but I can't help you anymore. My best bet is to stay on this station until I find some way to make myself useful, and–"

To the surprise of all three of them, Glimmer suddenly slapped the trackpad out of Bow's hands, sending it tumbling into the dirt. She

then sheepishly picked it back up. “Sorry. But I will not accept this from you, Adora! What happened to that girl who was willing to risk everything for what she believed in? Who, even before she became She-Ra, was capable of doing so much more with just her training than I could, even with my powers? *That’s* the girl we need right now! Whether She-Ra really is gone for good or not, that doesn’t matter–we still have *you* , Adora! So, are you going to let a setback like this get you down? Are you!?”

“No,” Adora said, startled by Glimmer’s sudden outburst.

“Good! Now get outta there, get back here, and blow up Emerald’s ship with nothing more than your know-how, your skills, and your sheer tenacity!”

Thoroughly reinvigorated, Adora jumped to her feet, tightly clutching the trackpad in one hand and the hilt in the other. “I will! Once I rendezvous with Lars and the others, Emerald and Modulok are through! See you both soon!”

The two of them were glad to hear that. “She’s back!” Bow declared. “We’ll hold the fort here until you’re done over there. Good luck!”

Just as Adora was about to end the call, Glimmer spoke up again. “Wait.” She sounded much less fired-up than before, looking away for a moment before looking back at Adora with genuine concern on her face. “Be careful.”

“I will, I promise,” Adora said, offering a small smile that Glimmer returned. The call ended, and she stepped out from the closet with newfound determination. “Now, I’ll need to find a way to bring this thing down. This station has to have a power plant, or a core, or something I can use against it–”

Her pondering was interrupted by a loud hiss. Leech had returned, and now stood at the end of the hallway. The creature began slowly lumbering towards her, apparently not regarding her as enough of a threat to charge.

“Or I can improvise by the skin of my teeth, that works too,” Adora said. She looked down at the sword’s hilt–had Bow been right? Was Grayskull really inside her all along? It sounded cheesy, but it also sounded like something Light Hope, the real one, would have told her. Holding the remains of the Sword of Power aloft, she recited the incantation with more vigor than she ever had before. “For the Honor of Grayskull!”

A silvery glow emanated from the hilt, but faded before it reached its usual brilliance. Despite her failure to transform, Adora could feel it within her. She-Ra wasn’t gone, just dormant. Perhaps things weren’t so hopeless after all.

This display made Leech rethink Adora’s threat level, hissing as it charged once again. She rolled to the side as its arms came down right where she had been standing, further leaping back as it wheeled around to face her. Though her weapon was marginally less effective now, she swung the hilt, smacking the creature in the face with it. Of course, this had no effect aside from making it angrier.

With a growl, Leech’s hand shot out with surprising speed, latching around Adora’s neck. She felt herself being lifted off her feet, the teeth from its secondary mouth feeling like needles against her flesh. She tried kicking at it and punching its arm, but the longer she stayed in its grasp, the weaker she felt. Much like its namesake, Leech was sucking the life out of her. Adora stopped fighting, and the hilt fell to the floor. Leech’s beady eyes stared into her very core as she struggled just to remain conscious…

The monster was rocked by an explosion against its back, dropping Adora to the ground and stumbling away. She used the distraction to snatch up the hilt, scrambling away from Leech and towards her rescuer. “Thanks for the assist, Entrap…ta…?”

“No problem!” Although Entrapta’s voice came from it, Adora found herself staring at what appeared to be a giant First Ones

robot, complete with armaments. “Oh, right, you probably don’t recognize Emily. I gave her some upgrades since last time!”

“...I see,” said Adora. Behind them, Leech had recovered from the missile, letting out an angry screech. “Let’s reminisce later–first, we have to take care of this guy!”

Emily’s cannons glowed as they prepared to fire. “Let’s do it!” Entrapta said.

– – –

*Minutes earlier…*

Entrapta was still reeling from Modulok’s betrayal. It had happened again. Just like so many before, someone she thought was her friend had decided to leave her behind. Hordak, Catra, even Peridot and Bow to a degree…was she cursed to have everyone she cared about leave her?

No. At the end of the day, she still had one friend she could count on. With no time to waste, she hurried towards the portal. With any luck, Emily hadn’t given up on her yet. She input the coordinates to Ophidia and headed through to Modulok’s base.

Instantly, she noticed that things were different. They had been gone for just over an hour, and it looked like the place had been completely ransacked. “Hello?” she called out, wondering if whoever had been here still was. Maybe the locals had finally found this place. Or was Modulok just very intent on covering his tracks? Either way, even though there was no answer, she had a feeling she wasn’t alone.

As she crept through the ruined laboratory, she kept hearing skittering from just outside her vision, thoroughly unnerving her. Leech and Mantenna were creepy enough, who knew what else Modulok had cooked up in his free time? Ideally, she would be out of here before she had the chance to find out.

"Emily? Emily, are you here?" As hopeful as she was, no telltale beeps or boops replied. She headed further towards the entrance. "I know I'm probably the last person you want to see right now, but…" Entrapta began to worry that her old friend had left for greener pastures. She had basically left her for her 'new friends,' after all.

This thought caused Entrapta to pause. Yes, Modulok and Catra had thrown her aside, but hadn't she done the same to *her* friends? She had joined the Horde without even letting the Princess Alliance know she was still alive. Bow had reached out to her, and all she did was double down. And when Hordak had disappeared, she didn't even try to find him–not hard enough, anyway. What if she was the one who kept abandoning her friends, and not the other way around?

Upon being hit with this realization, she fell to the floor, slumping against the wall. "This whole time, I've been a bad friend," she lamented. "All I do is leave the people who care about me, and help the ones who hurt them." She hugged her knees close to her chest, wrapping herself in her hair.

Entrapta would have been content to just stay there for the foreseeable future, but a clicking sound coming from a darkened room before her made her look up. She realized, with a start, that something was crawling closer. One of Modulok's monsters: it may have been a person at some point, but its multiple limbs and hundreds of teeth jutting out of its mouth made any resemblance incidental at best now. Her pigtails tightened their grip as the monstrosity crawled closer, leaping into the air to pounce.

Shutting her eyes tight, Entrapta waited to feel its teeth. Instead, a familiar rapport filled the air, and the creature screeched as it was blasted aside. Looking in the direction of the sound, Entrapta was overjoyed to see…

"Emily!" she cried, jumping to her feet and running over to embrace the large mecha. Crouching due to the low ceiling, Emily returned the hug as best she could. "I can't believe you're still

here! I-I thought you would've left me! I…wouldn't have blamed you if you had…" She looked away guiltily.

Emily replied to her master with a series of beeps and boops.

"You think so?" asked Entrapta, looking up hopefully. "I don't know if any of them would want anything else to do with me…"

More electronic noises, accompanied by a series of gestures.

Entrapta slowly began to beam. "Maybe you're right. I have to make this right, either way! I have to be a *real* friend in order to find out!" She looked into the machine's lone optic. "...Thank you, Emily. For believing in me. You really are the best pal I ever could've programmed!"

Emily responded with a humble gesture, only to suddenly go on alert. More monsters were on their way, having been freed when Modulok destroyed the cave. She quickly opened up, motioning for Entrapta to hop in.

And hop in she did, taking the controls with glee. "You're not taking over the planet on my watch!" she shouted, unleashing Emily's weapons on the approaching mass of tentacles, claws, and other lethal features. Missiles and hot plasma tore through the horde, sending what little of the base was left crumbling around them. But as the two of them pushed through the wreckage, they saw that the portal was still intact. "Come on, Emily–let's go save Etheria!"

Chapter End Notes

> The board is set. The pieces are in motion. The end approaches.

# Eclipse

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Entrapta struggle to escape from Modulok's trap, while Steven, Glimmer, and Bow set out to reach the Citadel themselves. Meanwhile, Catra duels with Shadow Weaver, and Modulok arrives on Etheria.

Chapter Twenty-Three: Eclipse

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Emerald was, to nobody's surprise on either side, growing angrier and angrier. "What is the hold-up!?" he yelled, still looking down at the barrier protecting Brightmoon. "We have superior numbers, superior technology, *and* superior firepower, but their defenses *still* stand!? How is this possible!?"

"T-they have powerful magic at their disposal, My Emerald!" a Nephrite said, shying away from her commander. "I recommend we wait and rely on our fighters to wear them down before we–"

But Emerald was not interested in excuses, shoving her aside. "Unless someone has an *actual* solution, I recommend we *keep firing* ! All weapons at maximum output, until we break through that shield!" Not wanting to anger her further, the Gems under her command did as they were told.

However, one Peridot spoke up, seeing something that should be brought to her attention. "My Emerald! We're detecting numerous craft approaching from the east! It appears that the Old Horde has deployed fighters to aid Brightmoon. How should we respond?"

Predictably, this news made Emerald even angrier. But rather than lash out, she simply placed a hand over her eyes. "How about we intercept them? Would that be too obvious? Do it, now!"

Further ships were deployed from the *Supermassive* , scrambling to engage the incoming enemies. Soon, the skies above Castle Brightmoon were filled with swarms of ships, explosions, and gunfire. But despite all of that, the shield held strong, refusing to go down. Emerald refused to go down either, ordering her troops to keep firing, no matter what.

"Aerial forces are wearing thin, My Emerald," reported a Citrine. "Should…should we begin charging the nova cannon?"

Emerald stared down at the shield. "Not yet," she decided. "If the shield survives *that* , we'll be more or less dead in the water. Keep wearing it down further." She reclined in her captain's chair, watching the battle play out with a predatory eagerness. "But when I give the signal…charge away."

Within the shield dome, Netossa was doing all she could to keep the barrier in place. Even with Hordak's fleet driving away some of the smaller ships, several shuttles still battered her net, as did ground forces. Glimmer knew that their only hope of stopping her lie with the Heart of Etheria.

So there she stood, just at the edge of the shield. The Citadel was only a short trek away, and with a little luck, they would be able to reach it before Brightmoon fell. "Are you sure this is the best idea?" asked Bow, standing beside her. "Brightmoon's in danger. Shouldn't the queen stay here to defend it?"

"Has Hessonite responded?" Glimmer asked.

"Well…no, but–"

"Then something went wrong." She looked up at him. "Bow, even with all of us together, we don't stand a chance against that ship. We can't wait around for Hessonite to activate the Heart at the last minute, or for Adora to drop in from above and save the day. If we want to stand any chance of surviving, we have to go. And the less of us drawing attention to ourselves, the better."

Bow was hesitant, of course, as he felt that just the two of them going was risky. But he had faith in Glimmer's power, and his tech. "Then let's go. We can't risk waiting any longer."

Glimmer took him by the hand, feeling his warmth against hers, and prepared to warp them to the other side. However, a familiar voice caused her to pause. "Got room for one more?" They turned around, and there was Steven, holding the Sword of Power in his hands. "Because I'm ready if you are!"

Three wasn't that much more than two, but could make all the difference if they got into a scrap. Not to mention, He-Man could provide a definite advantage. Glimmer held out her other hand, which Steven took. In a flash of light, they all stood outside of the barrier. The sounds of explosions filled the air as Emerald's forces hit it with everything they had. Hopefully, nobody would notice them amid the chaos.

"Here's the plan: we make our way to the Citadel, and I'll try and teleport us inside. Once we get down to the Heart, Bow will figure out how to activate it, we shoot down Emerald's ship, and restore peace to the galaxy. Any questions?" Glimmer said.

"Uh, one," Bow said. "Even leaving aside my capacity to get the Heart working, are you sure you can teleport us into the Citadel? If it's First Ones, they might have some sort of defenses against that."

"I guess we'll just have to wait and see," said Glimmer, as they made their way underneath the sky full of ships.

Steven, though he pressed on, had his doubts. Not just about their plan, but about their entire situation. "And if we can't? I know you're evacuating everyone, but you do have a plan in case Emerald wins, right? Some way to regroup with everyone?"

For a few moments, Glimmer was silent. "If Emerald destroys Brightmoon, she'll destroy the Moonstone along with it. And if that happens…I won't deserve to be the queen. Not only because I'll

be the only princess to have lost my powers, but because I let my kingdom down. And I will not allow that to happen."

"Glimmer, even *if* Emerald wins, and she hasn't won yet, it won't be because you let us down. We're all fighting our absolute hardest, you especially. It's just that sometimes…sometimes these things happen." He trailed off, only to realize how somber his tone had become. "But as long as we give it everything we have, I'm sure everything will turn out alright! Right, Steven?"

"Yeah, of course!" said Steven, though he didn't sound quite sure. "Just go in there, turn it on, and everything's great!" His forced smile slowly gave way to a ponderous frown. "Um, you don't happen to know what the Heart of Etheria actually *does* , do you? I mean, more specifically than just being a weapon. Because a weapon that's built out of a whole planet…that's a pretty big weapon. You guys probably don't know what the Death Star is, but what if the Heart of Etheria is a giant gun made for shooting other planets?"

"Then it should be more than capable of destroying Emerald's ship," said Glimmer, undeterred. "Look, with a gun that size, she'll probably back down without us even needing to fire it. We will if we *need* to, but just having it should be enough."

They continued walking in silence for a while, until Bow stopped in his tracks. He raised an ear to the sky–"Do you hear that?" he asked.

Steven and Glimmer both listened, but heard nothing. "Hear that?" the former asked.

None of them were prepared when a Gem dropship sped overhead. It turned back once it passed the trio, opening its side doors once it was just above them. Instead of Rubies or Quartzes, several Horde cybertroops fell, weapons engaging upon hitting the ground.

“That, I can hear!” said Glimmer, warping them out of the way of the incoming blasts. The cybertroops took a moment to zero in on them again, firing on them as they hid behind a tree. “Spread out!”

As she warped away, Bow dove out from behind cover, piercing one straight through the optic with an arrow. Before they could fire on him, Glimmer appeared between the closest two, blasting them apart with beams of light. She teleported on top of another, disappearing before it was riddled with shots from its fellows. And in the midst of all this, Steven continued to hide.

“You can do this, Steven–they’re just robots,” he assured himself. “They aren’t like Catra’s Horde posse. This should be a walk in the park! Just gotta take it slow…” He peered out around the tree, only for a cybertroop to fire, sending him ducking back to safety. “Nevermind, just go, go!” He ran out as fast as he could go, avoiding further laser-fire as he closed the distance between him and it.

Steven swung the sword with all his might, aiming to cut off the robot’s legs. Although he hit his target, it failed to cut all the way through, embedding in the metal. Thankfully, he was able to use this to his advantage, toppling it before it could fire by yanking the blade out. Before it could get up, he held the sword aloft and swung it down forcefully, cleaving through the cybertroop’s head and putting it out of commission.

But one victory was hardly enough, as more cybertroops continued to drop down from the ship. “We need to take down that dropship!” called Bow. “I don’t have any arrows strong enough to put a dent in it!”

“Leave that to me!” Glimmer replied. She vanished, and in an instant she was onboard the vessel. She demolished a few surprised machines with a burst of energy, before moving onto the ship’s computer, repeatedly blasting away at it.

Back on the ground, Bow was holding off the remaining cybertroops as best he could, but with their sheer numbers, there was only so much he could do. Exploding arrows and slime arrows put them down handily enough, but net arrows and the like were mere nuisances. He retreated to cover, firing off the occasional shot as he hid from their shots. "Steven! Meet with Glimmer at the Citadel!" he shouted. "I'll hold them off!"

"But what about you?" Steven cried back, similarly taking cover. "You're gonna run out of arrows before long!"

"I'll be fine–go, before they surround us!" One of the cybertroops reached the tree, grabbing Bow to pull him out into the open. He swept its legs out from under it, before driving an arrow into its optic before firing it at another. "Brightmoon is doomed unless you do something!"

Brightmoon was doomed…unless Steven did something. He looked down, examining his reflection in the Sword of Power. He was afraid of what would happen if he lost control as He-Man again, of the people he could hurt if he transformed. But now, all he could think about was all the people who would be hurt if he *didn't* transform. It seemed that if there was ever a time to lose control, it was now. "By the Power of Grayskull!"

The cybertroops had shot the tree so many times, it was about ready to fall over. Bow held fast, waiting for the right moment to leap out and strike. But with so many cybertroops, all firing in tandem, there might not be a right moment. Knowing the tree would fall soon, he prepared his last explosive arrow, hoping to take out as many of them as he could. Instead, almost all of the cybertroops were torn apart as a large projectile sliced through them: Steven's sword.

Bow watched as the sword raced back the way it came, destroying yet more cybertroops on its way back into its owner's hand. He-Man leapt into the air, crushing another beneath him and knocking more back with the shockwave. "We'll hold them off together!" he shouted, blocking their fire with his blade.

Bow just smiled, glad to see help had arrived. He hurried to his companion's side, firing off more arrows at the remaining machines. Between the two of them, they were able to handily dispatch the rest of the cybertroops, while the dropship above them had begun to smoke as Glimmer worked her magic.

With its navigational systems thoroughly sabotaged, the ship careened towards the ground in a spiral. Glimmer warped away before it hit the ground, exploding and taking out any cybertroops that remained within. Once she landed, she looked up triumphantly at her accomplishment…but something else caught her eye instead, something quite worrisome.

He-Man and Bow hurried over. "Glimmer, that was awesome!" said the former–despite his newfound bulk, he was still Steven. "...Wait, what's that look for? What's wrong?"

They had arrived at the Citadel. But instead of seeing Hessonite and her crew, as was expected, it was eerily silent. None of the Gems were present–it was as though they had all suddenly abandoned the place. The only sign they had been there was Demantoid's limb enhancers. "What…happened here?" asked Bow.

"Nothing good," Glimmer replied. "Come on." She led the three up to the wall, focusing to try and find the right spot to warp into. "If I can just find somewhere hollow, I can–"

Her attention, as well as that of the other two, was suddenly drawn to a section of the wall with grooves that glowed red. It was just the right size and shape to be a door; and seeing as it seemed to have reacted to their presence, glowing brighter as they got closer. "Huh. Did it do this before?" asked Steven.

Bow looked closer. "I've never seen it do anything like this," he said. As he looked between the glowing grooves and the group themselves, a hypothesis came to his mind. "...Steven? Can you hold up the sword for a minute?"

"Sure, but I don't know what…woah." As he held up the Sword of Power to the door, the glowing intensified. "That's new. Uh, can you open for me?"

The three of them were surprised when a female voice responded. "Administrator detected. Opening access shaft." The door slid open, revealing a circular platform in the center of a small room.

"I…I think that's the way to the heart," said Glimmer. With no time to waste, she stepped inside. "Well? Are you coming, or what?"

The two of them stepped onto the platform beside them. "I don't like this," said Bow. "What happened to Hessonite? Did everyone already head down here? Or did someone else get to her before us? We could be walking right into a trap."

"Only one way to find out," said Steven. The door shut behind them.

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Light pulsed through the chamber as energy flowed through a series of tubes. This had the disconcerting effect of giving Catra a half-second of sight, followed by a second of near-blindness. But her eyes were keen, and her ears were even keener. She easily pushed the rubble aside, readying her claws.

"Just going to run away again?" she asked into the darkness, her head on a swivel for her foe. "You never could back up your talk! As soon as things got tough, you ran away to hide behind someone bigger and badder than you! This time, you've got nowhere to hide!"

A shadowy tendril shot out from the blackness, smacking Catra across the cheek. "And you are the same insolent little miscreant you've always been!" Shadow Weaver said from the darkness. Her voice seemed to echo all throughout the tunnels, giving Catra no chance to pin down her location. "Always attaching yourself to the strongest you could find–Adora, Hordak, Emerald–only to

inevitably betray them. If I'm as power-hungry as they say, then you truly are your mother's daughter!"

More shadows swirled around her, but this time she was ready. Leaping and dodging their strikes, she moved like an acrobat, using the walls and cables like springboards and handholds. She watched as the streams came at her, trying to figure out where they were coming from. Eventually, she saw a flicker of a familiar silhouette just beyond a wall–she leapt in that direction, slashing with her claws.

She caught fabric, and nothing more. Shadow Weaver had moved just in time for Catra's claws to barely graze her robes. "You call yourself my mother–when have you done *anything* motherly!?" Catra shouted, swiping in every direction as Shadow Weaver disappeared and reappeared over and over again. "When were me and Adora anything more than tools to you? Just dolls for you to mold and reshape however you saw fit! To make into smaller versions of *you* !"

Shadow Weaver thrust out her hand, blowing Catra back with a blast of dark wind. "As if you could ever be me!" she hissed. "You should be thankful I took you both in! Without me, you and Adora would be nothing more than cogs in the machine! Pawns to Hordak, with no worth aside from what throwing your life away could bring him. Thanks to me, you rose above all of that! Everything you are, you owe to *me* !" Darkness began swirling around her, blanketing the already-dim lights.

Catra tried once more to leap aside, but Shadow Weaver was too quick. Tendrils of shadow latched onto her arms and legs, keeping her firmly planted on the ground. They pulled her down still, until she was forced onto her knees. Her mother-slash-tormentor glided closer, looming over her, though Catra refused to be intimidated. She glared up at her captor, not needing to speak a word.

"Do you know what I think?" asked Shadow Weaver, lowering herself closer to Catra's eye level, but still remaining above it.

"You need someone to blame for everything that goes wrong in your life. *Adora* was the one who betrayed you, not the other way around. All of your losses were due to Scorpia's incompetence…or Entrapta's, or Hordak's, or Emerald's, or whoever you happened to have attached yourself to at the time. And because you can't fathom your successes going to someone else, you blame me for every one of your shortcomings. But despite all of that, I forgive you. In spite of your shortcomings, I want nothing more than the three of us to be a family again. Come with me, Catra. Come and be part of my family again."

"I never want anything to do with you again!" Catra hissed, pulling against the shadows that bound her. "Nothing about us was ever a family! I…I…never had a family…" Her anger faded away, replaced with a look of regret. "Without Adora, everything is so… empty…" She went completely still, a thousand-yard stare on her face. "There's nothing…"

Shadow Weaver's victory was assured. As Catra sank into despair, she dissipated the tendrils, confident that she had thoroughly broken the girl. "You don't have to be," she said, reaching down to brush the hair from her eyes. "Help me get Adora back, and the two of you can be together again."

As soon as Catra felt Shadow Weaver's hand upon her, it was her turn to smirk in victory. "I will…but first…" She sprang upwards, her claws slicing into Shadow Weaver's mask. The force of the attack threw her backwards, the remains of her mask falling down to the floor. She roared in rage, clutching her hand over her face. Readying another strike, the balance of power had shifted. "...I'll deal with you."

"You…you…" Shadow Weaver's voice quavered as she trembled with fury. "You ungrateful *wretch* !" She rose up in a blast of darkness, causing Catra to fall back for two reasons. The first was her magic, but the second lay in her appearance: her face had all but rotted away, looking like that of a corpse. Her eyes seemed to be red with blood, her with pupils in the shape of diamonds. She

continued to roar and gnash her teeth as she hurled her shadows all over the room.

After the initial shock of the sight, Catra hid her disturbance quite well. “No wonder you wear a mask!” she said, leaping out of the way of her dark tendrils. A few that grew too close for comfort, she sliced apart with her claws. “At least now you’re as twisted and rotten on the outside as you are inside!”

Gone were Shadow Weaver’s strikes from the shadows, as she was now going all out to crush her adoptive daughter, all affection for her forgotten. “You can’t hide from the truth! If you continue on your path, you’ll end up just as ugly as *me* ! Stand down, or it will be by my hand!” Darkness lashed all around her, turning the room into a localized hurricane. Catra was certain that the tendrils had become grasping hands, and the flashes of light were eyes gazing on their battle from afar.

“And the truth comes out!” Catra said. “For all your talk of loving us, all your talk of wanting to make us stronger, you’re nothing more than a bitter old woman, blindly grasping at whatever sort of power you can find!” Using the swirling shadows to her advantage, Catra was able to close the distance between them. “You say you made me who I am, but you know what? You didn’t. *I* did!” She launched herself at Shadow Weaver, thrusting her claws forward. They hit their mark, piercing deep into her target.

Shadow Weaver gasped and groaned, her magic slowly beginning to fade. Looking down, he found that Catra’s claws extended from her chest, embedded deep within. She wasn’t the only one surprised by this, as Catra herself seemed to not believe what she just did. The two sat in silence for some time, until she fell to her knees. With her dying breaths, she lifted a hand to her daughter’s face. “Look at how far you’ve come…my Catra…”

Her arm fell to her side, and she began to dissolve. Shadow Weaver’s body faded away into a cloud of black dust, blown by an unfelt wind into the air. The dust spread upward and outward,

eventually fading from sight. All that was left of her was her mask, and even that, too, crumbled into the same black dust.

Catra had been sure that finally killing Shadow Weaver would have filled her with triumph. And while she was triumphant, to be sure, she also couldn't help but feel sorrow. With everything that woman had done, how could she still feel for her? But there was no easy way to forget your mother. Catra swallowed her tears–there would be time to mourn later. Preferably when she had forgotten her sympathy.

But it seemed things were not yet finished. Just as Catra was about to leave to find Adora, she noticed that the pulsing lights of this chamber had become erratic. The tubes carrying energy had begun to dissolve as well, becoming the same black dust that Shadow Weaver had. As they did, the energy began to leak out, sparking and flashing as more and more of the tubes rotted away. This was certain to have disastrous consequences for the rest of the station.

"You couldn't just die and be done, you had to get one last shot in," Catra muttered. Change of plans: Adora could wait, her new priority was getting off this station. She quickly made her way towards the nearest hangar–hopefully it, or one near it, would have a ship for her to commandeer.

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Although Emily had Leech beat when it came to size, the mutant was still remarkably strong. Both of her enormous guns glowed with heat as they poured plasma into the halls, but even the shots that didn't miss had barely any effect on its thick hide. Even though close-quarters strikes with her arms fared better, Leech was far too sturdy to be put down with just a few swings.

"Adora, I just wanted to say I'm *really* sorry about how all of this turned out!" said Entrapta, multitasking. "I thought Modulok was my friend! I had no idea he was going to break your sword and

use it to take over the universe! He tricked me! …Probably because I wanted to believe him…"

Glimmer's words had reinvigorated Adora. Even without the power of She-Ra, she fought with all the might and dexterity her Horde training had afforded her. She still didn't stand much chance of defeating Leech, but with Emily, they were able to keep him on the defensive. "Don't worry, I forgive you!" she replied, mostly because of the situation they were in, though she still didn't hold it against her. "When we get outta here, I'm sure you can more than make up for it!"

From inside her mech, Entrapta lit up. "You really think so? I'll do whatever I can to help!" She suddenly cried out at the sight of Leech's mouth clamping down on the viewscreen. Emily's arms grabbed the mutant, attempting to pry it off. "So, aside from everything, how are you?"

"Oh, y'know, hanging in there!" Adora had climbed onto Leech's back, trying to stick what remained of her sword under his mouth as a lever. "I'll tell you all about it once we're safe back on Etheria!" Leech grabbed her, and she felt her energy draining before being tossed aside.

Something similar was happening with Emily. "Uh, m-my battery reserves are declining far more rapidly than they should!" Entrapta announced. The mech's arms fell to its side as Leech deprived Emily of her power. She stumbled back and fell, unable to so much as stand anymore.

Adora knew that the mutant wouldn't just stop at Entrapta's machine. If she was going to do something, it had to be now. "For the Honor of Grayskull!" she shouted, holding the hilt aloft. The broken sword glowed silver at her declaration, but the light soon began to fade. "No, no! For the Honor of Grayskull! For the Honor of Grayskull! Please, c'mon, work! For the Honor of freakin' Grayskull!" But she just couldn't muster up the power to transform.

Leech continued to tear into Emily's fallen form, intent on reaching Entrapta. "Okay, let's review our options," she said worriedly. "Backup power has failed. Ejection seat has failed. It looks like we're dead in the water here!" The hatch at the front slowly opened, pried apart by Leech. Entrapta could only watch in horror, staring into its lifeless eyes, as Adora crawled her way over.

But just as things seemed hopeless, there was a light in the dark–almost literally. Following a cry of "There they are!" a bolt of magic streaked through the air, colliding with Leech and freeing Entrapta. Both of the fighters looked down the hallway, and it was safe to say neither expected their rescuer to be who it was.

"Scorpia!?" said Adora. The large woman sprinted down the hall, accompanied by a bearded man holding a staff. "You're alive!?"

"She's alive!" cried Entrapta, pulling herself free from Emily's wreckage. "Scorpia, it's me, Entrapta! I can't tell you how glad I am to see you again! When Catra had you sent to Beast Island, I thought I'd never see you again, and I…probably should have said something, but…" She trailed off, overcome with guilt.

For her part, Scorpia held nothing against her. "I missed you too! But what do you say we save the reunion for after we beat this guy?" Leech was back on his feet, staring down the four. It let out a hiss and charged, grappling with Scorpia.

Micah helped Adora up, getting her to safety. "You must be Adora," he said. "Scorpia's told me a lot about you. And let me just say, thank you for being such a friend to my little girl."

"Uh, don't mention it," she replied. She had no idea who he was talking about. "Wait, you're not Catra's dad, are you? 'Cause that would be…wait…King Micah!?" Looking closer, she saw the resemblance between him and Glimmer. "You're not dead?"

He grinned. "Reports of my death were greatly falsified." Using his magic, he pried open Emily's doors, allowing Entrapta to escape. "You can thank Modulok for that."

The mention of Modulok snapped Adora out of her shock. "Modulok! He's on his way back to Etheria–he'll probably already be there by now! We have to head back to stop him!"

Scorpia was then violently hurled into Emily, who Entrapta had thankfully departed. "Okay…this guy is one tough…bug? Fish? What is he supposed to be, anyway?" Leech leapt at her again, though she rolled aside. It landed on Emily, who gave an indignant chirp.

"Don't worry, girl, I'll fix you up!" Entrapta assured her. "Scorpia, look out!"

Leech had torn off one of Emily's guns, before hurling it at Scorpia. She blocked it with her claws, though the impact was still enough to send her skidding against the wall. "You two get to safety–we'll handle him!" said Micah, readying his staff.

Adora didn't exactly like the idea of letting them fight it alone, but without her sword, she was better suited to getting Entrapta out of harm's way. "Got it!" The two ducked into a nearby room, watching the battle from relative safety.

Casting a series of spells, Micah summoned a flurry of chains that shot up from the floor. These chains wrapped around Leech, binding it in place. "Now, it's all you!"

In response to this, Scorpia began to channel her energy. Shadows from within the hallway surged into her, and began to coat her form. She grew bigger, filling out as multiple legs appeared at her side. Red armor covered her body, and her transformation into a giant scorpion was complete.

Both Entrapta and Adora were shocked. "Did…did you know she could do that?" Adora asked. But Entrapta was too stunned to reply.

With one of her massive claws, Scorpia grabbed Leech and slammed it against the wall in one swift motion. This was not enough to defeat the mutant, however, as it began prying her

claw open to escape. She repeatedly bashed it into the wall again and again, but it soon was free of her grip. It ran down the length of her body, leaping over her tail towards Micah.

"Micah, watch out!" Adora shouted. She ran out to help him, despite having no weapon. Micah shot a magic projectile at the incoming beast, but it had no effect–it was almost as though Leech had absorbed it. It grabbed him by the neck, lifting him into the air. "Let him go!" Adora struck it with what remained of her sword, but she too found herself being lifted by the neck. Both of them were slowly drained of their will to struggle as Leech siphoned their energy.

Before it could hiss in triumph, Scorpia's stinger pierced it from behind. It dropped the two to the ground as it screeched in pain, feeling the venom pumping through it. But despite the wound, it managed to reach back and remove the stinger, turning around to face Scorpia. Before she could strike again, it darted past her claws and latched its mouth onto her head.

Scorpia raised her tail to strike again, only for it to suddenly feel much heavier. In fact, even just holding herself up was becoming difficult. As her energy continued to be drained, she collapsed to the floor, her new form evaporating. She couldn't even hold herself up, and Leech still continued to drain her. "Stop it…get off…" she said, barely audible.

Just as it seemed she was about to black out, Leech was hit from behind by a blast of plasma. Entrapta had managed to fire off one of Emily's guns, distracting it from Scorpia just in time. But she only had one shot in her–the mech was all but spent. Leech hissed angrily, but knew she was not a threat, turning back to its current prey.

In that short moment, with Leech distracted, Scorpia gathered up all her remaining strength, lifting her tail into the air. She waited, holding for just the right moment. And then, when Leech turned back around, and she saw into its spiral of teeth, she struck with everything she had.

Leech had opened wide to drain what little remained of Scorpia's energy, only to get a stinger shot into its maw. The pointed tip emerged from the back of its neck, having pierced straight through. The pair were still for a moment, before Leech shuddered, and finally fell to the ground. Scorpia simply lay back, recuperating now that the danger had passed.

But while this danger had passed, the crisis was far from over. Adora and Micah slowly worked up the strength to stand, while Entrapta ran over to Scorpia. "You did it! You save us all!" She leapt down to hug her, both with her arms and her pigtails. "And you turned into a giant scorpion! How did you *do* that!?"

"Well, I am a princess," she said, getting to her feet. "It just took a little longer for me to connect with my Runestone."

"While I wish this was the time for celebration, Modulok is still out there," said Micah. "Whatever he's planning, I have a feeling it's finally coming to fruition."

"He's after the Heart of Etheria," Adora said. "Apparently, it's some kind of ancient First Ones weapon that only She-Ra can access. I don't know exactly what he wants it for, but when has a bad guy wanting a superweapon ever turned out well?"

Scorpia pounded her claws together. "Well then, let's go put a stop to his plan! With the four of us together, we're practically unstoppa–"

The entire station shook, trembling like an earthquake. "Uh, I'm no space expert, but that didn't sound good," Adora said. "We should get going, right Entrapta? …Entrapta?"

The scientist looked quite worried after that tremor. "Did you all feel that?" she asked.

"...How couldn't we?" said Micah.

"No, I mean, feel how the artificial gravity shifted! Whatever caused that quake, it shifted us on our axis, and now we're on a

decaying orbit!”

“And…what does that mean?” Scorpia asked, even though she had a sneaking suspicion she already knew.

Entrapta wore a grave expression. “It means we have to leave. Now.”

– – –

The Citadel was an imposing sight, even for Gems who were used to towering constructions. It was by and large the biggest structure on all of Etheria, despite having no visible means of entry. Gems of all sorts scoured the exterior, searching for a way to gain access, but so far they had little luck.

Demantoid oversaw the project, staring intently at a holographic model of the Citadel. She didn’t notice Hessonite trying to get her attention, only looking away when the latter turned off the display. “Is this important? I believe we were making real progress,” she said.

“That was Glimmer,” Hessonite said. “Emerald’s begun her attack on Brightmoon. We’ll have to move fast if we want any chance of stopping her. Please tell me you’re close to reaching the Heart.”

“While we are no closer to reaching the Heart of Etheria than when we started, we have made significant progress concerning opening the Citadel.” Hessonite was unimpressed. “I have managed to isolate several doors, however the issue lies in getting them to open. We will need to connect with the structure directly, which will require a device compatible with both Gem and First Ones technology that does not currently exist. Give me five minutes.”

Hessonite hid her concern. She trusted Demantoid, but now was not the time to show off. “Five minutes may very well be all we have,” she said. “Hurry. The longer we wait, the more time Emerald has to–” She suddenly froze. Silently creeping closer to the Citadel, she summoned her weapon. “Did you hear that?”

“Hear what?” asked Demantoid, raising an eyebrow. “It is silent. There is nobody…here…” She realized the problem.

The two of them looked around. A moment ago, there had been dozens of Gems hard at work all around them. But now, it seemed like it was only them. “Stay alert,” Hessonite said, readying her saber to strike. “Whatever did this had the element of surprise–keyword being ‘had.’”

A rustle in some nearby bushes put the pair on high alert. Demantoid’s mechanical arms began to whir and hum as they prepared to fire at the unknown interloper. Hessonite slowly crept over, reaching out to pull the underbrush aside, her sword in place to strike. With one swift motion, she cleared it away…and there was nothing.

“Clearly, we are being toyed with,” Demantoid said. “I suggest we call for backup before we–”

She didn’t get the chance to finish her sentence, as a figure leapt onto her from behind, perching on her mechanical body and driving a blade through her chest. A snakekin with orange scales, the blade extended from his left arm, which was mechanical. Demantoid’s body disappeared, leaving her gemstone and suit to fall to the ground, where the snakekin faced towards Hessonite. He sneered, waving this blade tauntingly. “That’s, what, eight or nine for me? How ‘bout we make it one more?”

His victory was short-lived, as faster than he could blink, Hessonite rushed from her position to his, her saber pressed against his throat. “That’s all the Gems you’ll take today.” He tried to counter with his armblade, but she grabbed it by the wrist with her free hand, pressing it against a nearby tree. “Who are you? What are you doing here?”

“Oh, just some passing ne’er-do-well,” he said, smirking. “Saw you all had such pretty jewelry and thought I’d help myself. Say… that’d look nice on a brooch. What’s your price?” He eyed her gemstone with a glint in his eye.

She was not amused, pushing her sword closer to his neck. "No mere bandit can do all of this. I ask again: why are you here?"

"Hessonite?" The Garnet turned around to see, to her great surprise, Pyrope strolling towards her. "Oh, am I glad to see you! I tried to get in touch with you when Emerald showed up, but her ship almost crashed right into ours! I had to land quickly, or I would've ended up as space dust on her windshield! …Who's this? Where's Demantoid?"

Although rather confused by Pyrope's sudden, unannounced arrival, Hessonite had other things to worry about. "That's what I'm trying to find out." She turned back to her would-be assassin. "Answer me this, how does a single bandit destabilize an entire company of Gems alone, without being detected.

The snakekin grinned. "Who said I was alone?"

Hessonite cried out as the Gem destabilizer was pressed into her back, sending shocks coursing through her physical form. She vanished in a cloud of dust; Pyrope, who held the destabilizer, watched her gem fall with a wicked expression. "And that wasn't even my best performance!" she said, her eyes turning red.

"That it weren't," said the snake, picking up her gem to examine it. After some consideration, he chucked it over his shoulder. "Though I can't say Pyrope was yer best choice…"

Double Trouble scoffed, having taken on their true appearance. "I wouldn't expect a ruffian like *you* to understand the intricacies of subtle manipulation. In any case, we've successfully cleared out the camp. I believe I was responsible for twelve in total?"

"Eleven and a half," he muttered. "I held her in place for ya!"

The sound of clapping from the side drew both their attention. "Yes, yes, you both performed very well," said Modulok, stepping out of the forest. Mantenna crept along beside him, eyes darting all over. "But there is no time to celebrate this small victory. We

must press onward, as our goal is within our reach. The time has come to activate the Heart of Etheria."

The orange snake-man stepped forward, intentionally getting in front of Double Trouble. "Can't wait! I'm excited to see the look on those Gems' faces when they–"

"Just a moment, Jerrick," Modulok said, holding up a hand. "Unfortunately, you will not be here to witness our triumph. I have an important assignment for you instead."

Though visibly disappointed, Jerrick awaited orders. "Whatever you need, Master Modulok, I'll provide." Modulok approached and bequeathed him with a small pouch, filled with black dust. The significance of this gift was immediately known to him, as worry crossed his face. "M-Master…?"

"I trust you know where to bring this," said Modulok. "Merely a precaution. A failsafe, in the event that She-Ra should return. Go now, Jerrick–our destiny grows closer by the second."

As Jerrick dutifully headed away, the three remaining stood before the Citadel, none of them phased by its magnificence. "So, stupid question, but are you sure this will work?" asked Double Trouble.

Modulok only laughed. "I would not base our future on a gamble." He held up the Runestone he had retrieved from the Sword of Protection to the building. It began to glow, humming as a red light illuminated the formations carved into the Citadel's side. These grooves began to light up as well, and a chime sounded.

"System restored," said a voice that had not spoken in some time. "Note: data corruption detected. Maintenance procedures underway. Expected time to completion: five hours."

"Delay maintenance procedures," Modulok said. "Open access shaft to the Heart of Etheria. Activation code: Eternia."

After a moment of processing this, Light Hope spoke again. "Administrator detected: Galen Nycroft. Opening access shaft."

Red light spread in an arc over the section of the wall that lit up, lowering to reveal a tunnel into the Citadel. “Please, watch your step.”

Modulok led Double Trouble into the small chamber that had opened up. The door closed behind them, and with frightening speed, the floor began to descend. “So, about that failsafe of yours,” Double Trouble said. “You really think we’ll need it?”

“That, I cannot say,” Modulok replied. “What I am certain of is that the princesses will no doubt try to stop us. All we can do…is ready ourselves for the final confrontation.”

# Fallen

Chapter Summary

Adora and the others rush to escape from Modulok's collapsing base, while Steven, Glimmer, and Bow go after the Heart of Etheria.

Chapter Twenty-Four: Fallen

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With no bugs around, Mosquitor was pretty much powerless. Not that having any bugs around would have helped him much, considering the impenetrable shield Micah had around the shuttle. There were many things he wanted to do: warn Modulok of the incoming enemies, help Modulok fight off those enemies, get his revenge on the same enemies…but instead, all he could do was sit tight, hoping that his master was getting on fine without him.

His retrospective on how he arrived at this situation was interrupted by the entire station violently rocking as though it had collided with something. Mosquitor cried out as he tumbled off his chair and onto the floor, scrambling to stand back up. As soon as it had started, the rumbling stopped, leaving him more confused than frightened. As he peered out the door to check his surroundings, he noticed something: Micah's shield had disappeared.

"What's this? I appear to no longer be trapped!" Mosquitor slowly stepped off of the ship, making sure it wasn't some sort of trick. Satisfied that it wasn't, a grin spread across his face as he made his way further into the facility. "Freedom is mine! That fool Micah must have slipped up somehow. I must capitalize on this moment–for Master Modulok, I will hunt the intruders down! Long live Master Mo–eh? Who are you?"

Mosquitor had stopped his spiel as he noticed Catra running down the hall towards the hangar. Not thinking much of her, he wasn't prepared for her to shove him to the ground as she ran by. "Move it!" She darted towards the ship, aiming to climb aboard.

Despite having just escaped from there, Mosquitor now ran back to his former prison. "Get back here! No! Don't touch that!" Catra had already closed the door, and the shuttle lifted up off the ground. "That's my ship! Come back with that!" He pounded on the edge as it turned towards the hangar door.

But it was too late. The ship sped away, leaving Mosquitor in the dust. He was free, true, but now he was left with no way back home, on a possibly sinking space station, alone with only his enemies.

"Argh…this is *truly* not the best day for Mosquitor…"

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Entrapta was not usually the kind of person to be knowingly vague. So Adora figured that when she was being vague, it couldn't mean anything good. "So, I'm not a scientist, but I'd guess that 'decaying orbit' means that…"

"...that this station is in danger of plummeting down towards the planet, yes," Entrapta finished. The urgency of the situation was clear on her face. "You all came here on a ship, right? One we can use to leave?"

"Well, yeah, but I don't think all four of us are gonna fit," said Scorpia. "Adora?"

Adora was already prepared to lead the way. "This way!" The four of them headed back to the hangar, with Entrapta making sure to take Emily's core with her. "How long do we have until we're toast?"

"I don't know–it could be anywhere from a few hours to a few seconds!" Entrapta said. "I didn't get the chance to study this

station's subsystems!"

"Hey, should we go back for Mosquitor?" asked Scorpia. "I mean, I know he was working for Modulok and tried to kill us and all, but condemning him to a fiery death seems a bit harsh!"

"I'm sure he has the sense to fly out of here on his own," Micah replied. "Let's just focus on getting out of here ourselves!"

The four continued running until they passed by the room full of clones. Adora momentarily faltered, her thoughts moving at a million miles a minute. These clones…were they all like her? Each one created specifically to wield the Sword of Protection? If that was the case, then she really was nothing special. Easily replaceable, just one of hundreds of other identical copies.

Scorpia took notice of her distress. "Adora, you alright?" she asked. "We don't have time to hang around. Do you need me to carry you?" She held out her claws in case Adora required a lift.

Instead, Adora peered into the room full of what might have once been her sisters. "We can't just…leave them here, right?" she said softly. "I mean, they're like me. How are we supposed to just leave when they're all stuck here?"

"Adora, listen to me." Entrapta took Adora by the shoulders, turning her to face her. "They aren't real people yet. You are, because you came to Etheria and met everyone, but all those yous in the jars? They're just blank slates. Plus, I'm pretty sure they're well past their expiration date. You are the only Adora that matters. So let's get you off this station!" Taking Adora by the hand, she hurried her towards the hangar.

"I must have missed something," said Scorpia. "Are those clones of Adora in there?"

"I'll explain on the way home," Adora said. "Entrapta's right, we need to get out of here quick, before–

All four of the skidded to a halt as they almost ran straight into Lars and Padparadscha, who were running through the halls as well. “Here they are! You were right, Pads!” he said. “Guys, we’ve gotta go! This station’s–”

“About to fall out of orbit, we know!” said Micah. Lars stared at the strange man, opening his mouth to ask a question. “We’ll explain everything later, right now we need to get back to your ship!”

“Well said, Micah!” Padparadcha said. “This way, everyone! Mosquitor will meet us there!” She and Lars led the way back to the hangar. Micah decided he would ask how she knew about Mosquitor later.

Back at the hangar, everyone was packing up into their respective starships. It seemed a temporary truce had been called between the Off-Colors and Catra’s squad. “Theeere theeey aaare!” said Fluorite. “Quiiickly nooow!”

As everyone piled into Mara’s ship, Adora glanced over at the New Horde team. She was sure a certain nemesis of hers would be with them, but her absence sparked another pang of worry. “Is Catra with you?” she asked.

Karikon, the last to board, looked over at her. “Pah! You wanna know where Catra is? She already split! Got into some other ship and flew off without us! Good riddance, never liked her much anyway…” He climbed aboard, and their ship took off, rocketing into the unknown.

The Off-Colors and their allies waited around a bit longer. Sure enough, just as Padparadscha said, another figure came sprinting into view. “Hang on! Wait for me!” shouted Mosquitor, clambering up the ramp. “That miscreant feline made off with my shuttle!”

After a quick headcount, everyone was accounted for. “Punch it!” cried Lars.

“That’s doable!” Rhodonite replied. Mara’s ship’s engines ignited, carrying them out of the station. And none too soon, as it had reached the atmosphere of the planet below. Its exterior glowed with heat as it was pulled further and further down.

Adora and the others watched as the facility was consumed by the flames of reentry. Bits and pieces of it broke off as it rocketed downward like a meteor, taking everything within with it. Before long, there would be nothing left of Modulok’s research…nor the closest thing Adora had to family.

Unaware of Adora’s grief, the Off-Colors were simply relieved. “We did it! We actually didn’t die!” said the left Rutile. “Back to Etheria, captain?” added the right one.

“Back to Etheria,” said Lars, sitting back in his captain’s chair. “From the sounds of things, we’ve gotta stop Emerald from destroying Brightmoon.”

“And stop Modulok, don’t forget him,” added Padparadscha.

Making sure that Mosquitor wasn’t about to try anything funny, Micah went over to check on Adora. “Are you alright?” he asked, his tone fatherly. “From what I can tell, you’ve just been through a lot.”

“I want to say I’ll be fine. I’m always fine,” she said. “But this time, I-I don’t know if I will be. First I found out I’m not even a real person, then I lost She-Ra, Catra’s still out there, the closest thing I had to a family is gone, Emerald and Modulok are attacking my home…!” She wiped her eyes. “What do we do? What can we even do at a time like this?”

“Keep going.” The two of them turned to Scorpia, who now stood nearby. “My whole life, that’s all I’ve done.” She sat down next to them. “When Emerald showed up and basically took over the Horde, I felt so helpless. When I tried to stand up to her, Catra had me sent to Beast Island. But if that had never happened, I never would’ve unlocked my connection to my Runestone! I never

would've met Micah! And we never would've shown up there! What I'm saying is, even when things seem like there's no way forward, you'll never know until you keep going. So, the bad guys want to destroy our home? Sure, they have us outnumbered and outgunned, but that's no reason to roll over! She-Ra or not, you're Adora. You beat Skeletor. You beat Horde Prime. You can beat these clowns!"

Scorpia's speech had slowly gained everyone else's attention. "Weeell saaaid!" said Fluorite, clapping.

"Ah…I dunno," Scorpia said, blushing slightly. "Just said what came to mind!"

"Well, you're right," said Lars. "As long as the innocent are in danger, Lars of the Stars and his Off-Colors will be there to save the day, no matter the odds! Engage the hyperdrive!"

"Engaging hyperdrive!" said Rhodonite.

"Hyperdrive engaged," said the ship's computer.

And off into the void the ship sped, racing towards Etheria. Adora gripped the hilt of her sword tightly, hoping that they weren't too late.

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Steven was surprised with how stable the elevator was for how fast it moved. If it had been a human elevator, it would have left without them. He chalked it up to being First Ones tech, as there were more pressing matters at hand. "How exactly did Emerald find out about this place?" he asked. "And why would she waste time at Brightmoon if she knew the Heart was down here?"

"I don't think this was Emerald's people," said Bow. "Adora mentioned that someone called Modulok was going after the Heart. She didn't have time to explain who he is, but if he can take out Hessonite's whole team…" He let the idea speak for itself.

“Whoever he is, he doesn’t know we’re coming,” Glimmer said. She stared forward, determined and focused. “He’s got another thing coming if he thinks we’ll make this easy.”

After a little while of descending, the tunnel lining gave way to glass, revealing a massive chamber: a hollow cavity carved into the planet’s center. What looked like roots came from the ceiling of this chamber, glowing all sorts of colors as they twisted towards the middle. And there, directly at the center of the enormous room, a sphere of energy hovered, surrounded by a series of rotating rings. The Heart of Etheria.

The three of them stood momentarily transfixed by the sight. “The entire planet’s just one big battery for that thing,” said Bow. “The First Ones…who could they have been fighting that they needed to turn an entire planet into a gun?”

Steven knew. “Homeworld,” he said, remembering his encounter with Adam. “The Gems took over Eternia, made it their own planet. That must be the whole reason the First Ones came here in the first place: to get back their home.”

“If the Heart is as powerful as people say, they wouldn’t have had much of a home to get back,” Glimmer pointed out. “If Modulok gets his hands on this, there’s no telling what his targets could be. Adora was right: nobody should have this sort of power.”

It wasn’t much longer before the elevator slowed, coming to a stop at the very bottom of the shaft. Another door slid open, revealing a much larger, dimly-lit room. The three of them stepped into the dark, all of them prepared for the worst.

“Thank goodness you’re here!” a voice suddenly called out. The trio stood ready to attack, only to see Hessonite emerge from the shadows. “Emerald’s forces ambushed us! I managed to escape down here, but everyone else was captured! Hurry, if we can get the Heart up and running, we should be able to–”

Bow suddenly aimed an arrow at her. "And how did you get away?" he asked. "Or, more importantly, why didn't you stay and fight? The Hessonite I know would never have left her people behind."

"Bow, what are you doing?" Glimmer hissed. "Is now really the time to be acting all suspicious?"

"It's exactly the time," he continued, not taking his eyes off his target. "How come you didn't try to contact us? And like I said, why did you escape instead of staying to fight?"

Hessonite held up her hands. "Hey, I may be the valiant type, but even I know you can't win every battle! Surely you of all people understand that."

"Sure, *I* understand that," Bow said. "But Hessonite, the *real* Hessonite, didn't understand the meaning of the term 'tactical retreat.' So the question is, if you're not Hessonite…who are you?"

The Gem looked between the three for a moment, before apparently realizing there was no point in keeping up the charade any longer. "You're a lot sharper than I pegged you for," she said, her voice a mixture of her own and somebody else's. She blinked, her eyes turning red, before her body began to morph and change. Soon, Double Trouble stood before them.

"I must say, I never expected the great Queen Glimmer to abandon her people to Emerald's whims," came a voice from the darkness. Double Trouble sneered at the three, returning to their master's side as he stepped into the light. "Your lust for power must rival even that of Shadow Weaver. I can see a lot of her in you, you know…"

The heroes collectively shuddered at the horrible creature that crept towards them. "Are you…Modulok?" asked Steven.

"Ah, so you've heard of me!" he said, pleasantly surprised. "I can only assume Adora told you. Did she mention that she wasn't long for this world, perchance? Up against two of my servants, and

without her sword, no less…it would take a miracle for her to survive."

"Enough talk!" shouted Glimmer, stepping forward. "I don't know where you came from, or why you want the Heart of Etheria, but this ends now! For the record, Queen Glimmer *hasn't* abandoned her people: with the Heart, I can make sure nobody threatens Brightmoon, or Etheria, ever again! So step aside, before I *make* you step aside!"

Modulok cackled. "Such bravado! You truly are your father's daughter, little one. Perhaps I can arrange a reunion for you two once all is said and done. As for the Heart, I'm afraid I can't give it up just yet. I require its power to restore order to the universe, you see. But once Gemkind is but a distant memory, I will be more than happy to lend you its power…if you survive the process, that is."

"So you *do* want to destroy Homeworld!" said Steven. "Why? What do you have against them? Sure, they've destroyed a few planets, but–"

He was cut off by more laughter from Modulok. "This isn't about the planets they've destroyed! It's about the planets they've *taken* ! The beating heart of the Eternian Empire, for one: my homeland, Eternia! The Gems are a plague, spreading across the universe, defiling all that they touch! But now, I have everything I need to expunge their cancerous touch from existence once and for all! And I must thank the three of you for making that possible…especially you, Steven."

Steven faltered. "M-me? How did I help you!? I got the Diamonds to stand down, to dismantle their empire!"

"Exactly! By removing the Diamonds from leadership, you've fragmented their empire! All of their colonies are self-governing: some still loyal to their old leaders, others leaning sympathetic to the Crystal Gems, and yet others wishing to remain neutral. Ordinarily, the destruction of Homeworld would have plunged all

of Gemkind into chaos…but thanks to you, each colony will react differently. Chaos is an understatement: this will result in a civil war that will devastate all remaining Gem-controlled planets! And from Homeworld's ashes, the Eternian Empire will rise once again–with myself at its helm. That, children, is how to destroy your enemy utterly."

Bow, having been stunned by Modulok's speech, aimed an arrow at him. "We won't let you do that!" Double Trouble was ready to attack, but Modulok held up a hand, calling them off. "You may have planned this whole thing out, but you didn't prepare for us!"

"That's right!" said Steven. "My sword, Glimmer's power, Bow's… eh, bow–it's two against three!"

Modulok shook his head, disappointed. "And here I thought Etheria's heroes would be better than this… Rule number one of entering enemy-controlled territory: always check your blind spots."

In the split second before the trio could follow this advice, Mantenna leapt from the wall behind Steven, landing on his back. He scratched with his claws and sank his gnarled mess of teeth into his neck as he flailed to try and throw him off. "Steven!" cried Glimmer, her hands glowing in preparation to blast him off. But he was too close to Steven, and she worried about hitting him by mistake.

"Rule number two: turn your enemies' strengths into your own." With the heroes distracted, Modulok unclipped a small crossbow from his hip. "All it takes is a few adjustments, and three-on-three can very easily become two-against-four." He took aim at Glimmer, pulling the trigger.

A small dart was launched her way. As distracted as they all were, only Bow saw him readying the projectile. "Glimmer!" With no time to get her attention or get her out of the way, all he could think to do was shield her from the shot. He ran towards her faster than he had ever moved in his life, reaching her just as the

dart reached them, wrapping his arms around her. The pair of them fell to the ground, Bow wincing as the dart pierced his shoulder.

"Guys!" Steven slammed Mantenna into the wall, succeeding in knocking him off. He meant to run towards the pair, only to cry out as the mutant bit into his ankle. He fell to his knee, holding the creature back as it climbed atop him, trying to reach his throat.

Meanwhile, Glimmer got to her feet, only to find that Bow was struggling to do the same. "Bow? Bow!" She knelt beside him, checking the wound: his veins at the point of impact were turning dark green, spreading further by the second. With a cry of rage, Glimmer teleported over to Modulok, pinning him to the ground. "What did you do!? What did you do to him!?" she roared, her fist glowing.

"Me? I did nothing," Modulok answered, completely undeterred. "I was aiming for you. Your friend simply chose to get in the way of my mutative needle. I will admit, I was hoping to turn you into a Runestone-powered mutant, but I suppose he'll have to do. Shall we see just what sort of monster my serum will transform him into?"

Enraged, Glimmer drove her fist into Modulok's face, hard enough to knock him out of commission. She hurriedly warped back over to Bow, who was beginning to twitch and groan as the serum took effect. "Bow, can you hear me?" she asked frantically. "Please, Bow, you have to fight it! We need you with us!"

"I…can't…" he stammered, his muscles tensing up as more and more of his skin was stained green. His entire body began to ripple, slowly growing too big for his clothing. He cried out as his back arched, snapping his quiver's strap as his chest grew too big for it. "Glimmer…you…" The infection reached his eyes, which became bloodshot as his irises turned red. "RUN!"

Glimmer could only watch in horror as Bow's voice turned into a growl. His bones and joints began to crack as his form shifted into something unrecognizable as the boy she knew. He let out a skyward bellow, having nearly tripled in size, before his monstrous countenance turned to look at his former friend.

Double Trouble had helped Modulok up, whose features had completely healed. He watched the creation of this monster with awe. "No matter how many times I see it, I am still captivated by its beauty," he said in a reverent whisper. "I believe I shall call this one…Megator."

Megator snarled, shambling forward towards Glimmer, who teleported away when he reached out to grab her. "Bow! Please, Bow, listen to me! You have to remember who I am!" But the ogrish form of her friend showed no sign of recognition, or of anything else save rage. His fists continued to pound at the ground as he followed her, his sudden transformation leaving her unwilling to fight back.

Steven was similarly traumatized, but he couldn't do anything to help with Mantenna firmly attached to him. The creature was surprisingly strong for its build, and although he was stronger, its agility made it a tough foe to overcome. "Bow! Glimmer–Ack!" The creature was pulling him around like a rodeo, only with significantly more biting. Just as Megator followed Glimmer down the left path further into the facility, he was pulled down the right one.

"And that, my dear Double Trouble, is how you can turn any situation around in your favor." He turned around, heading down the central corridor. "Come. We still have much work to do."

"I thought all that was left was to fire the weapon," Double Trouble replied. "What else could there possibly be to do?"

The pair entered the final room, from which the Heart itself was visible through a giant window. In addition to several consoles near them, a raised circular platform sat in the center of the

room. A series of small jewels of all different colors lined the edges, numbering fourteen in total, with a fifteenth positioned in the center. “You’d be surprised. Now, where did I put that invention of Entrapta’s?”

Double Trouble held up a disk. “This one, boss?” they asked.

“Ah, yes, that’s the one!” said Modulok, taking the device. “You truly are indispensable, Double Trouble. I could never have made it this far without you. In fact…” He looked towards the raised dial in the middle of the room. “...I believe the time has come for you to fulfill your original purpose.”

# The Heart of Etheria

Chapter Summary

Adora and the others return home, only to find that they may be too late...

Chapter Twenty-Five: The Heart of Etheria

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Gingerly holding Entrapta's device, Modulok approached the raised platform in the room's center. "After so many millennia of planning, my vision will finally come to pass. If only dear Entrapta could know what part she played…but no matter. I will show my gratitude by seeing this through."

After pressing a series of buttons on the disk, he placed it on the platform where it whirred to life. With a click, the top half raised up from the bottom, which then opened up into seven slices. Out of each new hole poured a series of tendrils that seemed to be formed out of black sand. These tendrils each connected to one of the gemstones lining the platform, before solidifying into a stony substance.

"Master switch is in place," Modulok said. "Now, Double Trouble, it is time."

His creation's eyes flashed with excitement. "Showtime." Their body was enveloped by blackness, morphing until Glimmer's likeness stood in their place. They held out a hand above one of the gems, which had the same texture and color as the Moonstone. The gem soon started to glow, with this light traveling up the black stone.

With that, Double Trouble transformed back. The two watched for a few tense moments as the glow slowly made its way towards the machine's center. The stony tendril then flashed the same color, before itself turning from black to a pearlescent white. At

this, Modulok couldn't help letting out a triumphant snarl. "Triumph! The princess' DNA has been locked in! Now, my greatest creation, complete the procedure!"

Double Trouble cracked their knuckles and transformed again, repeating the process. With a sample of every princess' blood, as well as their likeness, each of the stones were activated one by one. Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta. Spinnerella, Netossa, Scorpia. This also included several princesses of kingdoms that had long since vanished. One was a woman with fiery red hair; one was a hulking figure made entirely of stone; one had skin that resembled metal. After the process had been done thirteen times, they last assumed Castaspella's form, and all of the gemstones had been activated.

With all of the gems' energy locked in place, Entrapta's machine opened further, revealing the fifteenth gem in the center. "Activation sequence verified," reported Light Hope. "Overseer input required."

Stepping up onto the platform, Double Trouble changed form one last time: now, they resembled Queen Angella. "Eternia," she said, spreading her wings as she held out a hand. Just as with the others, the jewel in the center glowed, like a prism containing the colors of all the other ones.

"Input received," said Light Hope. "Heart of Etheria charging process commencing." Modulok watched, with a look of absolute triumph, as the rings circling the Heart began to rotate faster and faster as energy slowly began descending from the roots above. "Input target."

"So, what you said earlier about the Gems being fractured," said Double Trouble, sitting on the platform in their base appearance. "How can you be sure they'll start fighting with each other instead of coming after us?"

Modulok smiled as he locked in the coordinates for Homeworld. "Because, my dear Double Trouble, I understand how people of all

sorts think. At the end of the day, all decisions ever made by thinking beings boil down to stimulus and response. For Gems, being machines made for one specific purpose–expansion–this goes doubly. What remains of their race will descend into infighting, mark my words. And even if some are able to pull together a movement to avenge their masters, they will have no reason to believe anything remains of their killers."

"Target locked: Homeworld," said Light Hope. "Warning: insufficient power to fire. Engaging safety protocols–" Modulok responded to this by smashing his fist into the console, crushing it with surprising strength. "Safety protocols disengaged. Beginning backup power collection."

"Wait, what exactly did it mean by that?" asked Double Trouble. "What did *you* mean by that? What exactly aren't you telling me–"

They were interrupted as the whole facility shook. An earthquake; one that reached the very core of the planet, at that. Unlike his creation, Modulok seemed to have expected the tremor, slowly strolling over to the window. "What that means is, I have successfully managed to bypass every possible setback this machine and its inhabitants could have posed. I *built* this device–I knew everything that could have gone wrong beforehand, and turned it into an advantage. The princesses are unwilling to go along with their purposes? I copied their likenesses to use as I see fit. Forces counter to my goals fighting over this planet? I pointed them at each other. The most powerful forces in this universe, from She-Ra to He-Man, Skeletor to the Horde, to the Diamonds themselves, were nothing more than *hindrances* in my plan to resurrect our empire. Hindrances that I overcame." He watched the Heart continue to gather power with a look of manic reverence. "Do you want to know what that truly means? It is time to…what was it that King Grayskull liked to say? Ah, yes: cast out the shadows!"

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Castle Brightmoon was on its last legs; everyone could feel it. Emerald's forces had run Netossa ragged trying to keep the barrier up, and it was moments away from falling. "Citrine?" she said casually, the slightest spark of preemptive triumph in her eyes. "Begin charging the nova cannon. It is finally time to take what is ours!"

"Understood, My Emerald!" said the Quartz. "Ready to fire in t-minus sixty seconds!"

The underside of the Supermassive opened up, revealing an enormous weapon pointing straight down. Dark red light began to coalesce within the cannon, preparing to obliterate anything that was in range. No barrier could keep something that powerful back forever, and everyone knew it.

"Just about everyone's been evacuated by now," said Peridot. "If we want to go too, now would be the time. Unless you're all planning on being vaporized, which I imagine none of you are! … Right? Please tell me I'm right."

Hordak stared up at the ship. His reinforcements were keeping Emerald's legions at bay, but there was nothing they could do against something of that size. "If the Fright Zone were to come under attack, I would fight to the last breath to defend it," he said. "If I wish to atone for my crimes as leader of the Horde, I can do no less here. Leave if you wish…but if Emerald wants to take Brightmoon, she'll have to pry it from my cold, dead claws."

"If you're still here when that weapon fires, you'll be dead, but what's left of you won't be cold," Peridot remarked. She climbed up onto the railing of the balcony. "Hey, everyone! It's now or never if you want to get outta here alive! That ship's gonna open fire in any second, and we shouldn't be here when it does!"

In the courtyard, Netossa was barely conscious. "You go," she said weakly to Spinnerella. "I'll cover your escape."

"I think you know me better than that," Spinnerella said, taking her hand. "If you're staying, *I'm* staying. We're doing this together."

Time was up. "Nova cannon charging complete!" said the Citrine. "Your orders, My Emerald?"

She grinned. "Fire one!"

The sky for miles around lit up as the nova cannon fired. An enormous stream of crimson energy surged down upon Brightmoon, washing over the shield. Everything within its range that wasn't covered by the barrier was destroyed: rivers boiled, stone crumbled, trees were reduced to dust as a deafening roar split the air. Netossa held on with everything she had, until finally, the beam dissipated. She fell, spent, caught by Spinnerella. The shield crumbled, leaving only a dome of ice in its place.

Everyone slowly opened their eyes now that the attack had ended. "Is…is it over?" Topaz asked nervously.

"No. Not by a long shot," Peridot said gravely. "Come on, we have to get out of here before–"

"Fire two!"

Just as before, the nova cannon ignited, bathing the landscape in searing heat. The ice shield bubbled and steamed as it rapidly melted. "Mermista, Frosta, on me!" shouted Lapis, flying into action. She pulled up as much water as she could, aided by Mermista, as Frosta froze it as quickly as she could. They held the beam at bay, but the ice was melting faster than they could replace it.

Spinnerella carried Netossa over to Bismuth. "Get her to safety. Perfuma, come with me!" She and the other princess launched into action, the former using her wind powers in conjunction with Frosta to freeze the air around the dome, while the latter held the crumbling ice in place with pillars of giant vines.

After what seemed like an eternity, the beam was quiet once more. Everyone involved was ready to collapse, but knew there was no time. "Quick, we need more water!" cried Frosta.

"We don't *have* any more water!" Mermista shouted back. "Everything around here's already been evaporated!"

Perfuma sent some of her vines into the soil. "I'll try and find some underground reservoirs! Just hang on, we can get through this!"

"Fire three!" One last beam raced from above like the fury of the sun itself, burning through their last line of defense. Perfuma dug up as much water as she could, but there was only so much. Giant cracks appeared in the dome; Lapis and Mermista tried to fill them in, but they were appearing too fast. And even with Frosta's and Spinnerella's efforts combined, they could only lower the temperature so much in the face of the overwhelming heat.

The barrier was already beginning to fail. It was getting hotter and hotter within, and all it would take was the smallest breach for the beam to slip through and devastate anything it touched. But just when it seemed like Brightmoon would be reduced to ash…a miracle happened. The beam appeared to move, both it and the ship it came from moving out to sea.

Lapis and the princesses collapsed. Everyone else ran over to assist them, with the remaining Crystal Gems diverting any falling blocks of ice as the barrier crumbled. "What happened?" asked Amethyst, carrying her allies to safety. "Did we scare her off or something?"

Garnet could feel something was wrong. "No…" She looked out to where the ship was going as the beam faded, before turning the other way. The sun had begun to set, stars rising in its place, each moving far too fast to be natural. "She isn't the one who's moving.

Aboard the *Supermassive* , Emerald was just as confused as they were. "What is going on!?" she hollered, pounding on her chair.

“How are they evading us!?”

Her subordinates worked tirelessly to answer her question. “I-I don’t think it’s them, My Emerald!” said a Nephrite. “It’s as if the entire planet is somehow moving!”

“Moving!? Impossible! How could–” A look of horror crossed her face. “No…the Heart of Etheria. They must have somehow accessed the Heart! Get us out of range, now!”

Everyone watched from the ground as the *Supermassive* turned tail and ran, speeding up into the atmosphere and beyond. However, though Emerald may have left, the planet continued to realign. “Is Glimmer trying to aim the whole place at Emerald’s ship?” asked Bismuth. “Because she’s that way.”

Pearl looked off into the direction of the Citadel. “Whatever’s happening…please, Steven, be careful.”

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“Entrapta, Mosquitor, you two worked with Modulok,” said Adora, stopping her pacing. “What do you know about what he’s planning on Etheria? What should we do to stop him?”

Mosquitor, sitting huddled in the corner, angrily turned away. “We may be traveling together, but I am not your ally,” he hissed. “Master Modulok’s grand plan will come to fruition, and there is nothing you can do to stop him!”

“I wouldn’t go that far,” Entrapta said. She had placed herself up front near the control console, having taken special interest in the ship’s computer. “That thing he had me make, it’s clearly pivotal to whatever he has planned. I imagine breaking it would go a long way to disrupting that!”

“So, uh, what exactly is this thing you built?” asked Scorpia. “If we knew what he’s using it for, couldn’t we figure out where he is?”

Entrapta looked away guiltily. "That…might be a bit harder. He was really vague about what he needed it for; all I know for certain is that it's supposed to act as a master switch for some sort of First Ones tech. I know, I know, I should've asked more questions…"

"We don't need to know more to know where he is," said Lars. "Remember what Hessonite found out? There's a tunnel beneath the Citadel leading directly to the center of the planet! If he's after the Heart of Etheria, that's where he'll be going."

"The Citadel… We had always suspected there was something off about that place," said Micah. "But we never imagined that it was connected to Etheria's very heart. If Modulok gains control of it…"

"...He'll be able to wipe out any planet in the universe whenever he wants," finished Entrapta, once more shrinking inward in shame. "I tried to keep the Heart away from anyone who'd try to use it for evil, but I ended up giving him exactly what he wanted."

Seeing how upset she was, Scorpia moved over, pulling her into a hug. "Hey, there's no need to be so hard on yourself. Modulok's a tricky guy–I'm getting the impression that it's like his entire thing."

"It really is," added Micah. "Even all the way back when he was a Force Captain, he practically had the entire Horde eating out of the palm of his hand. I'd wager he planned all of this out from the beginning. If anyone's at fault for this, it's him. So instead of feeling sorry for ourselves, we should focus all our efforts on stopping him!"

Adora's fingers tightened around the handle of the Sword of Protection. Even though it was useless in its current form, she couldn't bear to leave it behind–it was like a part of her. "And that's exactly what we're going to do." She stood up, walking to the center of the room where she had everyone's attention. "Modulok's not the only threat there, so we'll need to divide and conquer. Bow and Glimmer told me that Emerald's attacking Brightmoon, so we'll need to deal with her, too. Entrapta, Micah,

Scorpia, you're with me–Lars, drop the four of us off at the Citadel, then head to Brightmoon to help out there."

"Um…I *can* do that, but…" said Lars. "Are we forgetting that Emerald's new ship is the size of, what, a small country? What exactly can we do against that?"

Entrapta seemed to find this amusing. "You're not underestimating Darla, are you? She tells me this ship can do things you've never seen before! The magic of First Ones tech, baby!"

There was a momentary pause. "And, who's Darla?" asked Rhodonite.

"Oh! Darla's what I named the ship's computer," Entrapta explained. "'Cause she looks like a Darla. She'll get you through it, no worries!"

Despite her reassurance, the crew nevertheless had some worries. But there was no time to dwell on them, as they had arrived. "Destination reached: Etheria," Darla informed them. "Alert: spatial anomaly detected. Rapid shift in planetary alignment. Recommend turning back."

"'Turning back?' What exactly is going on?" wondered Lars. He would get his answer when the ship decelerated out of warp. It was still Etheria, that much was clear…but something was unmistakably off about it.

"Um, Darla?" asked Adora. "When you said that the planet was out of alignment, what exactly did you mean?"

"Etheria has shifted along its axis," explained the computer. "Further abnormal rotation is in process. Please be aware of lunar abnormalities."

"Now the moons are messed up, too?" Scorpia said. "What else could go…oh. Hey, guys? I think I know what she means." She pointed out the window.

It had become apparent what was off about Etheria: they were staring at a completely different section of it. It had indeed tilted, turning in a decidedly unnatural manner, and still going. As if that wasn't enough, the moons were moving as well. "Impossible," Micah said, his voice hushed in disbelief.

Each one of Etheria's moons had deviated from its standard orbit, seeming to congregate around a spot on its southern hemisphere. They formed into a ring, large enough to encircle the planet, but hanging slightly behind it. Then, the three largest moons, spaced equally far apart, began to glow. They shone brighter and brighter, before their light spread to the smaller moons near them, connecting the ring.

"W-what's happening?" Adora asked. "This is Modulok, it has to be, but what exactly is he doing?"

"It's some sort of…gravity brace," Entrapta said, just as horrified as the others. "The Heart of Etheria must be so powerful, the First Ones had to install a dampener to prevent the recoil from hurling the planet off-course. But to need one of *this* size…how powerful will the blast be?"

The 'gravity brace' was not finished yet. From each of the three largest moons, a beam of energy shot down towards the planet below. Everyone on board braced for an explosion, but none came.

It was then that Entrapta recognized the spots. "Each of those beams, they're going to a First Ones ruin. But if those ruins are there, then at the other end is…"

"...The Citadel," said Scorpia, realizing what this all meant.

Etheria, the planet itself, was an enormous gun. And if the Heart was the payload, then the Citadel was the barrel.

"There's no telling when this thing'll fire," said Adora. "We may not know where Modulok's targeting, but knowing him, it can't be

anywhere good. Uh, bad. Whatever. We need to get down there, *now* ."

Lars took a deep breath, banishing his fear. "You heard the lady, Off-Colors! Full speed ahead towards the Citadel!"

"Aye-aye, Captain Lars!" said Padparadscha. Darla rocketed forward, entering the planet's atmosphere. Adora and Micah scanned the surface below: nothing seemed amiss so far, but with everything already going wrong, they had to be ready for anything.

After the ship had sped through the skies for a time, they soon found themselves in familiar territory. The Citadel came into sight, looking the same, but somehow seeming far more towering and ominous than it ever had. "Alright, this is your stop," said Lars, as the vessel hovered near the ground, bay doors opening. "Are you sure you can handle this on your own?"

Scorpia helped Micah to the ground. "'On our own?' With the four of us together, Modulok doesn't stand a chance!"

"Uh, yeah," Adora said, not quite as confident in their chances. "We still don't know what the situation with Emerald is like. Be careful over there."

Lars offered a confident salute. "Will do!" The ship took to the skies once again, speeding off in the direction of Brightmoon.

The four were now left before the Citadel, with no obvious way inside. "You're certain this is the way to the Heart?" asked Micah. "To my knowledge, nobody has ever managed to find an entrance."

Adora scanned the massive structure, hoping that Modulok had been the first in that regard. "Glimmer and Bow did say that Hessonite was around here somewhere. Maybe she found the door?" She began sliding her hand along the wall, trying to find some sort of secret switch or button to open the way. To her

surprise, the symbols carved into the wall began to light up at her touch.

"Administrator detected. Opening access shaft." With the sound of an all-too-familiar voice, part of the glowing wall slid away, revealing an opening to a circular room.

Entrapta led the way, peering into the room to make sure it was safe. "Coast is clear!" she announced. "C'mon, we gotta hurry!" She and the others made their way into the elevator, but something else was on Adora's mind. She stepped forward as though in a trance, those seemingly innocuous words still ringing in her head.

This did not go unnoticed by Scorpia. "Something wrong?" she asked, as the elevator began to descend. "You look like you've seen a ghost!"

"More like I *heard* a ghost," Adora replied. "That…that sounded like Light Hope. But she was destroyed by Horde Prime. She can't have survived…could she?"

Suddenly, Entrapta gasped. "She *did* survive! Modulok wanted the runestone from your sword, right? That must be why he wanted it–Light Hope survived by downloading herself into the Sword of Protection! And he must have needed her to access the Heart."

The good news was Light Hope was still alive. The bad news was that a madman was using her to access the most powerful weapon in the universe. As would be expected, Adora was conflicted. The group sat in silence for the rest of the ride down to the planet's center.

"So…here we are," said Scorpia. The Heart of Etheria. Somehow, I don't think Modulok's just gonna let us waltz on in."

"There's no telling what sort of traps he could have for us," Micah said. "Be ready for anything."

He gripped his staff tightly. Adora did the same with her sword's hilt. Scorpia held up her claws. Entrapta held up her fists, and her pigtails. And slowly, the door opened.

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For their entire existence, Double Trouble had been unbothered by Modulok's enigmatic ways. He had a tendency to withhold information, twist the truth, keep things purposefully vague. They were never bothered, as he was rarely like that with them. But now that he was on the cusp of accomplishing his goals, they couldn't help but be a bit unnerved. "Okay, so let's assume you succeed. Homeworld becomes a new asteroid belt. The Gems that remain fight with each other. What's to stop the Princess Alliance or the Old Horde to come after you? I can't imagine they'll be too pleased by you using their planet as a weapon."

Considering his mutated teeth, a sadistic sneer was essentially Modulok's default expression. But as he turned around to face them, his sneer seemed much more sadistic than usual. "You know, I was hoping you would ask about that. In fact, you should have your answer just…about…now."

Double Trouble was suddenly seized by a pain shooting across their entire body. Sparks of crimson energy had suddenly shot out from the runestone in the table's center, forcing them to their knees. "What..argh…is this?" they asked through gritted teeth. "What did you do!?"

Modulok offered a condescending laugh. "I would have thought you would understand how your power works by now! You see, Entrapta's device allows us to activate the Heart even without all fifteen princesses here, but in their absence, the Heart has nothing to draw power from. That is why I disabled the safety protocols: the planet's Runestones will not draw upon every power source they can find nearby…namely, the life energy of everyone and everything nearby."

Horrified, Double Trouble tried to shapeshift, but found they had no energy to do so. “And what about me!? Has my loyalty all these years meant nothing!?”

“No, no, of course not,” said Modulok. “Your loyalty has been greatly appreciated…but, unfortunately, it meant nothing. This was always your purpose, Double Trouble. To act as the trigger for the Heart of Etheria, giving your life to aid in its restoration. I do hope you won’t resent me for this.”

Double Trouble was unable to respond, drained of every ounce of their strength. They could only just make out the voice of Light Hope as they struggled to remain conscious. “Energy collection process has begun. Twenty minutes until firing.”

# Everything Collapses, Part 1

Chapter Summary

Adora and the heroes give everything they have to put a stop to Modulok's plan.

Chapter Twenty-Six: Everything Collapses, Part 1

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Now that Emerald had turned tail and fled, Brightmoon was safe once again. But it would not stay that way for long, as, unbeknownst to everyone on the ground, the Moonstone's light had begun to dim. Before long, all color had drained from the Runestone entirely, leaving only an ominous black void in its place. Wisps of light began drifting up its tower, vanishing into its darkness.

With everything that had just happened, nobody's eyes were on the Moonstone. "Looks like we've stopped moving," Peridot said, gazing at the sky. Although it was still technically daytime, the sky above them was filled with stars. "I don't get it, what are they trying to do?"

"Maybe moving us out of harm's way was all they were trying to do," suggested Perfuma. "That could be why they stopped. Glimmer did say all she wanted the Heart for was to scare Emerald off, didn't she?"

Garnet wasn't so sure. "We can't be sure how the Heart of Etheria works yet. Even if it can move the entire planet, it might not be Steven and the others doing it…"

"What exactly are you saying?" asked Netossa, struggling to her feet. "Who else would be down there to work the thing?"

"I'm not sure," Garnet replied, "but something about this feels wrong." She didn't elaborate further, only gazing off in the general

direction of the Citadel.

Before anyone could dwell on this further, Amethyst made an announcement. “Hey, guys? Lars is back.” She had noticed the First Ones starship approaching in the distance, drawing everyone’s attention to it. Everybody gathered around as it touched down, hoping it came bringing good news.

As soon as the ramp lowered, Lars came tearing out, clearly distressed. “Everyone, quick, we have to get to safety!” he cried.

“What? Safety? What’s going on?” asked Frosta. “And where’s Adora?”

“Citadel,” Lars replied. “I’ll explain later, but right now, we have to go! Someone else is taking control of the Heart of Etheria, and there’s no telling what he could do with it!” He had meant to continue, but suddenly fell to his knees and let out a groan. Everyone rushed forward worriedly, only for whatever was happening to him to spread.

The miasma surrounding the Moonstone now extended far beyond its tower, draining the energy from everyone and everything in its wake. One by one, the princesses fell as well, their strength being sapped into the very thing that once gave one of them power rather than taking it. “W-what’s going on?” asked Mermista, trying and failing to stand up. “Why do I feel so…weak?”

Strangely, though every one of the princesses were soon in the same position, the Gems fared slightly better. “Um, you guys?” said Rhodonite, looking down at her gemstones. “I-I think something’s happening to me…”

“It’s happening to *all* of us,” said Pearl. She was trying to pull Perfuma to safety, which was next to impossible, as the Runestone’s sphere of influence was spreading. Even if it wasn’t, she was barely able to move her at all with her energy being drained. Ultimately, she was forced to set her down. “Garnet, what should we do?”

“Get everyone on the ship,” she said, doing just that. Both Netossa and Spinnerella were under her arms, something that normally wouldn’t be an issue for Garnet, but she was clearly struggling. “If we get them far enough away, they should be safe.” But even she didn’t know this for sure.

Fluorite was receiving all of the princesses from within the ship, but despite her size and strength, she could feel herself growing weaker as well. “Weee haaave tooo huuurry,” she urged, pulling the weakened humans aboard. Mosquitor was still over in his corner, fighting back against the forces draining him dry.

As she was the smallest Gem present, Padparadscha probably the one most affected by the energy draining. However, she was able to catch a glimpse of the cause of their problems using her powers. “It’s…up there,” she said weakly, pointing up towards the Moonstone. She then collapsed, leaving only a few who had heard her call. Rutile picked her up, carrying her to the bridge.

“There has to be something we can do,” said Peridot, growing similarly weak. She was making futile attempts to get Frosta onto the ship, the girl all but unconscious. “Some way to…to…” She fell to her knees as well, unable to keep going.

Amethyst leaned against the side of the ship, only just holding her form together. “Aw, man…I really didn’t want it to end this way…” She began to slump to the ground, alongside her fellow Crystal Gems.

And just like that, it seemed all hope was lost. This is how the Crystal Gems and the Princess Alliance would end: not with a bang, but with a whimper, literally losing the will to fight. Their life essence was slowly drained from their very bodies, being used to fuel Modulok’s insane machinations. The world, it would appear, was coming to an end.

But one among their number refused to die in such a way. Slow, trudging footsteps rang out, pulling the single defiant Gem forward, despite the sheer effort it took just to walk. “Is this really

how you all die?" Jasper hissed, contempt clear in her voice. "Just lying down and accepting defeat? Don't tell me you're that pathetic!"

Slowly but surely, she dragged herself over to the tower supporting the Runestone that was responsible for all of this. Reaching it, she threw her fists against the stone, each punch taking monumental effort. Even though she seemed to be growing more exhausted with each attack, each one grew in ferocity, with her letting out monstrous growls as she pounded the tower.

"I did not give everything I had to Homeworld…lead the charge against our fiercest enemies…overcome impossible odds time and time again…just to lose to the *ruins* of the fools who thought they could control Gemkind!" She shot a glare towards the others. "What are you doing!? The lot of you stood against the Diamonds themselves, yet *this* is enough to bring you to your knees!? Rose Quartz would be ashamed of you all…Steven would be ashamed of you all! Stand up and fight, or these pitiful remnants won't be the ones to shatter you!"

Bismuth's arms transformed into blades, digging into the ground as she pulled herself to her feet. "She's right, team," she said. "After everything we've been through, we can't let *this* be how it all ends! Stand up and fight!" The other Gems watched as she reached the tower, tearing into it alongside her former foe.

One by one, the others got to their feet. Water whips lashed against the tower as Lapis hovered above. Peridot hurled metal objects against it, using them to try and push it over. On the other side, Fluorite and Amethyst pulled to try and topple it. Garnet and Pearl fired their projectiles against it, and Topaz charged at the tower, slamming her shoulder into it.

It was gradual, barely noticeable at first. But more and more, chips and cracks began to appear at the tower's base.

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The four of them were surprised that all that awaited them was an empty room. Moving slowly, Scorpia led the way out into the open, all of them anticipating a trap to be sprung at any moment. "So, uh…where's Modulok?" she asked.

"I'm wondering the same thing," Micah said, looking around warily. "A large sealed door: instinct tells me that should be the first place we look. Any chance you can get it open?"

Scorpia tried to pry the doors apart with her claws, but they were sealed shut with ancient technology. Residual shadow magic flowed through her arms, but it still wasn't enough to open the way. "No good," she said, wiping her brow. "We'd need someone as strong as She-Ra to get through here! …Uh, sorry," she added, remembering Adora's current predicament.

"Don't worry about it," Adora replied. "There has to be another way in. Let's split up: Micah, Scorpia, you two go left, Entrapta and I'll go right. If you find anything, don't wait up, we don't have time." Wasting none of that time, she immediately headed down the right passage, with Entrapta following behind.

"Looks like it's you and me again," said Scorpia, making her way down the left passage with Micah at her side. "So, what sort of monsters do you think Modulok has guarding this place? This feels like his last stand, so I'll bet he has all sorts of gigantic, scary, freaky ones with more teeth than you can imagine, with–"

Micah froze, holding out his arm. "Hold it," he said.

"Sorry, was I being too scary?" Scorpia asked.

"No…there's something up ahead." Holding still and listening, Scorpia could hear what Micah was describing: it sounded like a fight going on, with at least one of the combatants being on the larger side. "I think we found your monster."

The two of them headed in the direction of the commotion. The path was linear, so it wasn't long before they found the source: a giant monster was indeed present, throwing its arms wildly as it

tried to smash a smaller combatant. "Yup: gigantic, scary, and freaky, this one checks all the boxes. Now let's see about those teeth!" She started to charge in, preparing to transform.

Once again, Micah held her back. "Wait…" Rather than the large monster, he was focused on the smaller one fighting it. Even after all these years, even with her newfound abilities, he still recognized her. "...Glimmer?"

"That *is* Glimmer," Scorpia noticed. "Well, don't just stand there, let's help her out!" She ran into the fray, with no resistance this time.

Glimmer teleported out of the way of her former friend's fists slamming into the ground. "Fight it, Bow! I know you can still hear me!" she shouted, trying desperately to reach him. If he could indeed still understand her, he didn't show it, continuing to go after her like any other of Modulok's creations. "Come on!" She fired the occasional energy blast, only using enough power to keep him at bay.

The battle was interrupted as Scorpia dashed down into the midst of it. "Glimmer! Don't worry, I'll help!" Before the princess could reach, she had transformed into a massive scorpion, tackling Megator to the ground.

Needless to say, Glimmer was confused. "Scorpia…!?" she said, frozen in place. Not only had one of her former enemies, who she hadn't seen in almost a month, come to her aid out of nowhere, but then, similarly out of nowhere, she transformed into a giant bug. She might have stayed frozen, watching the battle, if she hadn't seen something–someone–even more shocking. "...Dad!?"

She and Micah met eyes. Slowly, carefully, the two of them approached each other. "Glimmer," Micah said, his voice hoarse. "I've dreamed about this moment for so long, but I never thought I would get to see you again." He held out a hand, but she took a step back.

“No…this can’t…this isn’t…” she said. “How can you be real? You aren’t… Are you real? Is this some sort of trick?” She stayed wary, but it was clear from the look in her eyes that she hoped against hope it wasn’t.

“No tricks–it’s me,” Micah assured her, waiting with his arms outstretched. “I can’t tell you how good it is to see your face again, Princess. Look how big you’ve gotten…” It sounded like he was ready to tear up.

Beside them, Scorpia and Megator continued to grapple. “Yup, it’s really him!” Scorpia assured Glimmer, holding back her opponent’s arms. “He’s been on Beast Island this whole time!” Megator grabbed her tail, hurling her at the wall. She quickly recovered, sidestepping his next punch.

“Dad…” Glimmer stepped into her father’s arms, everything else forgotten. Tears freely fell now that they were in each other’s embrace, holding on tight to ensure the other wasn’t some sort of illusion. In that moment, it became clear that each one was the real deal. “I thought you were gone.”

“I was gone, in so many ways,” Micah said, holding her close. “There were so many times I almost lost myself. The two of you were the only reason I was able to stay alive, stay sane for all this time. I promised myself that someday, somehow, I would find my way back to you–and now, thanks to Scorpia, I have.”

Their reunion was interrupted by Scorpia being slammed into the ground beside them. “And speaking of Scorpia, do you think you could lend me a hand?” she said, before being dragged back by Megator.

“She’s right: there’ll be time to catch up later!” said Micah, preparing his spells. “First, let’s take this beast down!”

He was about to fire a spell at Megator, only for Glimmer to stop him. “Wait! That ‘beast’ used to be my friend! Modulok used some sort of poison on him, and he turned into…that thing!” Megator

was about to slam his fist down on both of them, but Glimmer teleported them out of the way. “Isn’t there some way we can help him?”

Micah took a moment to recover from the teleportation, silently noting how adept she was at it before answering. “One of Modulok’s mutants… How long ago did this happen?”

“Just a few minutes,” Glimmer said. “Why?”

“We need to counteract the poison, and fast,” he replied. “If he stays like this for too long…it will become permanent.”

Glimmer gasped. “How long?”

“My best guess is we have an hour, at most, but we can’t afford to waste any time.” Micah once again prepared his spells. “There’s no telling how much Modulok has fine-tuned his methods over all this time.”

With no time to waste, Glimmer teleported over to Megator, landing on his shoulders. “Sorry Bow–this is for your own good!” She covered his eyes, causing him to stumble around as he reached up to remove her.

Scorpia took this opportunity to thrust her stinger into Megator’s unprotected thigh. He roared in anger, momentarily ignoring Glimmer to go after her instead. Gradually, the venom began to take effect, and he grew sluggish.

Micah summoned a collection of magical chains from the floor, which lashed around Megator and pulled him down. He bellowed as he struggled against the bindings, but with Scorpia’s venom sapping his strength, he couldn’t put up much of a fight. “I should be able to hold him here for a while,” Micah said. “But we really need to find an antidote, before it’s too late.”

“You have the most experience with this kinda thing,” said Scorpia, turning back to normal. “Is there some sort of magic potion you can conjure up?”

“Unfortunately, it’s not that easy,” he said. “Normally, I could use some herbs that grow around Beast Island to dampen the effects, but I doubt we’d find any around here. Our only option now is to get to Modulok: if we get a sample of his mutative serum, I should be able to reverse its effects.”

Glimmer slowly approached Megator, still only able to see her friend. “Don’t worry, Bow. We’re going to do everything we can to fix you. I promise, you’ll be back to normal in no time.” Despite his anger, he didn’t move as she placed a hand on his cheek.

However, this seemed to only be because he was focusing his efforts on something else. Slowly but surely, a thunderous noise began to reverberate through the chamber. “Um, I don’t know what that is, but it doesn’t sound good.

The pounding was rhythmic, getting deeper with each one. “It’s… his heartbeat,” Glimmer realized.

Megator’s heartbeat filled the room, accompanied by his body beginning to glow, starting with his chest. Not green, but red, pulsing with every beat of his heart. The farther the light spread, the stronger he became, fighting through the venom to break the chains. “Modulok must’ve stepped up his game–I can’t hold him much longer!” Micah stumbled back as Megator finally broke free, roaring in anger at the trio.

“Want some more, huh?” said Scorpia, preparing to transform again. “Lucky for you, I could do this all day! Get ready to–oof!” Megator simply battered her aside, focusing his attention on the father-daughter duo. His giant fist was blocked by a spell from Micah, with Glimmer blinding him with a flash of light. He didn’t need to see to smash everything in his immediate vicinity, though, proceeding to do just that.

Thanks to Glimmer, she and Micah warped out of harm’s way. “Okay, it looks like we’ll have to try a different strategy,” he said.

“Like finding a path to Modulok directly,” said Glimmer. She warped away again as Megator stomped in their direction, thrashing like mad. “Something about these walls blocks my teleports, though. Any ideas?”

Scorpia pulled herself up, remembering the sealed door they ran into when they came here as she looked at Megator. “What if…we used one of Modulok’s mutants against him?”

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Thanks to experience, Steven knew to never underestimate the little guy. But even with how dangerous Mantenna had proven itself to be, he couldn’t help growing more and more frustrated as the smaller mutant darted through the darkness, leaping out unexpectedly to sink its teeth into him before retreating. Every second it held him here was another second Modulok could use to fire the Heart and annihilate Homeworld. He just needed to be patient–something easier said than done.

He heard the scrabbling of claws just too late to react, feeling them slashing against his shins. Angrily, he swung his sword at the source, only for Mantenna to vanish once again. “Come out here and fight fair!” he roared, to no response. Great, now he was starting to sound like Jasper.

“Steven!” He heard the last voice he had expected to hear, and turned to see Adora and, stranger still, Entrapta up near the pathway to the elevator. “Hang on, we’re coming to you!” They hurried down the stairway to the lower levels, only for him to see Mantenna peering out at them from the shadows.

“Wait!” he yelled. “Look out!” But he couldn’t warn them in time, with Mantenna darting out with fangs bared. It landed on Adora, pinning her to the ground. Entrapta was knocked aside by this, tumbling off the stairs, only preventing herself from falling into the abyss by hanging on with her hair.

Adora held Mantenna's maw back with the hilt of her sword: for now, she was safe. Steven instead focused on Entrapta, hurling his sword her way. The blade embedded in the wall beside her, to which she responded by grabbing hold of it tightly. Steven then held out a hand, pulling the sword back to him, and bringing Entrapta along with it.

He ended up with the Sword of power in his hand, and Entrapta in his other arm. "That was some quick thinking!" she said. "How did you know your sword's auto-return feature would be strong enough to support my weight?"

"Uh, lucky guess," he replied.

Meanwhile, Adora was able to throw Mantenna over her head, sending it very nearly tumbling over the edge. Its sharp claws saved it, as it crawled back up and returned to its hiding place in the dark. The other two had hurried over, glad to see her still in one piece. "It got away," she stated.

Steven grunted. "It's good at that. So listen, Modulok's trying to use the Heart of Etheria to destroy Homeworld, and that weird thing's trying to stop me from stopping him. To do that, we need to get up there." He pointed at the Heart's command center, located about a story above them.

The pair took this information in stride. "Hopefully those windows are more easily-broken than the doors," said Adora.

"Better make sure," Entrapta said. "Steven, now would be a perfect time to apply your returning sword."

He nodded, hurling his blade once again, this time at the upper window. Although the blade didn't break through on the first impact, it did carry enough force to crack it significantly. "One more should do it," he said, returning the sword to his hand as he prepared to throw it again.

Before he could, Mantenna came out of hiding, latching on to Steven's arm. The sudden attack caused him to nearly drop his

sword, but he was just able to hold onto it. He reached up to grab his assailant, but Mantenna leapt off before he could.

"I got him, I got him!" Entrapta shouted, having managed to grab hold of the mutant with her hair. Unfortunately, this only resulted in her being dragged away by it. "He's got me!" Mantenna scrambled up the wall, taking its prisoner to the upper levels. Steven and Adora hurried after.

The runaway mutant came to a stop on a walkway high above the 'ground' floor. As her pigtails were no longer wrapped around it, Entrapta considered making her escape while it was turned away. Before she could, though, Mantenna turned around, creeping closer.

Entrapta crawled back as the creature approached. "Um, h-hey there!" she said nervously. "You remember me, right?" Mantenna continued to passively observe her, as though deciding whether or not she was a threat. "You…you do?"

"Entrapta!" Steven arrived at the catwalk, ready to charge in to rescue her. Before he could, however, Mantenna pounced on her, pinning her head to the floor. The threat was clear: stay back, or she was done for. "Just hang on, we'll get you out of here," he assured her.

With both Steven and Mantenna caught in this stalemate, Entrapta noticed something the mutant didn't: Steven's eyes kept flicking to something behind them, as though silently directing someone's approach. Sure enough, a moment later, Adora appeared beside Mantenna, knocking him down and off of his captive. "Run, go!" she shouted, pulling Entrapta up and hurrying down the walkway with her in tow.

Steven raised his sword, its power coursing through him, and brought it down against the catwalk. Mantenna had been considering going after Entrapta, but decided that Steven was the bigger threat, charging his way. But the walkway had begun to crumble, metal creaking and groaning as it fell apart. Before it

could reach him, the bridge collapsed, its pieces falling into the darkness, taking the mutant with them.

Adora and Entrapta had managed to make it to the other side before the collapse. “That’s, uh, one way to do it,” said the latter, looking down into the pit. “Not that I’m not glad you rescued me, but what exactly was your plan to get up to the control center?”

Without the catwalk, getting up to that room would be a bit harder. “Hmm, I dunno. We didn’t discuss that far ahead,” said Adora. “Hey, Steven! What’s the plan?”

“I think I can make it from here!” Steven shouted back. “Sit tight, I have an idea!” The broken window was only a short distance away. Taking a few steps back, he took a running start, leaping off of the railing towards the point of entry. He crashed through the glass, scattering the shards along the floor as he skidded to a halt.

Sword at the ready, Steven looked around for any of Modulok’s other tricks. But aside from a broken control panel and Double Trouble kneeling on a table, the room was empty. He approached the shapeshifter, but they seemed to be in some sort of a trance, half-lidded eyes looking at nothing. Assured that the coast was clear (for now), Steven returned to the window to retrieve the other two.

Just as before, Steven threw his sword, which embedded into the wall beside Entrapta. Familiar with this tactic, she grabbed hold. The Sword of Power was then pulled back up to Steven’s waiting hand, carrying her with it. “When this is all over, we should let everyone give this a try!” she said, smiling. Her joy was short-lived once she saw Double Trouble, letting out a shocked gasp. “Oh no!” She hurried over to their side, examining the results of her creation.

“What’s wrong with them?” Steven asked, throwing the sword again.

“The Heart–it’s draining their life to fuel itself!” Entrapta said, horrified. “And it’s using these mini-Runestones as nodes to do it! If only a few imitation stones are capable of doing this… Steven, it’s not just Homeworld that’s in danger! Every Runestone on the planet is going to be acting like this! Everybody who’s near one will have their life force sucked out!”

This information shocked Steven so much, he almost didn’t catch his sword. “But that means…Brightmoon…” he said. “You built that thing, can you turn it off?”

Entrapta looked it over while Adora examined the damaged control panel. “I didn’t give it a killswitch! I had no idea it would be used for something like this!” She frantically rounded the pedestal as she tried to think of something.

Meanwhile, as Adora tried to find a solution as well, a familiar voice rang out through the chamber. “Energy collection process at fifty percent. Ten minutes until firing.” There was no doubt about it: that was Light Hope’s voice.

“Light Hope…?” said Adora, unsure if she could really trust her ears. This wouldn’t be the first time she had encountered Light Hope after her apparent death, and the possibility remained that this could be another imposter.

“Greetings, She-Ra,” Light Hope replied, her voice much more impersonal than she was used to. “It has been some time since I have seen you. How may I be of assistance?”

She clearly remembered who she was, so why did she sound so casual? And why did she still think she was She-Ra? “Shut down the Heart!” shouted Adora. “Turn it off! Emergency shutdown–anything!”

“Apologies, She-Ra, but safety protocols have been disabled,” she reported. “The Heart of Etheria cannot be deactivated at this time.”

"Well, there has to be *something* we can do!" shouted Adora, slamming her fist against the broken panel. "My friends are all about to die, how can you just write them off like that!? *You're* the one who told me that being She-Ra means doing whatever I can to protect the people I care about! I don't know what Modulok did to you, but I know you're still the same Light Hope who taught me what I know. Please…there has to be something you can–"

Adora's speech was cut short as she felt a sharp pain on her neck. She reached up to the spot, removing a small dart. A chill began to spread from the point of injection, even though she could feel herself growing hotter. Steven and Entrapta both looked up, the former going still as he recognized the projectile.

"And here I thought losing your sword would be the end of you." Modulok descended from above, clinging to the wall. He still held his bowgun at the ready in case any of them tried anything. "Yet here you are, still alive. I'd be disappointed, if that tenacity wouldn't make you a useful servant."

Steven snarled, ready to cut him in half. "You slimy little–!" He was about to charge, but Adora held up a hand, keeping him in place.

"Don't…come closer…" she said, falling to the floor. Whatever poison Modulok had injected her with, she could feel it spreading throughout her body. In time, she wouldn't be able to hold it back. "Stop…the Heart!"

Entrapta was still for a moment, staring at Adora in horror, before she took a risk. Her pigtails wrapped around Double Trouble's arm, with the intent on pulling them free from her machine. This only spread the energy-draining effect to her as well, causing her to cry out in pain.

With both of his friends in peril, Steven was frozen in place, unable to decide on who to help. Following Adora's wishes, he ran

to Entrapta's side, trying to pull both her and Double Trouble out of the disk's influence.

Modulok loomed over the helpless form of Adora, who tried to crawl away. "Yes, yes, I've been told it's painful," he said in response to her struggling. "Not nearly painful enough, if you ask me. If anything, you should be grateful. Now that She-Ra is gone, this will give you back some of that power you lost."

"Incorrect." Both of them were caught off-guard by that unexpected remark from an unexpected source. "She-Ra still remains within subject Adora," said Light Hope.

"What? How is that possible?" hissed Modulok. "I destroyed the Sword of Protection! No sword, no She-Ra!"

Upon receiving this information, Adora gripped tightly to the sword's hilt. Her friends had been right: she was She-Ra, not the sword. "The conduits may be broken, but the connection will remain," Light Hope said. "As long as the universe needs a She-Ra…there shall be a She-Ra."

It was now or never. With the last bit of willpower she had left with her consciousness fading, Adora spoke the words. "For the Honor…of Grayskull." Silence. Nothing. At first.

Adora's eyes shot open, glowing golden. She could feel the touch of the poison dissipating. With newfound vigor, she swung her sword, its blade growing back in an instant. Before Modulok knew what was happening, his arm was severed, his gun falling to the ground with it. That golden glow covered her entire form, becoming a layer of armor, and a length of hair. She-Ra had returned once more.

Steven had managed to free Entrapta in time to witness this. Both of them were amazed by what they saw: She-Ra still resembled her old self, but with an almost ethereal beauty about her. Modulok, meanwhile, was more concerned with his arm, and the fact that it was growing back much slower than usual.

“You’re done, Modulok,” Adora said, pointing her sword to his chest. “Turn off the Heart now, and maybe you’ll get the chance to answer for everything you’ve done.”

He only smirked in response. “Did you not hear the computer? I couldn’t shut the Heart of Etheria off if I wanted to. I know the concept of losing doesn’t mean much to you, but now would be a good time to make peace with the fact that there is nothing you can do.”

Adora grabbed him, angrily lifting him into the air. “I said turn it off! You’re the mastermind here, aren’t you? Surely you have some sort of plan B in case things go wrong! So where is it?”

“Plan B, plan B…ah, yes, I remember now.” Modulok reached into his armor, producing a large syringe. Adora tossed him away, assuming he was about to inject her, only for him to stick it into his own neck. Every bit of the orange liquid was drained, the trio only able to watch. “You are correct about one thing, child: I am always prepared for every outcome!”

Modulok’s body began to twitch and writhe, his armor breaking apart as he grew. Multiple extra arms sprouted from his back, each one tipped with giant claws. His jaw extended into a massive maw lined with fangs. His orange skin had been dyed a deep red as his eyes, the only part of him that had remained the same, glared at the heroes in a similar color.

“An uncouth solution, to be sure, but one more than effective!” Although his voice box had fallen to the floor, his distorted voice still carried through. “Champions of Etheria and Earth, this day marks the end of your story!”

He-Man and She-Ra, side by side, raised their swords.

# Everything Collapses, Part 2

Chapter Summary

Steven and Adora must fight with everything they have as the battle with Modulok reaches its peak.

Chapter Twenty-Seven: Everything Collapses, Part 2

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The tower's base had begun to crack even further. With all the Gems working together, even as their strength waned, its foundations were gradually worn away. Bits of stone fell to the ground, but it still stood, the Runestone that sat atop its height still enveloped in darkness.

The energy drain had taken its toll, with many of them growing weaker and weaker the more they pushed or pulled. Only one Gem still fought with the same ferocity she normally had, and that was Jasper. Even though it was clearly painful, she slammed her fists against the tower's side hard enough to shake it to its very core. Her mouth hung open like a wild animal, her eyes were glazed over, and even her gemstone seemed to grow paler, yet still she persevered. She would not allow herself to be bested by the First Ones, even posthumously.

But even her rage had its limits. Though her spirit never faltered, her body wasn't so lucky. Having used up just about all of her energy reserve, each punch started showing clear effects–namely, dissolving her fists. Each successive blow led to more and more of her arm dissipating, with a dim light shining through what remained. But even as her hands were reduced to stumps, she continued to drive her arms against the pillar, and when those too were gone, her shoulders. With nothing left to speak of for arms, she summoned her helmet, repeatedly hammering away at the cracks she had created.

“I don’t know…how much longer I c-can keep this up…” said Lapis, all but collapsed on the ground. She too fought through the pain, lashing at the tower with all the water she could stand to control. But the more she did, the more her physical form began to shut down, slowly dissolving. “I think I’m…at my limit…”

Gems all around were experiencing the same. Fluorite fell to the ground, unable to keep herself upright. Bismuth got her armblade embedded in the stone, and trying to pull it out tore her arm clean off. Padparadscha had already been reduced to her gem. “Keep…fighting…” ordered Jasper, her voice hoarse. Although she continued ramming her head into the pillar, her pace slowed more and more. “Keep…” Her physical form began to falter as well “...going…”

Suddenly, amid the quieting commotion, there was a bright flash of light, rising above the scene as a pillar. A vast titan emerged from the glow, bellowing out a pained roar. With the last bit of her strength that remained, Alexandrite hurled herself at the tower. Three giant fists crashed into the stone, sending a shockwave all throughout Brightmoon.

And then…silence. The tower remained standing. Unable to hold herself together anymore, Alexandrite crumbled, reduced to her component Gems. Pearl, Amethyst, Ruby, and Sapphire all fell to the ground, unable to fight any longer. “Well…I guess that’s it,” Amethyst said, accepting her fate. “We had a good run, didn’t we?”

“All we can do now is hope the others shut down the Heart of Etheria,” Pearl said. “Even if we aren’t there to see it…”

“I… No, we’ll be there!” Ruby shouted–or at least as much of a shout as she could muster. Despite her best efforts, she couldn’t even crawl, let alone stand.

Sapphire was in the same boat as the others, laying on the ground, her consciousness waning. But a flicker of movement

caught her attention. “Look,” she said, raising her hand to point at the tower: slowly but surely, its weight started to shift.

With a soft creaking sound that grew louder and louder, the pillar began tipping over. Slowly at first, it gained momentum, until all of their combined efforts finally bore fruit. The tower collapsed, falling into the ground with an earth-shaking crash and a cloud of dust. The dark swirling void within the Moonstone faded, leaving the Runestone a faded gray. And with it went the vacuum draining their energy.

Lars gasped, sitting upright as he coughed violently. “I’m alive! I’m…I mean, not technically, but still!” He got to his feet, stumbling a bit, but able to hold himself upright. Looking around, he saw everyone doing the same. The princesses were recovering their energy, and the Gems’ bodies were repairing themselves. He rushed over to help. “Is everyone okay!?”

“I’ll live,” said Mermista, propping herself up with her trident. “How about everyone else?”

Pearl did a quick head-count. “Everyone is accounted for,” she reported. “What should we do now?”

“Isn’t it obvious?” Jasper approached, her rage not diminished in the slightest. “The other Runestones all across the planet are likely doing the same thing. We can’t stop until each and every one of them has been smashed into powder!”

“What? No way, it’s too dangerous!” said Lars. “Need I remind you that we barely survived *one* Runestone? No, Adora told me to get everyone out of danger, and that’s exactly what I’m doing! Everybody, on the ship! Let’s get out of here before something else happens!”

One by one, everyone climbed aboard. “Captain? Are you sure this is the best idea?” asked Rhodonite, holding Padparadscha’s gem. “Shouldn’t we do something more to help?”

He looked away sadly. “I wish we could, but we’re in over our heads here. All we can do now is hope the others can handle things on their end.”

Once everyone was aboard, the First Ones ship took to the skies, blasting off into orbit.

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In his new monstrous form, Modulok hurled himself at the heroes. They swung their swords as he approached, only for him to leap over them. A tentacle caught them as he passed overhead, knocking them both apart as he continued against the wall and onto the ceiling. Before they could get their bearings, he leapt down from above, pinning them both to the ground.

“Are these the invincible heroes I have heard so much about?” he snarled, holding them down. “Perhaps I over-prepared for this confrontation. I never expected you to be so weak!”

Adora’s arm was pinned, leaving her unable to move her sword. “This fight only just started!” The sword transformed into a knife, giving her just enough room to jab it into his hand. Using it to gain leverage, she was able to push him off, escaping from his grip. Before she could follow up with a powerful slash, he held up Steven in the path of her blade. She stopped moments before accidentally hitting him.

Modulok then threw Steven at her, causing both of them to careen into the wall. “And this fight is about to end! I told you already: I prepared for every outcome! You cannot win!”

“Prepare for this!” Steven ran towards him, yelling a war cry as he swung his sword. Despite Modulok being larger, he was also much faster, darting out of the way of his every strike. Eventually, Steven slammed his sword against the floor, creating a shockwave that was successful in knocking Modulok back a small bit.

Adora got up, making her way over to the platform in the room’s center while Steven kept Modulok busy. “How are things going

here?” she asked Entrapta.

“Not too great,” Entrapta replied, hesitant to touch her device again. Double Trouble still sat atop it, still catatonic. “If we can disconnect it somehow, we might be able to shut off the firing sequence, but…” She stared at the disk, looking helpless.

“Stand back!” Adora shoved the Sword of Protection underneath the disk, attempting to wedge it in further. The black dust trails rippled with energy as she pulled, though the device itself barely moved. Before she could make any progress in prying it off, a large clawed hand wrapped around her neck, pulling her away.

She felt herself being slammed against the wall, before realizing Modulok’s eyes were inches away from hers. “According to the ancient legends, there will always be a She-Ra to protect Etheria,” he said. Adora noticed he was holding Steven’s sword, who had likewise been hurled away. “If one dies, another will be chosen to replace her. Perhaps we should test that?” He placed the sword against her chest, slowly pushing it further. She grabbed onto the blade with her free hand, doing her best to keep it away from her heart.

Entrapta grabbed She-Ra’s sword, attempting to remove it from its current position. “Hang on, Adora!” Even placing her full body weight on the blade didn’t make it budge. She pulled against it with every bit of her strength, but it remained firmly in place.

A short distance away, Steven got his bearings, seeing Adora in peril. He held out his hand, and the sword was pulled from Modulok’s grip, freeing Adora. As it returned to its owner, it made a small cut on Modulok’s arm. Only Adora seemed to notice this.

“You would stand against me, He-Man?” asked Modulok, looming over Steven. “You have seen the havoc wreaked by Gemkind yourself. I know you resent this destruction in your heart, no matter how loving you claim to be.”

“Maybe,” he replied, “but I would never wish for their destruction. Yours, on the other hand, I fully embrace!” He hurled himself at his enemy once more. Modulok was ready, throwing Adora as a distraction. Steven simply caught her, placing her down without breaking his stride as he hurled his sword towards Modulok.

The scientist avoided his projectile, readying himself as Steven prepared to throw a punch. His mouth opened wide, and he sank his fangs into Steven’s arm before he could do so. Steven let out a cry, grabbing hold of one of the many teeth as Modulok attempted to shake him like a ragdoll.

Adora returned to Entrapta, taking hold of her sword once more. “Light Hope, how much longer do we have?” she asked.

“Heart of Etheria ready to fire in…,” the computer reported, trailing off. “Moonstone no longer responding. Firing time has been delayed to eight minutes.”

The situation was still incredibly dire, but Adora couldn’t help feeling slightly relieved at this. Did that mean everyone back at Brightmoon was safe? No, this wasn’t the time to speculate–there were still many Runestones providing power to the Heart. “Can’t you program in some kind of manual override or something?” she suggested.

“Not without anything to program it with!” Entrapta replied. “Modulok destroyed the console, so there’s no way I can–” Her eyes suddenly widened. “That’s it! Emily!” She produced a small device from her pocket, apparently containing Emily’s mind. “You stop this guy, I’ll stop the Heart!” Adora nodded, pulling her sword from the pedestal.

Meanwhile, Steven continued to struggle with Modulok. Luckily, his strength meant that his arm hadn’t been bitten off, but it was still in Modulok’s mouth. If he could just get the chance to summon his sword, he could…wait, that was it! From the depths of Modulok’s throat, Steven opened his hand, focusing. The Sword

of Power was pulled towards its master's awaiting grasp, but Modulok happened to be in the way.

There was a terrible screech as the blade plunged into the back of Modulok's head. Steven stepped back, freed from his many fangs. The monster writhed for a time, before finally going still. "He didn't prepare for *that* outcome," Steven remarked.

The two examined Modulok's inert form. "...Is that it?" Adora asked hesitantly. "Is he just…dead?"

"Pretty hard for someone to survive something like that," said Steven. They waited a few moments to confirm that he was really dead, before Steven walked over to retrieve his sword…only for Modulok's arm to shoot out, grabbing him by the neck.

"Have you forgotten that those swords belong to the Eternians?" came Modulok's voice from his damaged box. He lifted himself off the ground, hoisting Steven up with him. "Did you not think I would make this body immune to such things!? Your power is useless against me! I am indestructible!" He reached back, pulling the sword from his head and letting it clatter to the ground.

Adora charged again, which he attempted to counter by slamming Steven into her. Seeing this coming, she slid underneath his arm, grabbing Steven's sword in the process. Swinging both blades at once, she severed his arm, freeing Steven and causing Modulok to hiss in anger.

She tossed the Sword of Power back to its owner. "You realize Skeletor said something similar, right? And so did Horde Prime." The two of them pointed their swords at him. "It doesn't matter how invincible you think you are, we'll find a way to take you down!"

Modulok was more concerned with his arm than her speech, which was struggling to regrow. Tendons slowly slid into place, as though a barrier was preventing their movement. "How poetic…I

believe Mara said something similar, all those years ago." He charged once more.

The pair were ready this time, rolling out of the way. He carried himself onward, smashing through one of the windows and climbing up above the command center. Back to back, Steven and Adora waited and listened as he rounded the bridge, occasionally rushing past a window.

"She really thought she could stop me…stop the revival of our great empire." Modulok's voice emanated from his voice box, laying on the floor. "All she did was delay the inevitable. Instead of fulfilling her duty, she passed the burden onto another She-Ra. It is thanks to her that everything turned out the way it did. She could not stop me…so what makes you think you can?"

Light Hope chimed in with a status update. "Heart of Etheria ready to fire in five minutes."

Meanwhile, Entrapta was busy trying to hook Emily into the remains of the control console. "Okay, let's see, this goes there, that goes here…come on, come on, where are you!?" Modulok had really done a number on it. This was going to be tougher than she thought.

"The longer this goes on, the more I'm starting to believe this guy," said Steven. "Any ideas?"

Adora glanced down at her own sword, and then over at Steven's. "The magic of our swords interferes with his regeneration," she realized. "He may have prepared for one, but with both at once…"

Realization dawned on Steven. "Are you saying what I think you are?" Adora grinned, determination all over her face. "Then let's do it!" The two of them clasped their hands together.

At that moment, Modulok rushed in through the broken window, ready to deal the final blow while they were distracted. Instead, just before he reached them, a blinding light filled the room,

emanating from their bodies. He was forced to stop in his tracks, screeching as he skidded to a halt.

Entrapta too covered her eyes, peeking out once the light had dimmed. "Wow…" she said, amazed by what she was seeing. A single figure now stood where Steven and Adora once had. Silver and Gold armor melded together, they stood almost as tall as Modulok's monstrous form. Pure white hair descended down to their ankles, the same color as the aura they emitted.

"It's true that you prepared for much of what has transpired," the being spoke. "That is why, in order to save the day, we must embrace the unexpected." They held a sword in each hand. Raising both blades, they slammed the two together, forming them into a single sword that glowed just as its wielder did. "Now, the only thing you can prepare for is your defeat! For now, you face He-Ra!"

Modulok scoffed. "A Crystal Gem utilizing fusion? Yes, *truly* unexpected!" He leapt up to the ceiling, crawling along until he was above He-Ra, dropping down on them. One of his arms caught their sword before they could strike, wrapping himself around them. "I always knew I would have to rip you apart, I never thought it would be literal!"

He-Ra strained against Modulok's grip, before transforming their sword into a whip. A flick sent the tip wrapping around his neck, which allowed them to easily pull him off. They slammed Modulok into the ground, following up by driving their sword into the ground, though he rolled out of the way before being impaled.

As Modulok darted along the walls, He-Ra threw their sword, in shield form, at him, embedding it into the wall. Now that they were unarmed, he leapt back onto them, only for them to call back their shield. Its sharpened edge left a small cut on Modulok's side after brushing against him–a wound that noticeably didn't repair itself.

Modulok snarled when he realized this, ducking out of the way of the next sword strike. He continued to dodge, but He-Ra was growing wise to his maneuvers, cutting him off with a beam of searing hot light launched from the tip of their blade. Falling to the floor, he looked up just in time to see He-Ra plunging their sword down once again.

A flurry of tentacles shot up at the fusion, but each one was sliced off with ease. He-Ra was a bladed tornado, moving too fast for even Modulok's enhanced eyes to see. Seeing that this method of attack was proving fruitless, he crawled away, his eyes falling on Entrapta.

"Heart of Etheria ready to fire in two minutes," announced Light Hope.

"I know, I know, stop rushing me!" Entrapta shouted. The device containing Emily had been hastily wired into what remained of the console, as Entrapta desperately tried to get her into the system. "Emily, if you can hear me, this is gonna come down to the wire!"

But Moduok wasn't about to take that chance. He hurled himself at Entrapta, fangs bared. She shielded herself, but there wasn't much she could do against his sudden attack. Then, his jaws snapped shut…just inches away from her face. "You will not win today!" shouted He-Ra, having grabbed hold of one of his remaining tentacles. "We will fight to ensure that you see no successes, no matter how small–of that you can be sure!"

The beast in their grasp turned around, pivoting his attack to face them instead. He-Ra held back his massive jaws as he bit and clawed at them with the ferocity of a true monster, a role which he was embracing very well. They held him back, but his augmented body was strong enough to give even them a hard time.

"You thought you could drain the life from our home…now we will show you what it feels like!" He-Ra tossed Double Trouble aside, slamming Modulok down on the pedestal. However, rather than

ending up in a similar condition to his creation, Modulok simply lay still, as though waiting for something. In any case, his energy certainly wasn't being drained.

"Just as predictable as ever," he drawled. Though his severed tendrils still hadn't regrown, he sprouted multiple new ones that began to wrap around He-Ra's form. "Did you honestly assume I would not prepare myself to be immune to the Heart's effects?"

He-Ra's assumption cost them the upper hand, resulting in Modulok hurling them over to a broken window. They tried to strike with their sword, but he caught their arm, twisting it and making the weapon fall to the ground. As he pushed them closer to the opening, he picked up the blade, tossing it down below as it vanished into the dark.

"The Heart is hungry," said Modulok, holding them out over the abyss. "Feed it!" With that, he shoved them out, sending them hurtling over the edge. However, He-Ra managed to grab one of Modulok's tentacles just before falling, pulling him with them. He managed to grab onto the ledge just before falling over completely, holding them both up.

"You now hold both of our lives in your hands," said He-Ra. "If you let go, we will perish, but you will as well. Is that truly the outcome you desire?"

Modulok only sneered, releasing his grip. The two of them hurtled downwards, only stopping when He-Ra was able to grab another ledge, pulling themself up. Of course, Modulok had grabbed them as well, pulling himself up and over, attempting to push them off.

But He-Ra stood their ground. Feet firmly planted, they fought against his grip, the two of them entangled like a snake constricting its prey. Modulok's voice box was now too far away to hear his thoughts, fully completing his bestial transformation. His teeth snapped before He-Ra's face, barely held back from biting down.

Unable to throw him off, He-Ra instead fell to the floor, slamming their body weight into Modulok. This didn't deter him for more than a moment, with one of his arms grabbing He-Ra by the back of the head and pulling them back. Forcing them back to their feet, he continued forcing them closer to the edge.

Something in Modulok's mutated biology must have allowed him to increase in strength to match his opponents. Without a way to end this fight soon, He-Ra felt they soon may be overwhelmed. There was only one way to end this: they allowed Modulok to lead them further, before turning to face him towards the darkness, pressing their hand against his chest.

From out of the abyss shot a streak of silver: He-Ra's sword, returning to its master. He-Ra pulled away their hand, and the sword continued blade-first along its path. Like a shining beacon, it sprouted from Modulok's chest, the beast letting out a primal screech before going silent. And then, everything was still. Slowly, Modulok's limbs went slack.

He-Ra then easily freed themself from his grip, grabbing the hilt of their sword. Modulok's lifeless body slid off of the blade, tumbling down into the abyss below. "At last…the fight is over." The fight may have been over, but the danger had not yet passed. They looked up to see the Heart of Etheria, still glowing brightly. "We cannot afford to rest now. Not until Etheria is saved!"

Getting back up to the control center was easy for He-Ra. A single leap was enough to carry them up most of the way–after a few jumps, they ended up back up top, entering through the same window through which they fell. Inside, Entrapta was frantically finishing up her patch-job wiring.

"Heart of Etheria firing in ten…nine…e-eight…sev–seven…s-s-s-s-s-s–eight…fourteen…" Light Hope's voice distorted, but the countdown was still proceeding, though delayed.

"Emily's doing the best she can, but we have to destroy that device!" said Entrapta, rushing over to He-Ra. The two of them

met in the center of the room, once more trying to remove the disk allowing the Heart to function. He-Ra was able to make it budge, but the black dust had all but sealed it in place.

Light Hope continued to fight through Emily's interference. "Te-te-ten…nin-ne-ne-ne-ne…eigh-eigh-eight…" Behind them, the Heart glowed brighter than the sun, its energy reaching its peak.

In the tenseness of the moment, neither of them noticed as something large and heavy slammed into the door, despite it being powerful enough of an impact to leave a large dent. At the second impact, however, Entrapta peered over, running through possible causes in her mind. By the third, a large enough gap had appeared for a red eye to peer through. "Watch out!" she shouted, diving aside at the last moment.

Megator burst through the doors, sending both flying across the room. He-Ra had heeded Entrapta's warning similarly close, managing to swat them aside. The mutant continued forward on his path, slamming his fists down on the first thing he saw: which happened to be the central platform.

The disk broke into pieces, scattering the black dust and miniature Runestones across the floor. "Th-th-threeeeee…twoooooo…" said Light Hope, her voice slowing down. "Firing sequence aborted. Heart of Etheria dormancy protocols reactivated." Above them, the Heart's light dimmed, as its spinning gradually slowed to a halt.

Everyone, even the giant mutant, was still. "Hey, it worked!" Scorpia peered in through the newly-opened doors, examining the scene. Her eyes fell on the stunned forms of Entrapta and He-Ra. "Oh, uh, sorry, are we interrupting?"

"Light Hope…?" said He-Ra. "Is it truly over? Has the crisis been averted?"

"Indeed," the computer replied. "Returning planetary shell to base orbital configuration."

A growl coming from the room's center interrupted everyone's relief. Megator stood up, red eyes scanning the room as he prepared to seek out his next target. Everyone readied themselves for a fight…but then, Megator's anger disappeared. He knelt down in front of the pedestal, staring at it as though it was familiar to him. He reached his hand out towards the jewels in the center, and one of them began to glow.

A similar-colored glow came from his chest. Both sources of light were red in color, pulsing at the same frequency. A palpable sense of calm washed over the room, as though everyone's worries were melting away.

Partly due to this calm, partly due to exhaustion, He-Ra split back up into Adora and Steven. "Is that…Bow?" asked the former, horrified.

Glimmer teleported in front of him, grabbing his head. "Bow, whatever it was Modulok did to you, you're still you. Ever since the beginning, you've been there to support us–well, now it's our turn to support you. Fight it, Bow, fight Modulok's influence! Take back control, we'll do whatever we need to do to help!"

Megator's monstrous expression softened into one almost recognizable as his previous form. The red glow spread across his body, carrying the soothing feeling with it. It then spread beyond his body, filling the entire room. They could feel Bow's pain, his fear, just as clearly as they felt their own. But they also felt his desire to help them. And that desire strengthened their own resolve to support each other.

As the light filled the room, Adora stepped forward. She held up her sword, and in a flash of light, a crystal appeared on the hilt. From it came a beam of blue light, washing over Bow's form and mixing with the red.

But Steven was the one most affected by the light. He could feel fear inside of him, fear that the Sword of Power would control him…but it soon vanished. With it came a sense of overwhelming

love and devotion, the source of which he had only felt from one place in his entire life. He looked down to see that his gemstone, for the first time in months, was glowing. “M-mom…?”

The pink glow spread up from his gem, covering his form. He placed his sword on his back, reverting back to his usual appearance as he approached Bow. Leaning forward, he planted a kiss on his forehead.

Red, blue, and pink light all intertwined, seeping directly into Bow’s very essence. Replaced by a pure white glow, his form body began to shrink. As the light dissipated, there he was, good as new. “Glimmer? Adora?” he asked weakly, looking up at them with his non-red eyes. “Did…did we win?”

With tears in her eyes, Glimmer burst out laughing, throwing her arms around him. “Bow! Yes, we did, we won! We stopped Modulok, and it’s all thanks to you!”

“It is?” he said, as the last few minutes were a bit foggy. “What exactly happened? Why do I feel so…warm?” He looked down at his chest, the red glow finally subsiding.

Micah looked over the pedestal, then back to Bow, focusing on the reddish gems. “Each of these seem to correspond to one of the planet’s Runestones,” he said. “The same ones that give the princesses their powers, and that only they can use. I think there’s only one explanation for how your young friend can do what he did.”

“You mean…I’m a princess?” said Bow, looking at his hand. “But I’m…I’m not even…how!?”

“Who *cares* how!” cried Glimmer, teleporting herself and Bow over to Micah. “We’ll figure that out later! You’re a princess! My friend Bow is a princess!” Overjoyed, she continued to laugh, the other two also joining in.

Entrapta was similarly overjoyed, rushing over to Emily to tell her what a great job she did. Scorpia had pulled Steven into an

enormous hug. Adora, with a relieved smile, sat down with her back to the wall. “Light Hope…what’s the status of everyone’s energy?”

“Life energy returning to its original source,” she reported. “No casualties detected.”

Adora looked down at her new sword, tracing her thumb over its brand new runestone. “Then we really did do it. We saved Etheria…Homeworld…maybe even the whole universe.”

# Horizons

Chapter Summary

> With the crisis averted and the day saved, everyone returns to their lives, unaware that an even greater threat looms just over the horizon...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

## Chapter Twenty-Eight: Horizons

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Everyone's first hint that the day had been saved was the planet's orbit returning to normal. All the beams of light receded, and Etheria's moons traveled back to where they had been before its activation. A palpable sense of relief washed over everyone aboard the First Ones vessel as they saw the crisis being averted before their eyes. Lars directed the ship down towards the Citadel to greet and recover the victorious heroes.

"There they are!" Pearl shouted excitedly as the ship approached the tower. Steven, Adora, Bow, Glimmer, Micah, Scorpia, and Entrapta all emerged from the elevator, haggard but alive, waving at them as they approached. The ship touched down, with its passengers disembarking. Some, such as Pearl herself, all but leapt from the vessel to reach the survivors. "Steven!" she cried, throwing her arms around him.

Steven almost tumbled to the ground under her, Amethyst, and Garnet's combined weight. "Woah! Hey, I'm glad to see you too!"

"You didn't die!" Amethyst said. "And you stopped the planet from blowing up too! I don't know which is more impressive!"

"It wasn't just me: I couldn't have done it with any of these guys," he said, looking over at the others. "We'd probably have been drained dry if it hadn't been for all of them."

The other Gems crowded around him. "Stop being so modest!" ordered Peridot. "You're He-Man! There's no way any of them would have been able to do anything if it hadn't been for you…" She zeroed in on his gemstone, noticing that it was shimmering in the sunlight. "...got your powers back!?"

He placed a hand over his stomach, feeling his gem's warmth. Such a feeling had been absent for some time, and only now realized just how much he had missed it. "Oh yeah. I sure did!" He summoned his shield, showing it off to the others. "Steven Universe is back, baby!"

As the Gems patted him on the back for rediscovering his inner power, he saw someone through the crowd, a sword of her own on her back. "I knew you could do it," Connie said, making her way up to him.

"I wish I had your confidence," he said with a small grin. "For a while there, I wasn't sure if everything was gonna turn out alright. Was…was everything alright with you guys? It sounded like things were pretty back around the Runestones."

"Yeah, they were," Connie replied. "The Moonstone started draining everyone's energy–I wasn't sure we were going to make it out, either. Actually, we probably wouldn't have, if it wasn't for Jasper." She turned to look at the one Gem standing apart from the others, who had her back turned to them.

Steven just stared at first. "Wait, you're talking about Jasper, right? *Jasper* saved the day?" Connie nodded. "...Huh. Maybe I had her figured all wrong." Curious, he walked towards the Quartz to get to the bottom of her heroics.

As he expected, she wasn't exactly glad to see him. "Well, look who survived," he said, watching him approach. "I assume Rose's

powers saw you through to victory?"

"Good to see you too," he said, slightly meaning it. "I hear you saved everyone from being drained by the Heart. Maybe you'd make a good Crystal Gem after all."

She scoffed. "Trust me, my distaste for the First Ones far outweighs whatever miniscule amount of respect I might have for your little band of rebels. If refusing to fall to their doomsday machines meant saving the others, so be it."

Steven shrugged–baby steps, he supposed. "Still, I'm grateful. You saved everyone's lives, and, well…" He took hold of the Sword of Power. "...I probably wouldn't have been able to control He-Man without you. So, thank you, for everything."

"You mean you were successfully able to destroy your enemies?" she asked, raising an eyebrow. "Hmm. Maybe I had you figured wrong. It might be you who makes for a good Homeworld Gem."

Just as Steven had been surrounded by the Gems, the rest of the princesses were crowding around Adora. "I just *knew* you would save everyone!" Perfuma said, throwing her arms around her, Glimmer, and Bow. "With all of us working together, I knew there was no way we would fail!"

"I mean, we did kinda almost get our energy sucked out by the Moonstone going haywire," Mermista said. I wouldn't exactly call that 'working together.'"

"Hey, I'm sure we all played our parts," Bow said. "All *I* did was get turned into a monster and try to crush my friends…"

Glimmer lightly socked him on the shoulder. "Uh, yeah, but you *also* broke the machine controlling the Heart!" she reminded him. "Not only that, but… You wanna tell 'em?"

"Tell us what?" asked Frosta. "Wait, you got turned into a monster!? What was *that* about? No, that can wait–tell us the other thing!"

Bow looked at all of his friends standing around him. "Well…I don't know a lot of the details yet, but it seems like…well, that I'm a princess."

Expectedly, there was a brief silence following this unexpected revelation. "What!?" shouted Perfuma. "You're…but how!? How does that even work? You didn't even know anything beforehand? D-does this mean you're…?" She took a few deep breaths. "Details, please."

"I don't really know much at this point," Bow admitted. "I mean, my dads don't really bring up their past too much, so it's possible I'm the descendant of some long-lost kingdom. It's probably going to take a lot of research to get to the bottom of this; which is why I'm glad I have someone to help me out." He turned around, looking at Entrapta with a smile.

She was taken aback by the gesture, turning around to see if he was referring to someone else. "M-me?" she asked, pointing at herself. "You want me to join you? Even after…everything I've done?"

Adora, Glimmer, and Bow all looked at each other. "Come on," Adora said, holding out her hand. "You're a princess too, right?"

Overjoyed, Entrapta joined in on the group hug, wrapping everyone up in her pigtails. "Yes! Yes, absolutely yes! I promise I'll be the best science buddy ever, and I'll never let you down again, and…and… I'm so glad to be back!"

Micah noticed that Scorpia was standing further away from the group, and although she was grinning, her eyes didn't look quite as happy. "You do realize what this means, yes?"

She blinked. "Uh, what?"

"The Princess Alliance accepts princesses of all kinds," he said. "You *are* a princess, aren't you?"

Scorpia's eyes lit up. "Hey, yeah, you're right! Make way for one more hugger!" She scooped most of the group up in her claws, squeezing them with all her might. "You don't mind, do you?"

"Nope, the more the merrier!" said Frosta, rather breathlessly. "As long as my ribs aren't broken…"

Eventually, Scorpia set them down. "Well, we got three new princesses in one day," said Mermista, looking at them all. "And, uh…who's the old dude?" She gestured to Micah.

Glimmer and Micah shared a sly smile. "Everyone…I'd like to introduce you to someone very special," she said, walking over to him. "This is King Micah, King of Brightmoon…and my father."

He looked at all of their surprised faces. Some of them he recognized, while others looked similar to their parents. "It's good to meet you all," he said. "I can already tell the Princess Alliance has come a long way since I have been gone."

If Bow being a princess had been a surprising turn of events, then King Micah being alive and well was a shock of shocks to the girls. Everyone was stunned into silence, with only Spinnerella able to say something. "Make that three princesses and a king."

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With the aid of Lars' ship, the princesses were able to return to their respective kingdoms in no time at all. Thankfully, damages were minimal, but everyone almost having their lifeforce drained understandably left the populace rather uneasy. It would take some work, but there was no question everyone would be able to recover from Modulok's attack.

As expected, Castaspella was shocked to see her brother again, though the surprise of it soon gave way to joy. The two were reunited again…but unfortunately, everything was not all happy back at Bightmoon.

“I went over this moment so many times in my head,” Micah said solemnly. “I imagined myself returning to the castle, dropping myself into her waiting arms. I would be exhausted, hurt, and ready to give out, but I would be home. …But is it really home without her?”

He stood before Angella’s makeshift grave, a pile of stones that now had several moon lilies growing around it. Castaspella stood behind him. “What will you do now?” she asked.

Micah took a breath. “Ordinarily, I would say that Brightmoon needs its king. But seeing everything Glimmer has accomplished, I would say it has a princess who is more than capable of ruling it. I’m still a member of the Rebellion, of course, but now I defer to my daughter. She’s grown into a greater leader than I ever was.”

“You always were the nobler of us,” said Castaspella, tearing up as she stepped forward to hug her little brother. “Welcome home.”

Surrounded by his loved ones, only now did he truly feel like he was home. “It’s so good to see you again, Casta,” he said.

Meanwhile, standing on a balcony overlooking much of the kingdom, Glimmer stared out at the remains of the Moonstone’s fallen tower. Without it, she wouldn’t have her powers. But considering the alternative was everyone being drained of their lifeforce, this was the less-troubling outcome. Besides, surely they would be able to repair it, right?

“You have been awfully quiet since you returned.” She glanced behind her to see Hordak approach. “I would have expected you to redouble your efforts to hunt down Catra now that Modulok has been dealt with.”

Glimmer sighed, setting her head on the railing. “Back when me and Adora had our big fight, what was it you told Bow? It hurts, but it has to be done. I think…I think that’s how I feel about Catra right now.” She lifted herself back up. “As much as I want justice

for my mom, it can wait. Making sure everything is right with my subjects–and my friends–is more important."

"In the short time I have known you, you have become a better ruler than I could ever be," said Hordak, the faintest hint of a smile crossing his face. "I am proud of you, and I am certain Angella is, as well."

The thought of her mother watching over her made Glimmer swell with pride, in a bittersweet way. "So…what will you do now?" she asked.

Hordak stood beside her to gaze out over the landscape. "I believe I am no longer needed here. Instead, I will return to the Fright Zone to begin the transition of power from myself to Princess Scorpia."

"You…you really meant that?" Glimmer asked. "I thought you were just gonna make her your second in command, or something."

"It is her ancestral home, after all," he continued. "Besides, I have built up a sizable empire of my own in the Crimson Waste. Those of the Horde still loyal to me will gladly follow me there. And any time you need aid against the forces of the New Horde, do not hesitate to call on us."

Glimmer could hardly believe this man used to be her arch-enemy. He had changed so much in the past few years–but then again, so had she. "Thank you," she said. "And if you need help, you know where to find me."

"I certainly do," Hordak said, returning the way he came. "Oh, and you have another visitor."

As Hordak left, Adora entered. "Glimmer," she greeted, leaning against the railing.

"Adora."

The two of them sat in silence for a little while, just looking out at the landscape. "So…" Adora eventually said. "Light Hope's back. That's pretty exciting."

"I've been meaning to ask about her," said Glimmer. "Does she have her memories back yet?"

"Not quite, but Entrapta and Bow think that she'll be able to restore her original systems before too long. She'll be back to how she was before Horde Prime almost killed her. Oh, and speaking of Entrapta, she thinks she knows a way to repair the Moonstone! That's pretty exciting too, yeah?"

Glimmer nodded. "Yeah." There was another period of silence. "Adora, I'm… I can't tell you how sorry I am. About everything. None of this would've happened if I'd been a better friend. A better queen. I should have told you everything. I should have gone with you."

"Hey, everything turned out fine in the end," said Adora, placing a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "I got She-Ra back, I found out where I came from, and we beat Modulok!" Suddenly, a look of sadness crossed her face, going back to staring.

"Does anyone else know?" she asked.

Adora shook her head. "Just you, Bow, and Steven. Oh, and Entrapta, she was there when Modulok dropped the bombshell." She looked down at her hands. "I know I shouldn't be thinking of myself as a copy of someone else, but…that's literally what I *am* . How can I be anything different?"

"Because you're not Queen Marlena, or whoever," said Glimmer. "You're Adora. Horde cadet-turned-my best friend. Light Hope may have picked you because of *what* you are, but you only made it this far because of *who* you are. And none of us would have made it this far without you, She-Ra or not."

"...Thanks." Adora and Glimmer pulled each other into a hug. "So, uh, what'll you do now?" she asked.

Glimmer thought about it for a moment. “Whatever needs to be done,” she replied. “Rebuild what needs rebuilding, help who needs helping, fight who needs fighting. You with me?”

“Always!” Adora said with a confident nod.

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“...and so, that’s basically the gist of it,” said Greg over the communicator. “Crazy maniac tries to blow up Homeworld with a planet-gun. Sorry if I left out some of the details, I just know what Steven told me.”

The three Diamonds were present on the other end of the communicator. “No need, Greg, that is plenty,” said Yellow. “To think Homeworld was nearly destroyed right under our noses…”

“Indeed. We will need to be far more cautious going forward,” Blue added. “There are undoubtedly many other factions who resent Gemkind for a wide variety of reasons. This Modulok character was likely only the first of many. …White, is there something on your mind?”

White Diamond appeared lost in thought, brought back to the present by Blue’s query. “Hmm? Oh, yes, I couldn’t help but be reminded of days past by Modulok’s motive. To think that one of the Eternians had survived for so long…I hesitate to imagine what else has remained hidden from us all this time. Does Modulok have any known followers?”

“Um, well, Steven said that we have two in custody at Brightmoon,” said Greg. “Some guy who controls bugs, and a shapeshifter or something. I don’t really know all the details, but I’m sure Hessonite can tell you more–she and her crew were directly attacked by them, after all.”

“Yes, I am told the *Crystallon* is on its way to Homeworld as we speak,” Yellow said. “And while we’re on the subject of ships, I understand that the *Supermassive* ‘s whereabouts have not yet

been ascertained. Does the Princess Alliance have any idea where Emerald fled to?"

Greg thought for a moment, only to realize that they had hardly mentioned Emerald in a rundown of the events to him. "No, they have no idea. She left once the Heart activated, but that's about it. She could be anywhere by now."

Yellow's eyes narrowed slightly. "Wonderful. Another loose end for me to tie up. Well, if that is all, Hessonite should be arriving shortly. Give my regards to Steven, would you?" With that, she ended her call, leaving only her two sisters on-screen."

"I must be going as well," said Blue. "With the New Horde having left Ophidia, now is the perfect time to start talks of an alliance. Do wish me luck." Her image disappeared as well, only White remaining.

The two of them were silent for a bit. "So…how are things over there?" asked Greg.

"Quite lovely, all things considered," White said, smiling wistfully. "Things have been so much easier now that I've stepped down, and Spinel is lovely to have around. Are things on Earth going well for you?"

Greg rubbed the back of his head. "Yeah, sort of. I don't really see Steven too much anymore. Between Etheria and Little Homeworld, he practically has a full-time job! I help out where I can, but…I don't know how good I am at this stuff…"

"Now, there's no need for that. I, for one, think you make a wonderful correspondent," White assured him. "I can see what Pink saw in you."

This caused him to blush. "Ah, well, if that's everything, I think I'll be going now. Call back if anything comes up."

She nodded. "Indeed, and you do the same. Farewell for now, Greg Universe." She disconnected as well, leaving Greg alone.

He set down the Gem communicator back in his van's glove box, leaning against the side. "From one planet-destroying disaster to the next…will it ever end?" he asked nobody in particular, glancing over at a picture. He and Steven both played their guitars, while the three Gems sat by, listening to the music they made. He had always known Steven was destined for great things, even back then, but this was all a bit much.

The van was parked within Little Homeworld, now attached to a communications array connecting it to a wide variety of other Gem settlements. The town had grown more than a little in the time since its creation, with Gems of all sorts calling it home. But among them, once adamantly refused to call it home, though it seemed something in her had begun to shift.

"You sure you're up for another round?" Steven asked, stretching as he prepared for combat. "Last time we fought, it didn't end so well, and that was before I got my  powers back."

Jasper only scoffed. "You think I'm afraid of you? Rose Quartz herself couldn't keep me down, and she was a Diamond! You think you stand a chance?"

"Well, I did mess you up pretty good back there, not to mention what I did to Karikon," Steven said uncertainly.

"And what about what you did to Modulok? You didn't seem so afraid when you faced him," she pointed out.

Steven turned away. "That was…different. Two whole planets were on the line, I couldn't afford to hold back."

"'Hold back?' Were you holding back when Skeletor threatened to turn everyone into the undead? When Horde Prime claimed Etheria as his own? When the Diamonds came for you?" She pointed at the Sword of Power. "You've been fighting for your entire life. Having a magic sword doesn't change that in the slightest. Now, I'm not afraid of you, no matter how powerful you may be. So tell me: are *you* afraid of you?"

Gripping the sword, Steven thought about the question. "No," he finally answered, looking at his reflection in the blade. "It's *my* power–I control it. I have nothing to be afraid of."

Jasper grinned, her helmet appearing on her head. "Then I see no reason why you should hold back. Now come on–show me what you're made of!"

Holding the Sword of Power aloft, Steven smiled as he spoke the incantation: "By the Power of Grayskull!"

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Emerald paced back and forth on the *Supermassive* 's bridge. "So close…we were so close!" she snarled. "The Heart was there, within our grasp…but *they* got to it first! Now we are outmatched, Entrapta is nowhere to be found, and *you all* screwed up the only assignment you had!" She whipped around, glaring at Karikon, Sqalish, Azurite, Crita, and Carnelian.

"In fairness to us, our commanding officer was not exactly the most focused," said Sqalish, alluding to the one of their number who had not yet arrived. "I think her grudge against Adora compromised her leadership ability."

"If it could even be called that to begin with!" Azurite said. "She led us on a wild goose chase for half the time, then had us playing into Modulok's hands the other half! No wonder she hasn't shown up yet–she's probably too ashamed to show her face!"

At that moment, the Supermassive was hailed by an approaching craft. It was a small, single-person transport, the same type used by Modulok's forces. Emerald was hesitant, but opened the channel anyway. "Speak."

"Ugh, it's about time!" Catra's voice was unmistakable, as was her ire. "I had to fly this hunk of junk through three whole star systems just to find you guys after you abandoned me on a collapsing space station–thanks for that, by the way!"

“I seem to remember *you* abandoning *us* !” said Crita, stepping closer to the speaker. But Emerald held up her hand, silencing her.

“How *lovely* to hear your voice again, Catra,” Emerald drawled. “I’m sure that aside from that, your mission was a rousing success.”

“Funny you should mention that,” she said. “Last I checked, Adora, Scorpia, *and* Entrapta were on the station with me before it collapsed. What exactly was our top scientist doing helping the enemy?”

Emerald blinked. “Im-impossible. Entrapta was here the entire time. Of course, I have yet to determine her true location, but–”

“Oh, so she *did* jump ship!” Catra continued, stifling a laugh. “First Scorpia, now Entrapta…our lieutenants really have a tendency to turn traitor, don’t they? I never had a problem with loyalty until you showed up!”

“For your information,” Emerald hissed, “all of *my* lieutenants are still here. Bluebird Azurite, Crita–”

“Topaz?”

Silence. Emerald stood completely still, remembering ‘Entrapta’s’ words to her. Catra had proven herself time and time again to be a liability. She and she alone was qualified to run the New Horde. “I believe you have a point. Perhaps relying on others only causes problems in the long run. We should really work on streamlining the chain of command.”

“That much, we can agree on,” Catra scoffed. “Now come on, open the hangar so I can land this crate.” To her frustration, the *Supermassive* remained still. “Emerald? Emerald, come on, open up! Don’t make me ask again!”

Eerily calm, Emerald spoke once more. “Do you know something, Catra? I think our grudges have been holding us back. You’re obsessed with showing up Adora, I was obsessed with destroying

Lars of the Stars. I like to think I've let go of the past, but you–you never will, will you? No, Adora controls every aspect of your life now, doesn't she? I'm afraid that time and time again, you've proven yourself to be a liability–once I can no longer justify keeping around."

To Catra's horror, the *Supermassive* 's weapons began to turn towards her. "What… You can't do this!" she shouted. "I created the New Horde! It's mine, just as much as it is yours!"

"Yes, it was. And now, it is only mine." She turned towards the others, her finger hovering above the button. "Any objections?" Nobody had any. "I thought not. Goodbye, Catra."

The *Supermassive* opened fire. Catra took evasive maneuvers, darting around and around as dozens of cannons filled the space with lasers. Her ship was tiny enough to be harder to hit, but slow enough that it could not outrun the guns for long. One hit its mark, winging the craft just enough to send it careening out of control.

Everyone watched as Catra's ship passed the moon the Supermassive hid behind, descending towards Etheria. Emerald was fairly convinced that she would survive, but that didn't matter–she was the Princess Alliance's problem now. "And then there was one," she said coldly. "One who would lead the New Horde in a better, far more efficient direction. Next stop: dominance!"

With that, the *Supermassive* sped off into the unknown, leaving Etheria behind.

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For millions of years, the planet of Ophidia had existed as an independent world–and it continued to remain as such. As strong as they were, the New Horde could not break through their armies, just as Homeworld had failed to do many times prior.

Much of this success was due to its people's fearless leader: an individual known only as King Hiss.

Obscured by rumors and legends, only a select few knew the path to reach his hidden underground palace. Modulok was one of those few, his servant privy on the details. Now, lit only by eerie candlelight, the figure walked down the length of the throne room. A number of guards watched as he approached, as did the king himself.

"Great Sovereign of the snakekin race," Jerrick said, bowing to the king. "I come to you on behalf of Master Modulok, whose efforts to rebuild the Eternian Empire have failed. In his stead, I bring to you a gift, one that will allow you to reclaim what you have lost." He held out his hands, which contained a small, nondescript pouch.

The great figure rose from his throne, stepping down the stairs towards the smaller snake. He was larger even than his many brethren, his dark green scales covered in the scars of a thousand battles. Golden armor covered his form, with his visage framed by a headdress made of the same. "Arise," he said, in a mighty voice that echoed throughout the halls.

Jerrick did so, still holding the gift. King Hiss took the pouch, opening it to observe its contents. He seemed surprised at what it contained, though also pleased. He poured the black dust into his fingers, the substance beginning to ripple and glow once it made contact with his skin.

"The echoes of the Unnamed One…I can feel his power within this dust," he said. "You have done well to return him to his rightful home." He held out his free hand, with a smaller snakekin hurrying over to place a scepter within his grasp. He then placed the cobra-shaped head on both of Jerrick's shoulders. "One who is named Jerrick…for your service in honor of the Unnamed One, I hereby entrust you with the title of Kobra Khan. You shall carry out his will in the coming days, as all are bowed to his whims."

Once more, Jerrick knelt before him. "I accept this honor with pride, Great Sovereign. I shall do my duty to reduce all to nothing, as is his will."

A palpable anticipation hung in the air as King Hiss held out his hand. He sprinkled the black dust on the ground before him, watching eagerly as it was absorbed into the stone. "Reunited with his servants, he shall awaken once more. Glory to the Unnamed One!"

"Glory to the Unnamed One! Glory to the Unnamed One!" Echoes of this chant rang through the palace as all of his servants praised their master's name. So fervent were these chants that they penetrated deep into the darkened depths of the world, where the will of his servants descended.

Just as one spark can light a massive fire, so too did a fraction of his power reawaken him. Down in Ophidia's center, surrounded by a nest of black branches and tendrils, a single light appeared. And from that tiny light, an enormous glowing beacon, bright red in color and shaped like a diamond, pierced through the shadows. Like the lone eye of a long-slumbering god, its power reverberated across the entire planet, preparing its inhabitants for what was to come.

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Deep in the darkness below Etheria, the Heart had calmed to its previous state, showing no signs of activating anytime soon. Aside from the low hum of its ambient energy, the chamber was silent.

Below even that, Modulok's warped body lay in what might have been his final resting place, brought low by the sword of He-Ra. But as an unseen power surged across the cosmos, something in his body was awoken. His form crumbled away into a black dust, floating into the air as though blown away by an absent wind. Soon, even that too was gone, leaving no trace he had ever been there.

All that remained of Modulok was the twisted remains of his voice box, which sat, untouched, in the Heart's control room. And although its owner was gone, it crackled to life to deliver one last message on his behalf, his voice garbled and distorted:

"Beware the skies above, young one, for darkness hides within.
The stars have all gone out, young one, they now control the sky.
The Many Who Are One, young one, the First Ones' greatest sin.
Devour all they see, young one, and now you've caught their eye.
Even though now they're gone, young one, they may yet still win.
For even a dead god, young one, can never truly die…"

Chapter End Notes

> And here it is, the beginning of the end! I think of all the stories in this series, this one was the one I was most excited to write, because of all the twists and turns it had. I hope you all enjoyed it as much as I did! Soon enough, though, we will be advancing to the final battle! Sleep tight, everyone...for the Unnamed One cometh...

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